

Marked States

Volume 5

Contact and Multidimensional Subjectivity Toward a Phenomenology of Disclosure

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Volume 5

Contact and Multidimensional Subjectivity. Toward a Phenomenology of Disclosure.

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Contact and Multidimensional Subjectivity Toward a Phenomenology of Disclosure

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Part I

Phenomenology, Contact, and the Multidimensional Subject

Introduction: Marked States and Witnessing Experiencers

Later that night, I go to bed. I don't know if I was dreaming. I don't know what was going on, but I felt like I saw a UFO with this white light coming down. We had a big bay window in our bedroom. I was awakened by forcibly being pushed up into an upright sitting position. It was an antique bed so there was a high footboard. And at the end of the footboard, I saw this head, the top half of a head. And I thought, "Oh my god, I think I know what this is but I've got to be dreaming." So I reached out and I poked it a couple of times and it was solid. At that point, I realized what I was hitting and I remember screaming like, "Oh my god, this is an alien." And then, the next thing I know, I'm laying on my side. That wasn't the position I was in, as I'm remembering this. I'm looking at my clock radio on the nightstand and I'm just laying there trying to piece together what I just experienced. I watch five minutes go by and I can hear one of the boys moaning really loudly. I thought, "God I'm a terrible mom. I'm too scared to even get up and go find out what the heck is going on." And I continued to sit there. Fifteen more minutes go by. Suddenly, my husband comes running up the stairs. Now, he had fallen asleep on the couch downstairs. He was one of those people that nothing short of an atomic bomb gets him up once he's asleep and I had just left him down there. He comes running up the stairs asking, "What was that noise? It shook the house?" It's like, he's describing now a "boom" sort of a thing. I didn't hear anything. He's going from room to room trying to figure out what large piece of furniture had to have fallen over. It's like, nothing made sense that night.

We begin with a puzzling description. A dream-like experience that doesn't feel quite like a dream. A white light descends from the sky and into the room. A mysterious head at the end of the bed, that feels solid when touched. Gaps of missing time. Finding oneself forcibly placed in a different position. Intense confusion about what occurred. Fear that is so intense it paralyzes. A mysterious loud noise heard by some parties and not others. Deidre is in many ways a perfectly ordinary and relatable individual: a mother and wife concerned for her children. She is also a contact experiencer, describing a baffling night in her home, one that many years later she still does not fully know what to do with.

Deidre is not without ideas. With many years to reflect on her experiences, she has entered her own process of sense-making and has her own hypotheses, although they don't necessarily align with our cultural tropes.

If you had to ask me what I think's going on, I think these are things that have always been here. I'm not convinced they're from another planet or anything. I think they operate somehow in the liminal between wherever their world is and our world is. Maybe when I'm in that hypnopompic state, I get images or whatever. Maybe they're made of plasma. Maybe that's why we see them glowing sometimes. But I think the message that I have gotten from the whole thing, personally, is because of all the synchronicities and the precognitive stuff that seems to go along with me in this, is that time isn't what we think it is.

Strikingly, Deidre does not express a conviction that she has encountered extraterrestrials. She is open to possibilities: liminal entities, her own altered perception, plasma beings. Her key interpretative takeaway from the experience does not mention visitors from Zeta Reticuli, nor technological objects from an advanced alien civilization, but rather *our experience and conception of time*. Time is such a cornerstone in how we experience and make sense of our world, that we rarely pause to examine it in depth.

Experiences such as Deidre's are difficult to assimilate not because they are unintelligible, but because they expose the fragile, often invisible distinctions through which we ordinarily create a world of stable objects, events, and temporal order. If experiences like this trouble us so deeply, it is because our most basic frameworks for sense-making depend on the reliability of distinctions that usually lie below reflective awareness. We move through the world by tacitly separating dreaming from waking, inner experience from external events, imagination from sensory perception, self from other, past from present and future. These distinctions do not merely help us interpret experience after the fact; they actively structure what can appear as real and experienceable in the first place. When an experience refuses to stay on one side of these lines—when it appears both dreamed and real, both internally generated but intersubjectively validated, temporally dislocated yet anchored in a time and place—it does not simply add a puzzling data point to an otherwise stable worldview. It calls into question the very operations through which a world is organized at all.

“Marked States” and the Age of Disclosure

Distinction is perfect continence. That is to say, a distinction is drawn by arranging a boundary with separate sides so that a point on one side cannot reach the other side without crossing the boundary.¹

¹ George Spencer-Brown, *Laws of Form* (London: Allen and Unwin, 1969), 1.

George Spencer-Brown introduces a simple *act of creation*: a line is drawn, and consequently, a delineation and distinction between “this” and “that.” Through the liminal act of making a distinction, we have a state within the mark and that which lies outside it: the marked and unmarked state. The distinction between them doesn’t get its validity from a deeper outside source—it comes from the very act of drawing the line itself. A system becomes “self-contained” when the boundaries it creates justify and reinforce themselves, looping back so that the distinction stands on its own without needing any external reference point. In relational dualities such as mind and matter, each term gains meaning only in contrast to the other: mind is not matter, matter is not mind. The distinction itself establishes this relational definition, functioning as a self-contained operational difference. Through such distinctions—the “marked states” we establish—we articulate a world of differentiated objects, properties, and relationships, shaping the field of experience within which phenomena become intelligible. *Through the drawing of distinctions, we create a world.*

And yet there are human experiences that disrupt these delineations—encounters in which the customary boundaries between subject and object, inner and outer, self and Other no longer hold. Distinctions become fluid, ambiguous, reconfigured— or dissolved entirely.

UFOs, or as they’ve been rebranded in government and academic spaces, UAP (unidentified anomalous phenomena) have made considerable headlines since 2017.² High-ranking military personnel and scientists have testified in front of Congress, and whistleblowers like David Grusch allege that the US is in possession of both crafts and biologies of non-human origin.³ A recent documentary *The Age of Disclosure* portrays decades of government coverup of what are insinuated to be crashed extraterrestrial technologies.⁴ As of this writing, we do not have confirmation of the truth of these allegations. Conversations surrounding UAP frame them as both *new* and *urgent* and primarily discuss them in terms of the observed technological capabilities of the craft. The profound existential implications for humanity of the existence of non-human technology are only briefly alluded to, if discussed at all. Further, these conversations lack a distinctly *experiential* and *human* element: how those who witness UAP— and allegedly have contact with their occupants— experience the uncanniness of potential non-human encounter. As

² When referring to the objects throughout this book, I will usually default to “UAP” or use “UFO/UAP.” However if an experiencer or an author discussed uses “UFO,” I will shift to their use of the term.

³ See Vanessa Romo and Bill Chappel, “U.S. recovered non-human 'biologies' from UFO crash sites, former intel official says,” NPR, July 27, 2023. <https://www.npr.org/2023/07/27/1190390376/ufo-hearing-non-human-biologies-uaps>, accessed October 12, 2025.

⁴ Dan Farah, *The Age of Disclosure*, documentary film, directed by Dan Farah (Farah Films, 2025), narrated by Luis Elizondo, premiered March 9, 2025 at the South by Southwest Film Festival (SXSW), released November 21, 2025, on Amazon Prime Video.

we move into the “Age of Disclosure”—a new era of taking UFOs/UAP seriously in official spaces—it is imperative that we take *experiencers* seriously as well.

“Experiencers” has emerged as a term from within the UAP community to refer to individuals who have had an experience with either a UFO/UAP or their alleged occupants, ranging from non-consensual abduction experiences to less intrusive forms of contact. For almost 80 years (and in some cultures, for much longer)⁵ ordinary, credible people have reported sightings of crafts, encounters and communication with advanced non-human intelligences, as well as abduction encounters in which physical procedures, often related to reproduction, are performed on the crafts. But these individuals have very rarely been taken seriously, and substantial efforts have been made to prevent, eliminate, or discredit their testimony in official spaces.

While there is growing consensus that UAP are beyond the capacities of human technology, there is still an observable hesitancy to directly confront who or what may be piloting them. Academic conferences and congressional hearings proceed while featuring few, if any, experiencers as speakers. The reality is that despite the progress we have made in making UFOs/UAP a respectable topic of academic discourse, experiencer testimony still fails to be taken seriously within the dominant discussion of trying to unpack what, exactly, UAP may be. One reason for this is that experiencer testimony strays considerably far from what our dominant ontologies and scientific theories tell us is possible from a physical standpoint. Taking experiencer testimony seriously may require a radical reconfiguration of our key distinctions and shared assumptions about reality that make intersubjective experience possible—as Edmund Husserl called it, our lifeworld. The lifeworld is our world of everyday experience—the shared, meaningful world of colors, sounds, shapes, and smells, as it is lived and encountered.⁶ However, any serious discussion of UAP that truly reaches into the complexity of this mystery must put the lived experiences of those who have been most directly affected by UAP and their alleged occupants front and center. My research on the narratives of those who report close encounter experiences has led me to the conclusion that UFOs/UAP manifest both as technological objects as well as *profound lived experiences* that subvert and transform the lives of those who confront them—or perhaps, are *confronted by them*.

⁵ Indigenous American tribes, for example, report a long history of contact with Star People or Sky People as a normal part of life. See Nancy Red Star, *Star Ancestors: Extraterrestrial Contact in Native American Traditions* (Rochester, VT: Bear and Company Publishers, 2012) and Ardy Sixkiller Clarke, *Encounters with Star People: Untold Stories of American Indians* (San Antonio, TX: Anomalist Books, 2012).

⁶ Edmund Husserl, *The Crisis of the European Sciences and Transcendental Phenomenology: An Introduction to Phenomenological Philosophy*, trans. David Carr (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1970), 107-111.

Indeed, I believe a robust investigation into what I will call the *contact phenomenon*, which includes encounters with UAP, the entities that allegedly occupy or are associated with them, and other anomalous experiences surrounding the encounters, reveals it as a subversive and transformative phenomenon. Across testimonies, contact repeatedly initiates the destabilization in subject, especially of taken-for-granted distinctions—the marked states through which we ordinarily organize reality. This includes the most foundational distinction we have drawn between what is “me” and “not-me,” between self and other, between subject and object.⁷ It includes boundaries between the physical and non-physical realms, between the corporeal and incorporeal, between matter and consciousness. It includes delineations between humans and Earth, between humans and non-human animals, and between humans and all other living things. It includes distinctions between the past, present, and future. Last, it includes borders between spirituality and science, and between the living and the dead. Contact experiences do not represent simply a collection of anomalous perceptions. Rather, they are revealed as subversive lived events that reconfigure the structures of subjectivity itself—reshaping how individuals experience their identity, relationships, and ethical values.

One of the most defining and puzzling aspects of these experiences is that they appear to call into question current scientific understandings of the universe, as well as many established distinctions regarding what is or is not possible. The academic researcher is often left puzzled with what to do with reports of contact. On the one hand, the easiest (and most common) route is to dismiss them as pathological, delusional, or hoaxes. On the other hand, experiencers sincerely avow their experiences, share them carefully and authentically, and are often involved in a quiet, deeply introspective process of sense-making. Additionally, substantial similarities between accounts of contact emerge, as well as reports of multi-witnessed experience that bring the encounters out of the realm of the private or subjective and into the realm of the intersubjectively shared. These realities make immediate dismissal intellectually dishonest and instead demand a more serious methodological response. What are we to do with experiences that are reported with sincerity and collective witnessing, yet remain resistant to conventional explanatory frameworks? Ignoring them, while it has worked as a strategy for preserving the boundaries of our marked states, is not intellectually honest. How do we begin to sort through them in a way that is both critical and meaningful?

⁷As Jeffrey J. Kripal writes, “[T]he impossible emerges from a knowing place before and beyond the subject/object split,” in *How to Think Impossibly: About Souls, UFOs, Time, Belief, and Everything Else* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2024), p. 8.

Belief vs. Participation

Experiencer testimony is often approached through the lens of whether or not we should *believe* it. In other words, the question is posed: “Do we have any reason to believe experiencer claims?” Such a starting point may already be asking the wrong question. Belief has a very specific phenomenological structure: to believe is to take a stance toward a claim as a proposition whose truth value must be affirmed or denied. Whether or not one “believes” experiencer claims thus treats these experiences as if they were primarily propositional in nature—like a set of statements we are evaluating. What if, instead of belief, contact is asking for participation? Participation does not ask, “What should I think is true?” but rather, “What does this encounter demand of me—of us?” How might our investigations change if we stopped approaching experiencer testimony from the standpoint of belief and instead stepped into the role of participant?

Such a shift would fundamentally reorient how experiencer testimony is approached, evaluated, and situated within our frameworks for producing knowledge. If contact is understood as participatory rather than merely propositional, then the task of investigation is no longer limited to adjudicating truth claims from a distance, or sorting through whether a particular narrative “really occurred” exactly as described. Instead, it becomes a matter of attending to patterns of transformation, meaning-making, ethical reasoning, and altered relationality that unfold during and after the experience. The task moves from verification to responsiveness: instead of hyper focusing on whether an experience corresponds to an external reality, we shift to exploring how it reorganizes subjectivity, relationships, and world-orientation. Methodologically, this invites approaches that consider full narratives and include experiencer meaning-making, rather than treating experiencer accounts as isolated data points to be confirmed or dismissed. To investigate contact as participatory is thus to recognize it as an event that implicates the investigator as well as the witness, requiring methodologies capable of remaining open to ontological ambiguity, and tracing transformation through multiple layers simultaneously.

This does *not mean* I do not believe that experiencer accounts correspond to an external reality—quite to the contrary, I think these accounts are worth exploring precisely *because* they are describing contact with an unknown Other. I am stating, rather, that far too much emphasis has been put on adjudicating whether or not we should *believe* what experiencers report, while far too little has been placed on asking the question of how contact calls us into forms of participation and responsibility. We should rather begin here: given the experiences and changes that contact experiencers report, what does this ask of us? How are we being called not to affirm or deny a story, but to show up differently in our ways of thinking, knowing, relating, and being?

The Harm of Partial Witnessing

Contact experiences present themselves in ways that exceed, disrupt, and subvert our traditional categories and delineations. The key challenge becomes honoring the integrity of lived experience without reducing it. Too often these encounters are dismissed off-hand as “impossible,” *or* only considered if they support researchers' chosen hypotheses surrounding what UAP are and who is behind them—most often, the extraterrestrial hypothesis.

This means that contact narratives have been engaged, but often in ways that amount to limited or partial witnessing. In other words, the experiences of human beings are taken as “data points,” as phenomena to be explained, often through traditional reductive frameworks of pathology, or as support for the researcher's belief that UAP are extraterrestrial spacecraft. Experiences are over-scrutinized, small errors or inconsistencies in memory are overblown or used as reasons to dismiss the witness entirely, or the accounts are selectively examined for elements that support the idea that UAP are piloted by extraterrestrial visitors (or the author's chosen hypothesis for the entities' origins). Often the most profound and influential aspects of their experiences— not just what they remember occurring but the transformation of key aspects of their subjectivity and meaning-making in the aftermath— are ignored, reduced, or intellectualized as “interesting” – but not of ultimate importance in the UAP conversation or of any real existential import. Thus, efforts to include UAP witness reports often result, at best, in a form of *partial witnessing* in which the individual experiencer may feel a substantial gap in what they are trying to communicate about their experience and what it has meant for their life, and in what the listener is willing to truly hear and understand.

Often experiencers emerge from their experiences with new ethical and philosophical insights, or even the receipt of new of scientific information, but these convictions are at best, acknowledged as “data” and not interpreted as clues about UAP or as suggesting anything regarding avenues of exploration for the nature of reality itself. Anyone who has had a moment of getting hopeful that someone you disclose something of crucial importance to will fully hear and see its meaning, only to instead receive distorted, partial witnessing that does not truly represent the integrity or depth of what you are trying to convey knows that being artificially seen can feel worse than not being seen at all. Partial witnessing is a form of epistemic and ontological harm— the audience “listens” but does not actually enter the experiencers' world of meaning-making nor see it as truly relevant nor important.

The key question becomes: how do we witness experiencers in ways that preserve their sovereignty and do overwrite their subjectivity? How do we see without distorting, without stealing the meaning of their experience, and without reducing what is expressed to a framework that is comfortable to our filters of

possibility? To truly see and witness experiencers is to step into the role of participant rather than believer. It requires a) listening and reconstructing what appeared to them in their encounters, as they lived it, to the best they can recall it through memory, b) fully acknowledging and hearing their interpretations and sense-making processes as they unfold in the aftermath of the encounter, and c) being open to what such experiences *ask of us*—being willing to philosophically and scientifically explore the potential *implications* and *applications* of the insights they gain through the contact experience. This does not mean that every interpretation or claim from an experiencer is taken as definitive or final truth; rather, that their lived accounts and meaning-making processes are heard, respected, and acknowledged as true generative insights — provisional hypotheses that may illuminate the nature of UAP phenomena, the intelligences involved, the broader reality in which they occur, and what this ultimately means for humanity.

A Phenomenology of the (UFO) Phenomenon

The call to participation and demand for a fuller, ethical witnessing of experiencers brings us in proximity to the discipline known as phenomenology. Phenomenology as a philosophical method centers the lived experience of the individual as the primary site of knowledge. Founder of phenomenology Edmund Husserl emphasized that reality is disclosed through its appearance to us as subjects, and that these appearances, while partial and not fully complete, do reveal essential structures of being. In other words, our first-person observations of the world—what we see, hear, smell, taste, touch, and process through the categories of our understanding—reveal fundamental truths about how things *are*. By suspending the assumptions of everyday life—the “natural attitude”—we can attend to how experiences show themselves on their own terms, examining how they manifest and the modalities through which they are apprehended. This process, known as transcendental reduction, allows us to bracket presuppositions and focus on what is present for consciousness. Importantly, when we employ a phenomenological approach, we begin by suspending our assumptions about what is or is not “real” — the aim is not to determine the ultimate ontology or identity of what appears, but to understand how it is lived, apprehended, and made sense of. This allows us to take experiences seriously without prematurely slotting them into categories of “real” or “unreal.”⁸

Through uncovering the core structures of contact as a lived experience, we surface how it serves as a form of experience that destabilizes even the most fundamental distinctions we make between subject and object. Contact as a lived experience represents an encounter with something radically unfamiliar, something

⁸ Edmund Husserl, *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and Phenomenological Philosophy Vol. 1*, trans. Frederick Kersten (Boston: Martinus Nijhoff Publishing, 1983), 61-65.

alien, something *Other*. Confronted with the face of an alien Other who is not supposed to exist, and experiences that are not supposed to be able to happen, individuals' foundational understandings of self, other, and world are forcibly dislodged and reconfigured. By using a phenomenological methodology to describe what appears, we respect the integrity of extraordinary lived experience without reducing it to our familiar categories, nor by making definitive declarations regarding the source of what the experience is.

While classical descriptive phenomenology introduced by Husserl provides an essential starting point for this study—allowing contact events to be carefully examined as they appear in lived experience—it is not, on its own, sufficient for the scope of questions this project raises. Descriptive analysis can clarify what is remembered as given to consciousness at the moment of encounter, but it cannot adequately account for how such encounters unfold across time, reorganize structures of subjectivity, or generate enduring transformations in sense of self, world, and values. In other words, it cannot fully see and witness the experiencers' interpretative process and what the contact experience means for them or the potential implications of their insights. Additionally, when we examine accounts of contact, we are not dealing with human experiences that anyone can relate to (like boredom or nostalgia), but with *recalled memories of extraordinary, seemingly impossible events* as they are remembered and interpreted by the individuals who recount them.

For this reason, the project necessarily moves beyond static description of the original encounter into *generative* and *interpretative* phenomenology. Generative phenomenology studies processes of becoming, how experiences structure the very conditions through which meaning arises, through which one becomes a subject who has perceptions that they describe and interpret.⁹ Interpretative phenomenology moves beyond the question of the structure of conscious experience and asks how individuals understand and make meaning of their experiences within their conception of the lifeworld. Interpretive phenomenology recognizes not only that experiencers interpret what appears through their own frameworks of meaning, but also that any researcher brings their own lenses of interpretation into a co-creative process of sense-making.¹⁰

Thus, what emerges in the chapters to come are not just neutral descriptions of conscious structures, but explorations in how contact events provide new parameters through which subjectivity emerges, and how individuals engage those

⁹ The foundations of generative phenomenology are found in the writings of Husserl himself. See Anthony J. Steinbock, "Generativity and the Scope of Generative Phenomenology," in *The New Husserl: A Critical Reader*, ed. Donna Welton (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2003), 287-324.

¹⁰ Virginia Eatough and Jonathan Smith, "Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis" in *The Sage Handbook of Qualitative Research in Psychology*, ed. Carla Willig and Wendy Stainton Rogers (SAGE Publications, 2017): 193-209.

experiences through their own hermeneutical processes: cultural, spiritual, and ethical frameworks. Additionally, I work with the retrospective accounts to identify key themes and moments of meaning-making, exploring the philosophical implications of the experiences, doing my best to fully witness and hear what experiencers authentically convey. Only this expanded phenomenological approach makes it possible to examine contact not merely as “data points” or interesting anomalies, but to step into the experiencers’ lived world and bear meaningful witness to their encounters and insights. It is not presented as an invitation to believe, but rather an opportunity to participate in the destabilizing and transformative nature of contact. While the reader must decide whether or not this is successful as a form of full witnessing, it is rooted, at the very least, in a distinct *resistance to partial witnessing*.

Phenomenology has too often failed to live up to Husserl’s radical goals, often limiting itself to exploring those experiences which are coherent within current scientific understandings. A good example of these limitations are found in the recent volume *A Phenomenology of the Alien*, which does mention contact experiences, but ultimately dismisses them as psychotic episodes and psychosocial manifestations.¹¹ Such reductions, while perhaps understandable in contemporary academic environments, are ultimately forms of partial, distorted witnessing that ultimately do more harm than just ignoring experiencer testimony altogether. They do not remain true to transcendental reduction, nor do they honor the integrity of lived accounts from individuals who are genuine, authentic, and importantly *recognize* the apparent impossibility of what they report. Further, such approaches perpetuate epistemic harms against experiencers, who are not treated as credible reporters of their own experiences, and often face stigma, shame, self-doubt, and pathologization alongside the potential trauma and perplexity of the original experience.

This book thus takes a different starting point. It starts with the question: what would it *look like* to treat reports of contact as sincere accounts of lived experience? What would it *look like* to step, even inadequately, into processes of fuller, more holistic witnessing? Partial witnessing—being “almost seen,” “almost believed,” or “almost understood”—enacts a subtler form of ontological harm than outright dismissal, because it invites vulnerability without providing the relational ground that can hold it. The illusion of being seen can feel intimate until the moment one reaches for real attunement and finds only surface-level responsiveness in return. In contrast, to encounter someone who genuinely sees and amplifies you, rather than contracting your depth reveals the ethical horizon of what phenomenological research must strive to embody.

Based on a 2023 IRB approved phenomenological study with 15

¹¹ Aaron Daniels, ed., *A Phenomenology of the Alien: Encounters with the Weird and Inscrutable Other* (London: Routledge, 2025).

experiencers who self-report a contact encounter, I begin by suspending judgment on whether or not what they report is “real” and instead explore the structures of how the experience appears, how the experiences generate new possibilities for becoming a subject, and how they open up processes of meaning-making that reconfigure the boundaries of subjectivity. These experiences are existentially and ontologically disruptive— they challenge individuals' fundamental assumptions about reality and what can and cannot happen in it. In placing “reality” itself into question, it also places their understanding of who they are and how they relate to others in question as well. Suspending judgment on what is behind contact encounters and examining how they appear, are lived, and organized in a subject's understanding reveals crucial insights about the lived experience of contact and how humans confront and interact with UAP and the intelligences assumed to be associated with them. It also reveals just how much is truly at stake if the experiences reported by these individuals indeed turn out to be true. If, between this writing and your reading, there is additional information revealed that corroborates these accounts, their testimony serves as lived evidence that UAP are about far more than potential advanced non-human technologies. They fundamentally change what it means to exist as a human being.

The Existential Stakes of Contact

The perplexing nature of Deidre's experienced intrusion into her home, as well as her complex sense-making process in the aftermath, foreshadows the existential stakes of contact. In contact experiences, UAP and the mysterious beings sighted in association with them appear as intertwined with profound existential implications. The phenomenological structure of contact events sheds light on how consciousness fundamentally reorganizes itself around that which disrupts, that which is unexpected. In encountering and being touched by something truly foreign, something that is *alien* to the individual's sense of world, processes of meaning-making, valuation, and relationality are ruptured and forcibly reconceived. The individual as subject must explore what it means to be a self in a world in which the boundaries of possibility and impossibility have been blurred and subverted. The question is not what they will believe, but how they will participate. This involves not just asking “What is the world now, that this has occurred?” but also “What becomes of me, in light of it?”

But the reorganization does not end there. Contact events are so radically destabilizing because they involve, at their core, ostensible communication with an *unknown, radical Other*. Following Sartre, the presence of the Other automatically introduces a new field of possibilities into our sphere of awareness-- I recognize my environment not just as there for me, but for others as well. I recognize the world

that we occupy as intersubjectively shared, that sense-making and interpretation of my world is a fundamentally collective enterprise. Additionally, I realize myself as being present for and seen by the Other and that their perception of me is not in my control.¹² Thus being in the presence of others is always a different experience than when I am alone. Contact raises the stakes of intersubjective encounter. The Other encountered is not just another human consciousness that escapes my ability to contain it or grasp it fully, but a mysterious perspective and gaze that remains truly unknown in its form, presence, and intentions. Experiencers are confronted and directly called by something that is *radically Other*, something that does not present in traditional human ways, something that does not play by the rules of intersubjectivity as we've previously understood them. It is an Other that ostensibly can see without being seen, that appears and disappears into the lived world on its own terms, that appears positioned differently in time, and that appears both in physical reality as well as in subtle realms and altered states of consciousness. It is an Other that does not follow the rules of Otherness as we've previously encountered them.

What does one become in the aftermath of an encounter with that which is radically Other? Encounters with Others inevitably bring us to the domain of the *ethical* – questions of what the Other's presence demands of us, as ethical beings. A revised ethical orientation emerges out of the rupture and destabilization. The encounter with that which transcends all our familiar categories, all of our delineations regarding relationality and otherness, engenders a new *ethic* – one that is up to the task of proceeding without full knowledge, without clear distinctions, and welcomes that which appears on its own terms. In such an ethical orientation, the individual knows that welcoming the truly Other radically destabilizes the self; that they cannot proceed without becoming different themselves. They further realize the boundaries between self and Other do not fully hold, and that an encounter with Otherness is also an encounter with themselves. Out of the ashes, new forms of relationality emerge, often deeply attuned to interconnectivity with human and non-human life.

In the encounter with radical Otherness, experiencers also encounter new dimensions *of themselves*. The boundaries of their corporeal life are put in question; they encounter beings both in physical reality as well as in out-of-body experiences, dreams, and altered conscious states. The entities reportedly communicate telepathically, introducing the possibility of non-local consciousness. Transpersonal experiences as well as experiences of mind separating from the body engender the possibility that consciousness survives death. Strange psychic occurrences often accompany the experiences both while they happen and in the aftermath,

¹² Jean Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*, trans. Sarah Richmond (New York: Washington Square Press, 2018), 347-406.

reconfiguring everything they understood about consciousness and the powers of the human mind. Synchronicities, or profound correspondences between one's inner life and the external world often follow the events. In short, individuals' understanding of their own subjectivity is ruptured and reconfigured by contact encounters. Experiencers emerge with what I call a *multidimensional* understanding of subjectivity: a conception of self not limited to the body, to the present or linear time, to the current psychological identity or ego, or to physical reality itself. This transformed subjectivity is accompanied by profound changes in metaphysical beliefs and ethical values: essentially resulting in entirely new processes of sense-making, relating, and being in the world. Subjects emerge as transformed selves in transformed worlds—delineations previously employed to understand both themselves and the world they relate to are destabilized and rewritten. This includes conceptions of agency, autonomy, and moral decision-making, all of which must be reinscribed in a multidimensional plane.

In the discovery of something new, experiencers may simultaneously be coming into contact with something very old. Contact encounters, despite only recently emerging as a topic in academic discourse and in relation to the conversation surrounding potential extraterrestrial intelligence, have been reported for much longer than the 80 years that they've been present in mainstream US culture. Indigenous peoples around the world, including in North and South America, have long reported contact with "Sky People" "Star People" or "Star Ancestors." These intelligences are understood to be advanced beings from the sky, sometimes interpreted as literal ancestors to human tribes, other times considered advanced spiritual guides. Indigenous Tribes of North America, such as the Hopi, Sioux, or Dinè (Navajo) include the Star People as integral to their origin stories and connection to their tribal lands.¹³ Such cultures also begin from ontologies and conceptions of the lifeworld that accept the intelligence in all forms of non-human life, make regular use of altered states of consciousness, consider the natural world alive and personal, and see an interconnectivity between all things.¹⁴ Thus, to unpack the lived experience of contact and how it ruptures the individual's experience of the lifeworld, we must not limit ourselves to the hermeneutical resources of modern scientific culture. The ontologies and cosmologies of Indigenous peoples, as well as their own experiences of contact, are natural investigative allies in unpacking experiencer narratives. Their lived, experiential conceptions of personhood,

¹³ Ardy Sixkiller Clarke, *Encounters with Star People: Untold Stories of American Indians* (San Antonio, TX: Anomalist Books, 2012). John Mack explores contact experiences with three Indigenous medicine people in *Passport to the Cosmos: Alien Encounters and Human Transformation* (New York: Crown Publishers, 1999).

¹⁴ Wahinkpe Topa and Darcia Narvaez, *Restoring the Kinship Worldview: Indigenous Voices Introduce 28 Precepts for Rebalancing Life on Planet Earth* (Berkely: North Atlantic Books, 2022).

responsibility, and interdependence resonate with the transformed orientations reported by experiencers and situate contact experiences within a larger web of knowing the world through intimate kinship relations. I work with Indigenous ontologies as a parallel interpretative lens, not with the intention of homogenization, but rather to situate experiencer testimony within a wider circle of hermeneutical resources, with the aim of initiating a horizon-widening dialogue.

Thus, the moral, ontological, and existential stakes of contact could not be higher. Exploring contact narratives phenomenologically reveals how they present in lived experience as new possibilities for being a self, new cognitive framings for interpreting that which appears, new opportunities for relationality and connection with that which is Other than ourselves. Situating such experiences within more diverse cultural expressions by putting them in conversation with Indigenous American ways of understanding the world adds an important contextual lens that further reminds us of the limitations of threat narratives that frame contact as new, urgent, and primarily about advanced technologies.

Contact and Multidimensional Subjectivity: Methodology and Overview

This book employs a layered phenomenological method that is later placed in ongoing conversation with Indigenous American thought. Beginning with the question of what it looks like to treat accounts of contact as sincere memories of lived experience, the early chapters adopt a descriptive and generative phenomenology employing Edmund Husserl, Bernhard Waldenfels, Emmanuel Levinas, and Jean-Luc Marion. I attend closely to how contact events appear, how they address or claim the experiencer, and how they disrupt familiar horizons of meaning. I trace how this initial rupture reorganizes the structures of subjectivity—perception, embodiment, temporality, and self–other relations. In the middle chapters, I shift to an interpretive phenomenology, engaging experiencers’ sense of meaning-making and how a new worldview, ethical orientation, and attitude towards being gradually takes shape in the aftermath of the close encounter. I articulate how the ontological rupture and sense-making that follows gives rise to a transformed ethical orientation, showing how responsibility, openness, and responsiveness emerge as consequences of the phenomenality of the encounter. In the final chapters, I step out of the phenomenological attitude and ask what it would mean to approach the world—including our ethics and our epistemologies—through the multidimensional framework that is born from contact events. To make full use of available hermeneutical resources for articulating these shifts in worldview and relationality, the second half of the book also engages key Indigenous philosophers—Kyle Whyte, V.F. Cordova, Gerald Vizenor, and Daniel Wildcat—whose work illuminates the often marginalized epistemologies, ontologies, and

ethics of Indigenous American peoples anchored in kinship relations with land and non-human forms of life.

In Chapter One, I explore why experienter testimony has been so difficult to take seriously, even in the renewed age of interest in UAP. The chapter explores how much experienter testimony challenges the boundaries of naturalism and current scientific knowledge regarding what can and cannot happen in our world. As a result, I argue that experiencers suffer distinct forms of *epistemic injustice*, or harms in their capacity as knowers, as first defined by Miranda Fricker¹⁵ and expanded more contemporarily by Kristie Dotson¹⁶ and J.Y. Lee,¹⁷ among others. The very act of reporting a contact experience is used as justification for attributing credibility deficits to individuals reporting them. I overview my 2023 phenomenological study and suggest an ontologically open descriptive, generative, and interpretative phenomenological project could serve as a form of restorative hearing and fuller witnessing for experiencers, and thus a meaningful way to work with the testimony.

In Chapter Two, I present a descriptive and generative phenomenological analysis of abduction encounters in which the witness expresses confidence that aspects of the experience took place in physical reality and involved the abduction of their physical body. Using the phenomenological work of Maurice Merleau-Ponty,¹⁸ Drew Leder,¹⁹ and Bernhard Waldenfels²⁰ as a starting point, I explore the implications of considering abductions embodied and intercorporeal experiences. By emphasizing the distinctly intercorporeal nature of these encounters in terms of encountering a perceived, embodied intelligent non-human Other, I illustrate how the abduction encounter fundamentally challenges the traditional consensus regarding the boundaries of the body. Ultimately this culminates in a multidimensional understanding of corporeality, or a concept of the body that conceives it as *one* locus of conscious experience but ultimately embedded in a much wider and more malleable experiential field.

In Chapter Three, I explore the distinct *liminality* of the Other encountered, with a focus on experiences that cross the thresholds of physical and non-physical, material reality and dream states. In the encounters explored, the entities blur the

¹⁵ Miranda Fricker, *Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing* (Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2007).

¹⁶ Kristie Dotson, "Tracking Epistemic Violence, Tracking Practices of Silencing," *Hypatia* 26.2 (2011): 236-257.

¹⁷ J.Y. Lee, "Anticipatory Epistemic Injustice," *Social Epistemology* 35.6 (2021): 564-576.

¹⁸ Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, trans. Donald A. Landes (New York: Routledge, 2012).

¹⁹ Drew Leder, *The Absent Body* (Chicago: Chicago University Press, 1990).

²⁰ Bernhard Waldenfels, *A Phenomenology of the Alien: Basic Concepts*, trans. Alexander Kozin and Tanja Stähler (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 2011).

distinctions between embodiment and incorporeality, often remaining hidden from the visual field. I show that while the presence of ostensibly material UFO/UAP and intersubjectively witnessed events ground the experiences with the entities partially in physical reality, the entities simultaneously appear to take on ethereal and psychical qualities, mediating the space between physical reality and non-ordinary realms. I then explore how these experiences unfold as intersubjective processes with a liminal Other. Is the liminal Other a threat or a mysterious call of Otherness that demands a response? Perhaps it is both or something in between? I use the work of Waldenfels, Emmanuel Levinas,²¹ and Jacques Derrida²² to explore how the liminal Other calls and evokes a sense of connection, communication, and ethicality from beyond the edges of scientific consensus reality. Fundamentally, it offers the possibility of restructuring our defining categories for what an Other can be and what it looks like to welcome that which is radically Other into our experience.

In Chapter Four, I examine contact experiences that take on a more spiritual or numinous nature, even though they may also include corporeal or liminal aspects. In these experiences, the contact event serves as a vehicle for the experiencers to encounter the transcendent aspects of themselves, leading to an expanded understanding of the boundaries and capacities of human consciousness, specifically as it relates to and is situated within time. I begin by exploring Jean-Luc Marion's idea of beginning phenomenological inquiry with givenness, considering the "I" as constituted by what appears. I then explore his concept of *saturated phenomena*, or those appearances that overwhelm the human categories of rationality, containing more in how they give themselves that can be put into human concepts.²³ By exploring the subject as one who receives rather than constitutes, or one who is *gifted* by the saturated phenomena of contact, I illustrate how a new, extratemporal conception of the "I" emerges as an accumulation of the gifts.

In Chapter Five, I shift into an interpretive phenomenological framework, exploring experiencers' processes of sense-making, with a focus on the changes in ethical orientation reported by experiencers as a result of their contact experiences. I show that the ethical attitudes that emerge from contact deviate significantly from the threat narratives surrounding UAP, and have more in common with what Indigenous American scholar and philosopher (Citizen Potawatomi Nation) Kyle Whyte calls epistemologies of coordination.²⁴ Epistemologies of coordination come

²¹ Emmanuel Levinas, *Totality and Infinity: An Essay on Exteriority*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Pittsburg: Duquesne University Press, 1969).

²² Jacques Derrida, *Of Hospitality*, trans. Rachel Bowlby (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2000).

²³ Jean-Luc Marion, *Being Given*, trans. Jeffrey L. Kosky (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2002), 199.

²⁴ Kyle Whyte, "Against Crisis Epistemology," in *Handbook of Critical Indigenous Studies*, ed. Aileen Moreton-Robinson, Linda Tuhiwai Smith, Chris Andersen, and Steve Larkin (New York: Routledge,

to know the world through kinship relations that evolve and persist through time, rather than trying to defend our modern ways of being from imminent crisis. Drawing on James Madden's²⁵ interpretation of Martin Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology,"²⁶ I suggest that contact experiences emerge from beyond the parameters of the human cognitive framing of reality, what Madden calls the human "Umwelt." To hear the call of contact experiences is to take a new attitude towards being, one that is far removed from our modern technological ways of relating that are focused on extraction, control, and domination of the natural world. The transformed worldviews expressed by experiencers are not rooted in a sense of crisis or fear, but in grounded interconnectedness, kinship, and holistic relationality²⁷

In Chapter Six, I consolidate the identified themes of ethical meaning-making in experiencer testimony into a coherent ethical framework and place them in conversation with the western philosophical discussions of ethics as well as the ethics of Jicarilla Apache philosopher VF Cordova.²⁸ I begin by tracing the basic tenets of utilitarianism, deontology, virtue theory, and care ethics, showing that all of these theories rely on a clearly delineated sense of self and clear self/other distinctions. I show that the multidimensional ethic that emerges from witnesses' sense-making transcends the western focus on agency, autonomy, and individualism, as well as the distinctions between stranger and relative. At its most transcendent level, it challenges the boundaries between self and Other. Ultimately, I show that the multidimensional ethic involves formulating ethical judgments on multiple planes or dimensions, often simultaneously. Additionally, there is a shift to thinking in terms of "we" instead of thinking in terms of "I," reflecting connections with the ethical thinking of the Jicarilla Apache and other Indigenous American tribes, as articulated by Cordova.

In Chapter Seven, I distinctly pivot out of the phenomenological attitude to asking what it would look like to approach the world and our ethical evaluations through the multidimensional ethical reasoning introduced by experiencers. This shows the usefulness of their meaning-making and the potential implications of taking contact seriously. Specifically, I use the ethical frameworks and insights from derived from experiencer testimony to evaluate the behavior of the alleged non-human intelligences (NHI) involved in contact events. I explore how approaching

2021), 52-64.

²⁵ James Madden, *Unidentified Flying Hyperobject: UFOs, Technology, and the End of the World* (Ontocalypse Press, 2023).

²⁶ Martin Heidegger, "The Question Concerning Technology" in *The Question Concerning Technology and Other Essays*, trans. William Levitt (New York: Harper, 1977), 3-35.

²⁷ Kripal, *How to Think Impossibly*

²⁸ VF Cordova, "Ethics: The We and the I," in *American Indian Thought*, ed. Anne Waters (Malden, MA: Blackwell Publishing, 2004), 173-181.

the alleged NHI behavior from a multidimensional lens acknowledges the felt epistemic gaps between experiencers and the entities. Additionally, such an analysis interprets the possible motives and effects of contact as expanding through a wider, multidimensional reality that exceeds the spatiotemporal horizon and corporeal embodiment. Continuing to make use of hermeneutical resources offered by Indigenous American traditions, I employ the work of Anishinaabe (White Earth Nation) scholar Gerald Vizenor to illustrate parallels with the trickster figure or archetype common in tribal narratives and cultures. This considers the entities' behavior in a more holistic, nuanced way that goes beyond traditional dualistic ethical framings.²⁹

In the final chapter, I close with a discussion of how we can cultivate ourselves as multidimensional knowers in relation to a multidimensional world—making the shift from believers to participants. This further expands on the question of what it truly means to treat these experiences as genuine accounts, rather than pathologies or aberrations. I begin with the assertion that multidimensional knowing requires moving beyond the science versus religion binary. I show that any attempt to know UAP and contact experiences as purely scientific or purely religious phenomena excludes too much from consideration. This once again brings us into proximity with Indigenous American epistemologies, such as the work of Muscogee Nation (Creek) scholar Daniel Wildcat, who argues that for many Indigenous American tribes, to know the world is to know it in inherently spiritual ways.³⁰ Such a project also requires cultivating a different type of self, one not held to an ideal of objectivity which removes all traces of the subjectivity of the knower. I ultimately argue that the contact phenomenon invites us to center the realm of the intersubjective—in all its variations—rather than the objective. But even our understanding of the intersubjective must evolve from its origins in phenomenology, for many aspects of contact events are experienced differently by different witnesses. Building on the work of both John E. Mack³¹ and Jeffrey J. Kripal,³² I propose a foundation for multidimensional, intersubjective, participatory knowing that incorporates shared meaning-making across divergent perceptions of contact events, as well as alternative knowledge practices, altered states of consciousness, synchronicity, and dialogue with potential non-human intelligence.

²⁹ Gerald Vizenor, *Manifest Manners: Narratives on Post-Indian Survivance* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1994).

³⁰ Daniel Wildcat, "The Schizophrenic Nature of Western Metaphysics," in Daniel Wildcat and Vine Deloria, *Power and Place Equals Personality: Indian Education in America* (Golden, CO: Fulcrum Books, 2001).

³¹ John E. Mack, *Abduction: Human Encounters with Aliens* (New York: Scribner and Sons, 1994).

³² Kripal, *How to Think Impossibly*

To conclude, I explore how taking experiencer testimony and meaning-making seriously offers an alternative to the threat and panic narratives of disclosure that frame UAP as *new* and *unprecedented*. Instead, I argue we should consider UAP as part of an ongoing participatory conversation between humanity and an unknown Other. This participatory conversation opens those who experience contact to a sense of multidimensional subjectivity and a corresponding multidimensional ethic. A full witnessing of experiencer testimony suggests UAP are not national security threats to be urgently defended against, but invitations to come to know the world differently, to bring a different ethical orientation to our relations with each other and to non-human life. I suggest we take seriously the possibilities that organically emerge for us as a species when we take kinship and relationality as our starting points and make full use of available hermeneutical resources, such as but not limited to, Indigenous American tribal wisdom. Seen in this light, there emerges a blueprint for a more holistic, reflective form of disclosure in which we see UAP not as technological threats to be shot down, but as catalysts for exposing the cracks in our current ways of knowing, being, and relating— and the opportunity to recreate them otherwise.

Chapter 1: Taking Experiencers Seriously: Epistemic Injustice and a Restorative Phenomenology

“At the end, she just makes it all about sex with aliens and ‘he’s clearly fucking crazy.’ Was I traumatized by how people treated me or reacted to me? Yes. That was probably even more disheartening than the experiences themselves.”-Parker

“To understand the world ‘as it is’ relies upon the presumption that the world is in a particular way and only that way.” - Jonathan Tuckett

“It is very easy to explain all of reality if you get to define what that ‘all’ is. It is very easy to explain everything on the table when you have just taken off the table everything that you cannot explain.”-Jeffrey J. Kripal

Introduction:

I began to have a sexual dream with me and my ex from 20 years ago...The dream seemed so real, as though I was actually feeling the things that were happening in the dream. I opened my eyes as I started to regain consciousness. I could see that there was a female on top of me. I was back in my room out of the dream. This female had blue skin. I could see her legs were straddling me. My hands were on her legs and I could feel her skin. It was not like human skin. It was clearly thicker and felt tighter than ours...As I scanned up toward her face it was a blur, although much clearer than before. It was obvious that she did not want me to see her face. I could only see the outline of her face and a very large black mass around her head. At one point, I felt her breath on my face. I remember thinking that I couldn't believe this was happening. I knew even in this state what she was. I knew she was not human. I knew there must have been some craft parked in the back yard...The next thing I remember was waking up the next morning...I was confused. I was angry. Most of all I was terrified. I was basically raped and there was nothing I could do about it. I had zero recourse. It was sinking in that there was absolutely nothing anyone could do about this...I began to unwrap this experience in my mind. How would this being have known about an ex I had 20 years ago? Why was there a complete disregard for me? What does this mean for humanity?³³

³³ Matthew Roberts, *Initiated: UAP, Dreams, Depression, Delusions, Shadow People, Psychosis, Sleep Paralysis and Pandemics* (Self-published, 2020), 83-84.

In this passage from his self-published book *Initiated*, former naval cryptologist Matthew Roberts describes his first direct contact experience with what he perceived to be a non-human entity, following his presence on the U.S.S. Theodore Roosevelt during the filming of the famous “Gimball Footage.”³⁴ Unbeknownst to him at the time, Matthew’s experience reflected several important characteristics and reactions that experiencers repeatedly describe. The encounter takes place partially when he is dreaming and partially when he is awake, yet he is confident it cannot all be reduced to a dream. He remembers physical sensations: the feeling of the entity’s skin, her breath on his face, a visceral sense of physical violation the next day. His attempt to comprehend the entity visually is distorted or denied, as she has a strange black mass around her face. The experience is explicitly sexual, beginning with a dream about an ex and transitioning to a sexual encounter he is confident occurred. The figure on top of him appears liminal—human-like in posture and movement, even clothed—yet marked by subtle but unmistakable indicators of Otherness: thicker blue skin, a blurred face, a refusal to be seen. He reports a strong inner knowing that she is not human, reasoning there may be a craft parked nearby. He wakes up hours later violated and terrified, and importantly, aware that there is absolutely nowhere for him to go for recourse. He *understands the impossibility* of his experience, and yet, he is confident that it occurred. Even in this immediate aftermath characterized by trauma and rupture he is curious about the experience and what it means not only for him but humanity as a whole. His experience straddles the boundaries of states of awareness, human and non-human, possibility and impossibility. His only firm conviction at the moment is that *it is*.

Many scholars, philosophers, or critically inclined readers may not know exactly what to do with Matthew’s account. Most commonly, it will be explained away as “sleep paralysis” or more pejoratively dismissed as a vivid “wet dream.” Not only will the original trauma and violation he experienced be minimized, it will not even be entertained as a possibility that he came into contact with a genuine embodied Otherness. The profound restructuring of self and world that follows—one of the most important phenomenological aspects of contact—is rarely considered or seen as relevant. Connections between his experience and the technological objects observed by pilots in the Roosevelt encounters remain unexplored. Crucially, Matthew’s experience does not end with the event itself. In the months and years that follow, he enters a sustained process of meaning-making and integration that yields an entirely new understanding of consciousness, agency, human existence, and the universe itself. His book is titled *Initiated* because the

³⁴ See 8News Now—Las Vegas, “Unedited Navy Gimbal video.mp4,” YouTube, *Unedited Navy Gimbal video.mp4*, published April 27, 2020, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QKHg-vnTFsM>, accessed 12/16/2025.

contact event functions as an initiation—an encounter that permanently dislodges the boundaries of his previous worldview and orients him toward a multidimensional understanding of reality. If his sense-making process and worldview transformation are engaged at all by researchers, they will be simply noted as data points, an individual doing his best to make sense of strange and anomalous happenings, not treated as providing genuine clues or insights into UAP, the contact experience, or the universe as a whole.

This is, then, the most common situation of a contact experiencer. Something occurs that defies the understood boundaries of consensus reality and dominant understandings of what can and cannot occur in the world. The experience is simultaneously traumatic and transformative, completely restructuring the individual's sense of self and other, as well as their understanding of reality and what can and cannot happen in it. The encounter is accompanied by a strong sense of mission, and metaphysical, scientific, and ethical knowledge is often received through non-traditional means. Experiencers often report that the knowledge gained feels urgent for humanity's relational, ecological, or moral evolution. And yet, there are few if any places where their experiences will be engaged seriously and meaningfully as genuine sources of insight or serious descriptions of events we should take seriously and learn from.

Matthew, like many experiencers, will find that most audiences are not in position to fully hear or witness the complexity of his encounter or how it has shaped his understanding of the lived world in the aftermath. At best, he will encounter many forms of distorted, partial witnessing: for example, a person listening and validating that he is describing it as he remembers, but insisting it must have been a vivid dream that he mistook for reality. Others may trivialize the narrative under reductive “sex with aliens” caricatures, either with prurient amusement or as grounds to dismiss his credibility. Some firm proponents of the extraterrestrial hypothesis may one-dimensionally interpret his experience as evidence of an alien invasion. The deeper insights regarding how the experience changed him and the knowledge he gained from it will be mostly overlooked, ignored, or explained away.

Matthew, then, finds himself in the company of thousands of other experiencers who have been confronted by the essence of the impossible, emerged not only intact but transformed and confident something important has been revealed, yet will be met with no socially recognized venues that can fully witness and contain the depth of what has been experienced. I cannot claim that the first time I read an experiencer account that I did not read it with similar reactions and biases to those I have identified here. It was engaging with many written accounts over time, and more importantly, getting to know experiencers through interviews, field work, and immersion in the experiencer community, that I became convinced

of the importance of truly hearing and centering their testimony. Not because any individual experiencer has “the answer” but because contact reveals itself most richly, substantially, and consequentially through the consciousness of the witness. Contact is not a “symbolic puzzle” to be solved, but an intricate lived reality for thousands of people, and our frameworks for engaging this reality have been, on the whole, woefully insufficient.

My 2023 Experiencer Phenomenological Study

Given this bind that experiencers face, I set off on an exploration of accounts of contact that would resist partial witnessing and step more fully into engaging the complexities of experiencer testimony. With approval of Molloy University’s IRB, and with recruitment assistance from the John Mack Institute (where I did not yet hold the official position I hold now as Research Director) I conducted a phenomenological study of the lived experience of 15 individuals who reported their own contact experiences, which I called “The Experiencer Worldview Study.” Phenomenological research, as a form of qualitative research, generally works with a small sample size: the goal is not to establish statistics or collect “data” in a conventional scientific sense, but to unpack the form, structure, and meaning of lived experience.

The participants were interviewed over the course of 2-5 hours, questioned not only about their initial or most formative encounter, but how those experiences had shaped their beliefs, values, and worldview in the aftermath. All names have been changed to protect the identities of the participants. While some of these individuals may choose to speak publicly about their experiences and are free to do so in other public contexts, for the purposes of this book and study their stories are anonymized. All participants signed written consent forms outlining the terms of their participation and ensuring confidentiality. The gender makeup was eight male, six female, and one who described themselves as not conforming to the gender binary. The majority of the participants were from the United States, and discussed their experiences within the context of US cultural narratives surrounding UAP. The two exceptions were Yosef, who lives in the Middle East, and Eric, who lives in Europe. Jeanette self-identifies as having Choctaw ancestry and considers this integral to her interpretation of her experience.

Participants were not asked directly about their employment but many offered it voluntarily throughout the interviews. Rachel and Deidre have built careers as reiki healers, Marin currently works as a librarian, Justin as a musician, Thomas works as a therapist, Parker works as an acupuncturist and energy healer, Jeanette is retired but had a long career working in political campaigns and offices, Derrick teaches online and hosts his own podcast, Linda works in human resources,

Catherine is a director of a non-profit organization, and Andrew works in direct support in human services.

There was a wide range in time periods in terms of when participants reported having their initial or most formative contact encounter. Some participants reported experiences beginning when they were children all the way back in the 1960s, with the bulk of the abduction-like encounters reportedly occurring in the 1980s and 1990s. Three experiencers, Linda, Justin, and James, reported much more recent initial encounters within the past two years. The encounters themselves varied in quality, content, and modality of contact. Five—Jeanette, Parker, Catherine, Sarah and Rachel reported ‘abduction’ style encounters where they perceived themselves being non-consensually taken into a craft or foreign environment and medically experimented on. Another five—Yosef, Marin, Eric, Deidre, and Andrew—reported what I describe as “liminal” encounters. Their accounts did not involve alleged capture or transport of the body into a craft, but described encounters with a blend of physical and non-physical elements, with entities that appear both in the physical world and in dream, out of body, and threshold states. The last five—Derrick, James, Justin, Thomas, and Linda—described experiences of a more psychical, spiritual or numinous nature, even though they may also include corporeal, liminal, and intersubjective aspects.

Participants were asked, to the best of their ability, to focus on the most formative contact encounters, with an emphasis on what appeared and how they remembered living it. Additionally, I asked targeted questions regarding if, or how, the experience had influenced their beliefs, values, and worldviews, on issues ranging from spirituality, key metaphysical beliefs, ethical and relational values, and socio-political orientation. The goal was to step into a form of fuller or more holistic witnessing— to understand and center not only what they remembered occurring, but also what the experience had *meant for them*, and what they believe the experiences mean for humanity as a whole. I aimed, in short, to take experiencers seriously. Why has this been so difficult to do, especially in academic contexts?

The Difficulty of Hearing Experiencer Testimony:

In his work *Phenomenology of the Alien*, Bernhard Waldenfels comments,

It may be assumed that every epoch (more specifically: every culture, society, environment, or form of life) behaves within certain boundaries, but that the relation to the boundaries, which is always accompanied by a certain politics, is subject to significant variations. The ways one handles boundaries serve as a clear indication of the underlying spirit of an epoch.³⁵

³⁵ Bernhard Waldenfels, *A Phenomenology of the Alien: Basic Concepts*, trans. Alexander Kozin and Tanja Stähler (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 2011), 9.

In other words, each historical and contemporary culture or society draws its distinctions for determining the boundaries of the real and true—in George Spencer-Brown’s language, its own “marked states” that create a world. However even within a given society the relationship to these boundaries is not static, how we relate and react to encountering the distinction reflects an *ethos*, or set of guiding values. Our current relationship with the boundaries of the real and unreal in modern western democracies is integrally interwoven with *naturalism* and *scientism*.

The conversation about UAP in “official” spaces centers around what are known as “nuts and bolt” approaches. In other words, the focus is on *physical evidence* and the ways that UAP are detectable by our scientific instruments, with a primary focus on the technological capacities of the craft. This is evidenced in shows like *The Secret of Skinwalker Ranch*, or in the work of scientists involved in the Galileo Project. It has also long been the approach of an organization like SETI.³⁶ The heavy focus on “nuts and bolts” approaches in part reflects the way science has cornered the market on truth in modern western democracies, leading to a reliance on purely naturalistic terms to give an account of what is “real.” Naturalism, in short, is a commitment regarding both what is real (ontological) and how we study what is real (methodological). Essentially, it asserts that natural science is the one true way to know the world, *and* that the world consists only of entities that can be verified through the processes of scientific inquiry.³⁷

Naturalism has many proponents throughout both science as well as philosophy. Philosopher Willard Van Orman Quine, for example, stated “[I]t is within science itself, and not in some prior philosophy, that reality is to be identified and described,”³⁸ and Wilfred Sellars stated “[S]cience is the measure of all things, of what is that it is, and of what is not that it is not.”³⁹ According to naturalist approaches, we should only consider real that which we can physically verify through the processes of the scientific method, and which is comprehensible according to our understanding of the natural laws that govern the universe.

We need not look far to see the dominance of naturalism across our modern institutions. Illness or ailments are only diagnosable and therefore “real” when there are corresponding imaging or tests to verify in objective physical terms what is wrong

³⁶ See for example, Kevin Knuth, et al, “The new science of Unidentified Aerospace-Undersea Phenomena (UAP)” *Progress in Aerospace Sciences* 156.1 (2025). And, Harvard University, “The Galileo Project” <https://projects.iq.harvard.edu/galileo/home>, accessed 7/18/2025. And “The SETI Institute: About” <https://www.seti.org/about>, accessed 6/11/2025.

³⁷ This is defined very clearly and succinctly by Mario De Caro and David MacArthur in *Naturalism and Normativity* (Chichester: Columbia University Press, 2010), 4.

³⁸ Willard Quine, *Theories and Things* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1981), 21.

³⁹ Wilfrid Sellars, “Empiricism and the Philosophy of Mind” in *The Foundations of Science and the Concepts of Psychoanalysis*, ed. H. Feigl, and M. Scriven (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1956), 173.

in the body. Ask any patient of medically unexplained symptoms how difficult it can be for medical professionals to take seriously pain or dizziness that has no identifiable biological marker in the test results.⁴⁰ Forensic evidence is always stronger than witness testimony, and homicide or sexual assault cases that rely only on eyewitness recall alone with no corroborating physical evidence are far less likely to be taken seriously or result in conviction. The traditions of cultures that understand nature to contain spiritual elements unknowable through the scientific method, such as Indigenous American communication with non-human entities or the dead, or who consider “non-natural” entities part of the everyday life, such the long history of interaction with the djinn in Islamic societies, are written off as cultural representations with no corresponding grounding in physical reality. The popularity of The Telepathy Tapes podcast, which highlights the alleged telepathic abilities of non-speaking people with autism, has called many deeply ingrained assumptions about the boundaries of consciousness into question,⁴¹ but lacking some kind of natural scientific, cause and effect explanation of how telepathy occurs, many have attempted to dismiss the findings in the podcast as hoax.⁴²

Much of this boils down to the perceived division between *subjective* and *objective* knowledge. Subjective knowledge is private to the individual, observable only within their own mind and conscious experience. Objective knowledge, that which can be brought into the realm of the shared, is observable in the third person, and on instruments considered to be “neutral” – to represent a view from nowhere. The subjective, if it can find no corresponding validation in the “objective” realm, does not enter the realm of the true or the real. Returning to the patient experiencing dizziness and pain whose MRI comes up normal: she will be told it is “all in her head” and referred to psychological counseling. While it may be “true for her,” it does not enter the threshold of objectivity, it is not recognized by the medical institution as a medical problem.

This binary division is problematic for many reasons, primarily because in between the rigid delineations of the real and unreal lies the *experienceable*.⁴³ Science

⁴⁰ I have written on medically unexplained symptoms in “The Patient Experience of Medically Unexplained Symptoms: An Existentialist Analysis,” *Theoretical Medicine and Bioethics* 43(2022): 355-373.

⁴¹ The Telepathy Tapes joins existing scientific research that demonstrate the existence of non-local conscious communication. See Ky Dickens, “The Telepathy Tapes” podcast series, 2024–, <https://thetelepathytapes.com/>. Also Dean Radin, *The Conscious Universe: The Scientific Truth of Psychic Phenomena* (San Francisco: Harper One Books, 2009).

⁴² See for example, Matta Busby, “The Problem with the ‘Magical Children’ of the Telepathy Tapes” *Vice* March 20, 2025 <https://www.vice.com/en/article/telepathy-tapes-podcast-autism/>. Accessed 6/11/2025.

⁴³ The idea of focusing on whether something is *experienceable* rather than if it is “real” has been periodically discussed by Darren King on the *Point of Convergence* podcast. Darren King, host, *Point of Convergence*, podcast, accessed February 22, 2026, <https://www.pointofconvergence.net>

has never been able to give a comprehensive account of what first-person consciousness *is* nor give causal explanations for how it unfolds. Many human experiences are not explainable in purely physical, cause and effect terms, nor are they subject to verification through instrumentation. Religious experiences, medically unexplained symptoms, the experience of being trans, the experience of altered states of consciousness, psychical phenomena, and a wide range of paranormal experiences fall well outside the bounds of having corresponding verification in observable “objective” terms.

This is not an indictment of science, which I respect and find very important, including for studying the physical manifestations of UAP/UFOs. It is rather a criticism of *scientism*, the idea that science alone can give a complete picture of the entirety of reality. According to philosopher Dimitri Ginev, “In granting epistemological and metaphysical privileges to natural science, the proponents of scientism believe that scientific knowledge is the only source that gives us essences and necessities.”⁴⁴ And further, “Prima facie scientism is the postulation of the natural sciences’ norms, standards, and criteria of objectivity as an absolute system of reference in recognizing and resolving global social problems.”⁴⁵ While other norms or standards may be accepted as “true for them” (referring to the group that holds them), they are not perceived as crossing the threshold into shared truth.

In “The ‘Alien Abduction’ Phenomenon: Forbidden Knowledge of Hidden Events,” philosopher Michael E. Zimmerman argues that in the development of modern societies, “science took over the role once played by religion and myth in defining the true and the real” in part “because we live in an era that has so few consensual sources of authority.”⁴⁶ Zimmerman describes our current “social ontology”—the socially and institutionally-sanctioned view of the real—as such:

The social ontology of modern democracies is usually an aggregate of naturalistic materialism and anthropocentric humanism. According to such materialism, “reality” is wholly constituted by natural phenomena that can be detected or at least plausibly inferred by sensory apparatus.⁴⁷

Thus, in the dominant social ontology, the only phenomena that get to cross the threshold into the boundaries of “reality” are those that are observable by the senses (or instruments extending our senses) and repeatable under some form of control. This coupled with anthropocentric humanism, or a belief that humans are the sole producers of meaning and value in the universe, prohibits phenomena like contact

⁴⁴ Dimitri Ginev, “Scrutinizing Scientism from a Hermeneutic Point of View,” *Social Epistemology* 27.1 (2013): 69.

⁴⁵ *Ibid.*, 73.

⁴⁶ Michael E. Zimmerman, “The Alien Abduction’ Phenomenon: Forbidden Knowledge of Hidden Events” *Philosophy Today* 41.2 (1997): 236.

⁴⁷ *Ibid.*, 238.

experiences with advanced, allegedly non-human beings from ever emerging into the realm of possibility.

While science itself is of vital importance, *scientism* is inherently limiting, to the extent of being harmful. As Jonathan Tuckett argues, the idea that natural science presents a “view from nowhere,” or the world “as it is,” constitutes a harmful epistemological arrogance, essentially postulating an “orthodoxy of perception” that all knowers are bound to conform to, or judged according to how they deviate from it.

My charge is that to understand the world ‘as it is’ relies upon the presumption that the world is in a particular way and only that way. This entails an orthodoxy of perception as a requirement of discerning that way. Once this orthodoxy is presumed the role of the scholar is not then to investigate internal logic—the world ‘as it is for us’ and ‘as it is for them’—but how well groups have discerned the presumed ‘as it is’ of the world.⁴⁸

By presuming an “objective” view from nowhere, potential knowers are then judged based on how well their reported knowledge or experience conforms to that which is discoverable through the sole accepted methodology for establishing “that which is.” This insistence that all subjective experience can only enter the realm of consideration with corresponding verification on instrumentation or “objective” measures leaves many types of experience completely “off the table” of consideration, to use a metaphor from Jeffrey J. Kripal:

At the end of the day, though, most of these objections boil down to a simple (and simplistic) attempt *to control what is on the table* so that the only permissible evidence left there is that evidence that supports the materialist assumptions. It is very easy to explain all of reality if you get to define what that ‘all’ is. It is very easy to explain everything on the table when you have just taken off the table everything that you cannot explain.⁴⁹

By only allowing experiences or appearances that conform to being knowable through science “on the table,” some of the most perplexing, profound, ontologically significant aspects of human experience do not pass through the gatekeeping that polices the boundaries of the real.

Many fields of modern science make some use of witness observation, especially fields like ornithology, but they privilege observation obtained by *experts* and in *controlled settings*. Close encounter experiences certainly do happen to trained scientists, pilots, and military personnel, but they also happen to ordinary people in

⁴⁸ Jonathan Tuckett, “Orthodoxy is not Scientific: A Phenomenological Critique of Naturalism” in *The Question of Methodological Naturalism*, ed. Jason Blum, Series: *Supplements to Method and Theory in the Study of Religion*, Volume 11 (Leiden: Brill, 2018), 88–89.

⁴⁹ Jeffrey J. Kripal, “The Already World,” in Jeffrey J. Kripal and Whitley Strieber, *The Super Natural: Why the Unexplained is Real* (New York: Penguin Randomhouse, 2017), 12.

random or mundane (and thus, uncontrolled) settings. Additionally, as we will see throughout this book, many aspects of what experiencers report violates some of the basic assumptions of mechanical causality that are still prevalent in materialist interpretations of current scientific evidence. Kripal points out that those committed to scientism will use strategies like dismissing eyewitness testimony as “anecdotal” or arguing for a naive definition of mind in which all visual phenomena are regarded as “imaginary” products of the brain with no objective reality behind them.⁵⁰ These strategies control what is considered “evidence” and are used as justification for a lack of witnessing: experiencer narratives cannot possibly be true, so there is allegedly no harm done in ignoring them.

Contact experiences like Matthew’s or those reported by the experiencers in my study, describing contact with humanoid but not fully human entities, being floated through walls or closed windows, telepathic communication, out of body experiences, the receipt of knowledge through non-local means, synchronicity, and ongoing psychic phenomena, stray considerably far from what could be verified through scientific instruments, or repeatable in some kind of controlled setting. Indeed, there is an inherent difficulty in applying methods that have been introduced to study causal interactions within the physical world to study the realm of lived experience. Experiencers who *do* go public with their stories are immediately othered and marginalized for reporting experiences that defy naturalistic and scientific explanation. Their credibility as knowers is immediately called into question. For example, the recent volume *The Reliability of UFO Testimony* features several chapters arguing that experiencers are mentally ill, have masochistic fantasies, have low self-esteem, or are outright liars.⁵¹ This is despite the fact that those who have conducted psychological research on experiencers, even while assuming their accounts could not possibly be true, have noted that experiencers do not suffer from any higher rates of psychopathology than the general population.⁵² Based solely on the fact that they report an experience that cannot be easily explained according to the universe as currently understood, they are assumed not to be credible or reliable reporters of their experiences. This brings us to a well-explored concept in contemporary philosophical literature—epistemic injustice.

⁵⁰ Ibid.

⁵¹ Vicente-Juan Ballester-Olmos and Richard Heiden, eds., *The Reliability of UFO Witness Testimony* (Turin: UPIAR, 2023).

⁵² JO Parnell and RL Sprinkle, “Personality characteristics of persons who claim UFO experiences,” *Journal of UFO Studies* 2 (1990):45-58; Mark Rodeghier, Jeff Goodpaster, & Sandra Blatterbauer, “Psychosocial characteristics of abductees: Results from the CUFOS abduction project,” *Journal of UFO Studies* 3 (1991): 59–90; Nicholas Spanos, Patricia Cross, Kirby Dickson, and Susan DuBreuil, “Close encounters: An examination of UFO experiences,” *Journal of Abnormal Psychology* 102.4 (1993): 624-632; Katherine Holden and Christopher French, “Alien abduction experiences: Some clues from neuropsychology and neuropsychiatry,” *Cognitive Neuropsychiatry* 7.3 (2002): 163-178.

Epistemic Injustice: Partial, Failed, and Refused Witnessing

The general phenomenon of refused or partial witnessing and the harms it produces has been explored in academic philosophy through the concept of epistemic injustice. Coined by philosopher Miranda Fricker, epistemic injustice refers to harms that can be perpetuated against someone in their capacity as a knower, when those harms stem from societal inequities or injustices.⁵³ Fricker introduces this concept primarily in the context of marginalized groups, who are often attributed credibility deficits on the basis of their race, ethnicity, gender or gender identity, or socio-economic status. Not all contact experiencers have identities that come from marginalized groups. However, within certain social contexts, individuals who are not marginalized in their daily lives on the basis of identity may be marginalized within the power relations of a particular space or conversation. I argue that contact experiencers suffer from forms of both testimonial injustice, in which their testimony is not given adequate weight or credibility, and hermeneutical injustice, in which society lacks the concepts and language to name and witness their experiences in a meaningful way.⁵⁴ They are subject to what the philosophical literature describes as pre-emptive testimonial injustice, testimonial smothering, anticipatory epistemic injustice, and contributory injustice. Let us unpack these one at a time.

Pre-emptive testimonial injustice occurs when a particular group's testimony is not sought out because of doubts surrounding their credibility, even though their testimony is relevant and important to the topic at hand.⁵⁵ Contact experiencers' knowledge and experiences are relevant to the conversation surrounding UFOs/UAP. Much of the insight gained throughout the contact experience and in the aftermath is directly relevant to understanding the physically observed objects and why they are present in our atmosphere. Congressional hearings or academic conferences dedicated to UAP should, therefore, feature the testimony of experiencers as a core learning opportunity and source of knowledge.

Due to the fact that the majority of experiencers are ordinary people, not high-ranking military personnel or academic researchers, their testimony is not sought, or only included if it supports dominant narratives surrounding UAP as extraterrestrial threats. Additionally, because their experiences violate the dominant social ontology, *the very act of reporting such an experience* means experiencers receive

⁵³ Miranda Fricker, *Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing* (Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2007).

⁵⁴ Fricker describes each type as such, "Testimonial injustice occurs when prejudice causes a hearer to give a deflated level of credibility to a speaker's word; hermeneutical injustice occurs at a prior stage, when a gap in collective interpretive resources puts someone at an unfair disadvantage when it comes to making sense of their social experiences," Ibid., 1.

⁵⁵ "Those social groups who are subject to identity prejudice and are thereby susceptible to unjust credibility deficit will, by the same token, also tend simply not to be asked to share their thoughts, their judgments, their opinions," Ibid., 130-131.

credibility deficits and are assumed to be lying, confused, or ill. Some high-ranking military personnel and academic researchers will admit privately that they themselves are contact experiencers, however they avoid admitting so publicly. Doing so would instantly mean that the credibility of what they have observed or researched will be called into question. Thus, spaces and contexts in which experiencer testimony is relevant and useful proceed without experiencers' descriptions of their encounters or the insights that flowed from them.

An additional form of pre-emptive testimonial injustice emerges in terms of the exclusion of non-naturalist cultures from meaningful participation in the public discourse. Indigenous American tribes have for centuries reported contact and experiences with the "Star People" or "Sky People." For these groups, contact with UFOs and their occupants are not anomalies, but regular and accepted parts of life.⁵⁶ And yet, tribal elders are rarely consulted and never centered in the conversation about what UAP/UFOs may be. Jeannette, who identifies as Choctaw, stated to me during her interview:

I really want people who are studying this seriously...to make connection with non-Western people around this phenomena; connection with Native people, with the Aborigines, with African tribes. It's sort of far-fetched, but you can start right here. Because, as Native people, we do have a different worldview. We do see this differently. And, if there's anything that annoys me, it's that so much of the work that's being done now, seems to be exclusively white and Western, and that's not the only way to look at this.

Jeanette's concerns are not unfounded. As government officials present UAP as an urgent and new threatening phenomenon, the cultural groups who have considered contact a lived reality for centuries are not consulted for their insights. John Mack recognized the importance of tribal wisdom and interviewed three Indigenous shamans/medicine people (one from North America, one from South America, and one from Africa) in his book *Passport to the Cosmos*.⁵⁷ With the exception of Mack's work, attempts to bring the viewpoints of Indigenous peoples around the world into conversation with the institutionally-sanctioned investigation of UAP are scarce and not a focal point of how the UAP conversation unfolds in government and academic spaces. This constitutes a pre-emptive testimonial injustice.

Another epistemic injustice experienced frequently by experiencers is called testimonial smothering, a form of silencing. Testimonial smothering occurs when a speaker's audience demonstrates testimonial incompetence— that is to say, the audience is not in a position to understand or appreciate the nature of the knowledge

⁵⁶ See Red Star, *Star Ancestors*, and Clarke, *Encounters with Star People*

⁵⁷ John E. Mack, *Passport to the Cosmos: Alien Encounters and Human Transformation* (Guildford: White Crowe Books, 1999).

that the speaker possesses, displaying forms of pernicious ignorance. “Pernicious ignorance should be understood to refer to any reliable ignorance that, in a given context, harms another person (or set of persons).”⁵⁸ The speaker then truncates their testimony in order to make it comprehensible to their audience. For example, Kimberle Crenshaw identifies how women of color often self-censor when it comes to reporting domestic violence that they experience due to their awareness of “violent black male” stereotypes that will be weaponized against their reporting.⁵⁹

Analogously, the events that experiencers remember happening often contain happenings that are “impossible” according to the parameters of the modern scientific worldview. They may also include symbolism, and confusing, vague, and at times absurd elements. As we saw in Matthew’s account, they may also include sexual encounters with the ostensibly non-human beings. Few audiences, including academically-inclined ones, are equipped to fully understand or appreciate the depth and meaning of what experiencers are communicating. This leads to experiencers only reporting the physical aspects of their experiences, the parts that are intersubjectively witnessed, or those aspects which can in some way be made comprehensible within modern scientific framings, intentionally leaving out many of the most unbelievable or “weird” elements. Consider for example, this comment from Catherine, who experienced experiences she was confident took place within physical reality.

The instinct, even for the people, the academics who believe us, the instinct is to put this in some other third, daimonic realm, right. To say, “Well, it’s not actually physically happening. They’re not actually physically manifesting.” But it’s not not real either. So, it’s over here. That’s the farthest they can go with their brains, right? And I understand it. The worldview we’re born into; it’s concrete. It’s really hard to shift out of and even really creative, dynamic, nuanced thinkers still can only go so far with it.

Catherine expresses frustration that even scientists and other academics who take the UFO/UAP topic seriously have limitations regarding how far they can go with accepting or understanding what experiencers are trying to communicate. She is most justifiably concerned with a continued insistence on placing her experiences into some kind of non-physical or daimonic realm, and having to shape her testimony around her hearer’s assumptions that they could not possibly have occurred within physical reality as we understand it.

⁵⁸ Kristie Dotson, “Tracking Epistemic Violence, Tracking Practices of Silencing”, *Hypatia* 26.2 (2011): 238.

⁵⁹ Kimberle Crenshaw, “Mapping the Margins: Intersectionality, Identity politics, and Violence against Women of Color,” *Stanford Law Review* 43 (1991): 1256. Dotson, “Tracking Epistemic Violence” 245.

Other experiencers have confided in me both in private conversation or in formal research that they often leave the weirdest aspects of their stories out, especially when it contains sexual components. An experiencer mentioned to me privately that “when you start bringing up the sexual parts, people just completely shut down and tune out.”⁶⁰ If experiencers only feel safe to communicate bits and pieces of their stories, or feel fundamentally misunderstood or unheard regarding what they *do communicate*, we have at best partial attunement and witnessing, where the experiencer desires to be truly seen, only to have their narratives and convictions reductively flattened into the hearer’s filters of possibility. At worst, we have silencing and a complete refusal to witness, leaving experiencers feeling worse than if they had not spoken up at all. When you communicate an experience that is both as impossible to believe as it is profound and meaningful to you as the one who lived it, only to have that experience dismissed, simplistically reduced to something “you believe” happened, or twisted to fit a researcher’s chosen UAP hypothesis, it is worse than keeping the experience to yourself.

But there are even more pernicious forms of ignorance that make testimony regarding contact experiences unsafe and risky, leading to testimonial smothering. Experiencers are aware that they face the possibility of being pathologized and considered mentally ill for reporting their experiences, especially in psychiatric or mental health contexts. Experiencers report withholding their experiences from their therapists, or only bringing them up in very subtle or implicit ways, using coded language, so as not to be diagnosed as psychotic. Those who do bring up their experiences have found themselves at the receiving ends of diagnoses that are determined solely by the fact that they are reporting an experience that violates the existing social ontology. Consider this account from Andrew, who discussed his experiences with his therapist, who told him in their sessions that she believed him and it was a safe place to share his story.

[There was a] psychiatrist— I mean he was just deadpan, cold-hearted, clinical, I guess, going through the notes from the previous therapist. And he’s like, “Ok, it says here you’re suffering from severe hallucinations.” I was like, “excuse me? She told me she believed me.” And he was like, “It says here that you’re having severe hallucinations.” I was like, “the aliens?” He was like, “Yeah.” And so I had to sit there and agree with him that yeah, I needed help. Otherwise, I’d get sent to a padded room in a hospital.

Andrew has the devastating experience of being betrayed by his therapist, who was only pretending to believe him, and then wrote in her notes to the psychiatrist that

⁶⁰ The experiencer granted me permission to share this quote anonymously.

he was suffering severe hallucinations. This put Andrew in a situation in which the pernicious ignorance of the medical authority in front of him demands he must truncate his testimony and go along with the psychiatrist's interpretation of what occurred. If he does not, he risks further pathologization and involuntary committal. This is perhaps the most harmful form of epistemic injustice that experiencers face. Contact experiences are traumatic, reality-bending, confusing, and experiencers are often in deep ontological shock and badly need support. However reaching out to the institutionally and socially-sanctioned forms of help may lead to immediate pathologization and further harm.

The awareness of these potential harms leads to experiencers being subject to anticipatory epistemic injustice, a term coined by J.Y. Lee. With anticipatory epistemic injustice, fear of stigma rather than the stigma itself leads the speaker to self-censor.⁶¹ A striking number of experiencers report that they simply do not speak about these experiences, even to their closest family and friends, unless they are explicitly sure the person is safe. When I asked Sarah if she had ever shared her experiences with a therapist or doctor, she stated, "I was afraid. When I realized things were happening, I was afraid, in the very beginning, after reading *Communion*, that they were going to take my kids away. So I kept my mouth shut until they were adults and I never talked about it, ever." Deidre mentioned simply learning not to talk about these experiences, and that even when she co-wrote a book about them, she didn't feel fully safe sharing everything that occurred. "I just don't talk about it. And even when we wrote the book, I didn't go into...the detail that I'm going into with you. I was afraid, if somebody knew me, then I'd be found out." In these situations, the mere fear of stigma, regardless of whether one knows the audience demonstrates pernicious ignorance or not, is enough to lead to the withholding of the testimony.

Even when the reactions of hearers are not impactful enough to result in extremes of pathologization, dominant social ontologies and cultural climate ensure that experiencers are met with at best, a partial witnessing. Partial witnessing begins with the lived experience of carrying something vast—an encounter, a meaning, a truth that is heavy with significance—and approaching another with the fragile hope that it might finally be truly seen. One offers the complexity of one's world, the layered textures of an event or identity, with the quiet expectation that this time the Other might meet it with presence and depth. Partial witnessing manifests in the moment that hope collapses into disappointment: when what one has carried is reduced to something manageable for the witness, flattened into familiar categories, ultimately reframed to fit their narrative needs rather than one's own. The

⁶¹ J.Y. Lee, "Anticipatory Epistemic Injustice," *Social Epistemology* 35.6 (2021): 566.

experiencer feels not only unseen, but fundamentally mis-seen—recognized just enough to believe recognition was possible, yet distorted in ways that obscure the very heart of what they hoped would be acknowledged. Partial witnessing thus becomes a uniquely painful form of relational rupture, where the speaker is not ignored, but translated into something that no longer resembles the truth they invited the Other to encounter.

This was illustrated painfully in a 1999 “Anomalous Experiences Study Group” at Harvard Divinity School, organized by John Mack. Contact experiencers were invited to participate in a conversation with academics, ostensibly a good faith step towards understanding and full witnessing. For part of the session, contact experiencers presented testimony about their experiences in front of the invited scholars. Afterwards, the academics discussed their experiences in their absence. The participating academics were later asked to send letters to Mack reflecting on the event. In the responses, it was clear that the participating scholars did not consider the experiencers reliable interpreters of their own experiences. “The abductees are typically phenomenologically naive,” wrote one scholar. “If something happens to them that appears to have occurred ‘out there’ in the real world, then they automatically interpret the experience in that way.” Another scholar wrote, “I don’t necessarily mind if a phenomenon violates the laws of physics (as we know them now), but I do mind one that seems to violate the laws of logic.”⁶²

More perniciously, Parker describes the time he was asked to do an interview for a national magazine oriented towards practicing psychologists. While the woman interviewing him came off as “very kind and generous and open-hearted” Parker was devastated by the nature of the eventual article written about him.

I’m trying to just present the data without any judgement— At the end, she just makes it all about sex with aliens and “he’s clearly fucking crazy.” Was I traumatized by how people treated me or reacted to me? Yes. That was probably even more disheartening than the experiences themselves.

These forms of distorted witnessing in which experiencers describe identity-constituting events and truths core to their being and sense of self, only to have them flattened and reinterpreted through the lenses of the hearers, do more harm than ignoring the experiences entirely.

Many of the barriers to fuller witnessing emerge, at least in part, from the forms of *hermeneutical injustice* that experiencers also face. Hermeneutical injustice occurs when mainstream society lacks the concepts or language for making sense of a group’s experiences in a meaningful way. Fricker’s notable example of this is that prior to the existence of the concept and term “sexual harassment,” many women

⁶² Rice University Woodson Archive 2025, “The John E. Mack Collection” Box 47. Currently under embargo for 50 years. Accessed with permission from the donor July 29-August 6, 2025.

had no way to name or label the types of hostile experiences they would regularly undergo on the basis of their gender.⁶³ As I will illustrate throughout the chapters to come, much of what is reported as occurring during contact experiences does not conform to any contemporary scientific, academic, or secular language. Especially in institutionalized contexts, like the academy or in doctors' and therapists' offices, secular, medicalized language and understandings dominate to the exclusion of any other interpretation. Anastasia Philippa Scrutton explains how hermeneutical injustice occurs in the diagnosis of mental illness, and how medical pathologization is considered the sole way to understand phenomena such as "hearing voices" or "communicating with the dead." "[M]edical diagnosis effectively constitutes a monopoly on the way the experience is interpreted."⁶⁴ Scrutton draws on a recent voice-hearing survey that illustrated most participants felt their voice-hearing experiences were meaningful and had sought alternative, often spiritual understandings, only to have those alternative understandings ignored by medical practitioners.⁶⁵

Even more prominently in close encounters, experiencers report phenomena that blur the delineations between physical and mental realms, experience consciousness as separating from the body, have portions of the experience that feel like they are occurring outside the confines of space and time, communicate telepathically, or feel their bodies dematerialize as they are floated through a wall or closed window. Some expressed explicitly to me that mainstream society and especially academia lack the conceptual frameworks for speaking about and naming what occurs during contact. Yosef, for example, reports a contact experience that began in an out of body state and then crossed over into physical reality. He describes how difficult it is to put what he learned from his experiences into words:

One important thing [regarding] exploration of contact with the aliens we have to understand is the way [in which] our consciousness is working in two phases. And this is one of the things the aliens want me to understand. By contact[ing] me at the beginning beyond my body and then from my body. They want me to see the differences and to understand that...consciousness without the body, is like a different dimension. But when we try to go back to physical awareness...the brain has to translate it

⁶³ Fricker, *Epistemic Injustice*, 150-152.

⁶⁴ Anastasia Philippa Scrutton, "Epistemic Injustice and Mental Illness" in *The Routledge Handbook of Epistemic Injustice*, ed. Ian James Kidd, José Medina, and Gaile Pohlhaus, Jr. (New York: Routledge, 2017), 349-350.

⁶⁵ Scrutton, 350, references Lana Jackson, Mark Hayward, and Anne Cooke, "Developing Positive Relationships with Voices: A Preliminary Grounded Theory," *International Journal of Social Psychiatry* 57.5 (2010): 487-495.

in the way the brain can understand it. So we...translate it.

While there is an inherent difficulty in putting experiences such as these into human language, the reliance on naturalistic concepts leads to a paucity of terms and language for making sense of an encounter that is experienced both in the body and separated from it. Thomas explains that so much of the content of contact experiences transcends the “nuts and bolts” limitations that are used to discuss it.

It is just one more [example of] the degree that people don’t understand that this is not just nuts and bolts. There’s more to it, the phenomena[sic], that touches in on so many different things and it opens up a can of worms and that may be why so many people don’t want to do it. Because this is near death. This is [about] archetypes. This is consciousness. This is so big that people don’t fully grasp how much this is going to change.

The disenchantment of the world and insistence that all of reality can be explainable in cause and effect terms, and through the concepts of science, has led to a lack of formalized language for bringing these experiences into the realm of the shared and social. Additionally, many therapists and other mental health providers lack protocols and discourses for dealing with these experiences in a meaningful way other than pathologization.

While genuine hermeneutic barriers exist, there are also forms of what Gaile Polhause Jr. calls *willful hermeneutical ignorance* taking place, leading to contributory injustices. Contributory injustice, coined by Kristie Dotson, is when a marginalized community *has* developed language and concepts for making sense of their experience, but the mainstream culture refuses to engage them.⁶⁶ As mentioned, Indigenous American tribal communities such as the Hopi or Dinè (Navajo) have long reported accounts of encounters with “Sky Beings” or “Star People” or may perceive what westerners call the UAP occupants as their ancestors or guides.⁶⁷

Additionally, within experiencer communities, like the support groups offered historically by John Mack and Budd Hopkins or more contemporarily by the John Mack Institute, as well as the experiencer groups in online spaces like Reddit, languages and concepts *have* been developed by experiencer communities for describing and making sense of what they have experienced. Terms like “downloads” are used to signify the receipt of non-local information telepathically, and experiencers refer to the different states of “vibration” and “frequency” they

⁶⁶ Willful hermeneutical ignorance is developed by Gaile Polhause Jr in the paper “Relational Knowing and Epistemic Injustice: Toward a Theory of *Willful Hermeneutical Ignorance*,” *Hypatia* 27.4 (2012): 715-735. Polhause’s concept is expanded into contributory injustice in Kristie Dotson’s, “A Cautionary Tale on Limiting Epistemic Oppression,” *Frontiers: A Journal of Women’s Studies* 33.1 (2012): 24-47.

⁶⁷ See especially Paul Werner Duarte, “It Will Happen in Hopiland,” and Sequoia Trueblood, “The Truth Has Always Been Here,” found in Red Star, *Star Ancestors*.

experience during the encounters. Some also develop meaningful interpretations of contact that involve the biological, moral and technological evolution of human beings to higher states of consciousness and ethics. Many express extremely nuanced philosophical and moral perspectives regarding what the contact experience is fundamentally about, making use of their own cultural lenses and meaning-making frameworks. These interpretations have positive and transformative effects on their lives. However, these hermeneutical resources developed by experienter communities themselves are rarely acknowledged by scholars, the mental health community, or within the mainstream UAP conversation—constituting *willful hermeneutical ignorance* and perpetuating contributory harms.

When entering the space of the conversation surrounding experiences, my goal, then, is to avoid these epistemic injustices, erasures, and forms of partial witnessing. I aim to engage experienter testimony in ways that are not reductive, distortive, or establishing certainty where little is certain and that allows experiencers to remain sovereign in their own processes of meaning-making. I sought a methodology that could not only avoid harm but in some sense *be actively restorative*. I strove then, to do three things: 1) To listen to what appeared in the initial encounter, to the best of their memory, suspending my own filters of possibility and impossibility, 2) to honor and witness their interpretations and sense-making regarding the meaning of the experience for themselves and humanity, and 3) to explore the implications and applications of their insights for thinking about UAP, contact, humanity, and the universe.

My Methodology: Phenomenology as Restorative Hearing

Confronting and writing about the experience of contact requires an ability to truly hold and witness ambiguity and complexity. In conversing with experiencers and analyzing their testimony in the aftermath, I chose to employ a descriptive, generative, and interpretative phenomenological approach throughout, with the aim of centering experienter meaning-making in the analysis. I also step out of the phenomenological attitude in the final chapters and apply the phenomenological revelations: I ask what it would look like to approach UAP and contact events, and our understanding of the universe, through the insights provided by the experiencers.

My descriptive phenomenology is rooted in the work of Edmund Husserl. Husserl argued that while our senses and categories do not reveal the whole of reality, appearances nevertheless disclose something real about the world. How the world gives itself in experience—its shapes, textures, colors, moods, and horizons—belongs to the structure of what the world is *for consciousness*. Husserl referred to this field of experiential givenness as the lifeworld, the pre-theoretical world taken for

granted in our everyday activity. Although lifeworlds vary across cultures, Husserl maintained that certain basic structures of experience—spatiotemporality, embodiment, and intentional directedness—are universal conditions of appearing.⁶⁸ The lifeworld, or world as we live it, is not “less real” than the world as it is known through quantification and instrumentation.

When we step out of the natural attitude, as he called it, we assume the standpoint of the “transcendental Ego,” an absolute consciousness that examines the structure of appearances. It does so without the prejudices of our everyday attitude, and without the assumptions of the scientific attitude. Such a process allows aspects of being to appear and reveal itself without being forced into a pregiven categorical box.⁶⁹ For Husserl, “evidence” refers to the stable self-givenness of an object across experiences, and truth is grounded not behind appearances but in the fulfilled coherence of what appears over time.⁷⁰

A key component of descriptive phenomenology is the process of *bracketing*. When we bracket, we suspend the assumptions of the natural attitude, or the everyday practical attitude through which we approach the world. “We put out of action the general positing which belongs to the essence of the natural attitude; we parenthesize everything which that positing encompasses with respect to being.”⁷¹ Carefully examining what appears to the witness, a descriptive phenomenological analysis identifies the types of *intentionalities* present, or the relationship of consciousness to the object it experiences. For example, objects can be experienced through the intentionalities of sensory perception, memory, anticipation, or imagination. Husserl argued we could use a process of eidetic reduction, or identifying key characteristics that are integral to how an object or experience unfolds. For example, to isolate the *eidos* of “boredom,” we identify the essential features of boredom: a disengagement from meaningful involvement, a distortion of the flow of time, and a heightened self-awareness of time passing. Without these, the experience would not be recognizable as boredom.⁷²

Husserl thought we could use bracketing to return to a fundamental ontological structure of being that would reveal itself in experiences in consistent ways. However, there are inherent limitations in attempting to apply such an approach to

⁶⁸ Edmund Husserl, *The Crisis of the European Sciences and Transcendental Phenomenology: An Introduction to Phenomenological Philosophy*, trans. David Carr (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1970), 108-109.

⁶⁹ Edmund Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations: An Introduction to Phenomenology*, trans. Dorion Cairns (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1982), 7-26.

⁷⁰ Edmund Husserl, *The Idea of Phenomenology*, trans. William Alston and George Nakhnikian (The Hague, Martinus Nijhoff, 1973), 44-51.

⁷¹ Edmund Husserl, *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and Phenomenological Philosophy Volume 1*, trans. Frederick Kersten (Boston: Martinus Nijhoff Publishing, 1983), 61.

⁷² *Ibid.*, 131-141.

contact experiences. Most importantly, contact experiences are not universal and *do not give themselves in consistent ways*. By definition, they are not experiences that everyone can have, nor can we easily parse out characteristics that are essential or universal to them. We may be able to identify patterns that are *common*, but contact experiences resist full closure and certainty about what is appearing and how it presents itself to different subjects. One of the most profound examples of this is that even in multi-witnessed UAP and contact events, witnesses will report having drastically differing perceptions of what occurred, even if there are points of corroboration. It is not possible to use eidetic reduction to isolate the core structure of appearances in the way Husserl's original descriptive phenomenology intended.

Bracketing does, however, provide us with an important analytical tool: suspending our own filters of possibility and impossibility, and attending as closely as possible to what the witness remembers appearing. This will not mean that we are isolating the "true essence" of contact, but it does importantly allow us to *keep everything on the table*. This means that we will not dismiss or reject testimony that seems "impossible" according to our current scientific understandings, nor will we ignore elements of experiences that do not meet a chosen hypothesis (most often, the extraterrestrial hypothesis.) I use elements of bracketing and descriptive phenomenology to present what experiencers recall as appearing without reducing it to simplistic cultural interpretations. Rather than attempting to isolate the "eidos" or universal structures of contact, which may not exist, I use bracketing to describe key patterns in the phenomenological structures described: for example, that abduction events are repeatedly described as non-consensual and corporeal, referring experiencers back to dysfunction within the body.

The later Husserl, as well as phenomenologists who followed him such as Martin Heidegger and Maurice-Merleau-Ponty, challenged Husserl's earlier convictions that there could ever be an interpretation-free appearance. This brings us to *generative phenomenology*, which is another layer of my method. In generative phenomenology, the goal is not to uncover the world "as it is" but to recognize that realities are essentially *generated*, not discovered. This means that the subject functions as a co-creator who brings a lens of interpretation to any appearance. The goal becomes to uncover the ongoing structures and meaning of experience; how the subject situates themselves within a lifeworld and how all attempts at "bracketing" will still reflect the structures of their subjectivity and their corporeal embodiments in a social and cultural world. The world is something that is continuously constituted, not something waiting to be uncovered by a reflective neutral subject.

Generative phenomenology rejects the idea of a "view from nowhere" or that there is a view of the world "as it is." In its place, there is the world as it is *given* to various perceivers in their experiences. To be an object, or a thing, means to be

presented to a subject— it is through presentation to a subject that an entity assumes the role of object. The task of sciences like physics is to understand the world as it is given to atoms, planets, etc., in other words, how the world is in relation to these entities and interpreted by us— not the world “as it is” independent of any positionality.⁷³ When we describe the world through generative phenomenology, it is always *the world as given to X*. This avoids the orthodoxy of perception identified by Jonathan Tuckett. Perceptions are not filtered or judged on the basis of how closely they adhere to the supposed “as it is-ness” of the world.

Thus, in analyzing experiencer testimony, I adopt a generative phenomenological approach, which understands contact not as a fixed phenomenon waiting to be described but as an event that brings forth new worlds of meaning. This approach examines how communication with the perceived entities reshapes the experiencers’ embodied, ethical, and relational horizons, generating novel structures of subjectivity and intersubjectivity rather than revealing a single, pre-given essence. Chapters Two, Three and Four employ a combination of descriptive phenomenology (identifying core phenomenological structures of contact) and generative phenomenology (how these experiences give rise to new structures of subjectivity). I use conceptual tools introduced by Husserl, Drew Leder, Julia Kristeva, Bernhard Waldenfels, Emmanuel Levinas, and Jean-Luc Marion to illuminate key generative themes in the experiencer narratives.

I also practice an *interpretive phenomenological analysis*. This occurs throughout the descriptive chapters but most explicitly in Chapters Five and Six, where I explore experiencers’ transformations in ethics and worldview. Interpretative phenomenology has its origins in Martin Heidegger’s concept of Dasein: a conception of the person as Being-in-the-world alongside things and other people. For Heidegger, we are “thrown” into a world of language, culture, history that we use to make meaning of the world.⁷⁴ While generative phenomenology examines how experiences give rise to new structures of subjectivity and world, interpretative phenomenology attends to the sense-making processes through which these transformations are understood and expressed. In examining the aftermath of contact, I turn to interpretative phenomenology to analyze how experiencers make sense of the phenomena and transformations that follow. This approach attends to the conceptual frameworks and meaning-making processes through which experiencers articulate their newly reconfigured worlds, including their expressions of new metaphysical beliefs and ethical values. Additionally, I put key conceptual themes in conversation with western philosophical as well as Indigenous American

⁷³ Tuckett, “Orthodoxy is not Scientific,” 96.

⁷⁴ Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time*, trans. John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson (Oxford: Blackwell, 2004 [1962]).

thought.

My aim of this combined method is to be restorative: to provide a starting point for repair of the epistemic harm experiencers encounter when their testimony is flattened, misheard, or prematurely explained away. Phenomenology, when practiced with rigor, care, and ontological openness, can function as *restorative bearing*—one that resists the forces of partial witnessing that so often diminish anomalous and marginalized forms of experience. My restorative stance operates in three interlocking ways:

1. I employ bracketing as a strategy of epistemic justice. By suspending common filters of possibility and impossibility, bracketing resists the default interpretive frames that routinely delegitimize anomalous testimony. It allows the phenomenon to appear on its own terms rather than through the narrow horizon of pre-existing explanatory models (null hypotheses or the extraterrestrial hypothesis). Bracketing is therefore not simply a methodological tool; it is an ethical refusal to collapse unfamiliar experiences into reductive and familiar categories.
2. My generative description centers the experiencer's world. Examining the experience as it is *given to the witness* resists the erasure inherent in neutral or "view-from-nowhere" accounts. Instead of treating experiencers as unreliable data points, generative phenomenology treats them as subjects disclosing newly constituted worlds of meaning. This approach restores the full complexity of their lived transformations—bodily, ethical, relational, and metaphysical—which are often dismissed or rendered unintelligible in mainstream discourse.
3. My interpretive analysis honors experiencer meaning-making. By tracing how experiencers understand and narrate their encounters, interpretative phenomenology restores their authority over the significance of their own experiences. It recognizes that meaning arises *through* their conceptual frameworks and lived worlds, and that these interpretative horizons are not distortions but essential dimensions of the phenomenon's disclosure.

Together, these components form a methodology that actively resists both partial witnessing (seeing experiencers only through reductive frameworks) and non-witnessing (failing to engage their testimony at all). Restorative phenomenology therefore becomes a practice of epistemic repair: it restores dignity, sovereignty, and ontological complexity to voices that are too often marginalized, pathologized, or ignored.

Finally, to more intentionally resist partial witnessing, I extend my analysis one step further, stepping out of a phenomenological method. After examining contact as a form of lived experience and analyzing experiencers' sense-making, I ask: what would it look like to use these insights as *frameworks for approaching the world*, especially the world of UAP and anomalous phenomena? Chapters Seven and Eight explore this question by applying experiencer-derived insights to our broader understanding of contact, UAP, and this cultural moment of potential disclosure. This includes putting their insights *in conversation* with western philosophical concepts as well as Indigenous American thought.

Resisting willful hermeneutical ignorance, in the second half of the book, I place experiencer testimony in careful conversation with strands of Indigenous American thought, not to subsume these traditions within phenomenology but to acknowledge the ways they illuminate dimensions of contact that Western philosophical frameworks may obscure or overlook. Indigenous philosophies that emphasize relationality, kinship with human and non-human life, and the permeability of the boundaries between physical and psychical worlds offer conceptual orientations that resonate with the phenomenological structures disclosed in experiencer narratives. These traditions challenge the modern western emphasis on control or certainty, and instead foreground modes of knowing grounded in particular, place-based knowing. My aim is not to treat Indigenous worldviews as interpretive tools imposed onto experiencers; rather, to highlight convergences between these relational epistemologies and ontologies and the subjective structures and insights that emerge through contact. By letting these frameworks speak alongside one another, I aim to cultivate a methodology that is both humble and responsive—one that recognizes that the phenomenon of contact may already be more intelligible within epistemologies that are experientially-oriented and acknowledge relationality and interconnectivity between human and non-human life.

This methodology does not presume consensus, nor does it aim to produce a single, authoritative interpretation of contact experiences. Experiencers do not agree uniformly on what their encounters mean, and participants in this study will not necessarily endorse all of the connections or applications developed here. Rather than treating such divergence as a methodological weakness, I take it as a constitutive feature of the phenomenon itself. My aim is to center, illustrate, and thoughtfully engage the insights of the fifteen experiencers who participated in this study, while also placing their interpretations in conversation with other publicly available experiencer accounts. This work does not claim to offer a final or exhaustive account of contact, but instead presents a starting point: a model for how experiencer testimonies might be taken seriously as sources of knowledge and ethical insight.

What follows is offered as an invitation—an initial framework for engaging the lived realities of contact and for considering what these experiences, taken together, may suggest about human subjectivity, relationality, and our evolving understanding of our place within a larger, more complex reality.

Conclusion: Preparing the Ground for Encounter

Matthew Roberts was confronted with an impossible experience— and an even more extraordinary process of sense-making that followed it. This chapter has not attempted to resolve the ontological question of what his or any contact experience ultimately is, nor to set myself up as the definitive or final authority of interpretation. Instead, I have examined the conditions under which contact testimony is heard, distorted, or refused altogether. By situating experiencer accounts within broader structures of epistemic injustice, partial witnessing, and credibility denial, I have argued that the difficulty of engaging contact narratives lies not only in the strangeness of how these experiences unfold, but in the limitations of our prevailing ways of knowing and relating.

If contact experiences are approached only through pre-established categories of plausibility, pathology, or threat, much of what they disclose—about subjectivity, corporeality, relationality, consciousness, and ethics—will remain inaccessible. Experiencers will be, at best, partially witnessed, and the most profound and destabilizing insights of the contact experience will not be heard or received. My phenomenologically-oriented methodology of restorative hearing does not ask the reader to suspend critical thinking, but to suspend premature conclusions: to allow experiences to show themselves before deciding what they must mean.

In the chapters ahead, I turn to the phenomenological textures of lived accounts of contact as they are remembered, narrated, and integrated by those who have lived them. The reader is invited not to accept these accounts uncritically, but to accompany them with attentiveness, humility, and ethical seriousness. Whether contact ultimately reshapes our understanding of non-human life, consciousness, or the human itself depends not only on what appears, but on our capacity to witness what appears without reducing it in advance.

Starting from lived experience, an ontological position of bracketing, and asking how contact generates new structures of subjectivity and intersubjectivity, I unpack how these encounters are experienced and interpreted. By employing a layered phenomenology, I take experiencers seriously, and restore the lived experience of UAP as a vital component of the conversation surrounding what they are. By articulating what was experienced, identifying thematic patterns, how experiencers make sense of and interpret their experiences, and how encounters restructure ethical orientation within the lifeworld, I bring the conscious structure

of contact experiences into the realm of shared recognition, language and discourse. I also identify the areas and aspects of the experience that defy our available concepts and language, and blur the distinctions and marked states we currently use to understand our world. Between the real and the unreal, the physical and the mental, the subject and the object, we find the uncertain boundaries of the *experienceable*.⁷⁵

⁷⁵ See King, *Point of Convergence*

Chapter 2: Abduction Encounters: The Uncertain Boundaries of

Corporeality

“At the time, it felt so repulsive. Like I can remember going, ‘Oh my god, I just had sex with an alien. I can’t believe this.’ And not only that, but was it against my will? Was it coerced? Did I agree to this? Like, how did this happen? I was devastated.” -Parker

“My left ovary was causing me problems and I had a lot of pain. And I remember waking up one morning and there was just a blue line that looked like a laser. It did not hurt any more. Not only that, but a few years later the doctor’s like ‘There’s no record of surgery. Where’s your ovary?’ My left ovary was gone. And I’ve never had surgery. All of my children were born by vaginal birth.” -Sarah

“Even the helplessness and loss or surrender of control which are, at least initially, forced upon the abductees by the aliens— one of the most traumatic aspects of the experiences— seem to be in some way ‘designed’ to bring about a kind of ego death from which spiritual growth and expansion of consciousness may follow.”- John E. Mack

Stepping into fuller witnessing requires looking at the entire scope of reported experiences, including the historically strangest and most unbelievable type: abduction encounters. Abduction reports, especially those involving allegedly physical, non-consensual contact, are perhaps the most baffling and difficult type of encounter to take seriously. Infamously, John Mack suffered a review and investigation of both his medical license and his tenure for *not* diagnosing abductees as mentally ill.⁷⁶ Even among scientists who are willing to acknowledge the existence of UAP and a need to explore them through scientific methods, there is a noted hesitation to seriously consider the accounts of individuals who report the experience of being abducted by ostensibly non-human entities, and an especially firm resistance to attribute any physical reality to these accounts. Beginning with a descriptive stance of ontological openness in combination with identification of generative themes, we confront these experiences on their own terms and witness what is reported without narrative flattening.

I begin by bracketing the question of the exact source of these encounters and focus on what appears in conscious experience. While some experiencers have reported “astral abductions” in which they perceive their energetic or astral body being abducted, or abduction accounts that take place in psychedelic or dream states, others report abduction events that they are adamant took place in physical reality, even if the experiences were accompanied by psychic phenomena or out of body

⁷⁶ See Ralph Blumenthal, *The Believer: Alien Encounters, Hard Science, and the Passion of John Mack* (Albuquerque, NM: High Road Books, 2021).

experiences. Using the phenomenological work of Maurice Merleau-Ponty, Drew Leder, and Bernhard Waldenfels as a starting point, I explore the phenomenological structures and implications of abductions as embodied and intercorporeal experiences. This does not mean that *all* abduction events are described as including physical contact, but that my focus in this chapter is articulating the phenomenological structure of those that are— this includes the five abductees in my study. While there may be no singular universal essence of abduction experiences, there are identifiable phenomenological commonalities.

In highlighting the physicality of the encounters, it becomes clear that any meaningful approach to abduction encounters must confront that many aspects are *experienced as physical events*. Drawing on Drew Leder's conception of the disappearing body, I show how the effects of abduction make the body present in lived experience, repeatedly referring the experience back to the body. By emphasizing the distinctly intercorporeal nature of these encounters, in terms of encountering a perceived, embodied intelligent non-human Other, I illustrate how abduction fundamentally challenges the traditional consensus regarding the boundaries of the body, and the limitations of what embodiment and corporeality entail.

In challenging these limitations, abduction functions in experiencers' lives as a catalyst for transformative experience. Given the encounter with an Other that challenges the parameters of intercorporeality as they've previously experienced and conceptualized them, abductees emerge from their abduction experience with subverted and transformed understandings of what it means to exist as an embodied subject. Ultimately this will culminate in a multidimensional understanding of corporeality, or a conception of the body that considers it *one* locus of conscious experience but ultimately embedded in a much wider and more malleable experiential field.

The Phenomenological Structure of Abduction

Five experiencers in the Worldview study— Catherine, Jeanette, Parker, Sarah, and Rachel— report non-consensual experiences of at least partially physical contact, involving alleged capture and transport of the body by ostensibly non-human entities. Catherine, Jeanette and Parker processed and integrated some of their experiences with John Mack himself.⁷⁷ When Mack listened to what his patients reported as appearing to them, he discovered a basic pattern to most abduction accounts. Mack's 1994 *Abduction* is a remarkable demonstration of the exercise of phenomenological bracketing and restorative listening, at least in his methodological posture. Mack comments that even for those who take abductions seriously, there is

⁷⁷ To protect anonymity, the pseudonyms I use are not how the individuals may have been referred to in Mack's work.

a tendency to accept elements of the experience that fit within naturalist understandings of how the universe functions, but to dismiss those elements that fall too far outside what we understand to be possible from a scientific point of view. Mack himself found such discriminations “not wise nor useful.”⁷⁸ In order to understand the structure of a human experience, you must leave everything on the table and suspend all assumptions about how the world is and how human beings are: “My criteria for including or crediting an observation by an abductee is simply whether what has been reported was felt to be real by the experiencer and was communicated sincerely and authentically to me.”⁷⁹

Mack employed a limited use of hypnotic regression in his work with his patients, as many of their experiences included gaps of missing time in which they could not remember what happened. Many of these cases involved only a simple state of relaxation.⁸⁰ The use of hypnosis to recover memories is highly controversial, because of the possibility of the investigator asking leading questions, as well as the possibility for the human imagination to introduce or embellish elements from the subconscious that were not part of the original experience. Mack does report attempting to “lead” his patients when they were in the regression, only for the patient to push back and say “no, it didn’t happen that way.”⁸¹ My concern here, however, is not to adjudicate the epistemic status of hypnotically accessed material or to defend hypnosis as a reliable means of memory recovery.

Rather, from a phenomenological perspective, what emerges in hypnosis must be understood as part of the experience as it is lived, integrated, and made meaningful by the subject. Even if certain elements arise through imaginative synthesis or co-collaboration, they nevertheless participate in the subject’s reality as experienced and can exert real psychological, relational, and existential effects. Of interest, the information recovered under hypnosis is remarkably consistent with accounts that surface under waking recall. As noted by Kenneth Ring, “It is important to note that whether the abduction is recalled as a dream, or through hypnosis, or spontaneously, *the nature of the episode is identical*.”⁸² In other words, individuals who have recalled their abduction episodes through hypnosis report an extremely similar structure to the progression of the experience as those who recall them in waking memory.. More importantly, even if *some* elements recalled through

⁷⁸ John Mack, *Abduction: Human Experiences with Aliens* (New York: Scribner and Sons, 1994), 31.

⁷⁹ *Ibid.*

⁸⁰ *Ibid.*, 21.

⁸¹ *Ibid.*, 25. Mack writes, “I and other investigators have tried repeatedly to trick abductees by suggesting specific elements—hair on the aliens, corners in the rooms on ships, for example—only to be met with direct contradiction of these efforts.”

⁸² Kenneth Ring, *The Omega Project: Near-Death Experiences, UFO Encounters, and Mind at Large* (New York: William and Morrow Company, 1992), 65.

memory or retrieved under hypnosis are not a direct one-to-one copy of the event exactly as it was lived, there are still meaningful insights that can be gained from examining these experiences as they are recalled and integrated.

From his analysis of patient accounts, Mack noted that abduction experiences often begin when abductees are at home in bed or driving in their cars. The first signs of an abduction experience include a blue or white light flooding the room, an odd buzzing or humming sound, and an unexplained apprehension or sense of an unusual presence. This is often followed by the direct sighting of one or more humanoid beings, and possibly a close-up sighting of a strange craft outside the window or above the car. The abductee is then floated by a beam of light down the hall, through the wall or window of the house, or through the roof of the car. They pass through solid objects, noticing only a slight vibratory sensation as this occurs. One or more humanoid beings usually accompany the abductee as they are guided to the ship, and the abductee often realizes they have been paralyzed. Once inside, experiencers find themselves in a small dark room; soon after they are taken into larger rooms where various procedures will occur.⁸³

The most striking aspect of abductions is the entities witnessed on board the ships. By far the most common entity observed by Mack's patients were the small "gray" humanoids which are 3-4 feet in height. There are generally two kinds of grays reported, including smaller drone or insect-like workers, who move or glide robotically. These are contrasted with the slightly taller leader or "doctor" who, in Mack's experience, was usually described as male. The gender difference is usually determined by intuitive feeling rather than genitalia. The small grays have large, pear-shaped heads, long arms with 3-4 fingers, a thin torso, and spindly legs. They are also reported as hairless, with no ears, rudimentary nostril holes, and a thin slit for a mouth which usually does not open. By far the most prominent feature of the grays are the large black eyes. The eyes are reported to have compelling power, and abductees will often avoid looking into them because of the overwhelming dread, loss of agency, or loss of will that occurs when they do. The communication between humans and the beings is telepathic, or thought to thought, sometimes appearing as images in the head.⁸⁴

Abductees report being undressed and put onto a body fitting table, where they are studied and prodded. They often feel as if the contents of their minds are being known from the inside. Abductees report extensive surgical-like procedures inside the head, which they feel alter the nervous system. Instruments that penetrate the abdomen or involve genitals are used to take sperm samples from men and remove or fertilize eggs in females. Most provocatively, abductees experience being

⁸³ Mack, *Abduction*, 33-36.

⁸⁴ *Ibid.*, 36-37.

impregnated by the non-human beings and later having the pregnancies removed. They also see the fetuses being put into containers on the ships, and in subsequent abductions may see incubators where the hybrid infants are being raised. Sometimes they will be encouraged to nurture or play with these hybrids. Last, information is communicated to abductees, either telepathically or through powerful images shown on television monitors in the ships, considering the fate of the Earth and the human responsibility for the destruction. Scenes of Earth's devastation are shown. Sometimes abductees are given assignments in the future holocaust.⁸⁵

Following their abduction experience, Mack's abductees report cuts, scars, scoop marks, and fresh ulcers on their bodies. Many note that electronic devices now malfunction in their presence. "But it is almost impossible to prove that these disturbances are related to the abduction process, or even that they have occurred at all."⁸⁶ Abductees frequently experience the feeling that some sort of homing object has been inserted into their bodies, especially into the head or leg, which they express they believe has been put there so the beings can track and monitor them.

Abduction as Bodily Events

As I studied abduction material and interviewed abductees, it became clear to me that any honest representation must include how the *body* is experienced in abduction events. Abductees report the physical experiences of capture, removal, transport, paralysis, non-consensual medical procedures, waking up with strange marks and scars on their bodies, and sometimes retrieving objects out of their nasal cavities or legs. Abductees additionally report an experience with an embodied, corporeal non-human Other. Among those who have taken abduction reports seriously, there has been considerable debate regarding "where" abductions occur, with some thinkers, including at times Mack himself, opting to place abduction accounts as occurring in an ontological third space, sometimes referred to as the "imaginal realm." This has been advocated for by thinkers like Kenneth Ring or Michael Grosso.⁸⁷ The imaginal realm is described as ontologically real but not possessing physical properties like extension or solidity, and is not perceived through the five senses.⁸⁸ It is rather allegedly experienced through altered states of consciousness, such as those induced by breathwork ceremonies, deep meditation, shamanic journeying, or psychedelics.

⁸⁵ Ibid., 38-41.

⁸⁶ Ibid., 41.

⁸⁷ Ring, *The Omega Project*, 218-222, and Michael Grosso, "The Symbolism of UFO Abductions," *UFO Universe*, Fall (1988).

⁸⁸ Henry Corbin described the imaginal realm as such: "[This is] a world possessing extension and dimension, figures and colors, but these features cannot be perceived by the senses in the same manner as if they were properties of physical bodies. No, these dimensions, figures, and colors are the object of imaginative [i.e. imaginal] perception, or of the 'psychospiritual senses.'" Henry Corbin, *Mundus Imaginalis or the Imaginal and the Imaginary* (Ipswich: Golgonooza Press, 1972), 9.

While I understand the temptation to place abduction accounts in an imaginal space, and some contact experiences *are likely* better explained in these terms, I think placing *all* abduction experiences into a consciously-accessed third space is a mistake. The five abductees' experiences that we explore in this chapter have a distinct *physicality* to them, and are experienced as bodily, corporeal interactions with another embodied intelligence. The physicality is often *accompanied* by vivid dream experiences, out of body experiences, or other altered states of consciousness, but not *reducible* to them.

Let us examine first, for example, the case of Sarah. Sarah's first close encounter experience took place when she was three years old and she fell into a lake while being babysat on a family friend's property. "I remember falling in the water and breathing it in. And that smell and that taste. I can still remember it to this day...and what actually pulled me out of the water and helped me to breathe were as I called them, the little gray men." Sarah remembered this as a physical experience—the smell and taste of the water as she was drowning, and her rescue from the non-human beings. At age 15, she began to experience abduction encounters, including one that also involved a friend who was sleeping over at her home. During this experience, which she later confirmed with the friend years later, she states "I remember them arriving and seeing them—all the colors [around the craft] and all that. I was wide awake for that; wide awake." Sarah and the other abductees featured in this chapter are not alone. Kenneth Ring describes respondents in the Omega Project such as Claire Chambers who insisted matter-of-factly that her alien captors were "physical beings with physical bodies."⁸⁹

Additionally, all five of the abductees experienced moments of *intersubjective validation* which grounded their experiences in the observations of others, transferring them out of the realm of the purely subjective and grounding them in shared reality. Parker, for example, reports an experience when traveling with three women from New York to Boston, where he stayed in the home of an uncle of one of the women. The three women were not aware of his experiences or that he had any association with UFOs. While there, the three women went for a walk and Parker fell asleep in a chair in the living room. While asleep, he had a vivid dream-like experience of the gray beings coming to him, of being on a ship, and the feeling of something entering deep into his nasal passages. When he found himself back in the living room after the experience, the three women, who were completely unaware of Parker's previous experiences, came home "visibly shaken and freaked out" reporting they had just seen a UFO outside.

⁸⁹ Ring, *The Omega Project*, 86.

Or, consider Catherine, who experienced an uncanny encounter in the upstate NY woods in which she and other humans were introduced to their alleged hybrid offspring. She remembered looking around and seeing an old wooden roller coaster and carefully noted a grass clearing in the woods where she and the other human beings had been brought, and seeing humanoid entities emerge from the tree line. Five years after this experience, she saw a drawing in an unpublished manuscript of the exact scene she had experienced that night. It included the grass clearing, the tree line, the roller coaster, and the hybrid children being brought to meet their human parents. Another witness who had the same experience that night had drawn the picture. She showed me the drawing and it resembled what she described. She did not draw the picture herself nor have it commissioned, nor does she know who the artist was. While these intersubjective validations do not rise to the level of scientific evidence, they show that the phenomena *behave and present* at least partially as intersubjective events with anchoring in what we understand as the physical world.⁹⁰

While the experiences will ultimately prompt an understanding of self that is greater than the body, abduction is also experienced as a distinctly corporeal event. Thus, to explore the phenomenology of abduction we must confront the experiences of embodiment and corporeality reported, and how the body rises to awareness as a core element of the experience.

Embodiment and the Dys-Appearing Body

Maurice Merleau-Ponty famously focused on the lived body as the locus of subjectivity, stating that consciousness is not fundamentally an “I think” but rather, an “I can.” In other words, the body serves as the foundation for a field of

⁹⁰ As I have argued elsewhere, there are more convincing alternatives to the “imaginal realm” hypothesis, such as that the alleged non-human beings may emerge, as philosopher James Madden argues, from our “Uber-Umwelt,” or a spectrum of reality right here on Earth that we do not have access to through our senses or our instruments. If the entities emerge from the “Uber-Umwelt” in relation to humans, many of the strange occurrences such as telepathic communication, flotation through solid objects, and the strange appearances and behavior of the beings may make sense if we are coming into contact with something that normally resides in a spectrum of reality we do not have access to. Another possibility draws on Michael Masters’ and Luis Elizondo’s hypothesis that the UAP intelligence appears to be able to create a bubble of warped-space time in the vicinity of their crafts. If this indeed is the case, this would explain not only how abductions are able to take place in populated areas without anyone noticing, but also the “alternate reality” feeling reported by some abductees. See “Beyond the Imaginal: Rethinking the Non-ordinary Nature of Abduction Experiences” in *UFOs Here and Now: 21st Century Perspectives on Unidentified Anomalous Phenomena*, ed. William Dewan, Alison Fields and Daniel Wojcik (Syracuse University Press, Forthcoming); See James Madden, *Unidentified Flying Hyperobject: UFOs, Philosophy and the End of the World* (Ontocalypse Press, 2023), 57-58; See Michael Masters, *The Extraterrestrial Model* (Full Circle Press, 2022), 243-254, and Luis Elizondo *Imminent: Inside the Pentagon’s Hunt for UFOs* (New York: William Morrow, 2024), 154-159.

possibilities for acting and being a subject. The body is a dynamic but unified whole, a “knot of living significations”⁹¹ that anchors our subjectivity spatially in the world, not an object like other natural objects. Merleau-Ponty describes the ‘habitual body’ as a pre-reflective engagement with the world, an automatic directedness that reveals itself in our daily operations: tying shoes, turning a doorknob, reaching for a glass. This experience of the body precedes our immersion in any particular situation.⁹² The habitual body acts at the level of a pre-reflective, operative intentionality, not at the level of reflective, conscious “acts.” Merleau-Ponty describes a type of pre-reflective rhythmic “pulsation of existence,” that makes our experience of our body more than a mechanical “collection of reflexes” but also not emerging from explicit awareness.⁹³ Merleau-Ponty illustrates this through his famous discussion of the phantom limb. When an individual loses a limb like an arm, the body still reaches towards its goals and projects, attempting to act in the world as it usually would. “The body is the vehicle of being in the world, and having a body is, for a living creature, to be involved in a definite environment, to identify oneself with certain projects and be continually committed to them.”⁹⁴

In *The Absent Body*, Drew Leder explores how even though the body serves as the locus of our subjectivity in the world, it often fades into the background, below our conscious awareness, unless it is in distress. If our body is functioning well, we often pay it little to no attention; it may fade into the background the way the buzzing of the air conditioner fades from my awareness as I focus on my writing. In moments of dysfunction the body appears and becomes present to us in its state of dysfunction—it “dys-appears.” “In dys-appearance, the body is thematized at times of dysfunction or problematic operation.”⁹⁵ The body dys-appears not only in states of pain, but disease, disruption, hunger, thirst, or the affectivity of rage or depression. If I stub my toe when walking into the kitchen, my body and foot in particular surge into my field of awareness, present to me as a dysfunction to which I must immediately react. My body in pain becomes a type of alien presence, disrupting my conscious intentionality.⁹⁶ The body emerges as an alien presence that may trap us, disrupt our intentionality and introduce a spatiotemporal constriction into the field of possibilities for the “I can.” We want to, but our body limits us.

In the bewildering experience of abduction, the impossible, ontologically shocking nature of what is occurring, as well as its vagueness and mystery, draws the

⁹¹ Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, trans. Donald A. Landes (New York: Routledge, 2012), 153

⁹² *Ibid.*, 96-97.

⁹³ *Ibid.*, 92.

⁹⁴ *Ibid.*, 94.

⁹⁵ Drew Leder, *The Absent Body* (Chicago: Chicago University Press, 1990), 85.

⁹⁶ *Ibid.*, 73-74, 87.

individual's attention away from their bodies and into the experience. However, as it is affected in the abduction experience, the body dys-appears, becoming an explicit object of awareness, presenting at times like an alien presence itself.

Abduction and the Dys-Appearing Body

Many of the events during an abduction experience bring the experiencers' awareness away from their bodies, most strikingly, the presence of humanoids with big black eyes. Contrary to accusations by debunkers, the overwhelming majority of experiencers I have spoken to *do not want* their experiences to have any physical reality to them, and hope they are explainable as dreams or psychopathology. It is in the moments when the body dys-appears that the physical nature of the accounts comes surging into awareness, often in haunting, ontologically shocking ways.

Famously mocked in South Park's first episode, one of the most traumatic aspects of Whitley Strieber's first remembered encounter was the significant rectal injury he suffered in the aftermath. This injury was severe enough to warrant medical attention. The events of that night were as shocking and unexplainable to him when they occurred as they are to some first time readers now, and he subjected himself to a brain scan and psychiatric evaluation in search of a traditional explanation.⁹⁷ As much as he wanted the incident to be explained away as hallucination or repressed trauma, his body repeatedly reminded him of the physical nature of the event in its dys-appearance.

Paralysis is extremely common in abduction events, and all five of the abductees I feature in this chapter remember instances of realizing that they cannot move. In paralysis, one suffers loss of sensorimotor function and kinesthetic impairment. The environment which usually presents as a navigable field of "I can" is disrupted, and the subject realizes they have been rendered an "I cannot." Rachel had an experience that began with a gold disk that flew in her window at night and then "manifested into a woman standing next to me on the left hand side of my bed."

When I went to look at her, I realized that I was paralyzed. But I could move my eyes. In my periphery, I could see that she was tall and she had long blonde hair... In my head, I'm so freaked out. I can't scream. Although I didn't really have the urge to scream really... just an exclamation to wake up my fiancé. But I couldn't move.

The ability to move and to scream are background functions, part of our habitual bodily field, that we take for granted in our navigation of the world. Rachel's body dys-appears in its inability to move. Her *ability* to move her eyes comes into

⁹⁷ Whitley Strieber, *Communion: A True Story* (San Antonio: Walker and Collier, 2022), 3-25.

awareness against the background of her *inability* to move her body. A gap forms between herself and her body; the body is experienced as an alien presence that is other than her. No longer an instrument she can use to explore the world, her sense of self is doubled: she is aware of her body as an object, but not a locus of her agency. In its inability to complete the task, its *dysfunction*, the body dys-appears as a theme in her experience.

The morning after Catherine's strange experience in the upstate New York woods, she found herself "instantly awake" in bed. She describes this distinctly not as a moment of waking up from sleep, but a displacement in time, a gap from one moment to the next. Extremely confused, but with vivid recall of parts of what had occurred, she reports going to the bathroom and checking her body for marks or signs. She noted to herself that this was strange behavior, that she must have just had a very bad and vivid dream. However, her body won't allow it; it dys-appears into her awareness, forcing her to confront the physicality of what occurred. "I went to the fridge and I drank almost an entire gallon of milk because I was so dehydrated. It felt as if I had been away for three days or something like that." In the moment of dehydration and exhaustion, her body issues a distinctly affective call that she cannot ignore. She must answer it by quenching her thirst, noting that her body is not fading into the background like it does on a normal morning. In its dys-appearance, her body reminds her of that haunting night, which refuses to fade from awareness like dreams do.

Jeanette's body dys-appears in her experience primarily in the form of nosebleeds and medical procedures on her nose. While her profuse nosebleeds began as early as five, it is in her first remembered abduction as an adult that her nose dys-appears as a theme of the experience. She describes observing the beings coming towards her with a "long knitting needle." Jeanette, coming from a Choctaw background that acknowledges the existence of advanced non-human intelligences, was not as initially disturbed as some of the other abductees. However, the knitting needle and thought of it being inserted into her body changes that tone.

This was not something I wanted to do. Whatever that was, I did not want to do that. And then, I guess I blacked out. I don't know if it was for twenty minutes or an hour. But I came to and yeah, my left nostril felt funny. And by funny, I knew someone had messed with it. It's not that it was sore, but there was something there and I couldn't figure out what it was. And the discomfort, you know, subsided over time.

While Jeanette describes herself as "blacking out" during the actual insertion, the experience lingers on in her dys-appearing body. She would normally not be conscious of her nose, but has the lingering feeling in the aftermath of the experiences that something is "off" about it. The sensation brings the nose to her

awareness, reminding her of the physicality of what occurred. The disruption does not end there. She continued to have nosebleeds so profuse that she eventually had to have her nose cauterized. This caused further discomfort and alienation, an affective demand that forces a response. In her attempt to respond, she ends up pulling an unidentified metal object out of her nose.

It was so god awful, because you feel like things are creeping in your nose and like there are bricks in your nose. So I went to the bathroom and I took a tweezer, like I've got to get this out or I'm going to go crazy. And I did. I gently pulled it out but it wasn't a scab. It wasn't a clot. It was a very tiny piece of rectangular metal that I could not bend. And I went, 'Huh.'

In the removal of a foreign object with no traditional explanation of how it got there, Jeanette's nose is made present in its dysfunction. The continued malfunctioning of her nose eventually brings Jeanette to the brink of death. Leder reminds us that death is the final termination of the "I can" and in the movement towards death in terminal illness, or in brushes with death, our bodies become present in their dysfunction, threatening to annihilate all future intentions and goals.⁹⁸ It is in these moments that we may feel the largest gap from our body; it emerges as an alien Other that stands in our way. Jeanette told me that although it's been many years since she had an experience she can recall, about one year ago she almost lost her life.

It was seven nosebleeds in nine days. And two trips to the ER. When they finally got it under control and I went back for a checkup, the doctor was very quiet about it. And I said, "You know, I'm somebody who thrives on information, so tell me what you saw up there." And he said "it was like a volcano erupted. I was afraid we were going to lose you." And I said, "Well, what causes this?" And he got very quiet and he looked at me and he said, "You know, you belong to a small group of people who have these issues."

Jeanette's brush with death is coupled with the doctor not being able to give her any conventional explanation for what is causing the dysfunction of her body. Having had lifelong experiences and coming from a culture where these encounters were accepted, Jeanette never seemed to doubt the physicality of what happened to her. However, the effects of what occurs are continuously made present in her bodily experience.

Although Sarah similarly reports experiences beginning as early as age four, unlike Jeanette she often questioned what was happening, attempting to write them off as dreams. One night she recalls waking up and seeing two gray beings walking her six-year-old son down the hallway. Panicking at the thought that they were taking

⁹⁸ Leder, *The Absent Body*, 84.

her child, she attempted to get out of bed to stop them. Rather than a feeling of paralysis, Sarah instead felt a pain in her leg, “like a shot and I went out.” Sarah says for the next year and a half, the spot on her thigh had a white circle around it that served as “a visual reminder for me.” Sarah’s thigh dys-appears originally in pain, but then in its strange appearance. This introduces a moment of existential rupture for Sarah, as she cannot write off the experiences any longer. In the dys-appearance of the mark on her thigh, she is reminded of the bodily nature of what occurred. “And that, that, that’s when it really broke. Because I was awake for this. This wasn’t something— a memory that somebody had to recall. This was me, wide awake, watching the whole thing happen and I couldn’t attribute it to a dream anymore.”

Sarah’s bodily experiences further intensify. In a profound moment of bodily alienation, the doctor informs her that she is missing an ovary, even though she had never undergone surgery.

My left ovary was causing me problems and I had a lot of pain. And I remember waking up one morning and there was just a blue line that looked like a laser. It looked like a bruise almost, but it looked like a blue line, and the pain was gone. It did not hurt any more. Not only that, but a few years later the doctor’s like “There’s no record of surgery. Where’s your ovary?” My left ovary was gone. And I’ve never had surgery. All of my children were born by vaginal birth.

Sarah’s body as the locus of her subjective life is interrupted and the missing ovary dys-appears into her awareness. It is not bodily dysfunction that serves as an interruption to her intended goals, but the mystery of the missing body part that will not allow her to carry on as usual.

Leder comments that bodily dys-appearance also has a hermeneutical moment— the disruption of our bodies “gives rise to a search for interpretation and understanding.”⁹⁹ The dys-appearance issues a call to understand what the bodily disturbances *mean*, why they occur, how they offer clues as to what is going on. All experiencers see the bodily disruption as demanding explanation and interpretation. Jeanette, for example, tells me she believes the beings have inserted devices into her nose to “keep track of me” and to “trigger a certain level of perception in me.” The body in its dys-appearance demands an explanation.

While the abduction encounter stretches beyond the physical, and also challenges and blurs the boundaries of what we understand the body to be, in its repeated dys-appearance, the body emerges as a core component of the abduction experience. Any explanatory hypothesis accounting for abduction events must take the bodily nature of what occurs seriously.

⁹⁹ Ibid., 78.

Intersubjectivity, Intercorporeality, and the Alien

The abduction experience is not only defined by the bodily disruption and disappearance of the body, but by the encounter with an embodied Other— an intersubjective encounter. Experiencers report that the entities they interact with are physically embodied— they touch them, use tools, gesture and point, have chairs and control panels for moving their craft, and can have embodied sexual experiences with humans. Husserl describes our encounter with the embodied human Other as an apperceptive process, in which we understand the Other and their body as similar to ours, as occupying space similar to the way that we do, and their stream of conscious creating their own world in a way that is analogous but not identical to our own. We perceive the Other "such as I should be if I were there."¹⁰⁰ We are able to empathize not only with their physical movements but their "psychic occurrences" and we are able to intuit if they are joyful, angry, or frustrated based on our own bodily conduct in similar circumstances.¹⁰¹ There is also a sense of symmetry and equality that emerges from the encounter with the Other. Sartre, for example, argued in his account of the Look that it is through the gaze of the Other that we realize ourselves as bodily objects for others to see, interpret and respond to. Simultaneously, we realize the Other is also an object for us to see and acknowledge.¹⁰²

In *The Visible and the Invisible*, Merleau-Ponty continues his dissolution of Cartesian dualism by arguing that both the perceiver and the perceived emerge from the field of "flesh." When our right hand touches our left, it is both the toucher and the touched, we are of the world at the same time we perceive it. Flesh is not flesh in the biological sense, but the elemental fabric of experience, the reversible field where the seer and seen, toucher and touched intertwine.¹⁰³ Merleau-Ponty in this text replaces discussion of intersubjectivity with *intercorporeality*, the Other's presence to me as another lived body (Leib).¹⁰⁴ The lived body is not just a private container of our subjective experience, but a relational field where we encounter and experience other bodies. Prior to reflective thought, there is a mutual openness to the bodies of others at the level of gesture, posture, facial expression, breath, and movement.

¹⁰⁰ Edmund Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations: An Introduction to Phenomenology*, trans. Dorion Cairns (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1982), 119.

¹⁰¹ Ibid.

¹⁰² Jean Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness: An Essay in Phenomenological Ontology*, trans. Sarah Richmond (New York: Washington Square Press, 2018), 347-409.

¹⁰³ Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *The Visible and Invisible*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1968), 133, 137, 146.

¹⁰⁴ Ibid., 142-143.

The Other ... is thus always on the margin of what I see and hear, he is this side of me, he is beside or behind me....He is like that double which the sick man feels always at his side, who resembles him like a brother, upon whom he could never fix without making him disappear.¹⁰⁵

The flesh as a relational field “animates other bodies as well as my own”¹⁰⁶ and the reversibility in the field— the ability to touch and be touched, to see and be seen, opens up a door to an “intercorporeal being, a presumptive domain of the visible and the tangible, which extends further than the things I touch and see at present.”¹⁰⁷ The same senses of touch that allow one hand to touch another enables a “transitivity” to other bodies, and we perceive other bodies as capable of touching or being touched.¹⁰⁸ The relationship and communication from one body to another “cannot be construed as occurring on the level of consciousness and thought but somehow are corporeal and fleshly.”¹⁰⁹

In Leder’s account, our bodies not only dys-appear when they are in a state of physical dysfunction, but when we are made present to the gaze of the Other, which he calls “social dys-appearance.” However social dys-appearance does not occur as long as the Other I encounter treats me like a fellow subject, an interlocutor who communicates with me. If the stance of the other is “antagonistic or objectifying” we become conscious of ourselves as an “alien thing” determined by the other’s gaze.¹¹⁰ I become conscious of my body when I walk into a party underdressed, when an Other catches me in an act I am ashamed of, when I enter a foreign land and clearly stand out from others.. In these moments, our bodies present as a problem for us, they dys-appear into our attention precisely because they are present as an object for an Other that feels out of our control.

This bridges to the work of Bernhard Waldenfels, who emphasizes the body’s vulnerability to that which is “alien” or that which appears as radically Other in our experience. Our bodies, according to Waldenfels, are not fully our own, but the site where we are touched by that which is foreign to us.¹¹¹ While our subjectivity is anchored in our body, Waldenfels argues it is not the *initiator* of much of our corporeal life— perception originates not in the body but in the objects or events that

¹⁰⁵ Merleau-Ponty, *The Prose of the World*, trans. by John O’Neill (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1973), 134.

¹⁰⁶ Merleau-Ponty, *Visible*, 140-141.

¹⁰⁷ *Ibid.*, 142-143.

¹⁰⁸ *Ibid.*, 143.

¹⁰⁹ Dermot Moran, “Intercorporeality and Intersubjectivity: A Phenomenological Exploration of Embodiment,” in *Embodiment, Enaction, and Culture: Investigating the Constitution of the Shared World*, ed. Christopher Durt, Thomas Fuchs, and Christian Tewes (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2017), 39.

¹¹⁰ Leder, *The Absent Body*, 96.

¹¹¹ Bernhard Waldenfels, *A Phenomenology of the Alien: Basic Concepts*, trans. Tanja Stahler and Alexander Kozin (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 2011), 46-47.

catch our attention. Thus in our embodied and corporeal experience we are often touched and interrupted by that which we do not author. “I call this happening *pathos*, *Widerfahrnis*, or af-fect, marked by a hyphen in order to suggest that something is done to us which we do not initiate.”¹¹² In our experience “there appear events that overcome or happen to us.”¹¹³ We are not the autonomous determiners of our lives, but constantly react to forms of alienness which make us never fully present to ourselves.

The alienness of our everyday experience leads to the presence of the alien in the Other. The presence of the Other emerges into our embodied life as *pathos*, as that which we do not expect or anticipate. “We are touched by others before being able to ask who they are and what their expressions mean. The alienness of the Other overcomes and surprises us, disturbing our intentions before being understood in this or that sense.”¹¹⁴ The alien call arrives through the body—a foreign touch, voice, gaze or presence— and is not something we initiate, rather, something we respond to. The presence of the Other’s gaze and the sound of her voice as she addresses me does not appear in our horizon as only sensory data, but as referring to ourselves, implicating us in an intercorporeal field. Our bodies are not merely ours, they are a social site where we are made present to Others, where that which is alien constitutes us while calling our boundaries into question.¹¹⁵ “The *pathos* which gives birth to sense and to myself, bears the features of an *allopatheros* which begins from others. We will never be completely settled in our own body as if we owned ourselves; but, maybe, it is this very restlessness that keeps us living.”¹¹⁶ While *pathos* is a general disruption that can come from inside or outside the self, *allopatheros* originates in the Other, in that which is foreign.

Waldenfels thus lays the groundwork for understanding abduction not merely as an anomalous event, but as a form of bodily and existential disruption—a profound *allopatheros* that emerges from beyond the familiar. The Other experienced by abductees is not one previously encountered in the field of flesh—not a human Other with whom intercorporeality has been lived, but a radically unknown presence. The truly unknown, alien Other, surges into their lives as *allopatheros*, disrupting their rhythmic and habitual bodies, and processes of sense-making. The body is the site where the non-human Other touches them, violates them, and simultaneously calls to them in a way that forces a response.

¹¹² Ibid., 46.

¹¹³ Ibid.

¹¹⁴ Ibid. 53.

¹¹⁵ Ibid., 56.

¹¹⁶ Ibid., 57

Encounters with the Embodied Other

The encounter with the non-human Other usually begins with a grasp for what is familiar— the experiencers first interpret the beings in their experience as other humans with bodies like themselves. They complete a Husserlian pre-reflective pairing, noting the ways their bodies mirror our own. But on reflection, something is not quite right. Rachel recalls her first abduction experience at nine years old, when she woke up to find herself in a circular room, with humanoid beings who had their backs to her. She first interprets them as human others, until they turn around and she cannot complete the pairing. “When they looked at me, I could tell that they were not one hundred percent human. Their faces were just a little different shape. Their eyes were a little bit more almond.” While recognizing the Others as bodies embedded in space and time like herself, she also notices ways in which their embodiment does not mirror hers.

Returning to Catherine’s experience when she strangely woke up in the middle of the woods, she recalls lying on the ground seeing “small people with even smaller people” walking towards her. As what looked like a female human with a young boy walked towards her, Catherine was shocked to realize that the being was not human. “[S]he had this humanoid looking face, with a pointy chin, but her eyes were quite big and her hair was wispy. Just not the way human beings look at all.” When she looked at the young boy, Catherine “got really disgusted and really stressed out because I realized he wasn’t human either.” The boy had a humanoid face, pointy chin, very small nose, was bald, had wispy hair, and larger than human eyes. She describes the child also as lacking in energy and affect. The inability to complete the apperceptive pairing is what brings the experience into the realm of reflection; the larger than human eyes signal that Catherine is not dealing with a traditionally human Other. She expresses a reaction of stress and disgust, as the non-human Other erupts into her experience as *allopáthos*. While we are used to sharing the field of *flesh* with embodied Others, such as humans and non-human animals, the beings that emerge into Catherine’s field of awareness are not beings she has encountered in the flesh before. Their presence is disruptive, unexpected, *truly alien*.

The situation becomes more disruptive when the female being approaches and pushes the small child towards her. “It was clear she was trying to connote some kind of relationship between us.” When Catherine pushed back and said no, this is not related to me, the being persisted.

She was making it very clear that he was connected to me. And I paused again...this time I could feel her inside of my mind...and she was trying to share this idea of mine...She said it again, “Yours.” And the way that she said it, and how loud she was in my head and then the meaning of it went through my body and then I got what she was saying. That this is my

offspring, my child. My brain just sort of melted after that. Like I had literally what John calls the ontological shock. It's just totally traumatic.

The *allopathos* encountered is not just the embodied presence of the non-human beings in front of her, but her hermeneutic realization of what is being conveyed—that this is her own child. A cognitive dissonance and existential rupture emerges—she is confronted with something alien, and simultaneously told it is something familiar, a part of her, her *own*. Catherine describes the moment of realization flowing through *her body*, as the ontologically shocking information is processed. What begins as an inability to complete the pre-reflective pairing, ends with a shattering of the parameters of her known self. She is confronted not only with embodied, not fully human Others, but with a child they communicate *is hers*.

Indeed, some of the most direct forms of physical contact reported come in the focus on reproduction and sexuality. While some experiencers, such as Whitley Strieber, report medicalized removal of semen or eggs, others, like Matthew Roberts and Parker in the Worldview Study, report direct sexual contact with the entities. Let's return to Matthew's description that we visited in Chapter One:

I opened my eyes as I started to regain consciousness. I could see that there was a female on top of me. I was back in my room out of the dream. This female had blue skin. I could see her legs were straddling me. My hands were on her legs and I could feel her skin. It was not like human skin. It was clearly thicker and felt tighter than ours.¹¹⁷

Matthew recalls this as a waking consciousness experience with an embodied Other. He is confronted not just with the image of the Other in his visual field, but with the tactile and kinesthetic perception of her body. The experience does not happen at the level of thought, but in “flesh and corporeality.” Using his hands, he touches her skin. He experiences himself as the toucher and the one being touched. In the intercorporeal field of *flesh*, he reflects on what he has touched. non-humanness of the encounter surges into his awareness in the blue color and extraordinary thickness of her skin. Her presence and the alienness of what occurs forces him to respond, she surges into his experience as disruptive *allopathos*. Before he can know who or what she is, or what the encounter means, he is touched by her in an intercorporeal exchange. “The alienness of the Other overcomes and surprises us, disturbing our intentions before being understood in this or that sense.”¹¹⁸ Matthew is struck by new layers of the alien flesh; it is through touch and intercorporeality and the presence of his own body in relation to hers that he is overcome by the height of the strangeness of the encounter.

¹¹⁷ Matthew Roberts, *Initiated: UAP, Dreams, Depression, Delusions, Shadow People, Psychosis, Sleep Paralysis and Pandemics* (Self-published, 2020), 83.

¹¹⁸ Waldenfels, *Phenomenology of the Alien*. 53.

Parker describes the most “unbelievable” part of his own experiences as a memory he recovered with Mack of a sexual encounter with one of the beings.

[I remember] being brought into a room. Being with an alien, but I also know that she is a female. Like I have this awareness of gender within their species. [T]here was a real clear awareness that I was being paired or mated with a female alien. And that female alien, again, had the attributes of the grays, but she presented with...some characteristics of a human female. And now I know it was to elicit my attraction response. And in that moment, there was an awareness. Like, “Oh, I’m supposed to make love with this being or we’re supposed to mate.” And the image [I recall] is us lying on a— it felt more like a block of stone than it felt like a bed— and an awareness that we were being observed by a group of aliens, the elders. It was all being monitored and we were supposed to...be sexual. It felt like it was a physical connection designed to imprint our connection for each other...And at the time, it felt so repulsive. Like I can remember going, “Oh my god, I just had sex with an alien. I can’t believe this.” And not only that, but was it against my will? Was it coerced? Did I agree to this? Like, how did this happen? I was devastated. Even in this moment, it’s so hard for me to comprehend it and sit with [the possibility] that it happened and not want to put it into a fantasy or an illusion.

Parker expresses a bodily intentionality that picks up on the subtle clues of the gender expression of the being, which has the attributes of the grays, but mixed with some “characteristics of a human female,” disrupting habitual perceptual categories. He encounters the gaze of others, who he senses as watching him, and that the sexual encounter is planned and for an intended purpose. He experiences social dys-appearance as he realizes he is present for Others in a way that is not under his control. His own body becomes alien to him; he describes the repulsion and disgust at the event and the circumstances surrounding it. Waldenfels’ use of “alien intentions”¹¹⁹ takes on new meaning in Parker’s experience. He is touched in a deeply corporeal way by the intentions of beings of unknown origin. Everything about the encounter emerges from outside of him, his body is not his own. The “alien intentions” take over the experience from start to finish.

The experience is not without its hermeneutical moment. In Parker’s attempt to make sense of what occurred, he communicated to me that he feels he had likely had experiences since he was a child, and that perhaps as he grew and matured, he “established a deeper and deeper relationship with the opposite sex being.” Parker’s encounter seems to blur the boundaries of how we understand

¹¹⁹ “My own body could be described as a half-alien body, charged by alien intentions, but also desires, projections, habits, affections, and violations, coming from others,” Waldenfels, *A Phenomenology*, 56.

agency and choice. At one level he communicates an encounter that is not initiated by him and is completely out of his control. But he simultaneously experienced in his own hermeneutic process that he may have been a more active participant than he initially thought. The ambiguity of the memory and wider context in which it occurred over a lifetime of experiences influence his meaning-making process.

It is clear from these descriptions however that it is not just the *physicality* of the abduction experience that characterizes the phenomenology of abduction, but the *non-consensuality* as well.

Non-Consensual Encounters

To explore the non-consensual aspects of abduction events, it may be useful to draw parallels with some of the phenomenological literature on consent and assault. This is not to argue that abduction is *reducible* to being assaulted by a non-human entity. As we have seen already, the encounters are far more nuanced and complex. However, exploring the phenomenological structure of other non-consensual events can illuminate key phenomenological themes. Ann Cahill, for example, argues that the act of sexual assault from another human being deprives the victim from the status of subject, making true intersubjectivity in the experience impossible. “Here in a radical way, only one person (the assailant) is acting, and one person (the victim) is wholly acted on. This imbalance, in its total nature, renders the victim incapable of being truly engaged intersubjectively.”¹²⁰ The intersubjective relation becomes one-sided in a non-consensual event. While many abductees over time progress to the point of a more reciprocal, consensual relationship with the beings, the paralysis, capture, non-consensual procedures, physical contact, and presence of the powerful, alien Other leave them feeling robbed of all sense of agency and choice.

Taking Merleau-Ponty’s phenomenology as her starting point, Ellie Anderson develops a phenomenological account of sexual consent as a form of an embodied “feeling-with.” She is critical of approaches in sexual ethics that rely on individualist concepts of personhood and see sexual consent as anchored in “giving permission.” Such accounts imply by nature that individuals have fixed boundaries that they can choose to permit others to transgress when the reality is more nuanced. A phenomenological understanding of embodied relationality begins with a more fluid and continuously constituted sense of self. She writes, “Phenomenologically speaking, we may define consent as an intercorporeal and dynamic coexistence of desiring bodies...To feel-with is to desire-with.”¹²¹ Anderson argues that consent is future-oriented, desiring a specific type of experience to unfold with the Other.

¹²⁰ Ann Cahill, *Rethinking Rape* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2001), 132.

¹²¹ Ellie Anderson, “A Phenomenological Approach to Sexual Consent,” *Feminist Philosophy Quarterly* 8.2 (2022): 15.

“This unfolding is intercorporeally situated and temporally dynamic. It involves a perceptual copresence with another body...”¹²² Our consensual engagement with the Other over time is not static and involves a direct perception of the others’ inner feelings. While Anderson references an erotic, sexual experience, there is something more essential implied. Any consent to touch another’s body, for medical purposes, during a friendly hug, or during a sexual encounter involves a co-presence with another’s body, and a direct perception of the other’s body language, feelings, and comfort. Consensual physical experience does not treat one person like an object, but as a fellow embodied subject in an intercorporeal field.

In the encounter with the unknown and unacknowledged Other, abductees find their bodies treated as objects rather than acknowledged as the direct expression of their lived subjectivity: waking to find scars on their bodies and surgeries performed without their knowledge, the recall of sexual encounters with the entities, the introduction to alleged hybrid children created without their consent, the removal of foreign objects from their bodies with no recall or understanding of how they got there. Memories surface of paralysis, bodily transport, waking up on a table, and the alien touch as they are prodded and poked by the entities. Even the boundaries of their own minds and inner mental life are violated when they look into the big black eyes of the abducting entities. In his phenomenological exploration of abduction encounters, philosopher Michael E. Zimmerman comments,

Apparently, being paralyzed, floated through walls into a non-human aircraft, and physically probed by strange life forms is frightening enough, but an extraordinary terror often arises when abductees are forced to look into the large, almond-shaped, intensely black, and seemingly impenetrable eyes of the aliens. The overpowering alien gaze often leaves on feeling drained of personhood and agency.¹²³

As Zimmerman notes, this aspect of the alien gaze has no direct correlate in our experience of the human gaze. Leder’s social dys-appearance cannot capture the loss of control and agency that occurs with the meeting of the alien eyes.

In the absence of recognition of their embodied subjectivity, and the disrespect for their autonomous boundaries, all from a non-human Other who ostensibly does not exist, abductees are rendered completely and utterly powerless, with no forms of recourse or resolution. Experiencers’ sense of autonomous agency is dislodged, the idea that they have control over what happens to them is completely subverted. The entities present as an unacknowledged, unknown Other that can see

¹²² Ibid.

¹²³ Michel E. Zimmerman, “Encountering an Alien Otherness” in *The Concept of the Foreign: An Interdisciplinary Dialogue*, ed. Rebecca Saunders (New York: Lexington Books, 2003), 164.

without being seen, can intrude into the boundaries of homes, cars, bodies, and minds, and leave experiencers bewildered and traumatized.¹²⁴

Julia Kristeva wrote extensively on the human experience of becoming a subject, and how this is an ongoing liminal process. Kristeva's "abject" is that which exists somewhere in between the state of being an object and being a subject. The abject is that which is cast off or separated from the norms, rules, and social order of society—that which disturbs social reason. The abject is usually associated with unsettling aspects of the bodily, such as death, excrement, vomit, menstruation, and childbirth, which challenge the boundaries of the inside and outside of the body. Abjection is the reaction of horror or disgust we have towards that which threatens a breakdown in the meaning and boundaries of the "me" and "not-me." Kristeva sees the subject as permanently "in process" never arriving at a firm, fixed sense of identity. In *Powers of Horror*, Kristeva writes, "[W]hat is *abject*...the jettisoned object, is radically excluded and draws me toward the place where meaning collapses...it lies outside, beyond the set, and does not seem to agree to the latter's rules of the game."¹²⁵ An encounter with the abject threatens the established boundaries of subjectivity and objectivity, the most essential categories for how we organize the lifeworld of marked states.

In encountering the abject, the boundaries of the "I" are challenged. The subject is cast into a state of being without borders—the abject intrudes, transgresses, and subverts. The subject feels the possibility of their existence as physical self put into question. "It is no longer I who expel, 'I' is expelled. The border has become an object. How can I be without a border?"¹²⁶ Though the abject is associated with filth, death, and disease, this is not ultimately what causes the reaction of abjection. It is rather the breakdown of social order, rules, and concepts we use to make sense of our experience. Crimes against the self, such as rape, assault, or other violations of autonomy, disrupt the borders of the self. The subject is thrown into an in-between space with undefined boundaries.

In non-consensual contact, abductees experience their boundaries being penetrated and put in danger, threatening their status as a subject. Confronted by an abject that seems to intrude from another world, their experience lacks clear definitions and cannot be neatly categorized and named. "How can I be without a

¹²⁴ Mack identified four dimensions of the traumatic aspect of encounters. First, the non-consensual experiences themselves. Second, the lifelong sense of estrangement and isolation from those closest to them. Third, the ontological shock that what happened to them is not congruent with the modern scientific understanding of the world. And fourth, the ongoing knowledge that the events could reoccur at any time, and there is nothing anyone could do to stop it. *Abduction*, 44-45.

¹²⁵ Julia Kristeva, *Powers of Horror: An Essay on Abjection*, trans. Leon Roudiez (New York: Columbia University Press, 1982), 1-2.

¹²⁶ *Ibid.*, 4

border?” Kristeva asks. This is precisely the question the abductees are left to confront in the aftermath. Their borders are continuously violated, again and again, as dys-appearance of their bodies in the months following their encounters serve as continuous reminders that the boundaries of the old world no longer hold. In the aftermath of her initial encounter, Catherine describes the literal splitting that occurred in her mind as she desperately tried to hold onto the boundaries of her worldview, a world that had order and rules.

I didn't even know I had a worldview until these encounters came in. Because the worldview was saying this isn't possible, and yet sometimes, several times a week, I was encountering these beings and having all of these strange things happen, I had this other part of my brain saying, “but this is actually happening” ...So it's not supposed to happen, but it's happening.

Experiencers *know* that what they are going through is impossible, and yet *it is*. They sense it threatens to annihilate them, or at least annihilate their previous conception of themselves. All of their deepest understandings of what it means to be an embodied subject in our world are on the table, up for contention and revision.

I offer this analysis to acknowledge the ontological shock and trauma suffered by abductees, and for most, suffered without a compassionate practitioner to work with or sympathetic witness to share in what they experienced. As we will see, many abductees with time and integration come to view their experiences in a positive and transformative light. This does not make the initial experience less violating, shocking, or terrifying. The experiences dislodge the conception of selfhood that many experiencers have been raised to accept, in which each individual is an atomistic, sovereign individual with clearly defined borders and boundaries. This occurs not only in the non-consensual nature of the contact and rendering of the individuals as powerless, but in the ways that the abduction experience subverts and blurs the boundaries of what we understand corporeal embodiment to entail.

Multidimensional Dys-Appearance

Drawing on Merleau-Ponty and Leder offers useful groundwork but also has limitations. The abduction experience takes us far from the parameters of subjectivity and corporeality as they have been understood throughout the history of western philosophy. To understand abduction as a subversive and transformative process, I will develop the notion of *multidimensional dys-appearance*. Multidimensional dys-appearance is the response to an encounter with embodied Otherness that breaks down the terrestrial boundaries of intercorporeality. The body becomes present to consciousness not in its lived dysfunction, but in a breakdown of the boundaries of the body as the locus of our subjectivity. Subjective experiences occur

across physical, psychical, and potentially transdimensional registers, destabilizing the body as it is conceived within the traditional spatiotemporal horizon.

The dysfunction experienced is the cognitive dissonance of undergoing multidimensional experiences while trying to maintain a limited understanding of corporeality. Like Leder's terrestrial dys-appearance, multidimensional dys-appearance demands a response; just as we must attend to the pain that strikes through our leg when we skin our knee, experiencers must attend to the distress of multidimensional dysfunction. However its remedy does not come in the form of fixing an ailment or restoring the body to previous pre-reflective humdrum; in other words, repressing the experience. Rather, it calls the subject to reconfigure their understanding of embodiment; to incorporate transpersonal experiences that occur across physical, non-physical and ambiguous domains— a multidimensional subjectivity. I employ multidimensional in a modest sense, to imply experiences that challenge or transcend the traditional spatiotemporal horizon of the embodied "I" and point to a more complex and expansive experiential field.

Finding themselves paralyzed by the look of eyes or the touch of an instrument, abductees' understanding of bodily limitation is subverted and overwhelmed. The "I can" is disrupted not by devastating injury or ailment, but by the apparent mysterious abilities of otherworldly, extremely powerful beings. The exact mechanisms of control are unclear; the experience sits in an in-between space of advanced technology (and instrument) and psychical control (the beings' eyes). This bodily disruption *and their reflection on it in its aftermath*, problematize the body in the abductees' experience; their understanding of how their bodies can be acted upon across space is challenged. Similarly, as many recall being floated through solid objects, noting only a slight vibratory sensation as this happens, the solidity of their corporeality— a key defining property of their body as it exists in a spatiotemporal world— is called into question. These experiences gnaw at the psyche of abductees precisely because the limitations of embodiment must be rewritten. Their borders are in question; the abjected is not just that which is repressed to form a self, but that which emerges from beyond human reality as we know it. A dis-ease or discomfort emerges that demands attention; a dissonance that can only be resolved by an expanded conception of what it means to live as an embodied subject.

The multidimensional dys-appearance is not limited to strange experiences of paralysis or the sensation of being floated through walls. Encounters with the strange Other emerge include distinctly disembodied elements; out of body experiences where the individual feels their consciousness displaced from their bodies. For example, after Catherine's experience in the upstate NY woods, which she is confident she experienced as a physical experience in waking consciousness, she reports ongoing psychical experiences in the aftermath:

I started having out-of-body experiences, which I had never had in my life, which were terrifying because I didn't have any worldview that accommodated that. In those out of body experiences, I would say 80% of them happened with two or three of these little gray beings that were standing there as I came out of my body. I could see the room. I could look down and see my body and my fiancé. A couple of times I was just out of body on my own, just spinning around. It was a really nauseating experience. Describing the experiences as "terrifying," Catherine's previous understanding of the borders of herself and her corporeality did not include the ability for her consciousness to separate from her body. Her worldview, which she describes as committed to naturalism and materialism, had no sense-making tools to process or place these experiences. The experiences cannot be ignored; they dys-appear, demand attention. They problematize her previous understanding of embodiment. Either the experiences must be denied, or the worldview must expand to accommodate them.

One of the most profound challenges to embodiment and corporeality as we understand it comes in the telepathic communication and "mind scan" procedures reported by abductees. According to the consensus boundaries of reality, I have access to my inner mental states, but do not have access to anyone else's. While the research on the telepathic abilities of non-speaking people with autism is now challenging that boundary in a meaningful way,¹²⁷ the abductees are confronted with intense experiences of telepathic communication for the first time, an existentially jarring experience as the most private contents of their minds become accessible to an alien Other. Even Leder's social dys-appearance cannot account for everything abductees report. In his research with abductees, historian David Jacobs describes the reported mindscan procedure:

This 'mindscan' procedure involves a taller [alien] being staring deeply and penetratingly into the abductee's eyes from a distance of roughly six inches to actually touching foreheads. During this agonizing procedure, the abductee cannot close his eye, nor can he look away...One person said he had the feeling his mind was being played back like a video tape recorder. Often abductees will say that specific emotions can be elicited during the Mindscan. The aliens can bring out profound feelings of fear, terror, rage, anger, shame, guilt, and the like.¹²⁸

¹²⁷ Ky Dickens, "The Telepathy Tapes Podcast," 2024, <https://thetelepathytapes.com>.

¹²⁸ David Jacobs, "Medical Examination and Subsequent Procedures," in *Alien Discussions*, ed. Andre Pritchard, David E. Pritchard, John E. Mack, Pam Kasey, and Claudis Yapp (Cambridge: North Cambridge Press, 1994), 54.

The realization that the contents of your inner mind are being revealed to the Other in a way you cannot control violates all of our core understandings of our embodiment and corporeality. Additionally, abductees may feel their own emotions are not under their control, that their inner feelings are being instrumented by the Other. These can be considered characteristics of *multidimensional social dys-appearance*, in which the gaze of the Other does more than objectify or make one conscious of their body. Rather, the presence of the Other causes the inner boundaries and understanding of one's own mind to be dissolved and problematized. This presents as a profound form of dys-function; a bringing to awareness of the fundamental boundaries between one's body and the Other. If an embodied Other can reach into the contents of their inner lived world; the boundaries of corporeality are not what they believed they were.

In our corporeality we also have an understanding of the limitations of dreams—which are conceived in a naturalistic framework as subjective hallucinations of one's brain as they sleep—not blending into the corporeal realm of experience. But dreams play a much more significant role in close encounter experiences, including abductions, blurring the distinction between the dream world and the corporeal. Consider this account from Sarah, who describes a dream that occurred after several months of her and her husband at the time struggling to conceive.

We were living in Portsmouth and I went to bed and I dreamt that I was in this big room. It was white and I was on this bed, and my husband at the time was on another bed and when I left [the entities] said, "Okay, now you'll be pregnant." We'd been trying for a year to get pregnant with our fourth, for a year, and I couldn't. And I never had a problem getting pregnant, but I just couldn't. And so I woke up and I said to him, "I had a dream." and he said, "Hey, so did I." And we were laughing, like, "oh, what a coincidence." In my head it was just a coincidence. So I go downstairs and I'm making breakfast for my kids who are probably five and six at the time. And Dustin said, "Hey, did you see that light last night?" I said, "what light?" He said, "It was a UFO. It was behind the house. I saw the red light go behind the house in the woods." And in my head I'm going, "I bet he did," because I had just had that dream.

Her husband reporting the same dream brings the experience out of the purely subjective and into the realm of the shared. Simultaneously, her son's sighting of the UFO in physical reality bridges the gap between "dream" and "encounter" although the exact mechanisms of interaction and what occurred remain ambiguous. But the most profound effects involve her corporeality: Sarah confirms that she was, indeed, pregnant after this night. In a future experience, the gray beings expressed shared ownership of her human child, claiming that "he's ours," something that she admits

still confuses her to this day, because her son clearly looks like her husband. The limits of Sarah's body and how it is implicated in the experiences are unstable, contradictory, and defy her understanding of the corporeal. Sarah faces an ontological ambiguity regarding "where" her body was during this experience. Was she asleep in bed, or confronting beings with an ontological reality to them? Why can her husband remember the same "dream?" Why did her infertility issues resolve after that night? Her embodiment presents as a problem, a conflict of the boundaries of her corporeality.

The last form of multidimensional dys-appearance comes in the conflict and dissonance between the disruptive, non-consensual, abject aspects of the encounters, and the more intimate and transformative forms of touch experienced. Again, we may call this a multidimensional social dys-appearance, in which the Other confronted does not conform to the human parameters of embodiment. In these experiences, bodily experience is disrupted by an *allopáthos*, the body is invaded and violated, and feels alien. Simultaneously, many abductees experience sensations of love and transcendence for the alien entities, who they feel connected with in a deeply intimate way. Parker reports a difficult, traumatic experience in which he remembers being watched while he had a sexual experience with a female being. But the story does not end there. When Parker worked through the disbelief and doubt he had surrounding the experience, the relationship took on a new tone. "Once I got through the disbelief, the connection felt really, really pure and beautiful. The same way I got to this place where I felt: 'Oh my god, these beings, these aliens are my family. They're my people. I feel at home here.'" This sense of violation combined with a sense of love sets up a cognitive dissonance in his mind that must be resolved. He describes a "split consciousness" in terms of how deep his love for the alien beings felt—this deep sense of love posed a conflict for the same love he felt for his wife and family. "I wrestled with that for the longest time. Of holding the split consciousness between, 'I'm human and I have an earth consciousness and earth people that I love,' and... 'I have this alien connection and family, and it feels real and honest and genuine and sincere and loving and intimate.'"

Similarly the presence of the hybrid children gnaws at the psyche of abductees. Experiencers' understanding of the process and limits of reproduction is subverted and challenged, as the beings present with embodied offspring who appear as a cross between the humans and the alien beings. The introduction of the hybrid children is often interpreted as one of the moments of most profound distress and heightened emotion. Some abductees report feeling "disgusted" at the listless children who seem to lack affect, but others report a "new generation" of hybrid that they describe as emotionally rounded and spiritually evolved. Catherine describes an experience of being introduced to the new generation of beings, "I was

on a ship again...and one of the hybrid nurses brought in...four or five little munchies that looked like they would have been two- or three-year-old toddlers. But they were already, instantly, way fucking more intelligent than I could ever imagine being in my life...what we might call spiritually aware and balanced, and loving.”

In the encounter with the hybrid children, the distinctions between “us” and “them”, “human” and “non-human” are distinctly blurred. That which is encountered is not radically alien, but family, with some kind of genetic connection to human beings. The attempt to place the visitors into the category of “alien Other” cannot fully hold; the hybrids make them relative, like us. They dys-appear into the abductees’ waking life, demanding attention. They pose an unsolvable ontological puzzle of “where” they exist. Are they literal human-alien offspring? Do they exist in a realm outside of the boundaries of time and space as we understand it? How do they surge into lived experience in ways that intersect with abductees’ corporeal life?

While Leder’s framework helps us see how the abductees are repeatedly referred back to their bodies during their experiences, the crisis that abduction events pose for abductees’ understanding of their corporeality goes beyond material disruption. The ontological boundaries of their bodies and the ways they can be affected are put into question. The abductees are faced with a disruption that demands a response: to either repress what they have experienced, or formulate a new, multidimensional understanding of their own corporeality.

The Response: Abduction and Self-Transformation

Abduction experiences fundamentally challenge the liberal conception of personhood on which so much of western philosophy and society relies. The legal system in the United States and other western democracies, as well as theories of contractual ethics in the history of philosophy by and large presuppose the liberal conception of personhood. The liberal conception of the person considers the human subject a rational, autonomous, atomistic, independent agent with inherent rights that must be respected. For example, J.S. Mill, the founder of utilitarianism, argued that the “distinctive endowment of a human being,” consists in our “faculties of perception, judgement, discriminative feeling, mental activity, and even moral preference.” These faculties are “exercised only in making a choice.”¹²⁹ Kant, too, saw the human being as characterized by reason and autonomy, seeing the highest human expression in following the moral law and acting independently of outside influence.¹³⁰ The liberal conception of self exists prior to its existence in a social

¹²⁹ John Stuart Mill, *On Liberty*, ed. Elizabeth Rapaport (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, 1972), 56.

¹³⁰ Immanuel Kant, *Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals*, 3rd Edition, trans. James Ellington (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing, 1993), 53.

context, and as an autonomous, choice-making being with clear boundaries, should be morally protected by rights, especially guarded against any forms of coercion or intrusion on the subject's self-determination and ability to choose.¹³¹

The abduction encounter fundamentally challenges the liberal conception of personhood, leading experiencers on an existential journey that breaks down the boundaries of the self, and reconstructs a more expanded, multidimensional subjectivity. The experiencers are disrupted by an *allopáthos*, and the initial trauma precludes the possibility of meaningful response. However, this is often temporary, and the abductee begins to understand that it is not necessarily that response is being blocked, but that a new understanding of their own subjectivity, corporeality, and relation to otherness is necessary for the dialogical process to begin. By breaking down the boundaries of the established corporeal "I" and disrupting the residue of the liberal conception of personhood, the abduction experience opens the individual up to a multidimensional understanding of self and world.

By multidimensional, I mean an understanding of self that is not limited to the three-dimensional body, to the present, to the current form of embodiment, or spatiotemporal horizon of three-dimensional experience. Abductees report transpersonal experiences involving their consciousness stretching beyond the parameters of the delineated body, and a shared sense of identity with the entities who ostensibly traverse an expanded version of spatial and temporal reality. Mack identified the roots of this transformation in the shattering of the illusion of control and established boundaries of the self, what I have identified here as aspects of the abject. Once this occurs, the idea that the highest expression of the human being is bestowed in rationality and choice-making also simultaneously crumbles.

This opening to a wider identity appears to be a direct result of the abduction experiences, if not a central aspect of the whole process...The abduction experiences themselves shatter the illusion of our control, and demonstrate forcefully that we are helpless in the face of forces and beings whose purpose we do not understand. Each abductee discovers that he or she is but one intelligent being in a universe populated with various other entities that are not 'supposed to' exist. Human beings are not lords of the

¹³¹ The liberal conception of personhood has come under criticism from thinkers like Michael Sandel as well as feminist thinkers in the care ethics tradition, who argue in favor of an interdependent, situational, contextually dependent sense of the self that emerges from a set of social relationships and material conditions. See Michael Sandel, *Liberalism and the Limits of Justice* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1982); Carol Gilligan, *In a Different Voice: Psychological Theory and Women's Development* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1984), Nel Noddings, *Caring: A Feminine Approach to Ethics and Moral Education* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984), and Virginia Held, *The Ethics of Care: Personal, Political, and Global* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2006).

earth, they realize, but children of the cosmos who must find their way to live in harmony with all manner of creatures on the earth and elsewhere.¹³² Throughout their lifetime of experiences, abductees begin to understand themselves as multidimensional beings with an expanded conception of self, who are in relationship with other advanced non-human intelligences, some of which appear more evolutionarily advanced than us. No longer at the top of the evolutionary hierarchy, they are removed from their positionality as the dominant species. Having experienced the loss of control of an embodied being having complete power over them, they are also more mindful of their own positionality and relationship to other species on Earth. Mack comments, “Even the helplessness and loss or surrender of control which are, at least initially, forced upon the abductees by the aliens— one of the most traumatic aspects of the experiences— seem to be in some way ‘designed’ to bring about a kind of ego death from which spiritual growth and expansion of consciousness may follow.”¹³³

While some critical of the transformative potential of contact dismiss this as Stockholm Syndrome, or a coping mechanism to regain some control into a situation in which they have been rendered helpless, I am in agreement with Mack that this is an insufficient explanation. The abductees embark on a complex sense-making process, which often involves giving up control as a critical step into a more complex and expansive understanding of self. When the boundaries of subjectivity and objectivity are ruptured and subverted, the possibility for new distinctions, or ways of being beyond existing categories, emerges. “[I]n contrast to the narrow and self-serving purposes of human abusers and political kidnappers, the beings reveal a shared purpose, and offer the possibility of openings to an inclusive, more expansive worldview that is powerfully internalized by many abductees.”¹³⁴ Unlike Stockholm Syndrome, which involves feelings of affection for your captor as a way to regain control in a situation where you have none, the abductees *years after* their experiences consider themselves sharing goals of human growth and evolutionary benefit with the alien entities. The shared intentionality that they enter into opens up them up to a new understanding of the lifeworld that is not limited by the confines of naturalistic understandings of the world, nor by the confines of anthropocentrism.¹³⁵

¹³² Mack, *Abduction*, 409.

¹³³ *Ibid.*, 399.

¹³⁴ *Ibid.*

¹³⁵ This worldview has more in common with views shared by Indigenous tribal cultures, that were historically dismissed as “primitive” due to their non-conformance with naturalism and scientism. But even this dismissal fails to understand that many Indigenous American tribes, for example, have an expanded conception of the “natural” in which the personal and conscious elements of nature are part of the universe’s natural laws. See for example, Vine Deloria, Jr. “Power and Place Equals Personality” found in Deloria and Daniel Wildcat, *Power and Place: Indian Education in America* (Golden, CO: Fulcrum Books, 2001), 21-28.

With an expanded understanding of what a human being is, the encounters are often cast in new light, even the non-consensual aspects. The focus on agency and choice is decentered; it is understood that non-consensual and traumatic experiences can serve as an initiatory site of transformation and change. In challenging the parameters of embodiment, intersubjectivity, and intercorporeality, the experiences force the individuals to confront a more expanded understanding of self and the Other. As they are continuously referred back to their bodies through dys-appearance throughout their lifetime of experiences, an expanded understanding of what their embodiment entails emerges. The defining limits of the body are disrupted, and a more holistic relationship with the universe emerges. The encounter ultimately functions as an initiatory process into a new understanding of self, other, and world.

For example, when I asked abductees how their experiences had changed the way they think of the relationship between consciousness and the body, they replied overwhelmingly that they now understood corporeality as an outgrowth of consciousness.

I think consciousness is an eternal phenomenon, if that makes sense. I think that that is the link to our “being eternal,” if you will. I certainly understand that it doesn’t need to have a solid body to function...It does not “live in the brain so that when the body dies it dies.” No. It might get sustenance from our brain, but once we go, it leaves. It’s got its own source of energy, if you will (Jeanette).

I understand that consciousness is fundamental, it’s foundational. It’s been demonstrated over and over again in various different ways but most profoundly in the out-of-body experiences, where it’s clear that I’m still alive. I’m still there. All my faculties are very, very sharp...So mind is distinct from consciousness, mind is the body’s interpretation of consciousness. So mind is local, consciousness is not local (Catherine).

I absolutely believe...that consciousness can affect matter. Consciousness can travel over time and distance...But I absolutely believe that consciousness can interact with matter at so many different levels. You know, consciousness can interact with animals, with plants, with the spirit world, one hundred percent (Parker).

It may appear ironic that in a chapter focused on the bodily aspects of abduction, I quote experiencers speaking about the foundational nature of consciousness. However, this transformative perspective emerges out of the challenges their experiences posed for their understanding of embodiment. The multidimensional dys-appearance *problematizes* their understanding of corporeality so profoundly that the affective call requires a response that reconfigures their understanding of what

it means to live in a body. To respond to the call, they reconceive of embodiment as *one* expression that conscious experience can take, and the *primary* expression in our human lives. Simultaneously, their experiences reflect that consciousness transcends the parameters of embodiment and can be expressed in other forms. Additionally, they have experienced these other forms of consciousness (dreams, OBEs) as affecting their embodied life, attributing a distinct causal influence to consciousness in its different expressions, including the ability to act on matter.

To understand abduction as an embodied, intercorporeal experience is *not* to try to fit the experience into the parameters of naturalism and scientism, nor to claim that what is occurring is reducible to space visitors flying into homes and kidnapping and operating on human beings. It is to challenge the very boundaries of what embodiment and corporeality *mean*, of how they can be lived and experienced. It is to conceive of subjectivity as having experiential capacity on multiple planes of reality simultaneously, as interacting with physical reality but not reducible to it, as expanding corporeality beyond its immediate expression in the three-dimensional field. It is to break down distinctions between mind and body, self and Other, alien and own.

Conclusion:

My aim in this chapter is to take seriously the descriptions of experiencers, how they live and process abduction events, especially as bodily experiences. Phenomenology on its own cannot tell us exactly what the source of the abduction encounters is, but it *can* tell us how these phenomena appear and are experienced. The abduction experience, rather than a fringe anomaly, reveals the inherent instability of embodied subjectivity and exposes the fragility of the liberal body-self model. With the disappearance of the body, including the multidimensional body, the boundaries of experiencers' corporeality are challenged, subverted, and transcended. Taking seriously the corporeal dimensions of what experiencers report, we are able to more fully appreciate the ontological revisions these experiences demand of those who take them seriously.

By including an expanded understanding of what a human being is and the types of experiences human beings can have, experiencer testimony introduces the groundwork for an expanded understanding of subjectivity and ethics that is not built on the small sense of "I," but a more interconnected and transcendent understanding of the human. Multidimensional subjectivity moves beyond a purely mechanical, naturalistic understanding of the human being. It also rejects the liberal conception of personhood and its residue, and the illusion that control and choice are the pinnacle of human experience. Indeed, further exploration will reveal that it involves an understanding of human experience that considers what happens to us,

our own choices, our actions, and the effects of our actions as all taking place in a much wider context than the established parameters of the consensus physical reality.

Chapter Three: At the Threshold: Encounters with the Liminal Other

“No category seemed to fit. The ‘visitors’ was a term that I used after I read Strieber and when I began to see that these experiences were going on and contemplate whether or not they were connected to the sighting that I had. That remains an open question. I just don’t know.”—Marin

“Liminal entities are neither here nor there; they are betwixt and between the positions assigned and arrayed by law, custom, convention, and ceremonial.”—Victor Turner

“The alien...behaves like ideas that occur to us, like obsessions that haunt us, like dreams from which we never fully wake up. It originates from an irrevocable ‘once upon a time’ and from an irrevocable ‘elsewhere.’” -Bernhard Waldenfels

As a philosopher, I generally take comfort in perfect continence, in clear distinctions between the marked and unmarked states. As we have already seen, the contact phenomenon does not. Stepping into fuller witnessing means confronting those liminal aspects— the dimensions of contact that blur our desire for neat or easy categorizations. In the previous chapter, we focused on the physicality of abduction, and how abduction encounters blur and expand the boundaries of corporeality. In this chapter, I explore the distinct *liminality* of the Other encountered, with a focus on experiences that cross the thresholds of physical and non-physical, material reality and dream states.

In the encounters that follow, the entities blur the lines between embodiment and incorporeality, often remaining hidden from the visual field. While the abductees we explored in the last chapter describe encounters with distinctly corporeal beings, experiencers in this chapter report experiences in which the bodies they encounter are absent, ambiguous, or liminal. I show that while the presence of ostensibly material UAP and intersubjectively witnessed events grounds the experiences with the entities partially in physical reality, the entities simultaneously appear to take on trans-physical and psychical qualities, mediating the space between physical reality and non-ordinary realms. This displayed liminality brings the UFO/UAP into phenomenological proximity with other anomalous or “paranormal” phenomena that are often assumed to be unrelated, such as cryptids or poltergeists.

Continuing my analysis of these experiences in the realm of intersubjectivity, I explore how these experiences unfold as intersubjective processes with a liminal Other. Is the liminal Other a threat or a mysterious call of Otherness that demands a response? Perhaps it is both or something in between? After showing how the liminal Other presents in experience, I use the work of Bernhard Waldenfels, Emmanuel Levinas, and Jacques Derrida to explore how the liminal

Other calls and evokes a sense of connection, communication, and ethicality from beyond the edges of scientific consensus reality. Fundamentally, it offers the possibility of restructuring defining categories for what an Other can be and what a relationship with the Other can look like. In doing so, the experiences open the door to a new understanding of the self—not as a bounded subject in a three-dimensional world, but as a multidimensional being called to commune with something that exceeds it. This process sews the seeds of a new ethical orientation in the experiencer: one attuned to thresholds, ambiguity, and intersubjective transformation.

The Liminal Other: Crossing Thresholds

Cultural anthropologist Victor Turner has produced remarkable work on the concept of liminality in his ethnographic studies of the Ndembu of Zambia. In the rites of passage ceremonies of the Ndembu, Turner illustrates that the ritual subject of such ceremonies undergoes a distinctly liminal stage. During the passage in between one fixed state to the next, the characteristics of the ritual subject become ambiguous, they occupy a “cultural realm that has few or none of the attributes of the past or coming state.”¹³⁶ The liminal stage involves a humbling and removal of their social status.

Liminal entities, such as neophytes in initiation or puberty rites, may be represented as possessing nothing. They may be disguised as monsters, wear only a strip of clothing, or even go naked, to demonstrate that as liminal beings they have no status, property, insignia, secular clothing indicating rank or role, position in a kinship system - in short, nothing that may distinguish them from their fellow neophytes or initiands.¹³⁷

Liminality, Turner argues, gives rise to *communitas*, an equaling of social status where the hierarchies of the formal system are not recognized. The liminal subjects that Turner studies exist in a state of transition between one structured state and another. They pass through initiation rites, different, but emerging again with a new set of characteristics and structure. After the transition, the ritual subject is “in a relatively stable state once more”¹³⁸ and restored with both individual rights that protect them and obligations to others.

Whereas Turner’s ritual subjects are liminal only temporarily—emerging back into structured life—the liminal Other encountered in the experiences that follow remains perpetually in-between, never fully reaching stability. The liminal

¹³⁶ Victor Turner, *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing Company, 1969), 95.

¹³⁷ Ibid.

¹³⁸ Ibid.

Other has no clearly defined boundaries. They inhabit a liminal register, mediating the boundaries between physical and mental domains, empirical reality and the imaginal, the natural and its ontological excess. They sometimes occupy physical space and sometimes do not, sometimes follow the rules of embodiment and sometimes do not, sometimes seem beneficent and sometimes do not. The liminal Other fundamentally disrupts expectations, subverts intentionality, and ruptures attempts to bring them into full clarity. Though the liminal Other shows no clear transition to stability itself, experiencers often sense that their appearance signals a transitional or evolutionary moment for humanity.

Encounters with liminal entities, especially those with trans-empirical characteristics, have been studied by both David S. B. Mitchell and Joshua Cutchin. Mitchell's work primarily focuses on liminal hominids like Sasquatch who present halfway between human and ape. He describes liminal entities thusly:

These entities straddle the psychological and physical boundaries between human and other, civilization and unspoiled nature, consciousness and unconscious, culture and the crude, and especially, between what we hope for and what we fear, including unbridled life and agonizing death.¹³⁹

While some may see Sasquatch encounters as far removed from UFO encounters, the liminality and observed behavior of the two phenomena have many similarities. This is illustrated in a 2003 work from Jacques Vallée and Eric Davis, who identified six layers of UAP characteristics: UAP have *physical characteristics* that are compatible with the known laws of physics; *anti-physical characteristics* in which they behave in ways directly contrary to the laws of physics; *psychological effects*, such as attempts to explain away an encounter; *physiological effects* on the human body; *psychic effects* where the experiencer develops extrasensory perception beyond the five senses; and *cultural effects*, such as the larger societal response to their existence.¹⁴⁰ Mitchell identifies the very same layers as present in encounters with Sasquatch: physical manifestations such as footprints and vocalizations, the anti-physical reported abilities of Sasquatch like disappearing into thin air, reactions of denial from experiencers when they report an encounter, the odors or sensations in the body in the presence of Sasquatch, and the receipt of telepathic information or the presence of poltergeist phenomena associated with Sasquatch events.¹⁴¹ UFOs and Sasquatch straddle boundaries; they sit in between the worlds.

¹³⁹ David S. B. Mitchell with Joshua Cutchin. *Sasquatch in the Psyche: Death Anxiety, Deep Memory, and an Enduring Enigma* (McFarland Press, Forthcoming). Final Draft shared 6/20/25, 155-156.

¹⁴⁰ Jacques Vallée and Eric Davis, "Incommensurability, orthodoxy, and the physics of high strangeness: A 6-layer model for anomalous phenomena," *Consciencias: Actas do Fórum Ciência, Religião e Consciência* October (2003): 7-9. Also Mitchell, *Sasquatch*, 156.

¹⁴¹ Mitchell, *Sasquatch*, 156-157.

Sasquatch sightings and UFO events, Mitchell argues, are both “manifestations of transitory states of the psyche, natural world, or both that appear as physical beings, subtle forces, spirits, or some combination thereof.”¹⁴² Liminal entities represent “many things that any number of humans have come to perceive as anti-structural, as denaturing to modern life, as unnatural, unclean, or even as immoral.”¹⁴³ Sasquatch, as human-like but also ape-like, is degrading to the modern understanding of the human, to anthropocentric worldviews that hold human beings high above the realm of “beasts.” Liminal entities disrupt the social order, blur the boundaries between the natural and that which is perceived as supernatural, and dislodge existing sense-making categories. In doing so, they sit in-between thresholds, inviting us to join the liminal space, perhaps to cross a threshold ourselves. “[A]nything or anyone representative of the liminal occupies a space at the threshold: those literal and/or figurative doorways, crossroads, and edges that populate the physical and psychical tapestries of our world.”¹⁴⁴

While the reliance on naturalism and scientism in our society has prompted many historically to either dismiss the existence of Sasquatch or try to establish Sasquatch as a flesh and blood, biological creature, Mitchell and Cutchin emphasize that the phenomenology of Sasquatch straddles the worlds – the phenomena associated with Sasquatch are strikingly similar to poltergeist phenomena, prompting Cutchin to introduce the term *wildnisgeist*—a wilderness poltergeist.¹⁴⁵ The psychokinetic effects witnessed in the presence of Sasquatch sightings brings Bigfoot into the realm of ghosts and spirits— straddling the worlds.

In *Ecology of Souls*, Cutchin argues that liminality appears “consistently throughout paranormal phenomena: the forest edge is dangerous, the devil appears at crossroads, trolls dwell under bridges, pixies appear at twilight...UFOs hover between Heaven and Earth.”¹⁴⁶ He describes the “psychopomps” present in many ancient traditions, guides between the realms, particularly there to help with the transition from life to death. Psychopomps are “diplomats straddling realities,”¹⁴⁷ advisors who act “in tutelary roles through major life events. They change destinies and cultures, leading their wards to divine revelation.”¹⁴⁸ Cutchin traces the appearance of faeries, cryptids, ‘aliens’, and other liminal entities as potential psychopomps, mediators between the realms. They emerge to help humans cross

¹⁴² Ibid., 157.

¹⁴³ Ibid.

¹⁴⁴ Ibid.

¹⁴⁵ Joshua Cutchin, “Wildnisgeist: Poltergeist of the woods?” *EdgeScience* 43 (2020): 6-13, and Mitchell, *Sasquatch*, 158.

¹⁴⁶ Joshua Cutchin, *Ecology of Souls: A New Mythology of Death and the Paranormal Volume 1* (Horse and Barrel Press, 2022), 48.

¹⁴⁷ Ibid., 254.

¹⁴⁸ Ibid., 49.

thresholds throughout their lives, leading up to the ultimate threshold between life and death. Drawing connections between phenomena often treated as disparate—ghosts, UFOs, Bigfoot—Cutchin reframes them as manifestations of a broader ecology of souls. Encounters with UFOs and their occupants are, in Cutchin's view, best understood as the most modern manifestation of humanity's attempts to make sense of death and come to terms with their own souls.

Given that many contact experiencers describe transformations that confront them with transcendent aspects of the self, Cutchin's psychopomp hypothesis offers a helpful interpretative tool, however in a phenomenological analysis we must suspend judgment and tend to the structure of what appears. As the examples to follow will show, these entities are described as helping individuals cross profound thresholds—initiating contact not only with Otherness but with the liminal and spiritual dimensions of the individual's own subjectivity. The phenomenological encounter with liminality introduces rupture that fundamentally reconfigures the individual's relationship with Otherness.

Encounters with the Liminal Body

The liminal Other described does not follow the rules of embodiment as we understand them. In contrast to the embodied beings reported by abductees, liminal entities rarely appear fully corporeal. They reside in between physical three-dimensional reality and a subtle, energetic, or non-ordinary space. By straddling a threshold, they refuse established distinctions, asking us to redraw them. Consider the experiences of Andrew, whose experiences began with his first UFO/UAP sighting at age 17 and continued as a married adult. Very intriguingly, Andrew's experiences crossed different thresholds at nine-month intervals. His adult-life encounters began with glowing orbs that appeared on his property for months, not as technological craft, but simply glowing balls of light. After nine months, suspiciously analogous to the thresholds of human pregnancy, a new phase appears—physical craft with more clearly defined shape and structure, bringing the experience further from the liminal and into a more structured state. What was once fluid balls of light with permeable boundaries solidifies into solid objects. Interestingly, after nine months of the appearance of crafts, his experiences cross another threshold and “give birth” to the appearance of entities.

One morning when his wife was pregnant, she told Andrew she had seen a being in her room. She described the being as a typical gray with big black eyes and a bulbous head, and said it came through the wall. This unnerving communication is amplified by the appearance of physical marks on both of their bodies.

I have four white scars going back down the back of my calf. I had a mark on my elbow, it was like a white discoloration with smaller white dots

around it, inside, like a purple—it wasn't a bruise...My wife would have scabs on her belly button. I would have scabs on my back, like syringe looking holes.

After he and his wife had a newborn baby, Andrew reports that his wife had a vivid dream involving the gray beings coming to the baby's crib. At the same time, the baby screamed in waking life like it was in pain, waking up the whole house. "And so I'm like, 'Are these things one foot in the metaphysical, one foot in the physical? They can somehow affect dreams.'" The entities appear in ways that blur the boundary of physical reality and dream consciousness. Andrew's experiences culminate with a being finally appearing in his visual field. After seeing orbs and a craft passing outside his window, he heard a female voice say, "communication will work better face to face." The next thing he observed was a shadow outside the kitchen window (appearing at a threshold) and then, "this green mist, like just coming in molecule by molecule, from a needle-hole in nothing. Just pouring in...It's just kind of hanging and it just slowly comes together and then 'Wham!' There's a gray...it's physically there." Andrew describes it as a typical gray alien, with big black eyes and very pronounced cheekbones and a pointed chin.

It just was suddenly like "bloop" and it was facing me....and I just like immediately turned away and covered my mouth, you know. And I was like, "No." I just said no because...the craft had already been everywhere, and the orbs, and my wife had seen the grays. And I already knew what was going on and I was like "screw you." And I felt betrayed in that moment because I was hearing a female voice and the female had said, "communication will work better face to face." And I was like that's not this female, loving thing. That's a creature. So either that's an intermediary or they're lying to me and I felt a little betrayed.

The sound of a loving female voice invites a new form of communication—face to face contact. Andrew allows the contact, and the being emerges into his visual field first in the form of a mist, then present all at once in its apparent embodiment. But Andrew turns away from the encounter, refusing to continue the communication, as something about it does not feel right. The body that appears seems inconsistent with the voice that he heard, he cannot connect the loving female voice to the hideous creature in his visual field. It presents contrary to his expectations, emerging into his experience as *allopambos*. The voice does not match the face, the Other does not present with characteristics that map onto structure and order.

Adding to the liminality of Andrew's experience, both his wife and mother tell him they believe the entities are "demonic" and that he should stop communicating with them. Simultaneously, he reports receiving telepathic communication from the craft about a coming apocalypse, and information that the

entities had altered his DNA so he would survive it. Andrew reports being simply unable to make any coherent sense of his experience or the characteristics of what he was interacting with.

That caused a lot of cognitive dissonance in my head because they're communicating to me that they're gonna like, save us from the apocalypse. You know, but then my mom said "those are demons" and my wife is like "those are demons and just get them out of here." So, I kind of had to come to the conclusion that...they're bad...I know some people are like, "I saw a craft land, and a being got out and I felt love and it got in the craft and left. Now my life is totally turned around." It's like, um, I don't know. Like, this didn't feel that way. This felt invasive. I did not ask for this.

The Other appears in structured technology above his home, yet he suspects they may be "demonic" blurring the boundaries of nature, technology, and the supernatural. Simultaneously the communication he receives from the craft tells him a different story, but one he cannot bring himself to fully believe. The positive experiences reported by others do not match the intrusion he feels into his own boundaries and borders. He reports shutting down, stopping all communication, and asking both a priest and a shaman to his home to cleanse the energy of the property.

The Other Andrew encounters straddles the boundaries of structured technology and unstructured nature (orbs of light vs. technological craft), the physical and the non-physical (embodied beings vs. telepathic communication and dreams) benevolence and maleficence (helping vs. harming him and his family) and biological being and disincarnate entity (embodied beings who travel in ships vs. "demonic" entities). Andrew is unable to place this experience of an Other in any distinct category, leading to self-described cognitive dissonance. Through his own reflection on his perceptions as well as the feedback of his wife and mother, he concludes that the intelligence he interacts with must have malevolent intentions.

Deidre, who we met in our introduction, similarly encounters entities in distinctly liminal, in-between ways. She reports a lifetime of atypical experiences, beginning with a vivid dream of her grandmother the night she died, as well as strange poltergeist activity in her 20s, primarily involving electricity and flashing lights. However, she did not interpret these early anomalies as having anything to do with UFOs/UAP. Years later as a married adult she reports her son telling her one morning, "Mom I went for a ride on a UFO last night." She dismissed this as something cute, and then her second son came downstairs a bit later and told her, "Well, I went for a ride on a UFO and they came back and put me back in bed and then they went over to [my brother's] room and took him for a ride." Deidre found this very strange but ultimately wrote it off as a shared dream between the two of them. About two weeks later, she was walking in the mall with her sons. "My oldest

grabs my arm and he's visibly shaken. He's just...he's pointing. And there's Whitley Strieber's *Communion* book stacked in a pyramid. And he said, "That's the ones that took us for a ride." While she found this increasingly unsettling, Deidre still reports letting it go. Soon after, she heard strange scampering upstairs in her home, like the sound of "five little kids running upstairs." The footsteps signal the presence of physical bodies, yet no beings appear.

About a year later *Communion* came out in paperback and Deidre bought it and read it. She describes it as an extremely difficult read that brought back a flood of strange childhood memories she had not thought about in years. "This was kind of—you hear that term, ontological shock—this what when it hit me. This was like, 'Oh my god, I don't know what's going on here, but something is going on.'" She recalled childhood memories of being on an operating table on her stomach, which she repeatedly asked her mother about but got no satisfactory explanation for what she was remembering. She also recalled a strange childhood memory of being in a curved circular room with her parents and grandparents. She recalls signaling to them and trying to get their attention, but they just "stared into space." She also had a memory at four years old of seeing a face "resembling Uncle Fester" from the Addams family in her bedroom window, which she found especially strange given how far her window was above the ground. A face appears at a window, the threshold between the inside and outside the home. She also recalled a UFO sighting outside her bedroom window when she was in 8th grade.

As Deidre was reliving her childhood memories, her children began reporting "witches" in their room, as well as describing sightings of the "typical grays" outside their window. Her son also reported having a very vivid UFO dream involving the whole family on the same night a UFO was witnessed in the area by factory workers leaving a night shift. In the midst of recalling these memories and the strange happenings in her own home, Deidre's own psychic abilities began to increase, and she began to notice more meaningful coincidences or synchronicities in her experience. "I got to the point where I was actually used by the police a couple of times because I had so many hits on things. And while this is going on, synchronicities really start taking off."

Deidre's experiences come to a pinnacle in the encounter with which we opened the book. In this experience, the apparent corporeality of the liminal Other leaves her baffled, as she experiences it through partiality, vagueness, and ambiguity. Recall her description:

Later that night I go to bed. I don't know if I was dreaming. I don't know what was going on, but I felt like I saw a UFO with this white light coming down. We had a big bay window in our bedroom. I was awakened by forcibly being pushed up into an upright sitting position. And at the end of

the bed...there was a high footboard. And at the end of the footboard, I saw this head, the top half of a head. And I thought, “oh my god, I think I know what this is but I’ve got to be dreaming.” So I reached out and I poked it a couple of times and it was solid. And that point, I realized what I was hitting and I remember screaming like, “oh my god, this is an alien.” And then the next thing I know, I’m laying on my side...I’m looking at my clock radio on the nightstand and I’m just laying there trying to piece together what I just experienced...suddenly my husband comes running up the stairs. He had fallen asleep on the couch downstairs...he comes running up the stairs asking “What was that noise? It shook the house?”...I didn’t hear anything. He’s going from room to room trying to figure out what large piece of furniture had to have fallen over. It’s like nothing made sense that night.

The encounter begins with an obscure modality of consciousness; Deidre is not sure if she is dreaming at the beginning but has a vague recollection of a UFO beaming a light down. The experience then transitions into waking consciousness when she feels herself forcibly pushed into a sitting position. At the end of her bed, the “top half of a head” emerges into her visual field. Unable to believe what is happening, she reaches out to “poke” it and feels its solidity. In her attempt at sense-making, she articulates the presence of the embodied, unknown Other in language, describing it as “alien.” Deidre is given a glimpse of the Other’s embodiment, through visual and tactile perception of its solid head, but the full presence of its being remains hidden from view. The alien Other “behaves like ideas that occur to us, like obsessions that haunt us, like dreams from which we never fully wake up. It originates from an irrevocable ‘once upon a time’ and from an irrevocable ‘elsewhere.’”¹⁴⁹ Importantly, recall that when Deidre reflected on the beings she had interacted with, she describes them as liminal entities. “I’m not convinced they’re from another planet or anything. I think they somehow operate in the *liminal state* between wherever their world is and where our world is.”

Confronting the Liminal Face

Last chapter, I explored the gaze of the non-human Other, a multidimensional form of social dys-appearance. In this chapter, I explore the liminality of this gaze, of seeing and being seen by a being that appears to straddle the worlds. As an example, consider the case of Eric. Eric’s primary experiences involved UFO/UAP sightings as well as waking up in the morning with a strongly felt sense that something had communicated with him— a hidden, unknown presence that does not reveal itself.

¹⁴⁹Bernard Waldenfels, *A Phenomenology of the Alien: Basic Concepts*, trans. Tanja Stahler and Alexander Kozin (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 2011), 41.

Eric recalls how one night in the mid-1990s, he put out a mental intention that if there were any intelligent non-human entities present near his home, he would like them to make themselves known to him. He had heard accounts of this happening and wanted to see if it would work. He specifically asked for the entity to carry a newspaper in order to identify itself. In the early hours of the morning, he took his dog outside to use the bathroom.

I saw this figure coming towards me and it was in sort of dark clothing...And when this thing got close to me, I realized that it was carrying something. But it was carrying it with both hands out in front of him, as if he was carrying a tea tray. Normally when you see people carrying a newspaper, you carry it under your arm or you just carry it with one hand, or you might have it in your pocket or something like that. It turned out to be a newspaper...And it was carrying it like a tea tray with his arms stretched out and he's walking down this lane. At first, I thought it was just some guy going to work or something like that. Now, people don't walk to work like that. But the weird thing was, when he came towards me, when I saw his hood, I looked at his face and he didn't have one. He didn't have a face.

Eric co-creates this experience by first putting out the intention for it to happen. The being arrives in response to his call, carrying the newspaper as requested, but carrying it in an atypical way that doesn't seem natural for a human. Eric's first response is intersubjective pairing, interpreting this as a human man on his way to work early in the morning. It is when he catches a glimpse of the being's face that something is amiss, that the alien and unexpected emerges; he is disrupted by *allopambos*.¹⁵⁰

The Other appears in Eric's visual field in a distinctly liminal way. It is embodied, yet the locus of conscious subjectivity, the face, is distinctly missing. This Other has no face and no gaze. Absent a face and defining characteristics, it cannot be placed in the category of human or non-human. It performs a human action, carrying a newspaper, but carries it in an awkward way. It wears clothes and has a hood like humans do but covering a face that does not fully appear or meet Eric's own gaze. It crosses a lane behind his home, disappearing as it reaches the other side of the threshold.

One of the most profound encounters with a liminal Other comes from Yosef, who reports a confrontation with beings who traversed from what he describes as a vivid out-of-body dream into physical reality. In this experience, Yosef

¹⁵⁰ Matthew Roberts similarly reports that when he looked up at the blue being who was on top of him in his strange sexual encounter, there was a deliberate screen placed in front of her face, blocking him from meeting her gaze. See *Initiated*, 84.

also experienced his own liminality, when he sees his body sleeping below him in the dream. It began when he was resting in the living room, on a bed near the wall.

The first thing that I remember after I fall asleep is that I'm out of my body...I can see my body sleeping on the bed and my head turned to the wall next to the bed. And I felt very good...And in that situation, I saw them. There was one of them standing near my bed, looking at me. And I saw—my point of view was everywhere in the room. I could see from above. I could see from the side...Now, I realize I'm going back to my body and I did. I woke up with my eyes to the wall. And I felt like I had a weird dream of three or four green beings; little green beings walking in the room...big black eyes, shining. Very long fingers. So when I woke up I thought I had a very weird dream.

Yosef at this point does not consider the experience anything other than a pleasant and strange dream. However, upon waking, he realizes he is not alone in the room, and the beings he encountered in what he interpreted as a dream space surge into his physical space.

But I heard the noise in the room. And suddenly, I saw them. The same creatures that I saw in the dream...And the one that I saw before, standing near my head; he was now standing half a meter from me, looking at me. And I felt the most fearful thing I've ever felt in my life. I was so frightened that I almost fainted. I was in shock. All of my body was paralyzed totally.

Yosef is bewildered when the dream does not resolve and stay in the dream space like an ordinary dream. The beings appear to cross the uncrossable threshold from "dream" to waking life. More uncrossable thresholds are ostensibly crossed as the being dissolves the boundary between Yosef's mind and its own.

What gave me even more of a feeling of fear was that when he looked at me, I could realize that he was sensing me all over. He can feel my feelings. He knows what I think...I know that he knows my feelings...and I know his feelings too. And then in an instant, the fear goes down and we start to communicate...what I felt from them was an amazing feeling of comfort, of peace...it seems that the connection gave me the opportunity to know what I want, everything in their consciousness.

As the boundaries between their minds dissolve, another threshold is crossed— the encounter transitions from intense fear to feelings of peace and comfort, and a productive, communicative exchange. After the beings retreat, Yosef's liminal state continues. For several hours after the encounter, he feels his senses heightened and expanded; he is able to have sensory perceptions he has never had before. He also sees a blending of his multiple senses together, the normal distinctions between sight, hearing, touch, etc. are dissolved.

Two or three hours after the contact, all of my vision, hearing, all my senses worked differently, for three hours, something like that. I think even my brain was touched with something. I could see without my glasses for a very long distance. It was something like...my senses became joined together, synesthesia or something like that. Because when I looked at the light on the leaf, I could hear the color. I could sense the voices.

Yosef confronts the gaze of a liminal Other, an Other who straddles the distinctions between dreams, out-of-body states, and physical reality. In encountering the liminal gaze, Yosef's own liminality is reflected back to him. Through the experience, he undergoes a breakdown of the distinctions integral to the structuring of his own subjectivity and anchoring in physical reality: the boundaries or thresholds between his own senses, as well as the boundaries between his mind and the mind of the Other.

Liminality Beyond the Body

Our final experiencer who reports a liminal encounter is Marin, who blends a physical UFO/UAP sighting with beings who present with absent bodies, or at least beings that are not embodied in a way we understand. Marin's contact experiences were preceded by their witnessing what is now known as the Hudson Valley UFO in 1984.¹⁵¹ Marin did not realize until 2020, when they were Googling things to pass time during the Covid-19 pandemic, that thousands of other people had also witnessed the Hudson Valley UFO. Four years after the sighting, their contact experiences began.

About 1988 was my first one...I was sleeping and I thought there was a cat in the room that was snuggling up to me...My next thought was 'Wait! I don't have a cat!' And the minute I sort of came out of my sleep and realized that it felt like there was something there with me, it drew away, very vividly. Like it was there and then it, whoosh, pulled out of some area. Anyway, the language is tricky.

Beginning in sleep, Marin first interprets the presence as a cat, an object that fits neatly with their possibilities and expectations. This is disrupted by their remembrance that they do not own a cat, and that there was some kind of unidentified presence on their bed. Just as they emerge from sleep, they feel the presence withdraw. Marin recognizes that human language and concepts do not map neatly onto what they experienced, as we are used to interacting with other presences physically, within the spatiotemporal horizon of an experiencing "I".

¹⁵¹ "The Mystery of the Hudson Valley UFOs," *Daily News*, New York, New York, June 25th, 1989. Accessed via <https://www.newspapers.com/article/daily-news-the-mystery-of-the-hudson-val/142277670/>, July 3, 2024.

Simultaneously, Marin had a strongly felt sense that these were encounters with some kind of Other, and that the energetic presence was operating according to some kind of intelligence. They describe the relationship between themselves and the being as “encountering each other” from different dimensions of reality.

The thing that made these experiences into something I call “experiences” is that there was a sense I could never argue with...that there was another being there, and it was operating by an intelligence, very much like you might say of a cat or a dog or a thousand different intelligences operating in a different way. And we were encountering each other...here again the language, different energies, different—it feels like a hazardous word to use, but [in] different dimensions.

Marin does not interpret the beings as “aliens” or “extraterrestrials” but the best that language provides is that it felt like they were interacting with an intelligence from another dimension. When I pressed Marin for more specifics regarding how they were sensing the beings, they tried again.

Let’s go by the five senses. There was no visual. There was no sound. Well, occasionally there were weird sounds, or the experience of a sound. No taste. No smell. It was touching, but not with my body...I didn’t like, leave my body. I knew that my body was where it was and I was slightly outside of it. But this was not an out of body, kind of astral traveling, anything like that. I was always firmly aware of where I was.

Marin’s “touching, but not with my body” names the felt sense of being “slightly outside” their physical body when they encountered and “touched” the beings. They do not describe a complete exit from the body, but an expanded sense of their own corporeality with an extension of their sense of touch beyond tactile perception. The touching seems to stretch their intentionality rather than dislocate it—still partially embodied but dispersed into a liminal field. As they realize the experience problematizes the boundaries of corporeality as they previously understood them, they experience multidimensional dys-appearance—the realization that their experience challenges the naturalistic boundaries of the corporeal. This dys-appearance demands a response, a reconfiguration of their own subjectivity within the context of liminality. *It invites them to cross a threshold.*

The Liminal Other and the “I”

Whereas Turner explored the ritual subject as temporarily occupying a state of liminality in between structured states, Bernhard Waldenfels explores the human as a *perpetually* liminal being, even in our more stable periods. Waldenfels describes the human as “a creature that is not locked in by fixed boundaries, but rather relates to

these boundaries in a certain manner.”¹⁵² Our sense of self, or conception of “I,” emerges from delineating boundaries and negotiating them, drawing—and re-drawing—lines between self and Other and self and world. Husserl referred to our own sensations, perceptions, bodily awareness, etc. as a “sphere of ownness”—the individually owned domain of consciousness.¹⁵³ Through the constant act of boundary-making—between my perceptions and those of others, between my body and the external world—I constitute the realm of “selfhood.” For Waldenfels, it is precisely this dynamic boundary-drawing that enables us to encounter what is *alien*. Experiences where the own confronts the alien are, in his view, “border-crossing experiences par excellence.”¹⁵⁴ These encounters involve a doubling movement, where the self simultaneously crosses into strangeness while reinscribing its own borders.

Waldenfels argues that the act of crossing a threshold or boundary (adulthood to old age, health to sickness, one profession to another, religious conversion, etc.) has a doubling movement. First, a movement beyond the familiar and the known, entering into a domain of strangeness becoming “someone other.”¹⁵⁵ In crossing the threshold, we are opened up to the unexpected, to that which disrupts our sphere of ownness. Simultaneously, there is a reinscribing or recognition of the border, a realization that there is a difference between states. The border is not erased, but experienced, and redefined. Through our ability to say “I used to be this, and now I am something else” we reassert the existential boundary. Through the confrontation with the other side of the threshold, the space within it is also redrawn. In a religious conversion, for example, crossing the threshold to a new faith also redefines the previous one.. Every threshold crossed is a departure from the familiar and an encounter with the unfamiliar, but the movement is never entirely one directional or complete—rather, it is an ongoing negotiation.

[T]his kind of restlessness, which leads to continuous self-doublings, springs from the fact that the place where boundaries are drawn is situated neither inside nor outside the orders, but both inside and outside at the same time. Self-withdrawal means that certain moments of the alien in the self, those moments of the alienness in the given order, are virulent.¹⁵⁶

It is thus in the confrontation with the border, and the transition from one identity to the next, that our encounter with what is alien emerges. In encounters with distinctly liminal, boundary-crossing beings, some of the most deeply held

¹⁵² Waldenfels, *A Phenomenology*, 8.

¹⁵³ Edmund Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations: An Introduction to Phenomenology*, trans. Dorion Cairns (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1982), 93-94.

¹⁵⁴ Waldenfels, *Phenomenology*, 15.

¹⁵⁵ Ibid.

¹⁵⁶ Ibid., 17.

boundaries and borders of selfhood and otherness are brought to the surface and must be directly confronted.

The liminal nature of the beings encountered reflects back the liminal nature of the sphere of the own. What have I encountered? What does it mean for me? What will I become in light of it? The experiencer struggles to find themselves on either side of the threshold. In confronting an Other that straddles the boundaries of the physical and the nonphysical, embodiment and subtle energy, beneficence and maleficence, human and non-human, and the material and imaginary, the experiencer decides where to stand in relation to these boundaries.

Marin, for example, struggled to place the beings they encountered in any existing category, even within the paranormal literature, making hermeneutical reflection on their experiences difficult.

I was very curious about them. I did a lot of looking online to try to figure out “what the heck are these things?” I called them, maybe, “astral wildlife.” That never fit. No category seemed to fit. The “visitors” was a term that I used after I read Strieber and when I began to see that these experiences were going on and contemplate whether or not they were connected to the sighting I had. That remains an open question. I just don’t know.

In their confrontation with beings that resist all categorizations, Marin must decide where they would stand in relation to them. In considering them to have an ontological reality, they realize that this would involve crossing a threshold, changing a deeply held belief, and becoming something different, renegotiating the previous self. Throughout this process, like many experiencers, they attempt to explain the experiences away as a psychological hallucination. This explanation was less threatening, as it would allow the experiences to still fit within the boundaries of the physical consensus reality. While it would still be an experience of that which is alien to the self, it is one that ultimately required the crossing of the fewest thresholds. “I went through my medical phase where I thought they were hypnagogic hallucinations...one would start and I would think, ‘oh, it’s just another hallucination.’” This temporary solution ultimately is unsatisfactory for Marin; they conclude that they miss the encounters and that the category of illness does not sufficiently account for what appears, although they still don’t entirely know how to place it.

Marin cannot find an established category that adequately names the properties of the beings, and so they settle on Strieber’s agnostic “visitors,” connotating an otherness but an openness to what that otherness ultimately is. “I just started referring to them as my visitors so that I could be open to them and not try to fit them into that paradigm of ‘this must be something horrible’ or ‘this must be something crazy.’” Marin allows the presence encountered to sit in a distinctly

liminal space. When they do, they cross several thresholds: First, from skepticism and denial into acceptance of a presence that calls from outside the boundaries of consensus reality. Second, they cross from a need to place the Other encountered into a category to a willingness to be open to the ambiguity and ontological uncertainty of what they are. In this transition to openness they mark a “before” and “after,” a process in which they find themselves on the other side of a boundary in their orientation toward reality and what appears.

Deidre, too, describes a period where she was desperate to find a medical explanation for what she was encountering. She describes becoming convinced she must have a brain tumor or temporal lobe epilepsy, hallucinations or hypnagogia. “I was looking at anything and everything and nothing was fitting.” A turning point came in an intersubjective moment when she encountered a psychic at a party. Without her giving any information, the psychic knew about Deidre’s encounters.

“You’re having a nervous breakdown or you’re on the verge of one.” I said
“I feel like I am. Yes. I don’t know what’s going on with my life.” And she
said “Oh my god, you’re afraid of the aliens.” And I’m like, “How did you?
Is that what’s going on?” And she said, “No, you’re seeing some kind of an
interdimensional being...but you’ve got to find a way to deal with this.”

This was like the most bizarre thing I’d ever experienced.

The strangeness of the psychic’s knowledge encourages Deidre to start making sense of the experiences in a coherent way, and deal with them so that they would not completely take over her life. In the hermeneutic process, she found herself drawn to courses and readings on herbalism and Carl Jung alongside UFOs. “I was just trying to devour it. I was looking for logic in what the heck was happening in my life.”

The encounter with the psychic marks a transition point for Deidre, where she must make a decision to either continue trying to find a traditional explanation for anomalous happenings that keeps them within the borders of the consensus reality, or enter into a complex sense-making process, to “find a way to deal with this.” She chooses the latter, and through the process, crosses a threshold, becoming different herself. The boundaries between the real and unreal must be redrawn, and to do so, she must respond and react differently. Entering into new stages, the study of herbalism, Carl Jung, and the psyche, she enters a new stage of her own existential journey. The passage is not into a state of stability, but an ongoing state of liminality, where key distinctions are consistently negotiated. Simultaneously, the Otherness she encounters remains in its Otherness, it is never fully subsumed to her sphere of ownness. The liminality of the beings and of the human self remain, and the alien sits firmly in between borders, never fully subsumed into the self.

The encounter with the liminal Other introduces a form of relational dys-appearance. In other words, much like the boundaries of corporeality were problematized and brought to experiencers' attention, the parameters of how we encounter and relate to the Other are problematized and brought to their awareness as well. While they may take aspects of their relationality with the human Other for granted, the encounter with the liminal, alien Other forces them to reflect on our most basic forms of responsiveness and interaction. Waldenfels, alongside Emmanuel Levinas and Jacques Derrida offer accounts of our encounter with the Other that challenge the liberal conception of personhood and identify ethics as fundamental to our encounter with Otherness. Exploring responses to the liminal Other through their frameworks illuminates the possibilities for responding to this relational dys-appearance.

Waldenfels and Responsiveness

In Waldenfels' description of "the alien," the alien is not that which necessarily emerges from another world, but that which destabilizes the subject's current world.¹⁵⁷ That which is alien are those experiences that defy or disrupt our current structures of sense-making. The alien is that which "proves to be impossible, a disturbance or challenge to existent possibilities."¹⁵⁸ When the alien emerges into our world as *pathos* or *allopoulos*, as the unexpected, it calls us to respond. This call begins with prompting us to put our own understandings and possibilities into question before we are able to formulate a response.¹⁵⁹

Our responsivity towards the alien call takes us beyond our current understandings of sense and rule, beyond our everyday categories, "thus provoking the creation of new ones."¹⁶⁰ Simultaneously, it opens up a space for invention and creativity, for remaking aspects of our experience anew. "The appeal directed to me corresponds to a response that fills no hole, but comes to meet the invites and calls of the Other. Responding in its full sense does not give what it has, but rather what it invents in responding."¹⁶¹ What we do with this disruption may be disorienting, but also opens up a space for renegotiating existing boundaries into something different and ultimately better.

The presence of the alien evokes a response that points us to something bigger than the individual situation, but cannot be subsumed under universal maxims or rules. The encounter with the alien "inaugurat[es] another way of seeing, thinking,

¹⁵⁷ Waldenfels, *A Phenomenology of the Alien*, 18.

¹⁵⁸ Ibid., 34.

¹⁵⁹ Ibid., 36.

¹⁶⁰ Ibid., 36.

¹⁶¹ Ibid., 38.

and acting,” defining events that “introduce symbolic orders, establish meanings, instigate histories, provoke responses, and create new obligations.”¹⁶² Simultaneously once we are called by the Other, we are put in a position in which response becomes an inevitability, as failing to respond is also a form of response—a refusal of the call. Responsivity also means that we must start with that which is Other, to respond is to “renounce a first and, consequently, also a last word.”¹⁶³ The alien experience becomes comprehensible only in retrospect, when we understand that we became different from it. Thus, we are not the initiators nor the finishers of the conversation.

Waldenfels argues that the alien introduces an asymmetry—it cannot be fully absorbed into the sphere of the own or made equivalent to familiar categories.¹⁶⁴ In responsibility we leave behind moral demands for equality; such demands emerge only in the presence of a third party who mediates interests. Any attempt to universalize or equalize Otherness risks flattening the very alterity we are called to acknowledge, doing violence to its irreducible difference.

The attempt to produce a definitive symmetry between the own and the alien, and to make both equal to each other, would in the end be similar to the attempt to balance present and past, waking and sleeping, or life and death, as if one could at will cross the threshold that separates one from the other in either direction. But the alien does not allow this...¹⁶⁵

The moral demand that Otherness presents in our phenomenological experience is quite high—to let Otherness truly appear, we must give up attempts to reduce it to the same. This means that our fundamental relation with Otherness directs us away from a contractual understanding of our relations to others. The liberal conception of personhood, in which each individual is an atomistic, autonomous being who enters into contractual agreements with others for their own benefit, is challenged by the alien call. Fundamental relationality is problematized, brought to awareness, and must be reconfigured.

We can illustrate the different possibilities of responsiveness by looking at the cases of Andrew and Deidre. Both are confronted with the liminal Other, a call that demands a response. Andrew gradually hears a call that increases in volume, as he moves through several thresholds from orbs to craft, to the appearance of a being. With the invitation “contact will work better face to face” he is confronted with the corporeality of the alien Other, in the field of flesh he is confronted by a gray being with big black eyes. But there is a gap between the call and the response; he is

¹⁶² Ibid., 39.

¹⁶³ Ibid., 41.

¹⁶⁴ Ibid.

¹⁶⁵ Ibid.

disturbed when the alien face does not match the loving feminine voice he hears. He turns away from the creature, stating distinctly “no.” He chooses no response as a response, refusing the call. He begins to ignore the craft, orbs, and phenomena when they appear. Gradually, the anomalous activity ceases. Andrew’s response shows a desire for the phenomenon to present with the framework of his expectations and conditions: he wants the face of the Other to match the loving tone of the voice that requests communication. When it does not meet the parameters he introduces, he refuses further communication; the welcome is terminated. He proceeds, still different, but without continuing the relation.

Deidre is confronted by the face of Uncle Fester in the window as a child, the picture of the face she sees on the cover of Whitley Strieber’s *Communion*, as well as the strange being whose head she feels in the middle of a confusing, ambiguous night. These experiences rupture her everyday understanding of sense and order. The liminal Other cannot be welcomed into the boundaries she has established. Indeed, it intrudes into her home in the middle of the night, rupturing the foundational security and safety of her space. Attempting to mitigate the effects of the call, she first reduces them to dreams, sickness or pathology, though she nevertheless feels something does not fit. She feels called to understand what is happening and why they appear, but they refuse all known categories of relating and dialoguing. She pieces together a conception of who this Other could be, learning about herbalism, spirituality, and consciousness in the process. The parameters of the “I” are put in question and remain in question. In her mysterious encounter with the psychic, a mandate is introduced: “you’ve got to find a way to deal with this.” Amidst this sea of the unknown and unexpressed, a truce is reached in her mind. An acceptance that she must accept the ambiguity and liminality of the Other she encounters. The call of the alien is not entirely intelligible, but she takes the risk of responsiveness and enters into a transformative conversation. She cannot respond from the rules or order that made sense in her experience prior to the alien interruption, so she improvises and becomes different. In response to the relational dys-appearance that surges into her awareness, she allows the call to open up the space of invention and creativity.

Levinas and the Call of the Face

Whereas Waldenfels focuses on the disruptive call of the alien, which resists assimilation and unsettles boundaries, Emmanuel Levinas frames the encounter with Otherness through the ethical demand of the face, emphasizing direct responsibility and infinite obligation toward the Other. William Large observes that Otherness for Levinas is that which is fundamentally non-cognizable in Husserlian terms; it does

not appear as a concept nor as an immediate perception.¹⁶⁶ The Other, for Levinas, calls us from beyond that which we can solidify and conceptualize within the horizon of our experiential field. “Levinas’s new approach is meant to liberate an interpellation, a call, a revelation of the other and by the other beyond any general constitution of the object by the subject.”¹⁶⁷ The Other, for Levinas, is not an object that I perceive or constitute, but a transcendent subjectivity that calls to me from beyond the world of delineated objects.

It is in our encounter with concrete, embodied Others whose being cannot be reduced to the status of an object, that we are exposed to a glimpse of the infinite, that which calls from beyond the conceptual horizon of the “I”. Levinas identifies a “divine transcendence embedded in intersubjective relationships.”¹⁶⁸ For Levinas, it is in our concrete, physical encounter with the human Other that we are opened up to the possibility of the Infinite, or alterity, because the embodied human Other introduces us to the more general notion of Otherness.

The face is present in its refusal to be contained. In this sense it cannot be comprehended, that is, encompassed. It is neither seen nor touched—for in visual or tactile sensation the identity of the I envelops the alterity of the object...¹⁶⁹

Levinas conceives of our encounter with the human Other as different from our encounter with physical objects. While the face presents to us in our sensory perception, it ultimately directs us beyond it; we know that it is not reducible to being a physical object, it houses another intelligence, a subjectivity with an inner life of its own. The Face, for Levinas, is not the anatomical face or even the visual gaze, but the encounter with vulnerability and ethical exposure — a form of presence that resists totalization. It cannot be reduced to sameness. It puts us in touch with that which is beyond our experiential horizon.

Through our use of words in speech, we communicate with the Other, introducing a realm of shared concepts and reasons. The ethical relation with the Other precedes language and rationality for Levinas. It is only because there is first difference that there is a need for speech and communication. Through speech, we acknowledge, invite, and open to the Other. It is through discourse that the Other becomes an interlocutor and not just a “theme” for me— a subjectivity with their

¹⁶⁶ William Large, “On the Meaning of the Word Other in Levinas,” *Journal of the British Society for Phenomenology* 27:1 (2014): 50.

¹⁶⁷ Cedric Cohen-Skalli, “Alterity, Asymmetrical Relationships, and Allegiance: A Historical Approach to Levinas,” *Levinas Studies* 17 (2023): 77.

¹⁶⁸ *Ibid.*, 84.

¹⁶⁹ Emmanuel Levinas, *Totality and Infinity: An Essay on Exteriority*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Pittsburg: Duquesne University Press, 1969), 194.

own ends and meaning.¹⁷⁰ Through the exchange of words and language, I am opened up to the Other as a subjectivity who demands responsibility from me, someone to whom I cannot be indifferent. In this process, the boundaries of the self become negotiable; we are forced to re-evaluate where we end and others begin. “For the ethical relationship which subtends discourse is not a species of consciousness whose ray emanates from the I; it puts the I in question. This putting in question emanates from the Other.”¹⁷¹

The Other in their presence prompts us to realize the full scope of what it means to extend ourselves into the world.

But the other absolutely other—the Other—does not limit the freedom of the same; calling it to responsibility, it founds it and justifies it...The ‘resistance’ of the other does not do violence to me, does not act negatively; it has a positive structure: ethical...I do not struggle with a faceless god, but I respond to his expression, to his revelation.¹⁷²

The Face represents the vulnerability of the Other and introduces an asymmetry in responsibility. Similar to Waldenfels, the ethic it engenders is not founded in reciprocity or mutual obligation, but a radical responsibility I have towards the Other that is greater than any obligation they have towards me. The alterity of the Other precedes the formation of the subject; it is in being confronted with the Face and ethical presence of the Other that we are *after* prompted to solidify the boundaries of the “I”. The Other’s presence confronts me before I assert myself as a subject, it decenters the “I” by placing a radical, asymmetrical demand on me that I can never truly fulfill.

While Levinas insisted that only the human face could present the infinite, the experiencers’ encounters with liminal beings show that ethical demand and subjectivity may exceed species boundaries. These narratives present the possibility of a post-anthropocentric ethic, where the capacity to call and to be called transcends the human form. For Levinas, the human face presents an ethical demand: “Do not kill me.” The mysterious or absent face of the liminal Other presents with its own call but one that is *not identical*. It appears primarily not in vulnerability but in invulnerability— with abilities and capacities that supersede human understanding of what can occur. Bridging the physical, psychical, social, physiological, and cultural realms, it surges into experiences in a way that forces a response. Its call comes in mystery and possibility— to acknowledge this Other is to acknowledge a transition to new epistemic frameworks and meaning-making processes.

¹⁷⁰ Levinas, *Totality and Infinity*, 195.

¹⁷¹ Ibid.

¹⁷² Ibid., 197.

Levinas argued the encounter with the Other puts us in touch with that which is beyond the experiential horizon of any individual “I”—a notion of divinity. The Liminal Other encountered does precisely this, as the beings appear with characteristics that challenge the parameters of the physical world as we know them, directing the individual towards a larger conception of self and world. Levinas also argues that the encounter with the Other is what prompts us to form concepts and language in order to communicate— it is through Otherness that we form a world. The experiencers encounter a radical Otherness that they rarely confront face to face, an alterity which calls to them from beyond the conditions of the possible and the known. It is an Other they cannot look in the eye without their sense of self and agency being dissolved, that they cannot speak with in the way they would with a human Other. It is a relationship with a being whose ontology remains uncategorizable and seems to exist on the boundaries of the finite and the infinite, of the concrete and the transcendent. The call from the mysterious face of the liminal Other presents the experiencer with a field of possibilities, and there are various paths for responding. Two interesting possibilities are elucidated in the experiences of Eric and Yosef.

Eric’s encounter with the entity that appeared without a face is particularly interesting. While the face establishes itself as an otherness and points to something beyond itself, it also brings a sense of familiarity—we recognize the face as another consciousness that experiences the world with some similarity to us. That sense of familiarity is absent in Eric’s encounter, he sees an Other whose face is distinctly missing. Similar to Matthew Robert’s encounter with the blue entity whose face was blurred from view, an emptiness blocks the face, a clear indication that he is not dealing with a human Other, even though the Other is presenting in human-like ways. Eric, confronted with the faceless being, shows remarkable calm. “Now at this point I’m thinking, ‘I have to try to control myself.’ I wasn’t actually frightened at the time. I just kind of thought to myself, ‘Thank you.’ I just thought the word ‘thank you’ for like, appearing and all that.” Having put out a call that an ambiguous, liminal Other answered, Eric makes an attempt to communicate on *their* terms, using his thoughts to convey gratitude. He does not panic nor reject the Other, nor try to assimilate them to sameness. Eric’s response shows that it is not the physical face nor the designation of the species “human” that calls us to task, but the relationality with an Other who does not have to assimilate to our categories— including membership in species *homosapien* or communicating in the same way we do.

It is Yosef who has the most powerful and direct face to face encounter, confronted squarely with the face of the liminal Other who ostensibly emerges into physical reality from his dream state. The initial encounter begins with the strongest sense of fear he has ever felt in his life, as the liminal entities transition from a

delightful dream to something much more threatening. The safety and security of his home is subverted, the non-human face of the liminal Other stares at him from his bed. While certainly appearing a stranger in a foreign land, the face does not present in vulnerability, as Levinas' human face does. It appears in liminal mystery and invulnerability, demonstrating capabilities that humans do not have. As Yosef describes it, "You are confronting something that is stronger than you. It can swallow you." Most troublingly, the Other's presence intrudes into the borders of his inner subjective states. "When he looked at me, I could realize that he was sensing me all over. He can feel my feelings. He knows what I think...I know that he knows my feelings."

As he comes to terms with what is being demanded of him, Yosef realizes the intrusion has opened a reciprocal connection: "So what it means is that I know his feelings too. And I know what is going on in his head." It is when he opens himself up to the possibility of communicating with the beings on their terms that the confrontation turns into a profound act of communion:

[W]hat I felt from them was an amazing feeling of comfort, of peace. They were totally open with me...They don't hide from me, nothing. It seems that the connection gave me the opportunity to know what I want, everything in their consciousness. So I started to do that. They let me do that. I felt that I had the permission to go there, to go into their consciousness.

What began as confrontational and threatening, a form of multidimensional social dys-appearance that made him aware of the uncertain boundaries of his corporeality, becomes an act of consensual sharing of each other's inner mental life. Despite the liminal Other intruding into his physical room and presenting in invulnerability, he does not feel threatened, nor does he feel any sense of superiority from the beings.

I felt that they were very humble... I didn't feel any kind of hostility to me or to each other...And they had no kind of ego that I have, or that people have, because they were totally open with me. I didn't feel any, you know, feeling of superiority from them over me or over humanity or something like that.

From Others who clearly have abilities that humans do not, and who experience the world in ways that humans do not, Yosef still feels a sense of moral equality.

Yosef opens himself up to communicating on the Other's terms, to letting go of his demands for what communication has to look like. Not knowing who or what they are, he is called to commune with them anyway. In the corporeal presentation of the non-human Other in his room, he gets a glimmer of the infinite, "I don't know how to say it in words, but they were connecting to a knowing of immense love that gives them existence. Years after that, I started to realize that this is what we call God." The beings present to him as having a more direct connection

to the transcendent or infinite—liminal entities halfway between the embodied three-dimensional plane and the ultimate transcendent Other beyond our grasp. In allowing himself to be “swallowed,” Yosef dissolves the established distinctions between self and Other. Yosef’s experience is ultimately a post-Levinasian encounter: communion beyond language, ego and species. In response to the relational dys-appearance, he accepts a willingness to be “swallowed” in the encounter—a model of transcendent relationality that is simultaneously ethical and numinously charged.

Jacques Derrida and Hospitality

The work of Jacques Derrida on hospitality offers unique insights for the possibility of a welcoming response to an alien Other. Derrida’s work has similarities with Levinas’, but he develops the concept of unconditional hospitality and what it would look like to truly welcome the other outside the existing human conditions, which so often presuppose the liberal conception of personhood. In *Adieu to Emmanuel Levinas*, Derrida writes, “Is not hospitality an interruption of the self?”¹⁷³ In other words, to welcome the Other into the parameters of our homes involves necessarily putting the boundaries of the self in question. Derrida wishes to explore what a true unconditional hospitality would look like. The concept of hospitality as we usually encounter it comes with rules and conditions. There are certain duties expected of the guest, and rules regarding how they must behave, conditions governing when they must leave. Hospitality in modern western societies is understood as transactional, an exchange between host and guest.¹⁷⁴

Derrida goes so far to define hospitality as ethics itself: it is in hospitality, the welcoming of Otherness that we find “the whole and the principle of ethics.”¹⁷⁵ Absolute or unconditional hospitality is a process of welcoming the Other without the rules and conditions that are usually imposed by a host on a guest. This includes the normal expectation of an invitation. To require an invitation is to put conditions on hospitality. Derrida writes,

Absolute hospitality requires that I open up my home and that I give not only to the foreigner, but to the absolute, unknown, anonymous other, and that I give place to them, that I let them come, that I let them arrive, and take place in the place I offer them, without asking of them either reciprocity (entering into a pact) or even their names.¹⁷⁶

¹⁷³ Jacques Derrida, *Adieu to Emmanuel Levinas*, trans. Pascale-Anne Brault and Micheal Naas (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1999), 51.

¹⁷⁴ Mark Westmoreland, “Interruptions: Derrida and Hospitality,” *Kritike* 2.1 (2008): 2.

¹⁷⁵ Derrida, *Adieu*, 50.

¹⁷⁶ Jacques Derrida, *Of Hospitality*, trans. by Rachel Bowlby (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2000), 25.

But there is a paradox— an act of true unconditional hospitality opens the door for possible violence— those who stand at the border are welcomed without conditions, and thus, the concept of the “home” is turned inside out. The guest may take over the home and the host or master becomes the hostage of the guest. Unconditional hospitality and indivisible sovereignty cannot co-exist. The necessity of hospitality to be governed by rules and limits in human interactions is in tension with the ethical demand of unconditional hospitality.

So it is indeed the master, the one who invites, the inviting host, who becomes the hostage—and who really always has been. And the guest, the invited hostage, becomes the one who invites the one who invites, the master of the host. The guest becomes the host’s host.¹⁷⁷

The picture is not simple. Unconditional hospitality calls to us as the ethical ideal—and yet, its actualization in human contexts must always come with conditions. Derrida thus does not propose unconditional hospitality as a practical realizable, but rather as an *aporia* that exposes the limits of our existing ethical thinking. Unconditional hospitality presents as an ethical demand, and yet it is not one that we can realize in practical human relations. Thus it functions not as a realizable ethical norm but as a form of phenomenological rupture. It marks the point where our ethical self-understandings unravel, and new modes of relating must be invented beyond rule and reciprocity. In its *impossibility*, it exposes the limits of our present ways of relating.

To unconditionally welcome the liminal Other that appears in the lived experience of our witnesses, we would have to give up our human conditions, including some of the key assumptions of the ethical principles we rely on in modern western democracies. This includes the focus on human beings as atomistic, autonomous, rights-bearing individuals with ultimate control over what happens in our lives. It would also require reflecting on and accepting our own liminality, the ways we are always in negotiation with our distinctions the moment that we draw them. The ideal of unconditional hospitality is *impossible*, and yet, as we have seen, our experiencers have already been exposed to many impossible things. Through the appearance of beings that bridge the gap between the corporeal and the incorporeal, between physical reality and dream or imaginal space, and between the natural and supernatural, their human conditions have already been put into tension and been redrawn. As what has been thought impossible gradually becomes accepted as possible, the ethical ideals that Derrida describes as paradox or *aporia* cross the distinction into the realm of possibility.

¹⁷⁷ Ibid., 125.

What would it mean to unconditionally welcome the liminal Other? It would require giving up demands for an invitation, for knowing who they are, or where they come from. It would require giving up demands that they communicate in our languages or on our terms. It would be an act that fundamentally ruptures our understanding of what we are and who they are. In the unconditional welcome, they become the host, and we become the guest. In the experience of Otherness, we release our conditions for how an experience must unfold.

This idea not only applies to the experiences in this chapter but also to the abductees we discussed in Chapter Two. For many, the key moment of entering into a transformative, relational space was in giving up the demand that the experience unfold on their terms or according to the parameters of traditional human ethics focused on agency and choice. The key question emerges as to how to answer the call in a way that preserves the alterity of the Other, that does not force assimilation, and that places the boundaries of the self in question while also not reducing the self to the Other. While unconditional hospitality exists in tension with the rules of hospitality as we understand them as applying in human relations, we can still use unconditional hospitality as an ethical compass to guide our moral motivations.

It is in Marin's encounter with what they call "astral wildlife" that we see the most striking illustration of Derridean hospitality and the *aporia* it presents. Recall that Marin did not see a face but felt an energetic presence and a form of intelligence, even though it was quite different from a human intelligence. As they opened themselves up to communing with this alterity, they remain ignorant of any of its ontological properties or boundaries. They do not share a common language, and thus the boundaries of relationality come surging into Marin's awareness. Marin admits that at first they did not know how to interpret the communication, and their attempt to put it in a human category most closely resembled something sexual. "I am going to tread carefully. It was a bit--oh gosh--at the beginning, I interpreted it as sexual. Okay? But we're not going to go there because it wasn't like 'sexual sexual.'" The energetic exchange they felt while partially outside their body takes on a deep form of intimacy that they associate with sexuality.

As the connection and interaction progressed, Marin began to rethink what they had categorized as sexual, realizing that it was likely the beings were communicating in their own language and did not consider it "erotic" in the same way humans do.

As time went on, I began to consider the possibility that I was seeing as sexual or erotic to them was just a metaphor and that it was a way of them communicating, reaching toward me, to communicate...to interact with me in some way that affected me profoundly. But I didn't feel like they came

with a verbal message. Because I don't think that these particular beings, if we want to call them that, I don't think that would have crossed their minds. Marin at first tries to fit the experience in terms of human relating, and comes to the conclusion of "sexual." With a wider openness towards letting the Other appear on their own terms, they realize it was a form of deep intimacy and connection, not sexual in the way humans understand it. They acknowledge that they do not think it would "cross their minds" to communicate in language and instead is open to the communication as it appears— their resolution to the relational dys-appearance.¹⁷⁸ Marin welcomes the Other into their home, into the boundaries of themselves, leading to a rupture of their own subjectivity. They let the Other appear without forcing assimilation, allowing the ambiguity and liminality of the encounter to stand. In doing so, they move as close to the ideal of unconditional hospitality as may be humanly possible.

True unconditional hospitality in the face of the liminal Other would involve giving up our human conditions regarding how the Other must appear and present themselves, including the liberal conception of personhood, and an ethics centered on agency, choice, and three-dimensional reality. We must give up our expectation for an invitation, or our need to make the rules regarding how the process unfolds. It may not be entirely possible, as these concepts are deeply embedded in our understanding of relationality. However, experiencers have come face to face with other impossibilities— the non-human, liminal Other— and emerged by redrawing the distinctions between the possible and the impossible. Perhaps the impossibility that emerges is a hospitality that allows Otherness to stand, that invites and welcomes without imposing human condition, and allows a redrawing of the distinctions between host and guest and the motivations for drawing these boundaries to begin with. In the welcome, both host and guest may be transformed, the distinction between them blurred.

The ethical rupture described above fundamentally reconfigures the boundaries of the "I," decentering the demand for agency and choice. Through the presence and communion with beings who are not supposed to exist, a transformed subjectivity emerges—one whose highest expression lies not in Mill's "capacity to make a choice"¹⁷⁹ but in its relational openness to the unknown. The I is no longer

¹⁷⁸ Matthew Roberts, who had an explicitly sexual encounter described in Chapter One, also eventually concludes that the being likely did not view the encounter the same way he does. "It occurred to me that maybe these beings don't view sex the same way we do. Maybe to them it's something that is viewed as simply creation just like the frame around my window," *Initiated: UAP, Dreams, Depression, Delusions, Shadow People, Psychosis, Sleep Paralysis and Pandemics* (Self-published, 2020), 101.

¹⁷⁹ John Stuart Mill, *On Liberty*, ed. Elizabeth Rapaport (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, 1972), 56.

the one who acts, chooses, or demands, but rather the one who allows the Other to appear, who takes on new forms of communicating, connecting and relating in the presence of an unknown and irreducible alterity. As we will explore in future chapters, this gives rise to an ethic that is no longer grounded in sameness or agency, but in a deep vulnerability to the unknown— and potentially unknowable— that is willing to put all existing parameters of order and sense into question.

Conclusion: The Liminal Other and Multidimensional Subjectivity

Fuller witnessing of contact requires confronting its liminality. The liminal Other calls from a threshold. In its liminal presentation, it reflects our human liminality back at us, inviting us to cross a threshold ourselves. Which threshold? Perhaps the Cartesian divide between body and mind, physical and psychical. More radically, the threshold between a three-dimensional conception of the human and a multidimensional subjectivity. From a conception of personhood which considers each subject atomistic and individual, to a subjectivity that is constituted and reconstituted by its encounters with the Other. By crossing the boundaries between dream states and physical reality, between corporeal and incorporeal, between the finite and the infinite, and between one consciousness and another, the liminal Other offers a mirror through which experiencers encounter their own liminality. As they learn to dwell in perpetual ambiguity, they begin to conceive of subjectivity as extending across multiple modalities or dimensions that do not have clearly defined boundaries: body, mind, dream, the mind of the Other, and beyond.

The works of Waldenfels, Levinas, and Derrida offer crucial groundwork for this transformation—each exploring different dimensions of alterity and ethical relation that challenge contractual conceptions of human relations. Yet the multidimensional ethic that emerges through contact exceeds their frameworks, demanding a shift from a strictly human ethic to interspecies relationality. This Otherness calls the experiencers to not only to confront and reckon with radical difference, but to abandon anthropocentric assumptions altogether, giving up their belief in human superiority. As experiencers go through the difficult process of humbling themselves in the face of the non-human Other, they do not sacrifice all sense of agency, but redirect their autonomy towards creative spaces of empowerment, invention, and transformation. By opening to the possibility of interspecies communion, they begin to redraw the boundaries of the human. In doing so, they expand the scope of ethical life, revealing new dimensions of their capacity to welcome that which is truly foreign and other—and to transform themselves in the process.

Chapter 4: The Gift of Contact: Saturated Phenomena and the Transformation of the “I”

“Having wrestled with this for four months, I finally reached this place where I said in my head, ‘the universe must be more mysterious than I’ve allowed it to be.’ And in this moment, I have the most visceral, spiritual experience I have ever had...my whole body just starts...to almost be electrocuted...I felt it pulse with energy somehow. And it washed over my whole body. I almost felt near paralyzed.” – James

“But one time, this being came and it was gold, it was light. And it kind of came down. It was like little particles, and formed something that looked like a man...It sat right on the bed. And I remember looking at it...and it turned and looked at me. And I felt so comfortable in its presence.”—Linda

“Phenomenality is not grasped; it is received. To receive, for the receiver, therefore means nothing less than to accomplish givenness by transforming it into manifestation, by according to what gives itself that it show itself on its own basis.” – Jean-Luc Marion

We began with corporeal experiences, in which embodied interactions with corporeal beings engender an expanded understanding of the body. We progressed to liminal experiences, in which the liminality of the Other encountered reflects the liminality of human experience and relationality. To conclude Part I and more fully witness the scope of how encounters can unfold, we examine contact experiences that take on a more spiritual or numinous nature, even though they may also include corporeal or liminal aspects. In these experiences, the contact event serves as a vehicle for experiencers to encounter transpersonal aspects of themselves, leading to an expanded understanding of the boundaries and capacities of consciousness. While the experiences certainly leave the individual changed and transformed, they do not include the same level of trauma and bewilderment as the corporeal and liminal encounters. All five experiencers described in this chapter report overwhelmingly positive views of their experience of contact.

In these experiences, it is succinctly illustrated how individuals find themselves *constituted and transformed by something that exceeds their conceptual grasp*. This brings us in proximity with Jean-Luc Marion’s idea of beginning phenomenological inquiry with givenness, considering the “I” as formulated through that which appears. I then explore his concept of *saturated phenomena*, or phenomena that give far more in their appearance than can be intended or foreseen by the individual subject. Saturated phenomena are those appearances that overwhelm the human categories of rationality, that contain more in how they give themselves that can be put into concepts. By exploring the subject as one who receives rather than

constitutes, or one who is *gifted* by the saturated phenomena of contact, I illustrate how a new conception of the “I” emerges as an accumulation of the gifts. Contact, in this sense, is not the object of belief that one affirms or disavows, but a call into a participatory and relational field. When received, this call restructures subjectivity—in fundamentally multidimensional ways.

Saturated Experience

I went hiking in Zion [National Park]....and I see a hawk...it's going off the trail and I just felt like I needed to follow it...and it leads me to this kind of cliff really...And I laid down and from there it got really weird. So I am looking up; I don't know if I'm asleep or not...but I looked up in the sky and there was a big cloud. And I could see behind the cloud there was a rectangular ship....and from there I remember waking up, like the best nap of my life, right? And I'm going back off the trail and all of a sudden, like madness, I got stuck to the ground. And I put my hand on the ground I can feel like cones going into the ground. Almost like I felt it leaving my hand and I also felt it entering the Earth as if it were part of me. And I could see code in my third eye. Just really weird writing...only symbols...I don't know if it's like the ancient, free Egyptian writing. I've looked for it to see if I could match it and I haven't been able to. So, I'm on the ground too. I knew I was aware of a prism around me and that there was also one in front of me with someone in it who may have been myself in some capacity. So I'm just giving all this code to the earth and...yeah, that was really wild. And since then, I've just have a really interesting understanding of things.

Justin's story presents with some phenomenological familiarity. A sighting of a large rectangular ship, although he's not entirely sure whether to classify it as a dream. Gaps of missing time, leading to waking up as “the next thing he remembers.” Imagery flashing through his mind's eye that feels important but that he is unable to place. Bodily dys-appearance as he is stuck to the ground. Additionally, the experience is permeated with spiritual or religious valence. A hawk appears at the beginning, symbolizing in many cultures a message from the divine or trust in one's intuitive abilities. Energetic “cones” are exchanged between him and the Earth. He feels himself inside of a “prism”—a sacred geometrical figure associated symbolically with clarity and the revealing of hidden truths. In front of him another prism appears, which contains a figure he thinks may be himself. This imagery seems to be explicitly directing him inwards—towards knowledge of himself—rather than towards visitors from the sky. Importantly, Justin considers this experience a key turning point in his subjectivity and way of orienting himself in the world. It is not an experience that he has *constituted* as a transcendental self who organizes or creates

a world. Rather, he *receives* the experience, finds himself immersed in it, and becomes a self through it. He is not asked to believe something, but instead *finds himself participating* in the creation and revealing of forms of truth. He cannot emerge unchanged.

While Husserl argued that a transcendental Ego constitutes a world of objects and things, later phenomenologist Jean-Luc Marion reversed this order. Instead, Marion argues that humans as subjects find ourselves “gifted” by what appears. In receiving phenomena as they appear, we are called into relation with them and are constituted as a self. Often, we encounter phenomena that *present in excess*—that contain far more in their appearance than we are prepared to receive through our commonly drawn distinctions that make up our conceptual world. This is the “saturated phenomenon” – that which cannot possibly be fully contained within the classic spatiotemporal horizon of human cognition and experience. In Justin’s experience in Zion National Park, he finds himself confronted by that which overwhelms his everyday capacities of reason and experience of the world. In the visual, tactile, symbolic and conceptual excess, core structures he uses to organize his sense of self are ruptured and remade. In his participation, something is revealed that was not present before.

Jean-Luc Marion: From “Subject” to “Receiver”

Just as Levinas argues that the Other’s face precedes and transcends our conscious intentionality, contemporary phenomenologist and theologian Jean-Luc Marion departs even further from Husserl by identifying other phenomena that are beyond our conceptual grasp. For Husserl, it is through appearing to a subject, the subject comprehending what appears as an object, and the object conforming to the concepts of the subject, that objects are constituted. Marion’s thought thus effectively constitutes a reversal of traditional phenomenology. By using the language of “being given,” Marion emphasizes that phenomena appear as “gifts” – which is not something the individual subject controls. While a subject “constitutes” a receiver “receives.” “The receiver therefore does not only receive what gives itself—it allows the given to show itself insofar as it gives itself...Phenomenality is not grasped; it is received.”¹⁸⁰ Marion’s point is that our concept of self and sense of “I” emerge through a process that is primarily not within our control. Subjectivity emerges as an accumulation of what is gifted in experience, which we attempt to order and understand. However, we frequently encounter phenomena that exceed our expectations and abilities to conceptualize them fully.

¹⁸⁰Jean-Luc Marion, *Being Given: Toward a Phenomenology of Givenness*, trans. Jeffrey L. Kosky (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2002), 264.

This does not mean that the individual is rendered inert or powerless. Rather, the subject is vulnerable to that which appears, they become a self through receptivity rather than control. Again, we see contrast with the traditional liberal conception of personhood that is defined by choice and autonomy. The subject is a witness; one who is summoned, receives, and called to respond, but not the initiator of experience. Marion's thought is especially useful in the exploration of anomalous experience, as in its very definition as anomalous, it appears outside the confines of our expectations about the world. In encountering UAP and experiencing the entities that accompany them, experiencers are gifted with appearances that defy expectation and exceed any attempts to control them. It is through letting the *experience appear without trying to force it into existing categories* that individuals experience its most profoundly transformative effects. Witnesses like Justin are not destroyed, but rather reoriented around something new that dislodges the traditional parameters of anthropocentric subjectivity.

Exceeding Expectation: Saturated Phenomena

To understand Marion's saturated phenomena, we need to review some basic terminology of Kant. Kant used the term "intuition" not in its modern sense of gut feeling or information received without the senses, but in the more general sense of the apprehension of particulars. That which is given in intuition are particular objects: humans, coffee mugs, trees, or cats.¹⁸¹ We then use the concepts of our minds, which are present prior to sensory experience, to make sense of what we receive in intuition. Through the concept of causality, I establish a causal relation between the cat pushing the coffee mug with his paw and it crashing into pieces on the floor. Kant thought we needed both particulars, or intuitions, *and* concepts to make sense of our world and utilize our reason. Kant also considered space and time pure intuitions, or *a priori* intuitions, meaning that they are given prior to any sense experience, and necessary for us to have experience at all.¹⁸²

Through reason the individual mind performs a synthesis of appearances in order to abstract universal concepts and form categorical judgments. The mind or understanding then uses the categories of quantity, quality, relation, and modality to organize that which it encounters through intuition. Using quantity, we understand things as singular, plural, or as totalities. Applying quality, we identify characteristics as present or absent and establish the limits between presence and absence. Utilizing relation, we organize things by substance and actualities, dependencies on other objects, and their mutual interactions with other objects. Through modality, we

¹⁸¹ Immanuel Kant, *The Critique of Pure Reason*, trans. and ed. Paul Guyer and Allen Wood (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 172.

¹⁸² *Ibid.*, 172-180.

conceive of things that are actual, things that are possible, and things that are necessary.¹⁸³

Marion observes that because both Kant and Husserl ultimately thought that a phenomenon had to be presented to an “I” or an experiencing subject, it therefore must be limited in its appearance. The object ultimately had to be inscribed within the horizon of possible human experience in order to make sense to a perceiving human being. In order for objects to be made comprehensible to the finite, individual “I” they had to become finite themselves, and be articulated in a plane of space, time and causality. Thus, Kant and Husserl thought everything we encounter ultimately has to take the form of a finite object in order for us to experience it.¹⁸⁴ Marion contends that this a mistake, and that phenomena that transcend what we can conceptualize do in fact appear—and not only that, they appear *often*.

Marion introduces three categories of phenomena. The first he refers to as “poor phenomena” and are appearances “thin” in intuition, that underwhelm the subject’s expectations, such as mathematical truths and concepts like geometry. Marion observes that these phenomena do give themselves in subtle ways in our experience, but we never encounter them phenomenally. We can *never* encounter a perfect circle or a perfectly straight line or the number seven in the world. Thus far from being overwhelmed by what is given, the subject must do the conceptual work. The phenomena barely appear. The second category is common law phenomena, or those phenomena which are measurable and observable through the natural sciences, given within the parameters of the horizon of the experiencing “I”. Common law phenomena include natural objects, trees, birds, bears, flowers, etc. as well as human constructed objects, like tools, coffee mugs, cars, etc. Common law phenomena also include scientific instruments and their measurements, cultural artifacts, and texts. These phenomena unfold according to predictable patterns and can be accommodated within our normal experiential horizons.¹⁸⁵

Philosophers have historically granted metaphysical primacy to Marion’s poor phenomena. They have been seen as “more true” and “more real” because they exist within the realm of reason and not within the messy realm of sensory experience. Marion joins Husserl in arguing that this is a mistake, and that such thinking leads to metaphysical assumptions that what we encounter in our daily experience is less real than that which we do not encounter. “Metaphysics thus confirms its nihilism by organizing itself around the paradigm of phenomena that do *not* appear, or appear just a bit, and by ignoring the paradigm of those that appear

¹⁸³ Ibid., 212-218.

¹⁸⁴ Marion, *Being Given*, 185-189.

¹⁸⁵ Ibid., 179-182.

sufficiently to lay claim to rank of official things.”¹⁸⁶

Marion posits a category of phenomena at the opposite end of the spectrum of poor phenomena—saturated phenomena—those phenomena that give far more in their appearance than the subject can intend, aim, or foresee. These phenomena *saturate* our reason’s attempts to categorize and classify them.

The saturated phenomenon will be described as invisible according to quantity, unbearable according to quality, absolute according to relation, irregardable according to modality. The first three characteristics put into question the ordinary sense of the horizon; the last, the transcendental sense of the I.¹⁸⁷

We cannot anticipate such phenomena, for our anticipations only go as far as our reason and organizing concepts— what we have encountered before through space, time and causality. Marion identifies four types of saturated phenomena— idol, flesh, icon, and event.

All of the encounters we have explored so far qualify as saturated phenomena— they cannot be conceived of fully within the spatiotemporal horizon of an individual “I”, nor can they be organized neatly according to quantity, quality, modality, or relation. In this framing, attempts to study contact experiences through “nuts and bolts” framings only result in a category error— that is to say, they assume that experiences with UFOs/UAP are entirely knowable within the spatiotemporal horizon of an experiencing “I,” through cause-and-effect mechanisms, studyable by the natural sciences. In particular, in this section I wanted to highlight experiences that illustrate contact when it is received as a distinct *gift*, and experiences in which the individuals report overwhelmingly positive, transformative and spiritual experiences. Additionally, these experiences tend to take on more noetic, quasi-physical or subtle body elements. Attempts to study them as a common law phenomena, or as entirely knowable through quantity, quality, modality, and relation, would leave out integral dimensions of their unfolding.

The Gift of Contact: Flesh and Idol

Justin’s experience illustrates with precision Marion’s categories of *flesh*, and *idol*. Marion’s “flesh” could also be called the lived body. In agreement with Merleau-Ponty, Marion considers the flesh not just a cause-and-effect mechanical object, but a living field through which we experience the world. The experience of living, human flesh, in Marion’s view, goes beyond our intentional abilities to classify it through relation or causality. “The flesh auto-effects itself in agony, suffering, and grief, as well as desire, feeling, or orgasm. There is no sense in asking if these effects

¹⁸⁶ Ibid., 195.

¹⁸⁷ Ibid., 199.

come to it from the body, the mind, or the Other, since originally it always auto-effects itself first in and by itself.”¹⁸⁸ Grief, pleasure, memory, love, and human experience in general are all experienced through the flesh. The flesh “auto-effects” itself, meaning that the phenomena and sensations that arise from it cannot be traced to a definite external cause.

Prior to his experience in Zion, Justin underwent a “multidimensional healing” session, after which he immediately saw two unidentified lights in the sky afterwards, resembling orbs rather than structured craft. For about four months, he continued to see unexplained lights nightly in the sky, many of which he caught on video. His experiences then culminated in his powerful encounter in Zion. Everything about this experience subverts his expectations and the constituting horizon of the “I”. Through his hands, his flesh, he feels some kind of energetic exchange between him and Earth. He also feels the extension of his flesh into the Earth itself, feeling the ground as if it were part of him, eroding the barrier between his body and the Earth. There is no clear way to reduce the energetic exchange he experiences to physical causality. “There is no sense in asking if these effects come to it from the body, the mind, or the Other.”¹⁸⁹

The experience of *flesh* is accompanied by the strange experience of the Egyptian symbols in his mind’s eye, which brings us to Marion’s *idol*. The idol refers to visually stimulating phenomena that overwhelm the subject with beauty or presence. Marion says this category saturates the category of quality—it gives itself in our phenomenal field in such a way that we cannot establish patterns of presence and absence or the limits between them. The quality becomes “unbearable” and the subject is “bedazzled.”¹⁹⁰ When Justin receives the strange symbols in his mind’s eye, it is unclear what these images are, or how they are causally related to the visceral, corporeal experience of his body. He is mesmerized by what appears; he cannot establish it with defined qualities. Additionally, the *relation* of the various elements of the experience remain ambiguous; the physical sighting of the hawk and the potential dream or sighting of the rectangular UFO haunt the foreground of what occurs, but direct causality cannot be established.

Justin is not in control of what occurs or how it appears, he can only allow the gift of contact to unfold in his experience. In an experience that blends the imaginal or noetic, physical light phenomena, dreams, physical animals, and a profound fleshly encounter with numinous elements, his experience saturates his spatiotemporal horizon and the ability to be understood through causal mechanisms. In receiving what is given—and allowing its unknowability to stand—Justin

¹⁸⁸ Ibid., 231.

¹⁸⁹ Ibid.

¹⁹⁰ Ibid., 229-230.

becomes the gifted. He lets his subjectivity be transformed by the strangeness, uncertainty, and awe of the encounter.

Another experiencer I call James reports an experience that while primarily noetic—registered in the ‘mind’s eye’ and beyond the sensory—nonetheless manifests through his body. James’ experiences began with hearing about the Pentagon videos of UAP and then seeing strange unidentified lights flashing in his backyard afterwards. However at the time, he describes himself as deeply persuaded by the materialistic worldview and seriously doubting that these flashings could be anything more than a coincidence. He emphasizes he was not convinced by the possibility of other intelligent life, whatever its source. Eventually, after a lot of reading and listening, he reports a change of heart after listening to an interview with a prominent government official about UAP.

Having wrestled with this for four months, I finally reached this place where I said in my head, “the universe must be more mysterious than I’ve allowed it to be.” And in this moment, I have the most visceral, spiritual experience I have ever had...my whole body just starts...to almost be electrocuted...I felt it pulse with energy somehow. And it washed over my whole body. I almost felt near paralyzed. I had no desire to move because what I was feeling felt like the most unconditional love I’ve ever felt in my life.

James’ encounter, which he interprets as explicitly spiritual, is an experience of the flesh. Marion argues that the flesh “auto-effects” itself, including in experiences that cause the traditional sense of “trembling” – those experiences that have some kind of transcendent element to them. Like Justin, James’ experience of his own body during this moment of personal revelation cannot be approached like an object among objects. The energetic sensation does not originate in mental causality, nor in any identifiable stimulus—it emerges from his flesh, precisely as it receives what is given in that moment of openness. In allowing the universe to be mysterious, in his conscious decision to let the rigidity of his assumptions about reality soften, he undergoes a corporeal energetic pulsation. It was in the moment of James’ decision to *let givenness appear*, to allow what was being shown to show itself without being forced to conform to his demands, that he feels himself overwhelmed and transformed by sensation. In a surge of feeling of “unconditional love” he is bedazzled, he cannot draw distinctions of quality, other than the awe of phenomenality.

After this experience, James began to experiment with human initiated contact meditations, which resulted in more sightings of flashing lights as well as orbs, some of which he captured on film. One day during a deep meditation, he reports a startling encounter with gray beings in his yard, all with his eyes closed. Additionally, he began to notice ongoing meaningful synchronicities involving

numbers, often seeing the numbers 1234 and 1111 in situations that had strong personal significance for him. What he once would have dismissed as coincidence—flashing lights, synchronicities, apparitions—now unfolds as an accumulation of gifts. By relinquishing his demands for how reality must appear, James becomes the gifted: his world reshaped by what gives itself on its own terms. James and Justin are transformed, not by trauma or loss of control that forcibly decenters the ego or identified self, but by a willingness to let phenomena appear, and to be constituted by the appearance.

The Gift of Contact: Icon

Marion's *icon* refers to the gaze of the human Other. Like Levinas, Marion sees the Other's gaze as something that transcends the concrete and material. I cannot predict, intend or control the emergence of the gaze of the Other into my phenomenal field. We realize it is not just the "I" that constitutes objects, but that I myself am constituted as an object by the gaze of the Other. "...I learn of myself from what the gaze of the Other says to me in silence."¹⁹¹ The face of the Other exposes us to a realm of meaning-constitution that we understand transcends us and our own conscious viewpoint. It resists mastery—it is not just *looked at*, but it looks back, unsettling the subject and initiating a reversal of intentionality. The experience of the Other exceeds our ability to articulate what is actual, what is possible, or what is necessary, saturating modality. These experiences reveal how encountering the face can be received as a gift. In encountering the face of Others that emerge from an unknown elsewhere and allowing these Others to appear on their own terms, the experiencers are constituted by a gaze that emerges from beyond known distinctions.

Consider Derrick, whose story begins when he was traveling across the country with his wife and small child in 2005. Shortly before daylight, he awoke to see a small humanoid figure standing at the end of his hotel bed.

I woke up to see this female entity at the end of the bed, looking mostly humanoid, and my initial thought was 'is this just our daughter who's gotten up and is maybe disoriented' because your brain just kind of tries to first apply something that makes conventional sense. But as I stood up it became clear that the being was too big to be our daughter. So I started moving towards the being at this point. And it turned towards me and seemed surprised, that's how I interpreted it anyway, then as I moved towards it, it started backing up. So I'm moving towards the end of the bed and it's moving away from the bed, towards the wall. And [it] proceeded to go right through the wall and disappear through the wall, dematerialize kind of thing.

¹⁹¹ Ibid., 231.

Derrick would have written this off as a vivid dream, but his wife was in the room and also saw the entity, bringing the experience into the realm of intersubjectivity. Derrick reports that he weirdly did not feel any fear or emotion during the experience, rather an unexplainable apathy towards the strange events unfolding in front of him. This uncharacteristic apathy—an absence of fear or emotional response—may reflect a disruption of habitual affectivity in the presence of an overwhelming icon which his body had not encountered before. Derrick was confused by his initial encounter and did not immediately associate it as having anything to do with UFOs/UAP. “At the time I just didn’t know what to do with it. Because it looked mostly humanoid. I didn’t initially think alien intelligence.”

Derrick’s story then jumps to 2017, after the famous *New York Times* article on the secret government UAP program broke. It was only then that he got interested in literature on close encounters and recognized similarities with his own experience. Most notably, he discovered that humanoid beings are commonly reported in association with UAP and also found other examples of his strange apathetic reaction to the uncanny events. At this point, he became extremely focused on and driven by the entire topic. “The degree to which I am focused on it seems uncanny, like I can’t really explain why I’m so focused on it.”

The gaze of the humanoid figure in front of Derrick subverts and defies all his expectations. It is present in his room in the middle of the night; it looks back at him—he experiences himself as being seen—and the face appears to display a reaction of surprise. Contrary to his understanding of the abilities of an embodied Other, it turns and walks through the wall. He returns to bed inexplicably undisturbed, until his wife’s reaction jolts him back to reality. The intentions and inner life of the being in their hotel room that night remain hidden, out of the reach of comprehension of Derrick’s or his wife’s intentionality. The encounter is filed away as a strange unexplainable experience for years, until the 2017 events bring the memory surging back into his awareness. In exploring the lived experience of Others, he discovers a new framework of interpretation for his own encounter. In the presentation of the humanoid icon, Derrick approaches the edges of intelligibility—a gaze that cannot be known, only responded to. In the mutual appearing and retreat of the face, contact appears as an ethical and phenomenological rupture— a new form of intersubjectivity.

Linda reports an experience of a luminous, non-corporeal gaze—experiencing herself as seen by beings that do not appear to be physically embodied yet still show a subtle energetic form. Linda’s experiences began with the vision of a woman she encountered in a meditative state, but when she opened her eyes the figure transitioned to the physical plane. “When I opened my eyes, the figure was still there. And then it didn’t... just poof. It kind of went into the distance and went

away.” After the woman disappeared, Linda experienced an episode of automatic writing in which it felt like someone else was guiding her hand, an experience of saturated *flesh*. The message of the writing was positive and encouraged Linda not to give in to fear. In the months that followed, Linda began to witness orbs of light as well as shadow figures. She would also see swirls of light above her bed when she meditated. This resulted in another encounter with a being she perceived to be made of pure light.

But one time, this being came and it was gold, it was light. And it kind of came down. It was like little particles, and formed something that looked like a man...It sat, right on the bed. And I remember looking at it...and it turned and looked at me. And I felt so comfortable in its presence.

Linda encounters not a traditionally embodied being, but a being made of light with distinctly numinous qualities. She describes looking at the male figure and him turning to look at her, experiencing the reversal of intentionality. She feels comforted by his gaze and his presence. Unlike the confusion or bewilderment that often accompany such saturated encounters, Linda experiences deep comfort—suggesting that saturation can welcome at the same time it overwhelms, establishing a gentle, ethical relation. Her experience of automatic writing in which she felt guided by an external force also reflects a subjectivity that receives what is given without mastery or control. The positive message received in the writing, along with her later visions of light swirls, orbs, and a light being, all contribute to an unfolding field in which Linda is exposed to a multidimensional icon—an unknown, non-corporeal face that gazes back, calls, and reconfigures the self without being fully understood.

In both Derrick’s and Linda’s encounter with the gaze of the Other we are reminded of the inherent ethicality of these encounters, a post-Levinasian call of the face. At its core, the gift of contact calls us into relation, into communion with the unknown, into new, diverse, and unknown expressions of the gaze and the face of the Other. Unlike the embodied Others who disrupt and violate in abduction events, Linda encounters an Other whose lack of traditional corporeal embodiment produces a sense of safety and security. Derrick is bewildered by what initially occurs, and it’s unclear how densely embodied the figure he encountered actually is. In the face of these ostensibly nonhuman gazes—whether bewildering, benevolent, or incomplete—experiencers find themselves not as initiators or constitutors of what appears, but as those who are seen, called, and transformed by a relation that both exceeds and redefines the human.

The Gift of Contact: Event and Time

Marion explores the saturation of quantity through the phenomenality of historical events that saturate any individual’s ability to claim a privileged perspective regarding

what occurred. These events are not limited to a singular time, perspective, place, or individual person, but encompass the phenomenal experience of many different individuals and perspectives. The event thus saturates according to quantity, it cannot be neatly organized as singular, plural, or a totality.¹⁹² Some UAP encounters, like the Ariel School Encounter, the Hudson Valley UFO, the Belgium Triangle sightings, or the Phoenix lights, are substantial enough and witnessed by enough people over time to rise to the level of historical *event* in Marion's terms. However, I would like to explore the saturation of quantity through a different lens: the *distortions in the passage of time* that are commonly reported in contact experiences.

All 15 of the experiencers in my study experienced some kind of time distortion in their experiences. This took the form of missing time, in which they had a gap of time they "blacked out" and could not remember; extended time, in which they had the subjective phenomenal experience of more time passing than actually had passed in objective time; or condensed time, in which they subjectively experienced a shortened amount of time than passed in objective world time. This is not limited to only a different mental perception of time, but for some a different *corporeal* experience of time. Recall abductee Catherine, for example, who experienced not only gaps of missing time, but also the feeling after her experience in the upstate New York woods that her body felt multiple days' worth of hydration.

Thomas reports an extended time experience, in which he witnessed images being downloaded into his mind and a sense that he was viewing them for days, only to find that only about 20 minutes had passed in actual time.

I'm putting eggs to boil...I left the kitchen. And as easy as stepping over the threshold from the kitchen to the living room, I was in another world. The world was real. It was tangible. I didn't question it. It was like a dream state, in a way, but it was not a dream; it was not a lucid dream...I felt like I was there for days. And I'm happy...And there was an explosion in real life that brought me back to the house...I haven't stepped one foot out of the kitchen. I'm turning around and I find the water boiled and the eggs are exploding. Whatever time it takes for the water to boil away and the eggs to explode, that's how long I was gone, even though it felt like days.

Eric, whose experiences we explored in Chapter Three, reports several events of precognition, of knowing that things were going to happen before they happened. His experience of the beings led him to understand that they can move in and out of time.

We only see time as being linear, which it isn't, by the way...I've said this on many occasions; to understand who these nonhuman intelligences are,

¹⁹² Ibid., 228.

we have to appreciate that our view of reality is just completely wrong. People who have been traveling in other dimensions, who've been watching over other dimensions, travel in time.

Recall also Deidre's striking sentiment which opened this book: "I think the message that I have gotten from the whole thing, personally, is because of all the synchronicities and precognitive stuff that seems to go along with it, is that *time isn't what we think it is.*" While not always sure what to make of it, experiencers observe that the entities seem to have a different relationship to time than humans do.

Michael Masters has done exceptional work on the distortions of time that often accompany UAP encounters in his recent work *The Extratemporal Model*. While Masters explores time distortion with the intention of providing evidence that UAP are piloted by our future human descendants, I work with these examples with the more modest goal of showing that the phenomenology of contact experiences does not proceed according to the linear rules of time we experience in the natural attitude. For instance, Masters overviews the details of the alleged Amy Rylance abduction, which occurred in Gundiah, Australia in 2001. Amy was at home with her husband Keith and their business partner, Pedra Heller, when she was witnessed being levitated into a craft at 11:15pm that evening by Pedra. Overwhelmed by what she was witnessing, Pedra temporarily fainted. When she awakened, neither she nor Keith could find Amy and the police were called. A call came in from a concerned woman who had found Amy Rylance, who was weak and disoriented, at a BP gas station approximately 90 minutes after she was last seen lifted into the craft through the window. She was confused, thirsty, and experiencing symptoms of anemia brought on by loss of blood. The medical staff at the Mackay hospital where she was taken noted that she was dehydrated, her stomach was empty, and her body exhibited hair growth of several days. Additionally, the gas station at which she was found 90 minutes after she disappeared was an *8-hour drive from her home*. Most strikingly, Amy reported the phenomenal experience of having been on board a craft for *one week*, even though only *90 minutes* had passed in terms of the temporal frame of those who were looking for her.¹⁹³

In a remarkable experience of *condensed* time, Jacques Vallée describes a case in *UFOs: The Psychic Solution* in July 1961. An anonymous university student and future engineering executive was hiking in the country with four other individuals, when he got separated from the other three. He encountered a disc-shaped craft on the ground and was brought on board. He was then transported to a remote area where he encountered what he described as a "teaching machine." He spent what felt like *three hours* learning from the machine, which he recalled playing recordings

¹⁹³ Michael Masters, *The Extratemporal Model* (Full Circle Press, 2022), 243-254.

and downloading information directly into his brain. The bewildered student was then found in the exact spot where he was last seen by his team members, only to learn that *eighteen days* had passed since he had last been seen by his friends. The disappearance was noteworthy enough that the student's father, who was employed by the French government, had launched military and search police parties to look for him in his absence. When he was finally found, his clothes were clean, he did not need a shave, and the flower he had placed in the buttonhole of his shirt was not wilted.¹⁹⁴

Husserl argues that humans experience time through a distinct sense of “inner time consciousness” in which we experience time as a unified, coherent, continuous flow, rather than through discrete individual moments. Husserl calls the horizon through which consciousness holds the past, present, and future together into a flowing whole the “living present.”¹⁹⁵ The living present is not reducible to an undefinable “now” but a *thickened* sense of the present that includes traces of the past as well as anticipation of what is going to happen. The present, in other words, contains the elements of the past and future folded within it. Through retention, the immediate past remains present in consciousness, much like when you hear the playing of a music note, you hold the beginning of the note in your conscious mind as it audibly fades. Through protention, the immediate future is passively anticipated in consciousness.¹⁹⁶ Thus if a song were to be abruptly turned off in the middle, it would disrupt your protention of the next moment. In the center is the primal impression, the actual present moment, the image being seen in front of you or the sound you are currently hearing. The primal impression is always surrounded by traces of the past and the future, retentions and protentions. Husserl's point is that we do not perceive time like an object, rather we *live in it*, it is one of the defining structures of our conscious experience.¹⁹⁷

In contact experiences, the structure of the living present—retention, central impression and protention—is disrupted and broken down. In experiencing gaps of missing time, common in abduction narratives, the continuity of the flow of time-consciousness is altered. Retention and protention collapse, and a temporal lacuna is experienced: there is a loss of continuity in the memory precisely because the primary impression as well as its retention never fully enter into the subject's

¹⁹⁴ Jacques Vallée, *UFOs: The Psychic Solution* (St. Albans: Panther Books, 1977), 16-17. See also Masters, *Extratemporal*, 169-170.

¹⁹⁵ Edmund Husserl, *The Phenomenology of Internal Time Consciousness*, ed. Martin Heidegger, trans. James Churchill (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1964), 44-45.

¹⁹⁶ *Ibid.*, 50-59.

¹⁹⁷ See also Inga Romer, “Time Consciousness, as a Theme in Phenomenology,” in *The Encyclopedia of Phenomenology*, ed. N. de Warren and T. Toadvine, et al., (Springer 2023).

conscious experience, constituting a rupture in the subject's inner constitution of temporality.

In the extended time experiences, such as Thomas' or that of Amy Rylance, the impression seems to stretch, or the retentional chain slows, allowing more phenomena to be packed into a smaller duration. This might reflect an over-saturation of intuition such that the present moment is densely packed with givenness, expanding its felt duration. In Thomas' case, we may compare this to how mystical or traumatic experiences feel longer than they are, because consciousness is absorbing more intensity per unit of clock-time. However, in cases like Rylance's, there was evidence of an altered passage of time on her *physical body*— she showed several days' worth of hydration and hair growth. Similarly, the case of the engineering student cannot be reduced to a protention-heavy structure in which the anticipated sequences unfold rapidly without full impression or retention. It was not just his subjective passage of time that was different, but that his body and the plant life in his clothes *did not show* evidence of having been gone 18 days. In these cases, we have intersubjective evidence of temporal discontinuity, of time distortions that unfold on multiple planes of reality and are not reducible to a distortion in the individual's perception. There is a temporal dys-appearance of the body, when the amount of time the body has aged is in conflict with how much time has passed in the material environment.

Both Michael Masters and Luis Elizondo argue that the UAP intelligence may possess the ability to create bubbles of warped spacetime in the vicinity of their crafts or technology, which could potentially offer an explanation for the different conscious and bodily passages of time that experiencers report.¹⁹⁸ It would take me too far from my phenomenological purposes to speculate on whether or not they may be correct here, although I find it an intriguing possibility. The key point is that contact does not only saturate perception—it appears to alter how the individual *mentally and corporeally experiences time*.

When subjects not only experience an inner subjective discrepancy of time, but their *bodies* show a differential passage of time as well, we have a form of what I will call *double givenness*— a phenomenon that saturates both inner conscious experience as well as the realm of materiality and corporeality. The individual's lived experience does not make sense in terms of quantifiable time, and their bodies, as perceived intersubjectively, exhibit a dissonance with the time passed in the material environment they supposedly never left. Time does not proceed neatly in ways that can be definitively quantified or measured. The “when” of their events cannot be isolated within any experiential horizon. The saturation comes not in the

¹⁹⁸ See Masters, *Extratemporal*, 169-172, and Luis Elizondo *Imminent: Inside the Pentagon's Hunt for UFOs* (New York: William Morrow, 2024), 154-159.

phenomenal experience, but in the dissonance between the bodily and mental time that has passed for the individual and that which has passed “objectively” for others.

This leads us to a core identifiable pattern in the phenomenology of contact experiences: time does appear to follow the same rules during contact events. Experiencers are referred to a *multidimensional sense of time*—in which time can both pass and be experienced differently in different planes of reality. These altered temporal planes can be experienced both mentally and corporeally. Time, consequently, is revealed in experience as far more complex than the *a priori* condition for experience identified by Kant and Husserl. Time is problematized in experiencers’ lived reality, and its boundaries must be re-written. Consider, for example, how Yosef describes his conception of time in the aftermath of his experiences:

I believe that time is really one. And our consciousness in the physical body is experiencing only a small fragment of time that we call present. And the things that we do today in that present can influence the future and the past. I believe that we can change the past with our consciousness. Because our consciousness is not limited by time, it can connect to the past and the future.

Having had experiences that disrupted a linear conception of time, Yosef reconfigures his understanding of time and how it relates to his lived experience. In being open to the gift of contact, he emerges with a multidimensional understanding of time and consciousness, in which consciousness is capable of directly experiencing moments beyond the present.

The Hermeneutics of Contact

Recall that interpretative phenomenology examines the sense-making processes through which these experiences are understood, integrated, and expressed. Thus, it is important to attend to experiencers’ hermeneutic frameworks for interpreting contact. What is the mediating or interpretative role of the subject, when we start with givenness? Marion argues that saturated phenomena expose subjects to “the call.” The call is an ethical appeal that *precedes* the individual’s sense of self, and summons the subject into participation, relation or responsibility. The call thus disrupts Husserl’s transcendental subject as the arbiter of meaning, revealing the subject as a *receiver*, rather than constitutor.¹⁹⁹ Phenomena like art, events, the bodily, or the face of the other “call us” because they appear in excess of our capacity to fully grasp or master them. In overwhelming rather than fulfilling our expectations,

¹⁹⁹ Marion, *Being Given*, 267.

they constitute us as a subject. This means that the subject is *dislodged* as the primary determiner of meaning; meaning instead overwhelms.

In receiving the call, the subject is transformed into the *gifted*—one whose sense of self is constituted by what appears and what is given. What the subject understands as “me” is received from responding to that which calls them into participation from beyond the parameters of the knowable and the expected.

The call, and not the I, decides myself/me before myself...The result of this is the birth of the gifted, a subjectivity or subjectness entirely in conformity with givenness— one that is entirely received from what it receives, given by the given, given to the given...Before knowing an object (surprise), before seeing the Other (interlocation), *I always find myself already transformed into a me under the impact of the call.*²⁰⁰

Contact experiencers find themselves precisely that— “already transformed.” Contact is not presented as something for them to believe, but as an “impossible” call into which they find themselves participating. They must reconfigure their understanding of self and world, attempting to make sense of something that does not fit within their traditional sense-making processes.

However, this does not mean that their sense-making becomes obsolete. Marion “ascribes a phenomenological mediating role to the receiver” meaning that the subject, while transformed by givenness, also must employ their own reasoning processes in responding to what is given.²⁰¹ Dominic Ekweariri, for example, argues that “evidence of givenness can only be attested through the way it generates meaning for the subject, based on his or her point of view.”²⁰² The gifted in Marion’s framework is charged with correctly reflecting the gift, but Ekweariri cautions that we must be careful to consider the role of the individual’s ability to interpret something that defies what they have encountered before. “[H]ow can the hermeneuticist mediate a meaning that they neither relate to nor find meaningful? More importantly, how can it be determined that the meaning they mediate is appropriate to what is given—that they are not suffering from deception?”²⁰³

That question seems particularly relevant to the study of experienter testimony. Jacques Vallée and John Keel have documented how deception seems to play an integral role in UFO/UAP encounters, with the entities sometimes delivering absurd information about their origins, predictions that do not come true, or simply bizarre and nonsensical events like feeding confused witnesses buckwheat pancakes

²⁰⁰ Ibid., 270–271. My emphasis.

²⁰¹ Dominic Ekweariri, “Towards a Hermeneutical Modification of Jean-Luc Marion’s Givenness and the Gifted” *Religions* 15.11 (2024): 4.

²⁰² Ibid., 3.

²⁰³ Ibid., 6.

or asking them for a drink of water.²⁰⁴ Moreover, the beings encountered are allegedly capable of either altering how they appear to witnesses or altering witnesses' perceptions of how they appear— as seen both in reported “screen memories” where the beings are remembered as owls, deer, or large-eyed people, as well as the alleged shapeshifting abilities of the entities. For example Rachel, who we met in Chapter Two, saw a beautiful woman appear by her bed only for the woman to reveal her “true appearance” as a hideous mantid. These distortions and ambiguities surrounding the appearance of contact disrupt the ability of the object to be given clearly and coherently. I will spend Chapter Seven exploring and engaging the potentially deceptive elements of contact experiences in depth. For the moment, it is sufficient to observe that many contact events cannot be interpreted in straightforward ways. Attempts to do so may render them absurd, contradictory, or comically nonsensical. Additionally, the individual responding to the impossible call of contact will use their own cognitive tools and lenses in their interpretive process.

Marion prompts the gifted to let phenomena appear on their own terms; not to force them into our pre-given frameworks of meaning. Ekweariri is correct to raise the concern that the gifted “brings with him his own point of view or worldview (the I, others, and the environment) to bear on what is received in a network of relationships that transforms him.”²⁰⁵ The sense-making process always takes place against the background of the subject's existing world, and is often intersubjective, involving trusted loved ones in their lives, or a compassionate practitioner like John Mack. The gift of contact is inevitably *mediated*, both through the individual who receives what appears and through those that share in their interpretive process— as Mack acknowledged himself.²⁰⁶ Thus what emerges through the contact experience is *the phenomenon as it has transformed the individual in their own subjective and intersubjective experience of the world*.

However, a clarifying point is important. Ekweariri, using the example of religious experience, argues that the witness “remains faithful to his or her world and givenness”²⁰⁷ meaning that in responding to the call of what is given, they retain elements of their established intersubjective world, often interpreting what occurs through their pre-existing religious or cultural worldviews. It would be disingenuous to claim that the individual's existing worldview and cultural beliefs do not affect how they receive and are transformed by contact. At the same time, the gift of contact is *not* merely filtered through existing frameworks—it *can and does explode them*.

²⁰⁴ Jacques Vallée, *UFOs: The Psychic Solution*, 68-70. Also *Passport to Magonia: From Folklore to Flying Saucers* (Brisbane: Daily Grail Publishing, 1969/2014), 35-36. John Keel, *The Mothman Prophecies: A True Story* (New York: Thom Doherty Associates, 1991).

²⁰⁵ Ekweariri, “Hermeneutical,” 9.

²⁰⁶ John Mack, *Abduction: Human Experiences with Aliens* (New York: Scribner and Sons, 1994), 391.

²⁰⁷ *Ibid.*, 11.

Many experiencers report an entirely transformed set of values, beliefs, and worldviews in relation to where they started prior to their contact events. Experiencers like James, Catherine, Linda, and Derrick report explicitly atheistic and materialistic understandings of humanity and the universe before their experiences, which were ultimately completely subverted and transformed. Experiencers report *leaving their previous hermeneutic frameworks behind* and adopting new ones.

The relevant question seems to be, then, when we let the phenomena appear on its terms, when we step back from assumptions about how the world is and how it ought to be, what does the contact experience reveal in its givenness? In answering this question, or I will not pretend that the experiencers nor I abandon all positionality. I will suggest, however, that in leaving as many assumptions as possible behind, we get a little bit closer to allowing the gift of contact to appear. Contact, when received as a call, is not merely an epistemological event—it is ontological. It remakes the subject, unmoors their frameworks, and installs them within a process of becoming whose trajectory is unpredictable and destabilizing. The experiences are still interpreted from within a lifeworld— but individuals are simultaneously transformed by something that exceeds their familiar categories and directs them towards something new. “Cultural lenses” do not sufficiently account for the entirety of what appears or is interpreted nor how the subject is ultimately changed.

As I have suggested that contact experiences often saturate traditional categories of rationality, some may argue it follows that the interpretations offered by experiencers cannot be trusted. But this seems to emerge from the standpoint of whether or not we should *believe* experiencer claims, which demands little of us and may already be asking the wrong question. Instead we should be asking what these experiences *do*, how they behave and function, how they summon those who encounter them or seek to learn from them into a new participatory process. Rational coherence is not the sole measure of truth, and that which cannot be neatly categorized should not be dismissed nor ignored. Marion contends that saturated phenomena are not less real because they exceed our capacity to constitute them—quite the opposite, they are *more* real. They are *more real* because they overwhelm, disorient, and rupture the very frameworks through which we typically grasp the world. Their incomprehensibility comes not in hallucination nor in failures of the individual to perceive clearly, but in *excesses of givenness*. In confronting and navigating contact, what matters most is not whether the experiencer correctly interprets what “happened” in empirical or scientific terms, but what the *event ultimately does*—how it reorganizes the structures of time, embodiment, selfhood, and relationality.

To dismiss experiencers’ interpretations on the grounds that they lack full conceptual clarity is thus to miss a central point: these experiences reveal the limits of conceptual clarity itself. They present in ways that resist full mastery and

knowability. The phenomenological task is not to adjudicate the objectivity of what appeared or decide which claims are to be *believed*, but to trace the transformations of the subject in the wake of the appearance. Interpretation at the edges of intelligibility should not be considered epistemic failure. Rather it is *testimony of rupture*, of what is encountered on the margins of comprehensibility. Testimony, especially when revealing some commonalities across diverse individuals and cultural contexts, reveals an aspect of truth. Not a deductive or scientific truth, but a deeper and more complex truth regarding how we encounter and construct a world. Further, this epistemic openness in the face of the unknown emerges as a key characteristic of multidimensional subjectivity.

Letting the Phenomenon Appear: Elusivity and Givenness

Experiencers confront something that exceeds expectations and saturates human categories of reason—appearing too strangely and too unpredictably to be subsumed under ordinary explanatory frameworks. Yet within this excess, a kind of coherence begins to form—not one that aligns with scientific reasoning, but one that nonetheless displays its own patterns and meaning. A structure emerges that obeys its own logic and form of disclosure.

One of these key structures or forms is identified by French philosopher Bertrand Meheust in “The Mystery of Elusiveness.” Meheust argues that by employing a “phenomenological-like” approach, what is revealed from the appearance of the UAP/UFO is precisely its *elusivity*: the phenomenon presents or appears in ways that never rise to the level of being fully knowable or undeniably true.²⁰⁸ Meheust argues that UAP exhibit a “spontaneous theatricality,” a private show presented for a witness or small group of witnesses.²⁰⁹ Meheust draws on examples of alleged “UAP breakdowns” in the 1960s, in which a small group of witnesses observe a crew scramble to “repair” their craft over a period of several hours. However, the incidents never last long enough for authorities to be called in, for filming to occur, for mass witnesses to bring the event into indisputable intersubjective verification. “In the stories of breakdowns, the repair process, if we are to believe the testimonies, may sometimes have lasted long enough, but never long enough for the foreseeable human reaction to such an extraordinary event to give it an irreversible factual significance.”²¹⁰

Meheust’s point is that the events always stop short of crossing the threshold of having irreversible consequences for humanity, of providing enough proof that they would be knowable in a factual, scientific, indisputable way. We can

²⁰⁸ Bertrand Meheust, “The Mystery of Elusiveness,” *Limina: The Journal of UAP Studies* 2.1 (2025): 30.

²⁰⁹ Ibid., 30.

²¹⁰ Ibid., 28-29.

draw connections with experiencers who report intersubjective encounters, and find corporeal traces on their bodies, but nothing that would rise to the level at which humanity would be presented with definitive proof and forced to fundamentally revise its history. Meheust articulates similar patterns with other paranormal phenomena—clairvoyance exists but is never demonstrated to the level that it breaks down our economic system or markets, rendering our casinos obsolete. Saints used to levitate in front of hundreds of witnesses, but since the introduction of video cameras, such accounts have ceased. “So, in my opinion, elusiveness is... about the thresholds of intensity [a phenomenon] can reach in a given time and place without threatening society.”²¹¹

Meheust argues that elusivity should be considered a *positive* characteristic of the phenomenal givenness of the UAP rather than an absent one—its essential mode of appearance lies precisely in remaining just beyond the reach of full comprehension. While at face-value it seems this emphasis on *withholding* is in contrast with Marion’s focus on *excess*, this contradiction resolves when we understand elusivity as a positive trait of UAP. Elusivity then presents as a form of excess in lived experience, remaining out of full conceptual grasp. While erasure of the physical object is a common, consistent characteristic of the UAP appearance, Meheust also makes the crucial point that these phenomena are *not erased* from the lived experience of the witness. “[I]n reality, the phenomenon does not totally erase itself, otherwise it would also erase the memory traces in the minds of the witnesses, and we would not even be able to evoke its intrusion, or even be aware of the problem.”²¹² The givenness lives on, not in the realm of scientific demonstration or widespread societal proof, but in the memory and lived experience of those who encounter it. In letting appear, this elusivity must be allowed to stand. This means the subject who is transformed by the gift of contact must explore the contact experience through a lens that allows its full comprehensibility to remain out of grasp. In understanding elusivity as a core characteristic of UAP, it is human memory that bears the primary imprints of the event. These phenomena appear *long enough and persistently enough* for subjects to be changed by them.

When previous ontological and hermeneutical frameworks collapse under the weight of contact, the experiencer must ask: what kind of subject can I be, if this has happened to me? What kind of self can emerge from an encounter that exceeds space, time, and reason? Again, we see a return to the theme of multidimensionality—an understanding of self that is not reducible to a physicalist understanding of the human, and in which individuals start to understand themselves as having interactions and relations on expanded, simultaneous planes of reality. Meheust

²¹¹ Ibid., 42.

²¹² Meheust, “Mystery,” 36.

suggests UAP are a manifestation of “psyche”—but not in the sense of an individual’s subjective inner mind. Rather, he describes psyche as a non-natural, intentional domain capable of theatrical, elusive manifestations—one that interacts with our collective perceptions and meanings.²¹³ The experiencers in this chapter seem to be interacting with collective perceptions and manifestations in multiple fields of awareness. They conceive of consciousness as stretching across multiple forms of corporeality, incorporeality, and diverse planes of reality that can be potentially “tapped into” through contact.

The Gifted and Multidimensional Subjectivity

While abductees and those with liminal encounters report transformed understandings of the bodily and the relation to the Other, experiencers with more noetic experiences emphasize the expansion of their understanding of consciousness and its ability to traverse multiple domains of reality, including different dimensions or progressions of time. This engenders the possibility of transpersonal expressions of self. Thomas, for example, reports a reoriented metaphysical understanding in which the appearance of the UAP is intertwined with the transpersonal dimensions of selfhood—beginning with the assertion that the human is not reducible to body or individual ego.

There’s something more significant going on. Whether that’s spirituality or consciousness. I have developed a greater worldview paradigm that helps me make sense of it that I don’t think anybody, short of Carl Jung, is going to appreciate because too many of us think we are our bodies. Too many of us think we are our personalities. And that just ain’t so.

Thomas describes a sense of self that *includes* his body and personality but is not reducible to it—a greater sense of “me” that fits into a wider conscious field. James, in a similar vein, extends this into a new ontological model: consciousness is fundamental and exists prior to embodied life and persists beyond corporeal death. James recalls his previous life as an atheist and materialist, and how his certainty in a limited, finite sense of self has been dislodged.

[B]efore as a materialist, [my “self”] would have been an accidental consequence of the material, and [I’d have thought] that we’re basically lucky to have this one life to observe with. And enjoy it while it lasts, basically. To where now, I believe consciousness is fundamental and I have a persistence beyond this body.

²¹³ Ibid., 34-35.

From previously understanding his subjectivity as a lucky emergence from matter, James articulates a sense of self that exists prior to its instantiation in a material plane— and is not dependent on physical embodiment to persist.

Justin and Derrick most explicitly describe a sense in which they understand themselves as capable of experiencing or connecting with other forms their consciousness can take, especially when displaced from linear, objective time. Justin reframes time itself as a tool of consciousness, not a given structure of the world. The dislodging and transformation of his concept of time enables him to conceive of what he calls a “transcendent” version of himself that is co-existent with his current embodied self, although he uses the illusion of time to experience it as separate. “I know that there is no such thing as time. We just use it here as a tool so we can have the experiences we need to have. But yeah, everything is happening right now, everywhere. This future me that is transcendent in the stars again is happening right now.” Phenomenologically, Justin’s language of transcendence describes a transpersonal and temporally nonlocal sense of self: a “future me” understood as multidimensionally concurrent with his embodied present. Because past, present, and future are reinterpreted as cognitive tools rather than ontological divisions, the co-existence of these expressions of self poses no internal contradiction.

Derrick offers the most articulate description of multidimensionality, explaining that his exploration of altered states of awareness has engendered explicitly transpersonal experiences, in which his consciousness experiences dimensions outside the parameters of physical reality.

Another thing that shifted is my sense of being a multidimensional being...So I’ll experience that I’m interacting with a different kind of intelligence in meditation, but it’s much more than just feeling like I’m interacting with a different intelligence. It feels like I’m actually part of that intelligence in some way. And it feels like some kind of a plurality, it feels like a group of intelligences together that also form a kind of collective intelligence or collective consciousness. And it feels like another dimensional aspect of myself.

Derrick expresses entering altered states of awareness and being confronted by or experiencing himself there, experiencing not only a different intelligence, but a collective sense of consciousness which he interprets as another aspect of himself. It is important to note that Derrick attributes his interest in alternative states of consciousness directly to his contact experiences. It is in dislodging the assumptions of the edges of reality and phenomenality as he’d conceived it, of responding to the impossible call, that he is opened to a wider model of awareness and forms of conscious expression. In experiencing himself as part of collective consciousness or

intelligence, Derrick has become less attached to the permanence of the current embodied version of himself.

I'm much more malleable about that sense of what I am, that those sets of experiences are sort of arbitrary in the sense of what I'm meant to be, or how other people perceive me... I've had a simultaneous experience of being myself or being part of some collective; it feels just as home to me as this does.

Experiencers thus report emerging from the contact experience with an expanded understanding of the multiplicity of planes that consciousness can traverse, decentering the body, the material, and the present as the foundation of conscious experience. They articulate other dimensions or planes, perceived atemporally, where the "I" can have experiences— past, parallel or future versions of themselves, as well as a notion of communal or collective consciousness that precedes and transcends their conscious experience of the body. Having experienced the saturation of the quantification of time, they interpret these versions as all happening simultaneously. The excess of the experience is allowed to stand; it is understood the experiences cannot make full sense within the traditional limits of a consciousness embedded in a spatiotemporal horizon only.

Through a blend of noetic, fleshly, and extratemporal experiences, the experiencers receive the phenomenon on its terms and simultaneously confront new capacities and boundaries of consciousness and its relationship to time, engendering the possibility of transpersonal experience. The multidimensional subject emerges as the lived response to saturation: a self gifted by what exceeds it, and remade in the encounter. From answering the impossible call, the experiencers offer not a structured interpretation of what UAP *are*, but rather, a reconfiguration of the parameters of the lifeworld and of subjectivity on the basis of what has appeared. *The multidimensional subject emerges as the accumulation of the gifts.*

Conclusion:

Starting from givenness, rather than the transcendental "I," we see how contact emerges not as an object of belief, but a call that restructures individuals' participatory orientation in the world. As we have seen in all three chapters on experience, the conception of subjectivity that emerges from the contact experience stands in stark contrast to the liberal model of selfhood and dominant assumptions about agency, corporeality, and consciousness. It also fundamentally posits new questions for relationality and our response to Otherness. Contact initiates not just an epistemological rupture, but a transformative reorientation of the individual in relation to their existential possibilities. The self that emerges from this rupture is no longer limited to the body or the spatiotemporal horizon of the "I" and is

inextricably entangled with other planes of reality and experience. It is from this entanglement that a new ethical horizon begins to unfold.

With the dys-appearance of the body, including the multidimensional body, the boundaries of experiencers' corporeality are challenged, subverted, and transcended. In the liminality of encounters, crossing the boundaries between dream states and physical reality, between the corporeal and the incorporeal, between the finite and the infinite, and between one consciousness and another, the liminal Other offers a mirror through which experiencers reconfigure their relation to Otherness. In exploring the saturated phenomena and experiencers who embrace the gift of contact, including the saturation of linear time, we see the unfolding of new domains of consciousness that interact in an expanded spatial, temporal, and dimensional field. The sense of agency that persists in the aftermath is not defined by the ability to make material choices about one's life, but by a creative responsiveness to what appears across multiple planes of reality, with an openness to ambiguity and the unknown.

In Part II, I will explore the interpretative lens in more depth, focusing explicitly on the changes in values, beliefs, and worldviews reported by experiencers. I will further unpack not just a sense of multidimensional subjectivity, but also the corresponding multidimensional ethic that accompanies it. This will include, most fundamentally, an ethical orientation that considers choices, actions, consequences, and relationality as all occurring in a wider context than the parameters of traditional physical reality. As the experiencers participate in expanded planes of reality, unlocking new dimensions of themselves, they reason ethically in expanded planes of reality as well. They grapple with the question: If contact dissolves the previous boundaries of subjectivity, what kind of world—and what kind of ethics—must follow?

Part II: Contact and a Multidimensional Ethic

Chapter Five: From Epistemologies of Crisis to Coordination: The Transformative Effects of Contact

"Maybe there are things from outside our cave that are subtly trying to awaken us to their ambiguous presence. If something wanted to reach out to us (from beyond our cave as it is currently constituted), we simply would not be able to take the call."—James Madden

"A world or situation that has members with active kinship relationships of care, consent, and reciprocity is one where the members have the capacity to respond in coordinated ways to change that are supportive of their mutual well-being, whether the members are humans, animals, or diverse others."—Kyle Whyte

"I'm interested in people on the fringes, all of the people on the edges...I'm interested in the people who are not so well-to-do, who might be viewed as evil; who might be viewed as crazy. Those are the people that interest me and I want to hear about their relationship to God. Or have they had experiences like mine?"—Marin

In the conversation surrounding potential government disclosure, UAP are often framed as both *new* and *urgent*. The narrative goes something like this: There are technological objects in the sky and we don't know what they are. The capabilities of these objects suggest they considerably dwarf the abilities of human technology. Given that our technological capacities are inferior, we are vulnerable to this advanced technological threat. Hence there is an urgent crisis that should be disclosed to humanity so we can immediately act to prepare for it. Epistemic harms suffered by experiencers, who often have a very different understanding of UAP and their potential occupants, are considered justified because our attention must be focused on the imminent UAP threat.

It is possible, however, that UAP and their alleged occupants are neither new nor urgent. As the experiences we have examined illustrate, they may represent non-human others who have been here interacting with human beings for a long time. In *Passport to the Cosmos*, for example, Mack documents the experiences of Bernardo Peixoto, a shaman born into the Uru-Eu-Wau-Wau, a small Indigenous tribe in Northern Brazil. Uru-Eu-Wau-Wau literally means "people from the stars" and their origin story tells of "a *buskerah*, something from the sky that makes no sound and was not a bird, landed in the Amazon basin and *makuras*, small glowing beings with large eyes who came from the sky, taught the Uru-Eu-Wau-Wau how to plant seeds and grow corn."²¹⁴ Peixoto describes these vehicles and their occupants as the Great Spirit taking physical form, and are considered "people with so much

²¹⁴ John Mack, *Passport from the Cosmos: Human Transformation and Alien Encounters* (Guildford: White Crow Books, 1999), 169.

knowledge that they cannot be from Earth.”²¹⁵ For many Indigenous cultures, what are called UAP in modern academic contexts are not believed to be piloted by alien others, but rather by one of many advanced intelligent non-human entities with whom we share the universe. Indeed, several experiencers in the Worldview Study commented that they do not perceive the entities as extraterrestrials who recently “found” Earth, but as ambiguous, likely interdimensional and liminal entities who have always been here.

These two very different lenses illustrate the divide between what Indigenous American scholar (Citizen Potawatomi Nation) and philosopher Kyle Whyte calls epistemologies of crisis and epistemologies of coordination. Epistemologies of crisis, which dominate post-colonial thinking, involve knowing the world through the experience of the present as new and threatening. The present poses an urgent and immediate crisis that we can suspend concerns of ethics and justice to solve. Epistemologies of coordination, on the other hand, come to know the world through kinship relations that evolve and persist through time, rather than trying to defend our modern ways of being from imminent crisis.²¹⁶ Even though experiencers emerge with a deep concern regarding human harm to the Earth and biosphere, their conviction is not to suspend the concerns of ethics and justice in order to solve the crisis. Rather, they emerge adamant that our ways of being must change, with utmost attention to care, consent, respect, and reciprocity for both human and non-human life. When UAP are approached through the lens of epistemologies of crisis, experiencers are marginalized. Epistemologies of coordination, on the other hand, align naturally with centering experiencer insights.

Through experiences that challenge the parameters of their subjectivity as they’ve previously experienced them, experiencers simultaneously reconfigure their understanding of the entire lifeworld. Entities and events that previously seemed impossible are brought into the realm of possibility, as are ways of relating to each other and to non-human life. Proceeding through an interpretative phenomenological lens, experiencer meaning-making and hermeneutical processes are brought to light. I submit that the transformative effects in worldview are an integral component of the phenomenological structure of UAP encounters. However, this does not mean that such changes are *universal*, as contact does not present as a universal human experience. It means, more modestly, only that they are common. With this in mind, I explore one aspect of those transformative influences: the effects contact experiences have on the ethical orientation and ethical commitments

²¹⁵ Ibid.

²¹⁶ Kyle Whyte, “Against Crisis Epistemology,” in *Handbook of Critical Indigenous Studies*, ed. Aileen Moreton-Robinson, Linda Tuhiwai Smith, Chris Andersen, and Steve Larkin (London: Routledge, 2021), 52-64.

that experiencers hold, even if they do not always express them in explicitly philosophical terms.

Drawing on James Madden's interpretation of Martin Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology," I suggest that contact experiences emerge from beyond the parameters of the human cognitive framing of reality, what Madden refers to as the human "Umwelt." To respond to the call of contact experiences is to take a new attitude towards being, one that is far removed from our modern technological ways of relating that focus on extraction, control, and domination of the natural world. Through the boundary-blurring and subversive nature of contact experiences, a sense of non-duality emerges that challenges dominant models of thinking and opens up spaces of ambiguity and liminality. From a place in between the classical subject/object distinction, a new epistemological foundation, attitude towards being, and ethical orientation emerge. These transformed worldviews are not rooted in a sense of crisis or fear, but in grounded interconnectedness, kinship, and holistic relationality and respect.

Reality Frames and Attitudes Towards Being

The framing of UAP as threatening technological objects must be brought into conversation with the role of technology in our modern ways of knowing and relating to the world. In 1954, Martin Heidegger published "The Question Concerning Technology" (QT) in which he discusses technology not in terms of tools or instruments, but as a distinct *way of revealing* the world. Heidegger's existential phenomenology, first developed in *Being and Time*, focuses on the ways that humans encounter and interact with being itself, and how what we bring into focus in experience both *discloses and creates* a world. Authentic being, in Heidegger's terms, was to be as open as possible to allowing Being to reveal itself on its own terms, rather than forcing Being to appear through lenses or framings that are useful to us.²¹⁷ In QT, Heidegger argues that technological advancement represents a fundamentally new way of "being in the world."²¹⁸ Technology is not a collection of objects that we happen to own and use, rather, it is "an attitude toward Being, which partly determines the beings to which we are attuned."²¹⁹ As humans have evolved and progressed over the last century, technology has become the "basic cognitive principle" that shapes our experience of the world.²²⁰ This new era is primarily

²¹⁷ Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time*, trans. John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson (Oxford: Blackwell, 2004 [1962]).

²¹⁸ Martin Heidegger, "The Question Concerning Technology" in *The Question Concerning Technology and Other Essays*, trans. William Levitt (New York: Harper, 1977), 3-35.

²¹⁹ Madden, *Unidentified*, 113.

²²⁰ Ibid.

characterized not by new devices, but by new attitudes and cognitive framings. “Technology is no mere means. Technology is a way of revealing.”²²¹

In his 2023 work *Unidentified Flying Hyperobject*, James Madden explores how humans filter available possible information to create a frame of reality— or “caves of meaning” —that we understand to compose our world. Madden argues that the UFO is best conceived as a “hyperobject”— that is to say, an object that we can only experience at its edges, never cognizing the entire object at once. Similarly, he argues that a more likely explanation than the extraterrestrial hypothesis is that the UFOs and their occupants exist outside the boundaries of the human *Umwelt*, or the spectrum of reality that our sensory apparatuses are attuned to. Madden’s point is that every organism, whether a tick or a shark or a human being, has a spectrum of reality with which it is capable of sensing and interacting. The sensory world of a tick is much different from the sensory world of a human; and neither is “more real”—rather, each organism is simply “tuned in” to those aspects of reality they need to be able to perceive to survive. When a fish encounters a scuba diver in the depths of the ocean, it must be as equally confusing and disruptive for it as seeing a UFO craft is for us.²²²

Our modern *Umwelt* is indubitably shaped by our technologies— technology influences what we pay attention to and how we bring it into focus, what we allow to filter into our “cave.” This modern technological way of interacting with the world, according to Heidegger, is characterized by seeing nature as something to be mastered, controlled, and extracted. We interact with the world and the Earth as one big energy storage pile, that we can subordinate to our needs and wants. While our ancestors may have worked with nature, for example, building their lives around water sources like a river, in the modern age we instead build dams to reroute the water, or nuclear reactors and other devices that alter nature and force it to bend to our wills.²²³ This attitude has been fundamental to the spread of colonialism and the displacement of Indigenous peoples around the world, who were often forcibly dislodged from their direct and intimate connection with land and the Earth.

The danger in the technological way of being comes in the potential for our reliance on technology to blind us to other ways that being may be disclosed; that it may close us off from the call of a “more primal truth.”²²⁴ This reliance rings even more true today in our age of the internet, smart devices, and artificial intelligence than it did when Heidegger originally wrote it. Madden writes, “The technological lens is increasingly, if not now utterly, the only window we have on the world. *We*

²²¹ Heidegger, “Question” 12.

²²² Madden, *Unidentified*, 48-61.

²²³ Madden, *Unidentified*, 117-118; Heidegger, “Question,” 16.

²²⁴ Heidegger, “The Question,” 28.

force the world to play by our rules, if we are going to encounter it at all.”²²⁵ Our modern modes of being in the world, dominated by technological means that shape what we experience and how we encounter it, make us unable to fully cognize what could be emerging from outside these framings. Things that appear but do not “play by the rules” we are used to are interpreted through the lens of threat and crisis.

Maybe there is more that can be in our *Umwelt* than what can be manipulated and controlled...but we have closed ourselves off to it by our recent technological obsessions. Maybe there are things from outside our cave that are subtly trying to awaken us to their ambiguous presence. If something wanted to reach out to us (from beyond our cave as it is currently constituted), we simply would not be able to take the call.²²⁶

Madden’s overarching point is that the UFO/UAP calls to us from beyond the parameters of our everydayness—it represents something radically Other, something that as we saw in Part I, defies our “common law” and “natural attitude” framings. The technological lens has blinded us to phenomena and happenings that emerge from outside this narrow conception of reality. Technological framing melds naturally into crisis epistemologies—when we relate to the world as one big energy pile that we can extract from, our inability to extract resources indefinitely leads to perceived or genuine crises that appear to demand an urgent response. UAP, in their technological superiority and refusal to present in experience according to the rules of reality as we understand them, are by default assumed to be a threat to humanity.

Contact experiences themselves suggest UAP and the entities associated with them point beyond technology—to a deeper ontological truth. Confronted with phenomena that will not be forced to “play by our rules” and that defy the boundaries of corporeality, consciousness, self, and other, experiencers are thrust into a radical openness, where Being discloses itself outside the confines of our dominant cognitive frames. While humans may generally struggle to “take a call” from beyond our *Umwelt*, extraordinary encounters attune experiencers to a multidimensional subjectivity, open both to what lies beyond normal human perception and to what exceeds our modern technological way of being. The thematic overview that follows illustrates what emerges from “hearing the call”: experiencers report reconfigured metaphysical beliefs and ethical orientations, grounded in a profound sense of interconnectedness with one another and with nature. This orientation moves beyond the technological frame of extraction and control, opening toward more hospitable and holistic ways of relating to the Other. A key interpretive theme is that they reveal a way of coming to know the world rooted in coordination rather than crisis.

²²⁵ Madden, *Unidentified*, 125-126, emphasis added.

²²⁶ *Ibid.*, 126.

New Reality Framings: Metaphysical Transformations

My interviews add to prior research that has consistently shown that contact encounters produce profound transformations in experiencers' values and worldviews. For example, Kenneth Ring's *Omega Project* found that both UFO experiencers and near-death experiencers reported greater ecological concern, reduced materialism, and heightened spirituality.²²⁷ And, throughout *Abduction*, Mack describes a process of "ego death," through which abductees—despite the trauma of their experiences—emerged with a renewed sense of interconnectedness and transformed understanding of the self.²²⁸ More recently, the large-scale FREE study reported that most participants viewed their encounters as positive, noting significant increases in altruism, spiritual concern, and reverence for nature.²²⁹ The interview questions that I chose on metaphysical and ethical themes were chosen based on thematic patterns identified in existing literature and written experiencer accounts, with the aim of getting more depth and detail about these changes.

In terms of metaphysical commitments, as outlined in Part I, participants express transformed conceptions of both consciousness and time. There was more agreement on these questions than any others in the Worldview Study. The most common metaphysical change expressed by participants was the conviction that consciousness, rather than matter, is the foundational property of the universe. They consistently conveyed that all of reality is conscious, and that consciousness ultimately produces matter rather than emerging from it. Many attributed consciousness even to objects traditionally considered inanimate. Participants also express that they no longer see consciousness as limited to the brain or coterminous with the body. For example, Jeanette states:

Consciousness is an eternal phenomen[on], if that makes sense...I certainly understand that it doesn't need to have a solid body within to function...It does not live in the brain so that when the body dies it dies. No. It might get sustenance from our brain, but once we go, it leaves. It's got its own source of energy if you will.

Additionally, experiencers expressed that they believe that consciousness can affect matter outside of the individual's body. An overwhelming theme was that the participants felt understanding consciousness was vital to understanding the entire UAP issue. Deidre comments, "I really think consciousness is the answer to all of

²²⁷ Kenneth Ring, *The Omega Project: Near Death Experiences, UFO Encounters, and Mind At Large* (New York: William and Morrow Company, 1992), p. 173-181.

²²⁸ John Mack, *Abduction: Human Encounters with Aliens* (New York: Scribner and Sons, 1994), 398.

²²⁹ Ray Hernandez, Jon Klimo, and Rudy Schild, "A Report on Phase I and II of FREE's Experiencer Research Study: The Results of a Quantitative Study," in *Beyond UFOs: The Science of Consciousness and the Contact with Non-Human Intelligence Volume 1* (The Dr. Edgar Mitchell Foundation for Research into Extraterrestrial and Extraordinary Experiences, FREE, Inc., 2018), 41-42.

this.” It is revealing that Deidre does not see the UAP issue as primarily a matter of technology, but rather about *the nature of consciousness*.

Additionally, all 15 participants expressed belief in the afterlife, and that their experiences either moved them in this direction or confirmed/expanded a previously held belief. Over half of participants expressed that after their contact experiences, they had no fear of death. For example, Justin says, “I cannot wait to die. Not in a suicide kind of way, but I’m very much looking forward to it. That’s the Egyptians right. They knew that that’s your goal, to die.” Multiple participants expressed that they now see the human conception of death as an inaccurate concept. Catherine remarks, “So the idea that we die is a misunderstanding. It’s a transition. So, we are leaving these physical bodies but this is the thing that’s temporary. Where we go is the thing that’s infinite.”

Time, as outlined in Chapter Four, is also reconceived differently, due to anomalous experiences of the passing of time, both bodily and mental. Themes include the malleability of time during contact events, the perception that the entities are operating outside of or across ordinary temporal frames, the idea that time does not proceed linearly, evidenced by precognition and retrocausal patterns, and reframing time as a constructed tool rather than an absolute feature of reality.

These revised cognitive framings of consciousness and time are accompanied by profound changes in individuals’ ethical orientations and their ethical commitments. From their revised understanding of what the world is, and what a human being is, they build a new model of relationality. Such a perspective has much in common with what made relative of the Oglala Lakota Wahinkpe Topa (Four Arrows) and psychologist Darcia Narvaez call the “kinship worldview”—a way of orienting oneself in the world that is common among Indigenous, nature-based cultures around the world.²³⁰ Such a worldview is rooted in coming to know the world through kinship relations, rather than through threat or crises.

New Reality Framings: Transformations in Ethical Orientation

“Ethical orientation” refers to the framing of ethical reflection and deliberation in terms of certain questions, attitudes, and background assumptions. “Ethical commitments” refers to the result of ethical inquiry that takes the form of concrete principles, maxims, rules, or positions.²³¹ Contact experiences appear to primarily reshape orientation rather than prescribing fixed moral maxims. Having undergone

²³⁰ Wahinkpe Topa (Four Arrows) and Darcia Narvaez, *Restoring the Kinship Worldview: Indigenous Voices Introduce 28 Precepts for Rebalancing Life on Planet Earth* (Berkeley: North Atlantic Books, 2022).

²³¹ This metaethical distinction is made by Colin Koopman in “The Formation and Self-Transformation of the Subject in Foucault’s Ethics,” in *A Companion to Foucault*, ed. Christopher Falzon, Timothy O’Leary, and Jana Sawicki (Chichester: Wiley-Blackwell, 2013), 530.

profound metaphysical changes in their understanding of what reality is and what a human being is, experiencers' background assumptions and default attitudes that they use to frame their moral deliberation undergo profound transformations as well. This includes a widened circle of moral considerability.

Spirituality

All 15 participants confirmed that their experiences had changed their views on spirituality. Themes included a shift from belief in a particular religious tradition to belief in a more universal form of spirituality rooted in oneness or interconnectivity of all things. For example, Rachel expresses a shift to seeing divinity as a "collective" that contains us all and is not separate or above humanity. "I do believe there's a higher power, but I think it's all-encompassing. We are all higher—I think it's a collective." Catherine too reported shifting to a sense of universal spirituality in which all things are interconnected: "I am whatever is exactly 180 degrees opposite of where I started out. I have an innate sense of the interconnectivity of all life; everything in the universe." James adds to this with an emphasis on connection and unity, "I've seen our connection, there is less separation between us...So you know, the spiritual boundaries that I live with now are wanting to become more present, more intentional, more loving." Several of the participants had religious upbringings and expressed negative experiences with organized religion. In these cases, their experiences served as a catalyst for reconnecting them with a sense of a higher power. For example, Linda explains, "I had a love/hate relationship with God before. There was a lot of religious trauma growing up...And then I had these experiences...it made me more in tune with the idea that there is like a god, a source, an energy."

These shifts show several new attunements or reframing of attitudes towards Being. Experiencers appear plugged into connections and relations they previously filtered out of their understanding of "reality." Many of these changes reflect their new understandings of consciousness and deeply felt sense that everything is connected through one conscious source.

Relating to Other Humans

Participants gave the most mixed responses in terms of how their contact experiences had affected their relationships with other humans, both those closest to them and humanity in general. The first theme included an isolation from those closest to them, as well as being more protective of those closest to them. Four experiencers reported that their contact experiences had directly led to the end of their marriages. Others reported that their contact experiences had led to less desire to control others, centering others' humanity and personhood, more compassion

and empathy for humanity as a whole, and anchoring their relationality firmly in the present.

For example, Rachel comments on the effects her experiences had on her personal relationships and how she views the purpose of relationships:

It's a very unconventional situation, being an experiencer, realizing the bigger picture...I think my experiences have taught me that...people are in your life for a reason, even if for a moment, and there should be no guilt or shame. My sister and I haven't spoken in years. But I just realize, you know, if we don't serve each other, then there's no reason why we should have to feel obligated to be in a relationship.

Parker comments that his experiences began with a period of feeling isolated and alone but eventually transitioned into having positive effects on his relationships.

For a long time there was a period of feeling isolated and alone, which also drove me probably deeper into my spiritual quest. And as that began to settle, I accepted that I have these dual relationships. I have this alien connection...But I'm here on earth, I have my wife. I have my family...It actually drove me to them once I balanced out...I'm connected to the aliens. They're my family. I love them. I care about them—Let's just focus on what I have here on earth and fully love and embrace that. So it was like this pendulum swing. And as I swung back towards my human relationships, it's almost like I committed to them in a deeper way.

Linda too says the experiences as a whole have had a positive effect on her view of her relationships with others, shifting from an attitude of wanting to control others to an attitude of unconditional love instead.

You know these experiences made me do like a complete 180...My relationships improved because I've learned to not be... in control. Right, that's not my job...I'm just trying to show them unconditional love. Right? Because that's the main message I got from this.

Catherine expresses that her experiences led her to relate to others in a way that always puts their basic humanity first.

I don't show up for work every day as a machine to fulfill the duties of my role. "I'm *not* just here to do this for you." I *start* from the place of humanity. I find it really disappointing to interact with people who lead in their professional relationships from a place of "you *are* the role, and your basic humanity is not a priority to me while you're here."

Derrick also expresses that he shifted to a sense of *relating* rather than *relationship*, anchoring his intersubjective interactions firmly in the present moment.

So relating is always present tense. It's always about tuning into who the person is right now, right? What is your energy like? What is your energetic signature in the present moment? Not "who do I remember you being?"

Marin expresses that her experiences gave her a new perspective and focus on individuals in the margins, those who are outcasted from the norms and rules of the dominant social order.

[T]he people who are doing well now, prospering, I'm not much interested in them. I'm interested in people on the fringes, all of the people on the edges...I'm interested in the people who are not so well-to-do, who might be viewed as evil; who might be viewed as crazy. Those are the people that interest me and I want to hear about their relationship to God. Or have they had experiences like mine?

It is revealing that Marin now associates a position of marginality or exclusion with having a unique or closer relationship to the divine. She also expresses a sense of comradery with those who find themselves excluded or isolated, wondering if they've had similar experiences with entities or other "impossible" things. Thomas, too, expresses that his experiences have instilled in him a deeper sense of empathy and understanding for all of humanity, stating that "It has increased my desire to cultivate compassion and understanding a hundred-fold."

These shifts in ethical orientation illustrate a movement from ego-centric or transactional moral reasoning toward an ethics rooted in attentiveness, presence, and relationality. Participants describe engaging others not through assumptions or obligations but through direct perception of their humanity, emphasizing responsiveness and care in the moment.

Widened Considerability: Relating to the Non-Human

Experiencers do not just report changed relationships with other human beings however, but also express changes in their ways of relating to non-human life. 10 of 15 experiencers said that their experiences had directly affected how they view the relationship between humans and animals. Of the five who answered "no," four of them stated that they had always had a high respect for animals even prior to their extraordinary encounters. Yosef expresses that after his encounter he began to feel telepathically connected with animals:

After the contact, I felt close to animals and even, almost telepathic with them. I had many situations of animals that were wounded or sick or almost dying and I felt that I want to heal them...It was so powerful that it totally gave me a love and responsibility to life— to nature and animals, especially.

Catherine echoes this, emphasizing attunement and responsiveness to animals' needs:

I can *bear* my animals like they're talking to me...I can *feel* what their needs are, not just by what they're doing. I can *feel* in my body when an animal is frightened, hungry, bored, annoyed, content...I know how to be very sensitive to cats and dogs. I *listen* and *feel* for what they need.

Parker expressed that his treatment of animals flows naturally from how he thought we should treat each other as well as all living things. "How I view how we treat each other and how we treat animals has totally transformed...It's made me love the earth and love human beings and love animals and love plants and love this planet even more so than I was conscious of before."

Catherine expressed the strongest sentiments regarding our treatment of animals, stating that her abduction experiences led her to realize that animals deserve to have their autonomy respected to every degree possible, and that many of our relationships with non-human animals resemble master/slave dynamics.

Animals should be granted their own autonomy. Any animal that would normally live outdoors should be living that way without being made to serve at the pleasure of a human master...It feels like a slave relationship. I used to ride and jump horses when I was young. But now, the thought of bridling and saddling a horse...just twists my gut.

Experiencers also expressed that their changes in relating had extended to entities that the scientific worldview does not traditionally consider as conscious: natural entities like plants, as well as the Earth itself.²³² All 15 experiencers confirmed that their experiences had made them feel a sense of kinship with plants and the Earth. Deidre, for example, expressed that she now felt a sense of guilt even doing things like pruning trees or mowing her lawn:

I feel guilty, like we have a lot of trees here on our property and I know some of them probably need to be cut down but I feel bad about doing that. I feel like I'm hurting them...Or even when I am out mowing, I worry about the bees that are in front of me on the flowers.

Catherine expressed that concern for the Earth and healing the biosphere had taken over as the primary moral concern of her life. Even her changed ways of relating to human beings were ultimately tied back to a connection with Earth. "My relationship to nature is completely transformed. It feels like the number one priority. If there are two priorities in life, they are healing the biosphere, and healing humankind so that we can change the way we relate to the biosphere." Five of the 15 experiencers

²³² In *Light Eaters*, Zoe Schlänger details the existing scientific evidence for plant communication and plant intelligence, suggesting that the dominant understanding of plants as lacking in consciousness or intelligence may be incorrect. The views of the experiencers are not radically incompatible with the most current scientific findings, though they are drastically different than the western cultural understanding of plants. See *The Light Eaters: How the Unseen World of Plant Intelligence Offers a New Understanding of Life on Earth* (New York: Harper Collins, 2024).

directly expressed that due to their extraordinary experiences, they now viewed plants or the Earth itself as conscious beings:

I feel like all plants are living, in some sense, more than we give credit for. More than how this thing leans to the light. There is something, there is a consciousness in it...I feel like maybe, in the same way all this is alive, Earth has a consciousness of its own...But for sure there's a presence of our planet that I wouldn't have seen before. —James

It's really hard for me to even eat a plant. It's really problematic because I know the plant at some level has its own consciousness to it. —Catherine
Being amongst the trees definitely feels like, not just to breathe all of the oxygen that the trees produce, it energetically impacts me too. There's a consciousness wavelength in the forest you know, that I also feel like I can tune into and be a part of. Like this ecosystem. Not just in terms of just flat land, physiology, and physical aspects of trees, but in the consciousness between every sentient expression in the environment.—Derrick

Yosef expresses that he now sees a direct connection between human consciousness and nature itself, as if the natural world exists in a reciprocal relationship with our own conscious experience. If our collective consciousness is out of balance, this directly influences nature. “What I think they [the beings] meant is that our consciousness is crucial to nature. And it's like nature is contaminated like our consciousness is contaminated...So I think that if humanity will be more good, in a moral sense, nature will heal itself, because we are connected.”

These accounts demonstrate a profound transformation in ethical orientation. Experiencers' expanded relationality moves beyond human-centered concerns to include non-human animals, plants, and the biosphere itself. Beginning in a place of deep interconnectivity with other human beings, their relationality with others moves towards interactions rooted in centering human respect and agency, giving up control and extending unconditional love. Their circle of moral considerability expands to include non-human entities, such as animals, plants, the Earth, and the biosphere as members of the moral community. This changes how they “show up” in ethical interactions; how they ground their relationality, and what deeply embedded ethical attitude they bring to their relationships—human and non-human. Experiencers' widened moral circle reflects a deeper attunement to Being itself, allowing them to recognize the agency, presence, and ethical significance of entities they previously considered “inanimate” or morally peripheral.

New Reality Framings: Transformations in Ethical and Socio-Political Commitments

Experiencers' expanded ethical orientation naturally results in changes in their ethical and socio-political commitments. As they come to anchor their relationality in respect for autonomy and holistic consideration of each person's humanity, they also evaluate societal structures through this transformed lens. Their insights reveal both a critique of existing systems as well as visions for alternatives grounded in interconnection and transformed relationality.

Economic and Political Commitments

When asked about economics, 12 of 15 experiencers reported significant shifts in how they view economic systems. Common themes included decreased attachment to materialism, skepticism toward capitalist growth models, and concern for sustainability and ecological wellbeing. James reflects: "There is a limit to natural resources. And this idea of shareholders just need to make more money each year is unrealistic. A company can't grow indefinitely forever...I feel very anti-capitalist kind of sentiments." Catherine similarly links interconnection to economic reform:

One person is not more or less valuable than another person. But capitalism says that they are, and that is a fundamentally flawed premise... We don't need money, credit cards, loans, or interest—they're artifacts of an ancient paradigm.

Parker frames his critique more broadly: "[I am] becoming more and more disheartened by the system...It's an unsustainable pyramid."

The experiencers were also questioned about whether their experiences had changed their views of politics and political systems, with again 12 of 15 answering yes. Themes included an overall lack of interest in politics in general, viewing politicians as untrustworthy and the entire system at odds with how they think society should operate. Catherine expresses a need to move to decentralization, ground-up organizing of communities, and creating a society that reflects a more holistic relationality:

Everything needs to be decentralized...In general, governing bodies should be localized, globally interconnected, and functioning on a shared set of principles grounded in a basic value system that the majority of healthy human beings innately understand.

Derrick envisions politics as ideally being guided by an extension of relational transparency:

We need a new model...You want a system where people's felt sense of who they are is expressed in what they do for work...actually finding ways to help people really tune into their core expression of who they are...We

need to recognize wisdom again, and actually how to share a sense of what wisdom is...[W]e build from the ground up, this bottom up kind of approach to how we interrelate with each other, what it means to show up, because this is key to the political part. As we develop this radical transparency, it gets to the point where a politician cannot fool you.

In short, the experiencers describe our current economic and political institutions as fundamentally incompatible with the ethical orientation they now use to anchor their relationality. They do not see our current economic and political systems as reflecting a holistic interconnectedness, or truly promoting equality, equity, and honesty. They desire to see the inner changes in themselves and their personal ways of relating reflected in our broader social interactions and societal arrangements.

Specific Issues: Criminal Justice and Education

I asked more specific questions about education and criminal justice, in order to get a sense of precisely how participants thought our institutions should change. 12 of 15 said their experiences had influenced their views on criminal justice. Themes included a need for rehabilitation and compassion and addressing underlying trauma. Participants also emphasized that if we make the shifts in ethical orientation and relationality necessary, we would naturally transition away from retributive forms of punishment. Marin and Linda both express a sense of compassion and understanding for what leads people to deviant or harmful behavior to begin with.

Even if it's an innocent kid who grew into a hardened criminal, I would see them as the same innocent person. Probably distorted because they've been punished and hurt all their lives...Did that come from my experiences? Probably. Only because I had to look at myself in a different way. I was suddenly this crazy person who's seeing aliens or whatever. --Marin

Compassion. I really changed. I used to go like, "people are killers. They're blah blah blah blah blah." I really feel like these people just need love and rehabilitation...I just know that more compassion should be involved. --

Linda

Sarah expresses that her experiences led her to believe that people should be given more chances to understand the effects of their behavior and make changes that reflect this understanding.

You have to try to teach them or reach them to let them know why they should do what they do and the devastation it's done to other people. That's what I think is missing; that they need to see what that has done to people...and help them change who they are at the core, because people can change who they are.

Parker and Catherine both expressed that the social systems we have are what give rise to crime in the first place, and that making fundamental changes to those systems in line with the desired ethical orientation would change the need for things like prisons.

What I got from the aliens was...they don't understand how we treat each other...And if we had a different society, probably 95% of those crimes wouldn't get committed because they're committed out of desperation. So our legal system, our crime and punishment system, is based on an archaic human consciousness that will continue to exist unless, until there is a shift in consciousness. —Parker

There's a whole science, consciousness, and paradigm shift that needs to happen regarding how we relate to individuals who manifest socially aberrant behaviors out of, let's call it "faulty wiring," whether made so by nature or nurture. The new paradigm should be focused on healing; healing individuals and the collective.—Catherine

With respect to education, 14 out of the 15 reported that their experiences had influenced their views on education. One prominent theme included the idea that education should be tailored to the unique strengths and gifts of the individual. This idea stems from seeing the unique value and worth of each person, rather than educating based on standardization. For example, Parker and Catherine comment:

Because every human being will be valued, then the investment in their education to contribute to society...there will be an importance to it. So we'll know everybody is important to civilization or the tribe or the group. Then education will address everyone's needs. —Parker

We should be much more attuned earlier on to seeing and recognizing the strengths, interests, gifts, and talents of a child; and make it a priority to discover who that individual soul is and what they feel called to express in this life distinct from their parents' needs and projections. —Catherine

Sarah comments on a similar theme but also emphasizes that the current system stifles and inhibits creativity and love of learning.

I think people should be taught what they love. And then everybody would be good at what they're good at...Put them with somebody that could mentor them in that area, you know, like apprenticeships. Because kids really do have a love of certain things at a young age and we just tear it out of them.

In addition to a focus on individuality, Derrick comments that he would love to see the fundamental interconnectivity between all things taught to children.

I think that what we want to have is a felt sense of to live is to learn... a feature is to teach this fundamental connecting between all things and

beings and get to a point where every child has developed that sense that they're part of the world and of themselves and that becomes the primary way they orient to everyone else...I think we would have this sense of helping people get in touch with their own energetic signature.

The other major theme was the idea that children should be taught about universal spirituality, psychic gifts, and UFOs in primary and secondary school as well as in higher education. James comments, "I would love, eventually, if there were more opportunities to be trained in this sort of stuff" [anomalous and psychic experiences]. Similarly, Jeannette states, "I do have a fantasy...that at a very early age, children get in touch with their psychic abilities."

Across both criminal justice and education, experiencers articulate reforms grounded not merely in pragmatic concerns, but in an ethical and metaphysical vision shaped by their contact experiences. Their emphasis on compassion, rehabilitation, and systemic transformation reflects a commitment to relationality, inter-connectivity, and respect for individual autonomy. These reforms can be seen as a response to the call of *being*, an attunement to the ethical possibilities of existence that arise when one confronts the deeper structures of reality. Just as they now see consciousness and moral worth extending beyond human boundaries, so too do they imagine social systems that nurture, rather than punish, and truly educate, rather than standardize. In this sense, their proposals for criminal justice and education are inseparable from the broader transformations in multidimensional subjectivity and the ethical orientation that flows from it.

Roots of Transformation: Subjectivity Reconfigured

The "Mind Control" Hypothesis

Having shown that these results align with other researchers who have also shown experiencers develop an entirely new worldview, including ethical orientation and commitments, in the years following their encounters, the question arises as to *why* these changes occur. An argument informally floated in UAP academic circles and communities is that this is simply a sophisticated form of mind control; an intentional manipulation to make colonized and dominated subjects more complacent with an invasion from the non-human entities. While "mind control" theories may fit nicely with epistemologies of crisis that view the UAP intelligence as an imminent threat, I find this scenario highly unlikely for several reasons when we reflect on the phenomenology of the experience.

First, given the apparent advanced abilities of UAP technology, I see no reason why an intelligence controlling them would have to go to such lengths to manipulate us if they are simply a colonizing power who plan to control and dominate us. Their technological capabilities appear to vastly exceed those of human

beings, and they could easily employ much more straightforward methods of domination and control if this were the intended aim. Second, the transformative changes are not instant, but often emerge over time, and for abductees in particular, after a period of trauma, shock, and abjection. As shown in Chapter Two, the immediate reaction to abjection, having the boundaries of self and world break down, is one of horror, disgust, and sickness. Several experiencers reported periods of depression, isolation, and ontological shock in the aftermath of their encounters. If this were about sophisticated mind control, why would these periods of trauma, and ultimately deep introspection be part of the game? Additionally, not all experiencers come to the same conclusions, with the FREE Study showing that about 20-30% still viewed their experiences as negative and not as forms of transformative experience. If this is an elaborate mind control plot from an invading colonizing power, they seem to be doing a pretty poor job.

More importantly, the transformations of the experiencers leave them feeling more empowered and confident, and with a new appreciation for life and other members of the human and non-human community. The goal of manipulative mind control is to make people weaker and more complacent, less sure of themselves, and more likely to follow the commands of the invading empire. Experiencers emerge from these experiences with the exact opposite sense; they rely more on their own inner knowing and discernment and feel empowered by their new understanding of their humanity and the reality in which they live. Moreover, the new worldview is not presented as an inevitability or something that strips them of their culture and traditions, in the way that colonized subjects are imperialized and forced to adopt the values of the oppressor. The experiencers are offered an *invitation* into an initiatory process, but one that it is ultimately up to them to accept or reject. While loss of agency and autonomy are core to the abduction experience in particular and sometimes contact experiences as well, experiencers often come to see this very loss of agency as serving an important functional role in expanding their conception of self. Still, they feel they had choice or agency in terms of how they responded to the confrontation with the non-human Other— they are not forced or coerced to adopt new metaphysical or ethical views. Rather, they report feeling they are shown and offered an *opportunity* to transform.

If not part of a game of advanced manipulative mind control, where might these changes originate? I do not think there is a single answer to this question, but the structure of the experience points to several likely contributing factors:

- 1) Collapse of anthropocentrism: A natural progression from the realization that we are not the only advanced intelligence in the universe leads to a post-anthropocentric worldview that includes a deepened respect for other forms of life.

- 2) The nature of the experiences themselves: transpersonal experiences, non-ordinary conscious states, out-of-body experiences etc., lead to the belief that consciousness is not coterminous with the body and can have experiences on other planes or dimensions of reality.
- 3) Alleged communication from the entities: the messages and imagery described as communicated by the non-human intelligences, often but not always referring to environmental or nuclear disaster.
- 4) Increased psychic and empathic abilities: following their encounters, experiencers report an increased ability to empathize with or feel the conscious states of other minds and lifeforms, including non-human lifeforms.
- 5) A position of marginality: finding themselves at the edges of society, having had experiences that the dominant social ontology (naturalism) tell them are impossible, experiencers are opened up to the other “impossible” things.
- 6) A blurring of the subject/object distinction: Experiencers report a blurring of our key distinction between the “me” and the “not-me.” From their encounter with radical Otherness, their own multi-dimensional nature is reflected back to them.

While I think it is likely that all these factors contribute to the transformation and growth, I would like to spend some time exploring point (6), as I think this is crucial to understanding the experiencer phenomenon, especially through a phenomenological lens.

The Boundaries Between Subject and Object

The distinction between subject and object—between what consciousness conceives as “me” and “not-me”—is foundational in phenomenological analyses of experience. These are not considered *a priori* structures fixed in advance, but *a posteriori* distinctions that emerge through our engagement with the world. In Sartrean phenomenology, for example, the conscious subject forms a conception of self only by differentiating itself from what it is not. Consciousness is always immersed in a physical and social environment of objects and other bodies, and through this immersion forms a sense of the “not-me.” Anchoring experience from the standpoint of its own perspective, the subject comes to apprehend both its own identity and its borders.²³³ The lived body and inner conscious life constitute the boundaries of the “me,” while the external world of things, animals, other humans, and other minds constitutes the “not-me.”

²³³ Jean Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*, trans. Sarah Richmond (New York: Washington Square Press, 2018).

Contact experiences unsettle these habitual delineations. A common phenomenological rupture reported by experiencers is the experience of consciousness as not confined to the individual brain, and lived as a foundational property of the universe itself. From this perspective, the strict separation between mind and world collapses. The experiencer finds themselves belonging to a larger field of subjectivity in which consciousness interpenetrates nature and other beings, both human and non-human. This expansion of self is not merely conceptual but practical. Experiencers frequently describe capacities of consciousness that appear to exceed a physicalist framework of causality. They report, for example, that consciousness can act directly on matter, or that it can communicate with other minds non-locally. Such possibilities, strictly ruled out by materialist assumptions, enter their existential field as live options. Many experiencers, such as James, Derrick, and Justin, participate in close encounters of the fifth kind (CE-5s), events in which groups set a conscious intention to invite contact with non-human intelligences. These protocols typically involve meditation and visualization of oneself as interconnected with the universe, affirming that mind alone can reach across space, time, and dimensions. Participants take seriously the idea that non-local consciousness makes telepathic communication with non-human entities possible, and they act on this belief in practice.

The reconstitution of selfhood also extends into the temporal dimension. Experiencers often come to see themselves as existing beyond linear time and local embodiment. As Justin described: “This future me that is transcendent in the stars again is happening right now.” One of the fundamental parameters of our experience of subjectivity is that it is anchored in a body, in a particular time and place. Through contact, experiencers perceive a new layer of identity that transcends these limits. They variously describe this as the higher self, transcendent self, or soul—a dimension of being not bound by ordinary space-time coordinates.

Finally, the dissolution of boundaries reaches its most radical form when the distinction between self and other beings—human, animal, plant, or Earth itself—begins to give way. Experiencers come to see these categories as provisional, useful for navigating the world, but not ultimately fixed. At the deepest level, they describe reality as emerging from the same underlying “stuff.” Consciousness individuates into distinct perspectives, giving rise to the apparent divisions of subject and object, self and world. But in their encounters, experiencers tap into what feels metaphysically prior to these distinctions: a shared ground of being from which differentiation arises. A useful phenomenological concept we can return to is Merleau-Ponty’s notion of the *flesh* of things— a fundamental ontological category through which both the perceiving subject and perceived world emerge. “The flesh we are speaking of is not matter. It is the coiling over of the visible upon the seeing

body...The flesh (of the world or my own) is not contingency, chaos, but a texture that returns to itself and conforms to itself.”²³⁴ The *flesh of the world* is the fabric of being itself, where perceiver and perceived are intertwined and cannot be fully separated. Through our experience of physical reality, we experience flesh as our own or as the world’s—yet this relational field exists prior to us making the distinction between subject and object.

Jeffrey J. Kripal and Dual-Aspect Monism

In his work, Jeffrey J. Kripal refers to this dissolution of subject and object as “dual-aspect monism,” a position that ultimately denies any final distinction between the mental and the material. As he emphasizes throughout *How to Think Impossibly*, the world is one, but the human is two: human consciousness can experience reality as either physical or mental, yet these are not ultimately separate. It is through consciousness that we impose the division between mind and matter, a division that obscures the “deeper unity of everything and everyone.”²³⁵ Kripal lays all his cards on the table early in the book:

[T]here is no final distinction between subjective and objective states, between consciousness and the cosmos. Moreover, and this sounds even more outrageous, the past, present, and future are all one ‘thing’ and they are constantly interacting outside or to the side of us...Reality only appears to be divided into mind and matter, into consciousness and cosmos, or into a past, present, and future because *you* experience it as such. *You* are the splitter of the real and the creator of linear time.²³⁶

Kripal frames this not merely as speculation, but as a position supported by insights from modern quantum physics, such as the double-slit experiment, which challenges the neat separation of observer and observed. In the chapter “Why They Don’t Land,” he draws on the work of Jeremy Vaeni—an alien abductee, kundalini experiencer, and friend—who argues that extraterrestrials do not land because, ultimately, they are us. Kripal finds this proposition exciting: “Why don’t they land? Because there are no aliens, at least not any that are ultimately different from us. ‘ALL is ALL’ as he puts it in so many places.”²³⁷ I do not take this to mean that the entities exist only in our minds, or that they lack must lack any material or biological reality. Rather, the idea is that these beings represent different physical manifestations of a monistic universal source.

²³⁴ Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *The Visible and the Invisible*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Evanston: Northwestern University Press 1968), 146.

²³⁵ Jeffrey J. Kripal, *How to Think Impossibly: About Souls, UFOs, Time, Belief, and Everything Else* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2024), p. 9.

²³⁶ *Ibid.*, 8-9.

²³⁷ *Ibid.*, 79.

Kripal does not see the UAP phenomenon as evidence of an alien invasion. Rather, he thinks:

There is an attempt, largely a missed opportunity, to tell us that we are not, and that our violent nation-states and horrible histories are not really worth preserving—that those histories are there for *mourning*, not celebrating, that we need to go back to *remember* and *redeem* the past, not to deny, preserve, or conserve it.²³⁸

It is from a mindset of subject vs. object, me vs. not me, us vs. them that we have built a version of reality based on power, control, colonial conquest, and survival of the fittest— which organically bleed into viewing the world through the lens of threat and crisis. The experiencers describe these systems as incongruent with the call of communion and interconnectivity they feel from their experiences, and with the vision of reality that their encounters tell them is possible.

The phenomenological and ethical reorientation described by Kripal resonates with a broader reconsideration of how knowledge itself is structured and transmitted. Experiencers' expanded sense of relationality, their awareness of interdependence across human and non-human life, and their critique of hierarchical, extractive systems reveal a shift in epistemic stance: from a reactive, survival-oriented understanding of the world toward a more integrative, ethically grounded approach to knowing. This movement mirrors what Kyle Whyte characterizes in Indigenous scholarship as a transition from crisis epistemologies— knowledge frameworks that arise primarily in response to urgent threats or immediate survival imperatives—to coordinated epistemologies, which emphasize relationality, foresight, and collective responsibility. In both cases, knowledge is inseparable from ethical orientation and social responsibility; how one comes to know the world shapes and is shaped by, the way one acts within it.

The Kinship Worldview and Coordination Epistemologies

The transformed perspectives that experiencers express as key to their new understanding of subjectivity and reality take us far from western epistemologies and metaphysics anchored in anthropocentrism, scientism, domination of nature, and technological advancement. This reframing of Being, however, *does* take us in natural proximity to the worldviews of non-anthropocentric cultures that live in closer connection with nature, such as the Indigenous peoples of North and South America.

In *Restoring the Kinship Worldview*, Wahinkpe Topa and Darcia Narvaez articulate 36 criteria of the kinship worldview, which they argue are common tenets

²³⁸ Ibid., 80.

held by Indigenous/tribal people around the world. Acknowledging that these traits exist on a spectrum, they contrast the kinship worldview with the dominant mainstream worldview. Some of the criteria of the kinship worldview include: non-materialistic, emphasis on community welfare, emphasis on Earth and all systems as living and loving, animistic and biocentric, flexible boundaries and interconnected systems, nature as benevolent and relational, time as cyclical, recognition of spiritual energies, regular use of alternative states of consciousness, and emphasis on holistic interconnectedness, among others.²³⁹ These characteristics vary in degree and expression in different Indigenous cultures, but Topa and Narvaez emphasize that Indigenous people in various places around the world have more in common with the worldviews of other Indigenous groups than with the dominant scientific worldview. We also see many aspects of this worldview directly reflected in the positions voiced by experiencers.

Indigenous American (Citizen Potawatomi Nation) philosopher Kyle Whyte argues that Indigenous peoples, in contrast to cultures supportive of colonialism, employ “coordination epistemologies” rather than “crisis epistemologies.” As discussed above, Whyte argues that perpetrators of colonialism often frame their actions as defensible in order to prevent or respond to a perceived or actual crisis. Whyte argues that climate change is only the most recent example of this phenomenon. Because climate change is perceived as an imminent threat to human welfare, mitigating climate change is seen as a justifiable reason to harm or disrespect Indigenous peoples—whether denigrating their knowledge systems or putting wind power projects on their sacred lands.²⁴⁰ Or, the UAP is framed as an imminent threat requiring a national security response— including firing Hellfire missiles at the unidentified aerial objects that may contain living beings.²⁴¹ Luis Elizondo titled his book on UAP *Imminent*, showing the influence of crisis epistemologies on dominant UAP framings, even when they come from well-intentioned actors.²⁴²

The idea of an imminent crisis includes “the sense that something horribly harmful or inequitable is impending or pressing on the present conditions people understand themselves to be living in.”²⁴³ Crisis epistemologies contain a *presentist narrative* structure— that is to say, “time is put together (arranged) to favor a certain

²³⁹ Topa/Narvaez, *Restoring*.

²⁴⁰ *Ibid.*, 52.

²⁴¹ Charlie d’Agata, “Newly released video at House UFO hearing appears to show U.S. missile striking and bouncing off orb,” CBS News, September 10, 2025
<https://www.cbsnews.com/news/video-house-ufo-hearing-us-missile-strikes-unidentified-object/>. Accessed September 18, 2025.

²⁴² Luis Elizondo, *Imminent: Inside the Pentagon’s Hunt for UFOs* (New York: William Morrow, 2024).

²⁴³ *Ibid.*, 54.

conception of the present as a means of achieving power or protecting privilege.”²⁴⁴ Part of this presentist structure, or privileging of the present means that the crisis is interpreted as both *unprecedented* and *urgent*. *Unprecedented*, because it is assumed there are no similar situations that have happened in the past from which we may draw wisdom or experience. *Urgent*, because they must be responded to quickly, and thus harms to human and non-human life are seen as unfortunate but necessary. Due to the unprecedented and urgent nature of climate change, clean energy solutions that result in the economic deprivation of Indigenous peoples, land dispossession and desecration, and silencing of Indigenous leadership are seen as necessary trade-offs to solve the crisis. Epistemologies of crisis, then, cleverly mask the operations of colonial, imperialist, capitalist, industrial power in the name of preserving the current way of life and mitigating the crisis.²⁴⁵

Epistemologies of coordination, in contrast, “emphasize coming to know the world through kin relationships.”²⁴⁶ The Indigenous people of North America, such as the Ojibwe or Nez Perce, come to know the world through the articulation of moral bonds that entail mutual responsibilities. Examples of kinship relationships are “care, consent, and reciprocity, among others.”²⁴⁷ Epistemologies of coordination understand that reality constantly changes and networks of coordination that pay close attention to relationships are key to navigating these changes. In a constantly moving and changing world, kinship relationships between human and non-human parties are what allow us to keep concerns of ethics and justice intact, and to learn from the past, not privileging the present at the only moment that matters. For example, Whyte draws on Ben Colombi’s documentation of how the Nez Perce people demonstrated remarkable resilience and adaptivity when faced with colonial invasion, emphasizing that it was kinship bonds, including leadership traditions, that were able to sustain coordinated responses to colonial harms.²⁴⁸ “A world or situation that has members with active kinship relationships of care, consent, and reciprocity is one where the members have the capacity to respond in coordinated ways to change that are supportive of their mutual well-being, whether the members are humans, animals, or diverse others.”²⁴⁹

Epistemologies of coordination are *not* presentist. They understand that kinship extends across time and cannot be created urgently. Nor do they hesitate to draw on wisdom from the past in order to articulate and create a more just future.

²⁴⁴ Ibid.

²⁴⁵ Ibid., 56.

²⁴⁶ Ibid., 58.

²⁴⁷ Ibid.

²⁴⁸ Ben Colombi, “Salmon and the adaptive capacity of Nimiipuu (Nez Perce) culture to cope with change,” *The American Indian Quarterly* 36 (2012): 75-97.

²⁴⁹ Whyte, “Epistemologies,” 59.

The sense of imminence in epistemologies of crisis makes some people believe that it is possible to make transformation in the world in ways that ensure societies can bounce back to some current state of affairs. Given that, for many Indigenous peoples, the current state of affairs is one that people are trying to move beyond given how it has been shaped negatively by oppression. This means that what appears as an acceptance of an inevitable end is more akin to a deep motivation to create a better world.²⁵⁰

Experiencer testimony can be read as resonating with this very shift from crisis epistemologies to coordination epistemologies. Like Indigenous traditions that emphasize kinship, reciprocity, and continuity across time, experiencers often describe their encounters as invitations into deeper relationality—with the Earth, with non-human life, and with one another. Additionally, they see our current social structures as contributing to various states of separation and marginalization and ultimately not worth preserving. Rather than interpreting UAP as imminent threats requiring defensive action, experiencers tend to reframe their meaning as calls to ethical transformation, mutual care, and ecological responsibility.

While experiencers emerge with a much deeper concern for the biosphere and for the harms we are invoking upon the Earth, they do not see this concern as warranting suspension of ethics and justice to solve the “imminent crisis.” Having been forcibly dislodged from a linear experience of time, their orientation is not presentist nor aimed at preserving the present moment. Rather, their reasoning incorporates multiple dimensions, timelines, incarnations or versions of themselves and others. Seeing that the institutions, practices, and systems that we have are ultimately not benefiting human or non-human life, they are not invested in trying to preserve our existing ways of life at all costs. Rather, they envision forms of relationality that may take time—lifetimes—to develop that honor our interconnectedness with each other and other forms of life. Concerns of ethics and justice are forefront and not to be suspended for the sake of solving the immediate “crisis.”

Additionally, many experiencers express the sentiment that the UFO/UAP entities have “always been here” (Rachel, Deidre, Eric) or have been here for a long time and thus do not view the UAP as a “new” state of affairs that demands a national security response. Rather, the experiencers are interested in developing relationships of kinship with the entities—some, like Parker and Catherine report they feel like they have known these entities for multiple lifetimes and are growing into deeper communion with them through their encounters. Such kinship is understood as slow growing, a relational process that transcends individual lifespans

²⁵⁰Ibid., 61.

yet serves the evolution of humankind. They do not hesitate to draw on resources from the past to understand their experiences, often exploring various nature-based spiritual traditions that report contact with non-human entities, or ancient esoteric, cultural, or religious texts that may inform what occurred. Thus, experiencers are not drawn into the dominant threat narrative surrounding UFOs/UAP as national security concerns, nor do they see humanity as needing to immediately act to defend our systems and institutions from the "imminent crisis" of UAP. They see the UFO/UAP and contact experience as catalysts for moving beyond our current state of affairs, and growing in deeper kinship, care, and respect with human and non-human life.

The ideas of consent and reciprocity that are integral to coordination epistemologies and the kinship worldview are also reflected in the positions of experiencers. Linda mentions giving up her desire to control others in her relationships; shifting instead to starting in a place of love that respects the paths and self-determination of others. Catherine reflects on how barbaric she now finds it to saddle a horse and force it to carry her weight, extending concerns of autonomy towards non-human animals. Derrick emphasizes the importance of radical transparency and honesty in ways that allow honest representations of ourselves when showing up in present *relating*, enabling reciprocity in our connections. Yosef explicitly states that he believes human consciousness exists in a reciprocal relationship with nature, and that healing human consciousness heals nature as well. Rachel, Catherine, Jeannette and Parker spoke directly on the reciprocal relationship they felt with the non-human beings— that something was indeed taken from them during their encounters, but they had gained so much as well in their own understandings of themselves, the universe, and their relationality.

Madden suggests UAP may be offering a call from outside of our caves— our dominant technological cognitive framings— that may be drawing our attention to a deeper, more primal truth that Heidegger thought we were in danger of missing. The technological mindset bleeds easily into crisis epistemologies— when it seems our technologies can no longer sustain our current way of life, or when we encounter something that does not play by our rules, an urgent, unprecedented crisis is perceived. By ontologically shocking experiencers out of their dominant framings of reality, by challenging the boundaries of corporeality, relationality, and consciousness, the UAP encounter appears to open them up to attitudes that transcend the technological framing. Here, on the margins of reality—in a more malleable metaphysical plane of consciousness and time—they come to know the world through kinship connections: with other humans, with non-humans, with Earth itself, and with the Unknown Other.

Conclusion

Through our sensory apparatuses, cognitive framings, and attitudes towards being, we create an understanding of what the world is and how we relate to it. Heidegger shows that in the modern age, technology has taken over as our default mode of being, our way of orienting ourselves in the world. Such a framing lends itself nicely to the logic of colonialism and the crisis epistemologies that accompany it—presentist narratives and linear models of time give way to senses of urgency and unprecedentedness—whether we're talking about climate change or UAP. Experiencers, through their experiences of multidimensionality, express profound transformations in their metaphysical beliefs about time, consciousness, and the survival of consciousness beyond death. Additionally, they report a new ethical orientation rooted in interconnectedness, transparency, respect for autonomy, and an expanded circle of moral patiency. Their specific ethical commitments on issues of ethics and social justice reflect this orientation.

These transformations come into natural proximity with *coordination epistemologies*—ways of knowing the world through networks of kinship relationships that extend overtime. Taking coordination epistemologies as a starting point is an anti-colonial way of anchoring our attitudes towards being—of framing reality in such a way that we relate to it through reciprocal relations rather than domination and extraction. The more primal truth of contact experiences may be that we should consider UAP disclosure not as an unprecedented crisis that we must navigate; but containing an element of *return* to more holistic, reciprocal, respectful ways of knowing and being.

What would it look like to explore this ethical orientation and commitments as a philosophical approach to ethics itself, in conversation with other philosophical ethical traditions? What would a multidimensional ethic that flows naturally from a multidimensional subjectivity ultimately look like? How might it be anchored in wisdom from the past, but simultaneously represent something novel for us at this moment? These are precisely the questions we will explore in the next chapter.

Chapter Six: A Multidimensional Ethic: An Expanded Moral Realm

“So the sense of ‘I’ changes. There is no longer an ego self with a little ‘s.’ ‘I’ is the big Self recognizing our innate connectedness.”—Catherine

“And in that moment I have zero identification with Derrick who is a human being living in 21st century America. And yet, I still feel like myself. So I have this experience of being a different being that also has a sense of me or us.”—Derrick

“We were not put together for either the moral or the transcendent. We were put together for both.”—Jeffrey J. Kripal

Part I was an exploration of how contact serves as an initiatory catalyst into a multidimensional understanding of subjectivity. By multidimensional subjectivity, I mean an understanding of the conscious self as not limited to the body, to the present or linear time, to the current psychological identity or ego, or to physical reality itself. Through multidimensional dys-appearance, the boundaries of corporeality are problematized and extended. Through the encounter with a liminal, ambiguous Other, experiencers’ understanding of intersubjectivity and relationality is subverted and transcended. Through saturated phenomena that overwhelm Kant’s conventional categories of understanding, they realize an expanded plane of consciousness and non-local perception. This results in a new framing of reality, a transformed attitude towards being that hears a call from outside our caves of everyday meaning.

Multidimensional subjects require a multidimensional ethic. We’ve seen the blueprints for such an ethic already in the ethical orientation just explored. This prompts the question: What does the *moral realm* look like when it both incorporates and transcends the corporeal, is situated in relation to liminal Otherness, and is not confined by the boundaries of linear time? How are ethical obligation and responsibility reconfigured when they unfold across multiple planes of existence simultaneously? How is moral reasoning transformed by consideration of how our actions resonate beyond our current embodiment, how they affect beings both human and non-human, and how they participate in forms of kinship and relation that exceed the parameters of consensus space and time?

In this chapter, I extend my interpretative lens, sketching how multidimensional subjectivity engenders new forms of moral reasoning that deviate from traditions that presuppose the liberal conception of personhood. Through contrast with traditional western ethical theories like utilitarianism, deontology, and virtue ethics, I show that the multidimensional ethical reasoning extends beyond the western focus on agency, autonomy, and individualism. At its most cosmic or

transcendent level, it dissolves the boundaries between self and Other. Through the work of Indigenous American philosopher (Jicarilla Apache Nation) VF Cordova, I show that many of the tenets hold similarities with the ethical orientations of Indigenous American tribes, rooted in epistemologies of coordination.

Ultimately, I posit that in the expanded moral realm, experiencers employ various layers or dimensions of moral reasoning at the same time. The three identified planes mirror the corporeal, liminal, and transpersonal dimensions of experiences as outlined in Chapters Two through Four. Experiencers articulate making judgments at the level of the corporeal and embodied, liminal or interspecies, and transpersonal registers, often simultaneously. The multidimensional moral realm is rooted in a post-anthropocentric reasoning that evaluates the full scope of what occurs—in terms of consent, intent, and effects—as transcending the boundaries of consensus physical reality. Are we up to the task?

Rejecting Spiritual and Moral Bypassing: A Multidimensional Moral Realm

Discussion of extraordinary or transpersonal experience happens most often in the context of religious studies. Especially when these experiences engender a rhetoric of “oneness,” “interconnectedness” etc., there are understandable concerns about what is referred to as *spiritual bypassing*. Spiritual bypassing occurs when attention to otherworldly or transcendent dimensions of experience enables us to ignore the pressing injustices of our earthly existence: persecution on the basis of gender or sexuality, rampant anti-Black racism, the ongoing dispossession and spiritual harm suffered by Indigenous peoples, entrenched class divisions, and the ecological devastation of our planet. To center the spiritual at the expense of the material is to risk a dangerous disavowal of the overwhelming suffering and structural violence that demand our immediate ethical attention and response.

Yet the opposite mistake is equally possible. In *The Superhumanities*, Jeffrey J. Kripal argues that spiritual bypassing is *not* remedied by replacing it with another form of bypass: *moral bypassing*, or an “avoidance of ultimate things for the sake of more immediate psychological, social, and moral concerns.”²⁵¹ Kripal suggests a simple thought experiment: imagine a secular world where we have essentially solved all of our pressing social and moral issues: gender, racial and class inequalities no longer exist, and ecological concerns are remedied. In such a world, would any of our core ancient and universal questions related to the transcendent dimensions of human existence be answered? Would we have answers to who humans truly are or where we ultimately come from? Would we have achieved knowledge of the nature of the world we occupy or how and why we find ourselves here? The issue, for

²⁵¹ Jeffrey J. Kripal, *The Superhumanities: Historical Precedents, Moral Objections, New Realities* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2022), 28.

Kripal, is not that moral and social issues are unimportant, but rather that they are insufficient as a full exploration of the human. “If the study of the history of religions means anything, we were not put together for either the moral or the transcendent. We were put together for both.”²⁵²

Kripal challenges his readers to directly confront the ontological. Too often, he argues, we are content to stay at the level of moral criticism and social critique but refrain from taking a stand regarding ultimate truth, or the big picture of what the world is and who humans are in relation to it. Of key importance, the very fact that we avoid these “big questions” that underlie all of our social interactions may be preventing us from making meaningful progress on solving many of the moral problems we face. If we want to improve how we treat and interact with each other, we must be willing to probe honestly, creatively, and novelly into ancient questions about the human and the universe.

I want us to make a claim on the real, not because I think we know what the real is but because I think our present problems are mostly functions of inadequate ontologies and a subsequent refusal to imagine new realities. I have become more and more convinced that, if we are going to move beyond those present problems, then we are going to have to operate out of radically new ontologies.²⁵³

What Kripal poses as primarily a theoretical exercise, experiencers embody through lived encounter. Their contact events yield precisely the kind of radically new ontologies that Kripal mentions. They do not turn away from corporeal moral life in favor of a transcendent elsewhere, nor do they reduce human existence to social and political struggle alone. Instead, they return from their experiences with a transformed sense of both—an ontological reframing that renders earthly relations more, not less, urgent. Simultaneously, these earthly relations are put into conversation with a wider dimensional field and an expanded conception of human capability.

The pattern, as we have seen, is remarkably consistent. Experiencers describe consciousness as fundamental, flowing through all beings and uniting humans, non-human animals, plants, and even seemingly inanimate entities into a shared conscious field. They describe a monistic sense of oneness, not as an abstract doctrine but as a lived, phenomenological given of their encounter. In this framework, human beings are reconfigured as multidimensional: embodied and spatiotemporally situated, yes, but also capable of experience beyond the strictures of linear time and bounded corporeality.

²⁵² Ibid., 26.

²⁵³ Ibid., 29.

This recognition guards against both spiritual and moral bypass. Against spiritual bypass, experiencers insist that the very *facticity* of embodied, earthly life—including its injustices and moral failures—becomes more ethically pressing *precisely because* it fails to reflect the direct phenomenological givenness of interconnectivity that is core to their encounters. Against moral bypass, they demonstrate that ethical life cannot be adequately pursued without simultaneously contemplating the nature of the real: without grokking the deeper ontologies and layers of meaning that may undergird and exceed our spatiotemporal existence. In experiencer accounts, embodied human interactions and multidimensional ontologies that extend beyond traditional physical reality are not competitors but equally important dimensions of human experience.

This, then, is the contribution I want to underline. The multidimensional ethical orientation that emerges from contact is not a convenient bypass in either direction but a radical re-situation of the ethical within an expanded ontology. It insists that humans are multidimensional beings, and that our moral life must be reconceived in light of this fact. Earthly, corporeal relations are not diminished but intensified, precisely because they are an important layer of the real. Transcendent experiences do not provide an escape from injustice but instead disclose why these injustices matter: because every act of harm distorts a relational whole that extends beyond linear time, beyond corporeality, and beyond the human. In short, experiencers compel us to reimagine the ethical as multidimensional: rooted in embodied spatiotemporal relations yet simultaneously dislodged from them, stretched across horizons of consciousness that traditional frameworks only dimly scratch the surface of. It is here, I contend, that we find an ethical orientation capable of avoiding both spiritual and moral bypassing, and capable of truly speaking to the demands of our present crises.

Realms of Moral Reasoning and Action in Western Philosophy

To examine where I think our ethical explorations should go, we must first examine where we've been. Within our traditional reality framings and in the history of western philosophy, the moral realm, or the sphere of human thought, action, and relation that is subject to ethical evaluation, has been based primarily on the liberal conception of personhood and the atomistic self. Frameworks that *do* acknowledge the social or interdependent notions of self still limit the moral realm to the scope of a corporeally embodied, reasoning being whose actions must be considered in the context of three-dimensional physical reality and within linear time. The self is one who is distinguished from other selves through the boundaries of their corporeal embodiment and the privacy of their inner subjective life. Moral action is evaluated according to how it affects other similarly bounded selves within a temporal realm

of cause and effect. Such accounts presume that moral responsibility begins and ends with embodied agents acting upon one another within the boundaries of consensus reality.

Both utilitarianism and deontology, two dominant moral frameworks of the modern philosophical era, are constrained by their reliance on the traditionally liberal conception of the person. Both theories presuppose an atomistic, autonomous self defined by its rationality and choice-making ability. Utilitarianism, founded by J.S. Mill, is focused on producing the greatest amount of positive value (whether measured in terms of pleasure, happiness, preferences, or overall welfare) for the greatest number of beings (human and non) who can experience pleasure and pain, looking only at the consequences or effects of the action or rule.²⁵⁴ Kantianism, the foundation of deontological approaches, is rooted in the idea of universal moral duties, or rules, that apply to all rational beings equally. According to Kant, we should only act in ways that are rationally universalizable, and we should never use a fellow rational agent as a means to an end. That is to say, each individual deserves inherent respect as an autonomous decision maker.²⁵⁵ Both theories assume a neutral, rational individual decision maker who either must calculate the greatest good of available possible actions or act only in ways that one could reasonably want everyone else to act as well (known as Kant's categorical imperative).

Mill's *On Liberty* makes explicit the liberal assumptions underlying utilitarian thought. For him, the society most conducive to happiness is one where each individual enjoys maximal autonomy, restricted only by a duty not to cause harm to others.²⁵⁶ Although framed as serving the common good, this vision relies on the atomized self as the center of moral action. Likewise, Kantian universalism, for all its emphasis on respect, applies only to beings capable of rational deliberation within the spatiotemporal horizon we communally occupy as embodied, corporeal beings. In both frameworks, morality is confined to the spatiotemporal plane of consensus reality: actions are evaluated either by their measurable consequences for other embodied agents or by their conformity to universalizable duties. These theories, while useful aids in moral deliberation, cannot accommodate moral relations and evaluations that extend beyond embodied rationality and linear temporality.

²⁵⁴ See John Stuart Mill, *Utilitarianism*, edited by George Sher (Indianapolis: Hackett, 2001). Also James Rachels, *The Elements of Moral Philosophy Fourth Edition* (Boston: McGraw-Hill, 2003), 102-116.

²⁵⁵ See Immanuel Kant, *Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals, 3rd Edition*, trans. James Ellington (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing, 1993). This of course leaves non-human animals and other non-rational beings out of the moral community, although theorists like Tom Regan have expanded Kantianism to include some animals with advanced cognitive capacities. See Tom Regan, "The Case for Animal Rights," in *In Defense of Animals*, ed. Peter Singer (New York: Basil Blackwell, 1985), 13-26.

²⁵⁶ John Stuart Mill, *On Liberty*, ed. Elizabeth Rapaport (Indianapolis: Hackett, 1972).

Aristotle's virtue ethics represents a departure from the abstract universalism of Kant and the utilitarian calculus of Mill, focusing instead on cultivating good moral character. Revived in the twentieth century by Elizabeth Anscombe and others,²⁵⁷ virtue theory emphasizes that ethics and the good life emerges not from detached rules or maximizing welfare, but from habituating virtues such as loyalty, generosity, honesty, courage, temperance, friendliness, and righteous indignation.²⁵⁸ These virtues are cultivated over a lifetime through good habits. Context is key, and there are no easy moral formulas for determining the right thing to do. For Aristotle, moral life is deeply relational: family, friends, and those close to us are given moral preference, in contrast to the impartiality demanded by deontology or utilitarianism.

Yet the vision of the moral agent cultivated through virtue is still situated within a set of ontological assumptions and embedded within a clearly defined material plane. The Aristotelian subject is autonomous, rational, atomistic, clearly distinguished from the natural world and other beings. Virtue ethics conceives of moral development as the progressive cultivation of character across the arc of a life. Acting virtuously requires developing practical wisdom, or *phronesis*, a type of wisdom or intelligence with regard to practical action that stems from a rational agent embedded in a lived world. One who possesses *phronesis* has the ability both to posit a goal and figure out how to achieve it, and also to reflect if these pursued goals are consistent with a flourishing human life.²⁵⁹ *Phronesis* necessarily presupposes deliberation within finite, linear temporality: discerning goals, means, and ends in relation to a stable sense of self and a predictable field of spatiotemporal possibilities. When we develop virtuous habits, we practice these habits with behavior and relations within the traditional boundaries of our reality framings. Virtue is thus grounded in lived embodiment but simultaneously foreclosed to nonlinear temporalities or transpersonal experiences of subjectivity which may dislodge the core sense of "me" to which virtues or vices are attributed.

Another theory that prominently challenged the assumptions of thinkers like Kant and Mill is care ethics, which has its roots in the work of feminist thinker Carol Gilligan. Gilligan argues that historical western conceptions of ethics were all conceived of by male thinkers and thus had certain biases embedded within them: most notably, a disregard for moral thinking and moral traits that had been traditionally associated with women. Gilligan draws on the caretaking roles that women have been engaged in over history as caregivers of children and relatives, as

²⁵⁷ Elizabeth Anscombe, "Modern Moral Philosophy," *The Journal of the Royal Institute of Philosophy* 33.124 (1958): 1-19.

²⁵⁸ Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, trans. Terence Irwin (Indianapolis: Hackett, 2019).

²⁵⁹ Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, Book VI.

well as women's workforce dominance in fields like health care and early child education, to argue that these experiences have led to women having a different moral perspective. Gilligan develops a "female voice" for ethics, anchored in the concept of natural caring and the nurturing of caring relationships. The female voice emphasized interdependence, vulnerability, empathy, sympathy, compassion, and understanding of context.²⁶⁰ Gilligan and her contemporaries developed an ethical framework based on natural caring, interdependence, and understanding of an individual's needs.²⁶¹ Care ethics rightly criticized the atomistic conception of the individual offered by deontology and utilitarianism and acknowledges that the subject is always embedded in a relational network of interdependent connections. Our development as a self, as well as our choice-making is influenced and sustained by the caring relationships in which we find ourselves. Similar to virtue theory, care ethics also sees the boundaries between friend/relative and stranger as morally relevant. In a care ethics framework, we have stronger moral ties with those we are in relationships with than we do with strangers who are not connected with us.

Care ethics marks a decisive advance beyond the abstract individualism of Kant and Mill and offers a corrective to masculine biases within Western philosophy that reduce ethics to rules and calculations. It restores the moral significance of relationality, interdependence, and empathy within ethics. Yet even as it widens the scope of the moral realm, care ethics remains bound to a recognizably modern and human-centered subject. The "relational self" it posits is still situated within the spatiotemporal horizon of linear development, and the caring ties it centers are overwhelmingly interpersonal, confined primarily to the human sphere and reflecting conventional social roles. While care ethics rightly critiques the atomistic conception of an individual, it does not fully destabilize the embodied subject who moves through historical time. Nor does it conceive of ethical relations that transcend corporeality, potentially cross dimensions, or include a variety of modalities of conscious experience. In this way, care ethics achieves an important reorientation of moral philosophy but still falls short of the multidimensional ethic required to account for the expansions in subjectivity undergone by contact experiencers.

The ethical theories described above are all distinctly human theories, built on the assumption of an acting (human) moral agent embedded in space and time, who has rights and responsibilities to other human beings and sometimes, to non-

²⁶⁰ Carol Gilligan, *In a Different Voice: Psychological Theory and Women's Development* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1993).

²⁶¹ Nel Noddings, *Caring: A Feminine Approach to Ethics and Moral Education* (Berkeley: University of CA Press, 1982), Annette Baier, *Moral Prejudices: Essays on Ethics* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1994), Virginia Held, *The Ethics of Care* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2006).

human animals or ecosystems. By contrast, the multidimensional ethics reported by experiencers both incorporates and exceeds these frameworks. In the aftermath of contact, many continue to affirm the moral truth of human ethical insights—commitments to the greater good, the dignity of persons, the cultivation of virtue, and the fostering of caring relationships. Yet these familiar values are reframed within an expanded conception of subjectivity and relationality. Experiencers come to see themselves as multidimensional beings engaged with advanced non-human intelligences, some of which appear more evolutionarily developed than ourselves. In this encounter, humans are decentered: no longer the apex of the evolutionary hierarchy, they become acutely aware of their positionality and their ethical responsibilities toward other species on Earth. The ethics modeled by non-human entities often appears to have purpose and meaning, but is not reducible to traditional embodied human perspectives. In recognizing this, experiencers emerge with a transformed horizon for moral life—one that decenters the human and destabilizes the liberal conception of the self.

Indigenous American Ethics: The We and the I

The western philosophical theories outlined above are certainly not the only way to conceive of the moral realm. If you'll permit me a vast generalization, the history of ethics in western philosophy has been, primarily, an ethics of the "I." The dominant ethical frameworks seek to clarify the moral responsibilities of the individual, as well as our responsibilities to other individuals, occasionally lumping the individuals together as a group. Care ethics, with its focus on interdependence, vulnerability, and community has an increased focus on the "we" or group as primary but maintains a separation between selves as well as a distinction between those close to us and strangers. Traditional western ethical theories are also distinctly *anthropocentric*, centering a human agent and prioritizing the interests of human beings over non-human life. The Indigenous people of North America, by contrast, begin with a non-anthropocentric framework, welcoming of expanded or altered states of consciousness, and a human self with more porous boundaries. The starting point of epistemologies of coordination, which come to know the world through kinship relations that extend through time, bring Indigenous American tribal perspectives on ethics in close proximity with a multidimensional moral realm.

This distinction between an "ethics of we" and "ethics of I" has been explored in depth by Jicarilla Apache thinker Viola Cordova, the first Indigenous American woman to earn a PhD in philosophy. Coordination epistemologies conceive of humans as interdependent and part of an interspecies community. In "Ethics: The We and the I," Cordova argues that a fundamental difference between western philosophical ethics and what she calls "Native American ethics" is the

Indigenous American emphasis on “We” rather than on “I.” Cordova argues that western ethical systems have been grounded in an “I” that is the essential “bargaining unit” in social relations, envisioned as “being ‘at war’ with each and every other individual.”²⁶² If the individual is to exist as a member of a community or group, this must be *justified* as somehow in their best interest. If the individual chooses to become part of a group, it is only because it serves them in some way. “Autonomy” thus refers to an individual who is isolated and atomistic. “The ‘I’ is conceived as containing the capacity to be ‘self-determining.’”²⁶³ Especially in Kantian ethics, the highest expression of the human being is to be self-governing and free of influences, following the universal moral law rooted in reason.

While virtue ethics and care ethics more directly acknowledge the sociality and interdependence of human life, they remain primarily anthropocentric and rooted in human concerns. Cordova illustrates that Indigenous American tribal people have a very different starting point.²⁶⁴ Not only do they begin with a sense of the group rather than the individual—the We rather than the I—they also have a more expansive understanding of who is included in the “We.” The group or community, for Indigenous Americans, does not only include human beings, but extends to other species as well as to the Earth itself.

[The Native American] acknowledges that he is a part of a natural process that has led to his existence as well as to the existence of all other things, “animate” and “inanimate”...The Native American recognizes his dependence on Earth and the Universe. He recognizes no hierarchy of “higher” and “lower” or “simple” and “complex,” and certainly not of “primitive” and “modern.” Instead of hierarchies he sees differences which exist among equal ‘beings’ (mountains, as well as water and air and plants and animals would be included here). The quality is based on the notion, often unstated, that everything that is, is of one process. The Native American, in other words, has a more inclusive sense of the We than others who share a sense of humans as *social* beings.²⁶⁵

Indigenous American communities recognize the value of non-human entities, including respect and inclusion of non-living entities within the moral community. Rather than a hierarchy amongst species, there is an understanding of different natural entities as representing a spectrum of expressions of a *monistic source*.

²⁶² VF Cordova, “Ethics: The We and the I,” in *American Indian Thought*, ed. Anne Waters (Malden, MA: Blackwell Publishing, 2004), 174.

²⁶³ Ibid., 173

²⁶⁴ Like Topa and Narvaez she argues that Native American groups have more in common with each other than they do with the worldviews of western Europeans.

²⁶⁵ VF Cordova, “Ethics: The We and the I,” 177.

Within the ethical lens of “we,” a very different conception of autonomy emerges. Autonomy naturally engenders a sense of obligation and responsibility towards the We.

[T]he autonomous person, in this environment, is one who is aware of the needs of others as well as being aware of what the individual can do for the good of the group. “Autonomy” in this case, would be defined as self-initiative combined with a high degree of self-sufficiency.²⁶⁶

The Indigenous American sense of autonomy includes an understanding of independence, in the sense that one should not ask another to do something for you that you can do for yourself. But autonomy also comes with a sense of responsibility to take initiative to benefit the group or community. It includes a strong sense of accountability for one’s actions, not in the sense of punishment or revenge, but with the conviction that if one has caused harm to other members of the We, even unintentionally, they are responsible for making restitution for their actions in some way. The autonomous individual is not one who acts alone and makes individual choices for oneself, but who understands their choices as part of a delicately interwoven web of human and non-human, animate and inanimate beings.

Cordova’s understanding of ethics and autonomy echoes the exploration of the kinship worldview and coordination epistemologies of Kyle Whyte, illustrating more similarities the experiencer ethic has with Indigenous cultures who lived more harmoniously with nature, and who understand human beings not as fundamentally isolated and atomistic, but as one type of being interconnected among many different kinds. This attitude towards being and orientation within the lifeworld leads to an understanding of autonomy in which a sense of responsibility to the group is of integral importance. As I unpack the multidimensional experiencer ethic, it will also include a conception of autonomy that deviates from the standard emphasis in western ethical thought. The importance of self-determination and liberty emphasized in modern western societies is replaced with a conviction that true liberation comes from a realization of our fundamental interconnectivity, and corresponding responsibility to an interspecies community.

The Multidimensional Experiencer Ethic

Experiencers’ wider framing of reality that moves beyond the technological mindset requires a different kind of moral realm. A key characteristic of the ethical orientation expressed by experiencers is that the *moral realm is widened beyond the traditional anthropocentric and spatiotemporal horizon*. The individual is considered within an expanded plane of interspecies reality, and thus there are multiple, co-occurring

²⁶⁶ Ibid., 178

levels or “dimensions” to their moral reasoning. These planes of reasoning mirror the dimensions of encounters explored in Part 1: the corporeal, the liminal, and the transpersonal.

Plane I: The Corporeal

Contrary to approaches of spiritual bypass, the subjectivity-expanding aspects of contact experiences imbue the Earthly realm of interaction with new importance. Experiencers understand physical experience as one expression of a broader monistic source that pervades all things. Through their corporeal experiences with beings they perceive as embodied, as well as forms of multidimensional dys-appearance that problematize and blur the boundaries of their own bodies, experiencers come to more deeply appreciate the importance of physical embodiment in anchoring the experience of human life. Through encountering liminal beings that do not appear to be embodied in the same way humans are, they draw contrast with the lived experience of the entities they encounter and our own densely embodied human experience. Additionally, they become more cognizant of our direct physical interdependence with Earth and other natural entities.

For instance, Parker comments on how he now sees embodied human existence as a direct extension of Earth itself:

There’s this sense that human beings are directly the result of earth consciousness. I mean, we are the Earth. We exist because we breathe Earth air, we drink Earth water, we eat Earth animals, and plants. We are alive because of the trace minerals that come out of the Earth. So we are an extension of the matter of Earth.

Recall that in Parker’s discussion of his own relationships, he explains how his experiences with what he perceived to be another advanced intelligent species actually drove him to care more about his Earthly relationships: I accepted that I have these dual relationships...As I swung back towards my human relationships, it’s almost like I committed to them in a deeper way.” Rather than moving him away from his human relationships in order to explore other planes, Parker’s experiences had the opposite effect, drawing him closer to his wife and family. Even as experiencers undergo the separation of consciousness from the body or confront an apparent otherworldly species, their concern with Earthly affairs and relationships remain paramount. They become attuned to how our fractured forms of interaction fail to reflect the phenomenological interconnectedness pervading all things they see reflected in their encounters. In *Initiated*, Matthew Roberts comments on how his expanded understanding of what the universe *is*— monistically comprised of a vibration of unconditional love— influenced how he now thinks about social and moral affairs: “Whether it’s a beggar asking for change, or a national health care plan;

the result should always be an act of love that is unconditional. Anything else flies in the face of the *natural laws that govern the universe*.²⁶⁷

The first *layer*, then, of moral thinking and action, is at the level of the embodied self that lives and acts in an Earthly, physical plane. This plane of reasoning co-occurs with others in a widened moral realm. There are several common themes of evolution that frame their thinking: a) a widening of the circle of moral concern to include members other than humans, b) more focus on non-interference and respecting the self-determination of others, including non-humans, c) a utilitarian focus on the evolution of the species as a whole and d) centering the “We” over the “I.” These changes flow primarily from a dislodging of anthropocentrism, a sense of relational individuality, their expanded understanding of consciousness as not limited to the brain, and the blurring of the boundaries between subject and object.

As Cordova notes, traditional western ethicists focused primarily on what we owe to other humans as fellow rational agents. Utilitarianism in particular argued that the capacity to feel pain and pleasure alone was enough for moral consideration, and thus sentient non-human animals are also part of the moral community. Biocentrism extends moral considerability to all living things, and ecocentrism as an environmental ethic considers the ecosystem itself as a moral patient.²⁶⁸ Some contemporary moral theorists have argued for extending our most common ethical frameworks to include the interests and welfare of non-human animals.²⁶⁹ While Indigenous American communities begin with an inclusive, multi-species moral realm, western philosophical thought began with the idea of obligations towards other humans and then slowly widened the circle.

As we saw in Chapter Five, experiencers’ ethical orientation widens to include forms of non-human life— not just non-human animals, but plants and the Earth itself. This is in no small part influenced not only by the collapse of anthropocentrism, but also by their expanded understanding of consciousness as a fundamental property of the universe that flows through everything. As Andrew comments, “I see the same consciousness in [animals] that I see in us.” Additionally, understanding the kinship or reciprocal relations between humans and the natural world is a core theme of the contact experience. The experiencers acknowledge that

²⁶⁷ Matthew Roberts, *Initiated*, 391. Emphasis added.

²⁶⁸ See Paul W. Taylor, “The Ethics of Respect for Nature,” *Environmental Ethics* 3 (1981): 197-218, and Aldo Leopold, “The Land Ethic,” in *Environmental Philosophy: From Animal Rights to Radical Ecology*, ed. Michael E. Zimmerman, J. Baird Callicott, George Sessions, Karen J. Warren and John Clark (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1993), 95-109.

²⁶⁹ Peter Singer, *Animal Liberation: A New Ethic for our Treatment of Animals, Fourth Edition* (New York: Harper Collins Books, 2009); Regan, “The Case”; Mylan Engel Jr., “Demystifying Animal Rights,” *Between the Species* 21.1 (2018); Cheryl Abbate, “Valuing Animals as they are: Whether they feel it or not,” *Journal of European Philosophy* 28.3 (2020): 770-788.

as biological organisms we must at times take the lives of other species (even those who are vegan must end the life of a plant) but adopt a respect and concern for the interests and welfare of the biological life they consume, as well as a sense of not causing more harm to other organisms than is necessary. For example, Derrick comments,

Even to consume plants is not a completely clean way of dealing with this...And animals are intelligent, caring, emotional beings and I think it really does matter how we interact with them...it's about creating an entire landscape of shared, cooperative, loving interaction with all sentience, and that definitely extends to animals as well.

An expanded circle of moral considerability that considers bonds of kinship and relationality with non-human life is key to how experiencers reason and act in the corporeal plane.

Experiencers also develop a stronger sense of non-interference in the paths of others, including their fellow humans as well as other species. They express giving up any desire to control others' behavior, even those closest to them, with an emphasis on the idea that every conscious being has its own life course and process with which we should not interfere. Recall Linda's comments on her relationships: "My relationships improved because I've learned to not be...in control. Right, that's not my job." Matthew Roberts comments that his increased focus on giving up control over others' behavior even led him to see traditional romantic partnerships as attempts to interfere with the self-determination of others. "When two people become involved and they decide to date exclusively, this becomes the first condition, the first mechanism of control over each other, it is born of the lower emotions and it is not love."²⁷⁰ This respect for another's path extends to non-human beings as well. Experiencers often express that it is inappropriate to force human purposes onto non-human life, especially in service of human wants. Catherine expresses this most emphatically: "Everything that we do to animals, riding horses, keeping them in zoos, all of it needs to end. Those animals should have autonomy the way that we have autonomy...Anything that can be outdoors, or be on its own, should be that way, without being made to fucking serve at the pleasure of the human master."

This increased respect for autonomy and self-determination emerges because, within this expanded moral horizon, individuality is no longer conceived as isolated independence but as inherently relational. To interfere with another being's self-determination is to compromise the integrity of the relational whole of which we are all a part. It reflects a deep conviction that autonomy is a quality of embodied

²⁷⁰ Matthew Roberts, *Initiated*, 245.

beings embedded in reciprocal relations, living in overlapping lifeworlds. Autonomy thus arises within a web of interdependence, grounded in respect for other forms of life and the larger systems in which they exist and interact. To interfere with the path of another is to disrespect the intricate web of relationality and kinship. Unconditional love is understood to be truly unconditional— to give up any desire to coerce others to bend to your will.

This does not result in a sentiment of “any behavior from others goes.” Nor is it reducible to Mill’s idea of a rational choice-making agent who is free to do as they please as long as they are not harming others. Similar to Cordova’s description of the Jicarilla Apache conception of autonomy, the experiencers’ framing is accompanied by a sense of accountability and responsibility to other members of the We. For example, in their discussion of criminal justice, experiencers describe a shift to restorative justice as including a sense of accountability and understanding of the harm one’s actions have caused. As Sarah commented, “You have to try and reach them to let them know...the devastation it’s done to other people...they need to see what they’ve done to that life.” Derrick adds a similar sentiment, “If someone makes a decision that’s not in the best interest of the whole, then the whole actually feels a responsibility to help them better understand how it did impact the collective, so they can make decisions differently.” Reflected in these sentiments is the idea that justice practices should aim to change the behavior of individuals, but not through coercion, punishment, or force. Rather, individuals should be given an opportunity to understand the full scope of the consequences of their actions on the community. Autonomy comes with a duty to take initiative as well as a sense of responsibility towards the whole. If one has caused harm to other members of the We, being autonomous includes taking action to repair it. This is not considered a form of retribution or punishment, but a need to heal the relational web of which we are all a part. No one can exist without shaping and being shaped by the whole.

The embodied, Earthly experiencer ethic also includes utilitarian thinking, but the utilitarian goal is not just to increase human welfare or happiness in a way that reflects the liberal conception of the human. Rather, what will truly benefit the greater good is framed as the evolution of the human species to higher states of consciousness and relationality. Abductees in particular, like Catherine, Parker, Jeanette, and Sarah, acknowledge that they felt traumatized and violated by some of the things that happened to them, especially the experiences of being physically taken and having medical procedures performed on them without their consent. Simultaneously they now recognize the actions as part of a “larger program” as Parker says, which is ultimately aimed at aiding in the evolution of humankind and human consciousness. This utilitarian goal is of such importance that they see it as justifying the overriding of their own consent and autonomy. Importantly, they

believe the entities possess knowledge they do not regarding the future of the species and the ultimate purpose of abduction encounters (a point that will be explored in depth in Chapter Seven).

Which brings us to the last shift in the plane of embodied corporeal relations: even though the experiencers show an increased respect for the self-determination of every individual being (human and non-human), they simultaneously see a dissolution of the barrier between themselves and others, and a shift to centering the collective. They think in terms of the “We” rather than the “I”, how *we* as a species will respond to our opportunity to interact with the entities, and how *we* as an interspecies (human, non-human animals, plant, etc.) community will survive and thrive. They understand self-interest to be inseparable from community-interest. For example, Derrick comments,

I have this sense that when you have that relearned way of being and even go so far as to change your understanding of who you are and what is in your self-interest, and when you begin to experience self-interest being expressed as a collective, how we are and how we’re doing as a group, that really fundamentally changes how you make decisions.

The whole in this sense is comprised of the wider cosmic community, including the advanced non-human beings. To develop oneself as sovereign is to ask what one can contribute for others and how our own interests and wants must be balanced in service of the bigger, cosmic “We.”

Thus, experiencers express several patterns of changes in moral thinking at the level of embodied, Earthly relations. Experiencers navigate a moral realm with an expanded circle of moral concern, extending moral patency to non-human animals, plants, and even traditionally inanimate entities. Experiencers have an increased respect for the autonomy and self-determination of all beings, grounded in a relational sense of individuality. Simultaneously they adopt utilitarian goals for the overall evolution of the species to what they perceive as higher states of consciousness. Last, they shift from thinking in terms of “I” to “We,” a notion of collective self-interest in which to think of the self is to naturally think of the group. These changes in moral interaction reflect their deeper *metaphysical and ontological commitments* regarding the ultimate unity of all things.

Plane II: The Liminal

Encounters are not entirely corporeal, but as we’ve explored, include encounters with liminal and ambiguous beings. In such encounters, experiencers are confronted with their own liminality, which engenders a second level to the realm of moral reasoning and acting, that co-occurs with the embodied, corporeal plane. This liminal plane could be considered the *interspecies* ethic, in which they understand

themselves *in relation* to an advanced, unknown species that is not traditionally human. This results in three distinct shifts: a) First, contact encourages species-level solidarity, a sense of “we” anchored in our specific experience of dense embodiment and experience of the world through space-time, b) a shift in positionality in which they realize themselves in relationship to a more advanced species with its own ethical norms, revealing the limits of human ethical concepts, and c) the encounter with radical Otherness destabilizes the foundations of the liberal conception of personhood, offering new possibilities for responsiveness.

From the liminal space, experiencers must reconcile the reality-bending and ontological shocking dimensions of the encounters with the call of communion they feel towards the unknown Other. They feel they are offered an opportunity to enter into new forms of communication, states of being, and ways of relating, that transcend the boundaries of time, place, and species— something radically different from what they’ve encountered previously. As Jeannette describes, “I really don’t want people to think that it’s just the next-door neighbor popping in. It is not that at all. You are confronted with something you’re totally unfamiliar with, that doesn’t look like anyone or anything you’ve ever encountered.” Recall this passage from Levinas, who argued that the face of the Other presents a radical alterity that points us toward something transcendent and beyond the parameters of purely physical experience.

But the other absolutely other—the Other—does not limit the freedom of the same; calling it to responsibility, it founds it and justifies it...The ‘resistance’ of the other does not do violence to me, does not act negatively; it has a positive structure: ethical...I do not struggle with a faceless god, but I respond to his expression, to his revelation.²⁷¹

The liminal, interspecies ethic often begins from a position of resistance and fear, primarily from the ontological shock of realizing that humans are not the only advanced intelligence in the universe. Experiencers who are able to integrate and reframe their encounters over time transition into the positive structure described by Levinas. They come to see the unknown Other not as a threat to their existence, but a new opportunity --- a new expression of conscious life that they have the privilege of responding to. “Thus in expression the being that imposes itself does not limit but promotes my freedom, by arousing my goodness.”²⁷² The presence of the liminal, radical Other thus introduces a new field of possibilities for creating oneself as an ethical subject.

Within this liminal stage, experiencers are able to see points of commonality with the beings, even as they stand in radical otherness. For example, Andrew

²⁷¹ Ibid., 197.

²⁷² Ibid., 200.

comments, “Even though they have one foot in the metaphysical, one foot here, apparently these crashes have happened and these things have a brain just like we do. They’ve got genetics. I think that’s what connects us to them more.” Not completely leaving the plane of the corporeal, they contemplate what it would look like to enter into ethical relation with beings that emerge from in-between spaces.

Consequently, the contact experiences open new existential possibilities for the very idea of “We.” Confronted with a universe appearing to be inhabited by other intelligences—some with radically different forms of embodiment and luminosity—invites experiencers to reimagine human beings less as fragmented nations and more as an entire species. Recognizing both the distinctiveness of human embodiment and subjectivity, and the ways these may diverge from other advanced beings, shifts the focus toward a shared humanity. By embracing the density of our embodiment and the depth of our emotional life—capacities that cut across race, culture, and class—they begin to cultivate a more expansive, planetary sense of “We.” Crucially, this solidarity does not emerge in response to an external threat but instead from the recognition of what marks us as uniquely human in relation to other forms of intelligence. Parker comments:

What the beings showed me, being up on the ship and looking at the Earth, is that we’re very tribal, very ethnocentric, and religious centric, thinking in terms of borders and nation states and all that. As long as we continue to relate to each other in that way, we can’t jump to the next level of evolution, which is basically...a planetary consciousness where there’s recognition that we’re all one.

The next “level of evolution” is described as recognizing the inherent oneness and interconnectivity of all things; giving up our fractured, tribal forms of interaction that distort the deeper truths uniting us.

Simultaneously, experiencers realize themselves as part of a bigger, interspecies “We” in which they are *not* at the top of the evolutionary hierarchy. Anthropocentric humanism, and just general human supremacy are subverted. Andrew comments, “There is an incorrect sense that we are masters and commanders of known reality. That went away.” Recall Mack’s description of abductees’ transformative process, “Human beings are not lords of the earth, they realize, but children of the cosmos who must find their way to live in harmony with all manner of creatures on the earth and elsewhere.”²⁷³ Feeling that the illusion of control has been shattered begins with a sense of loss of autonomy and freedom, a position of resistance. But once they are able to accept this loss of control, understanding they are entering into relation with liminal Otherness, they are

²⁷³ Mack, *Abduction*, 409.

simultaneously able to open up to their interconnectedness with other beings, including advanced non-human species with whom we share the universe.

Recall Bernhard Waldenfels' assertion that to let Otherness truly appear, we must give up attempts to reduce it to the same. Our fundamental relation with Otherness points us away from our sphere of ownness, and away from a contractual understanding of our relations to others. To truly let the alien appear, we must give up our demands for equality. Derrida, similarly, introduced the ideal of unconditional hospitality, of welcoming the Other without forcing them to conform to the host's conditions and norms of comprehensibility. To unconditionally welcome the liminal, interspecies Other requires releasing assumptions and conditions related to anthropocentric western human ethics. This may include decentering the focus on human beings as atomistic, autonomous, rights-bearing individuals with final control over what happens in our lives.

The plane of liminality is thus the mediating realm; the plane in between the realm of corporeal embodiment and the transpersonal plane that exceeds traditional spatiotemporality. There are essentially three distinct shifts that take place in the liminal level of reasoning and acting: First, contact experiences destabilize narrow cultural or national divisions and engender species-level solidarity, grounded in the specificity of human embodiment and conscious experience. Second, this introduces an interspecies ethic in which humans are *not* the most evolutionarily advanced species but acknowledge themselves as liminal beings. From this space, experiencers recognize that moral concepts like autonomy and consent are grounded in specifically human forms of interaction and are not necessarily universal. Third, the liminal encounter destabilizes western individualism by placing the experiencer in relation to radical Otherness. Ethics becomes less about isolated agency and more about different paths of responsiveness: what it would look like to transform the self in a way that allows the truly alien to stand. Resistance and fear towards the Other transition to a call of responsibility to let the Other appear without our conditions and demands. This requires humility, a willingness to reimagine human beings as "children of the cosmos" rather than "masters of reality."

Plane III: The Transpersonal

The third plane of moral reasoning and acting, emergent in the lived experience of contact, constitutes a profound ontological shift, one that emerges from hearing the call from beyond the limits of our *Umwelt*. The transpersonal layer of the multidimensional ethic names the horizon in which moral life is situated within a field of interrelation that exceeds ordinary spatial and temporal coordinates. At this level, the self is reconfigured as a multidimensional entity, whose identity transcends the boundaries of corporeality and whose moral horizon is not confined to the

parameters of linear temporality. Importantly, experiencers do not interact with this plane as a matter of “belief” as if its existence is a hypothetical proposition that they can accept or reject, in order to be more “correct” in their beliefs. Belief preserves distance from the experience, as it refers to the consideration of concepts only. You can “believe” in a soul or higher self without being structurally implicated. Belief allows the original parameters of subjectivity to remain intact. Rather, they interact at the level of *participant*—immersed in a *lived reality* to which they must *respond*, not merely affirm or deny. The meaning emerges through direct participation and lived experience, being taken up into a field of relations that expands beyond spatiotemporal reality. *Participation* requires ontological repositioning; the subject cannot remain unchanged.

The transpersonal plane builds upon the changes of embodied Earthly ethics and the relational reorientation of the liminal encounter but moves beyond them to a deeper transformation: the realization that moral life may be situated within an expanded spatiotemporal horizon. At the transpersonal level of the ethic, we see several co-occurring shifts: a) a commitment to *soul growth*, including the integration of other embodiments, identities and dimensions of being; b) a sense of non-duality, enabling the simultaneous holding of conflicting truths; and c) a radical dissolution of the boundaries between self and Other, entailing the recognition that, ultimately, there are no Others.

Crucially, this plane entails a dislodging of ethics from linear time. In the testimonies of experiencers, moral action is not contained within the sequential temporality of cause and effect but is understood to reverberate across a manifold of temporalities: into past lives, future incarnations, and parallel or co-occurring realities. Actions undertaken in the here-and-now are conceived as extending beyond the embodied present, affecting both co-existing and non-linear dimensions of existence. This is not an erasure of embodiment, but rather an intensification of it: the spatiotemporal self must consider moral consequences to their actions that extend beyond the immediate temporal horizon of bodily life.

Experiencers articulate that this temporal dislodging is rooted in their direct experience of consciousness as not bound by corporeal temporality. As Catherine explains:

So the sense of “I” changes. There is no longer an ego self with a little “s.” “I” is the big Self recognizing our innate connectedness to that which is...We are connected to all consciousness that has ever existed and have access to that, in greater and less[er] degrees, in this body and certainly when out of body, there’s a sense of just being intrinsically a part of the sea of all of that is.

Experiencers also report contact or experiences with their past and future selves. Some have spontaneous memories of first-person experience of other lives, others receive information they interpret to be from the future or experience dual human/alien identities in which they themselves are participating in the abduction program.²⁷⁴ The altered understanding of time, including the conviction that everything is happening *now*, as well as the commonly noted belief in retrocausality, enables the possibility of being in relationship with their past and future selves, communicating with previous and future versions of themselves (in this lifetime and others), that they paradoxically interpret as existing and happening right now.

This expanded temporality reframes moral responsibility. From the perspective of multidimensional subjectivity, the ethical self becomes accountable to past and future selves, to co-occurring realities, and to the broader temporal horizon of the cosmos. This temporal expansion could engender a critical advance in moral theory. Unlike traditional western approaches which evaluate moral significance within a bounded temporal frame, the ethic of multidimensional subjectivity requires a moral ontology that includes time itself as a mutable, relational horizon. Part of this reframing is experiencers' description of an eternal, cosmic self that exists simultaneously with their current embodiment but goes beyond it, experiencing realms and realities that they cannot see from a limited corporeal perspective. This is sometimes referred to as their "soul," "higher self" or "higher mind," and understood as their true, eternal form. This cosmic self can survive embodiments and incarnations and different forms of identity; it is the eternal Me that is also identical with the monistic source itself. This is elaborated perhaps most concisely in this statement from Derrick:

Another thing that shifted is my sense of being a multidimensional being. I've had experiences... of some kind of plurality, like a group of intelligences together that also form a kind of collective intelligence or collective consciousness... And in that moment I have zero identification with Derrick who is a human being living in 21st century America. And yet, I still feel like myself. So I have this experience of being a different being that also has a sense of "me" or "us."

Justin states that while his experiences showed him that everything comes from the same original One source, he experiences his current physical form as an "avatar," and simultaneously feels a sense of identity with multiple versions of himself, or "avatars" in other places. "So I'm having different experiences through a different avatar in other places. And my awareness is happening to me here, but there's so

²⁷⁴ See Mack, *Abduction*, 335-368.

many different things...There are infinite scenarios going on simultaneously, forever and always.”

This understanding of the self as eternal and transcending the current embodiment in turn leads to a recognition of the multidimensionality of other humans *and* relationality. Marin for example, expresses that their relationships with others now include a recognition of other planes or dimensions co-occurring with the corporeal:

Because the experiences added different dimensions...in such a way that I didn't see [others] as just me and another person...there was definitely a trajectory with my experiences that led to my being able to listen to them and look at it in the perspective of other dimensions, other kinds of importance, other kinds of meaning, seeing, coincidences, connections, and so on.

The transpersonal dimensions of multidimensional subjectivity, then, lead to considerations within their ethical orientations that extend beyond corporeality and embodied relationality, understanding the wider, multidimensional context of the ethical realm. Actions are evaluated not only for their immediate consequences but for their reverberations across dimensions of existence. This does not erase corporeality but rather deepens it. Moral reasoning is grounded in an embodied situatedness in time that acknowledges both the linear flow of earthly life and the atemporal scope of the higher self.

The transpersonal sense of self leads to a moral reframing of what happens to them, as well as a reframing of the impact of their own actions. This appears to be anchored in an idea of soul evolution or soul growth, in which the sense of identity not co-terminous with the body integrates and expands from what is experienced. Consequently, experiences that may have been painful and traumatic within the context of their temporal, corporeal embodiment may be understood as having value in terms of the overarching evolution of their cosmic or higher self. The parameters of the corporeal, Earthly ethic still apply, however, they also understand that the *meaning* and *effects* of what happened may only be fully realized at the level of their eternal selves.

Consequently, experiencers express a sense of consequences that expand beyond the parameters of immediate physical reality. Again, this is not reducible to a simplistic “belief” in heaven and hell, or an ultimate creator that rewards or punishes you. Rather, it is interpreted as a participatory evolutionary process that will span multiple forms of conscious, embodied expression. They also see the effects of what happens in the corporeal plane as offering their “higher selves” the possibility of new material experiences that ultimately facilitate their growth and expansion. When the effects and meaning of an experience are no longer limited to

the spatiotemporal parameters of the current physical lifetime, a broader cosmic interpretation of events that have occurred emerges.

For example, Derrick comments, “[Physical reality] is meant to eventually help us evolve...our energetic core is meant to evolve through our experiences here.” Yosef expresses a similar sentiment, stating that embodiment and corporeality offer consciousness the possibility to struggle and ultimately expand.

[T]he main reason that we go into a body that limits our consciousness is because when we struggle with the body, we widen our consciousness. Because you know, when consciousness is without the body, it's not limited, it doesn't have to do this work. Only in the body, we have to really find a way to achieve more from yourself and the consciousness can be widened.

Catherine reframes her struggle with relationships in her embodied, corporeal interactions as reflecting something her consciousness needed to learn on an evolutionary level: “I clearly had a series of challenging life lessons to learn about relationships...but I think there's a more spiritual way of looking at it. Like, what do I need to learn about myself that I keep finding myself at the center of all these things?” Additionally, some experiencers express interpreting the *effects of their own actions* as extending beyond the present moment and the corporeal plane. Derrick comments:

[I]t's like there's an accordion of different lifetimes sitting right next to each other. So decisions I make here, impact these other dimensions as well. And vice versa, they impact here. So it really made me much more aware that when I choose fear or anger or any of these negative states, that they directly impact these other realities.

We see in these expressions a multidimensional moral realm that is much wider than the traditional spatiotemporal realm of thinking and action articulated in moral philosophy. Thoughts, choices, and actions, are seen as potentially having effects across transdimensional registers that are reciprocally intertwined with the physical plane.

By extension, while the experiencers are adamant they did not consent for their experiences to happen by the ethical standards of human consent and agreement, some communicate that they believe they have agreed on a “higher level.” In other words, they express the conviction that the aspect of themselves that will persist beyond the current embodiment may have agreed, at some level, to experience these events for their own growth and benefit. Some explicitly express they see the current physical expression of their existence as the result of an explicit choice. Rachel comments, “I believe that we choose this life prior [to birth] and then

we go back. That's how I view death." Justin expresses that his experiences with the entities helped him *remember making the choice* to become embodied on Earth.

And they also showed me when, because I agreed to come here again... And I remember when I came down from... the sky, or however you want to describe it and I knew, the minute I left to cross over, to come down, I thought, "oh what have I done?" Like, "Oh, I remember this." And it was tough. Really tough. But I needed that perspective to know that I am beyond this and this is just an experience.

The memory of the choice to become embodied again and have a human experience grants Justin a sense of agency in all of his Earthly experiences, even those he didn't consent to in his embodied physical life. Again, dislodging his conception of himself from a traditional linear conception of time allows him to participate in connection with expanded dimensions of himself as he navigates corporeal life.

The expansion of ethics beyond the corporeal and linear time is accompanied by a sense of non-duality, of not framing the experiences into conventional categories of "good vs evil" or "beneficial vs. harmful." The transcending of binaries core to the contact experience extends into the ethical plane, leading to an ability to hold what are traditionally seen as conflicting moral truths simultaneously. For example, experiencers express a sense that we both *are* and *are not* autonomous beings in the traditional western sense, and that respect for autonomy both *is* and *is not* of utmost moral importance. At the level of corporeal human experience, our social agreements make respect for an individual's choices and lifepath morally imperative. At the level of the eternal or "higher" self, soul growth and evolution which may occur as a result of trauma, abuse, and loss of autonomy take on more importance. Respect for autonomy may remain morally important at the level of embodied interaction, but it is reframed alongside a multidimensional recognition of soul growth that may include suffering or the suspension of consent. Importantly, one is not collapsed into the other, but are both allowed to stand. Experiencers are able to hold the two conflicting assertions at once: It is unethical, according to the guiding principles of corporeal interaction for their autonomy and choice-making to be disrespected *and* the experience facilitated their expansion in ways they are ultimately grateful for.

Abductees in particular express feeling traumatized and violated by the apparent non-human captors but simultaneously enabled and empowered by them. For example, Rachel expresses gratitude and optimism despite the fear and trauma she's experienced:

For as much as this experience has been scary and frowned upon and looked at as ridiculous and not true; and as much as I've kept these things to myself not to be discounted as a normal person, I am so grateful that I've had the

experience in every way. Even if some of the experiences were horrible...I'm still grateful because I wouldn't be the person I am today if these things had not happened and I cannot imagine myself in my life without it.

Parker expresses a similar sentiment, adding that he sees his experiences as evidence of benevolent forces beyond the human.

As pessimistic as I can be from these experiences, the aliens also offer...a type of hope that we aren't alone in the universe. And that there are these benevolent forces. And they might come in the form of extraterrestrials or odd, humanoid things. But on some level, I believe this is a reflection of the benevolence in the universe and the generosity and the kindness, and we are not alone on this little planet at the tail end of the Milky Way galaxy. There is something else and it might be in the form of these beings.

From a position of non-duality, the experiencers are able to see multiple layers to their experiences that transcend binaries like good vs. evil or immoral vs. moral. At the level of Earthly interaction, they may feel, at least initially, wronged, violated, or traumatized, but at the level of the species as well as their growth as an eternal self, the experiences may take on a higher level of meaning that does not erase, but co-occurs with a more straightforward earthly interpretation.

The last shift in the transpersonal layer of the ethic involves a realization, at a deep level, that the Otherness they have encountered is ultimately not an Otherness at all. In other words, the experiencers recognize everything that is as a manifestation of the same ultimate source. Catherine comments, "I don't have a sense that anything is disconnected." Jeannette adds, "That was the big takeaway for me. How all this stuff holds together and we are all literally connected." In one sense, this presents as a paradox, considering we have spent so much time emphasizing the radical Otherness that these beings represent in the individuals' lived experience. The importance of non-duality becomes clear to resolve the paradox. There both are and are not others. At the ultimate, ontological level, *there are no others*. At the level of embodied Earthly experience, they have the *experience of Others, including radical Otherness of a different advanced intelligent species*.

With the realization of oneself as a multidimensional being, and of all species and entities as generating from the same ultimate source, there emerges an expanded conception of relative—no one is a stranger. We see the dissolving of another duality—the lines we draw between those closest to us and strangers, important in virtue ethics and care ethics frameworks. At the level of the multidimensional self, the love, compassion, and concern we extend to those we care about the most is also extended to beings that we perceive as radically Other. At the level of embodied human experience, they *are* Other than us, and we *experience*

them as Other. At the deepest ontological level, they are recognized as part of the monistic One. As us. This deep realization helps take the love, care and concern that experiencers are able to extend naturally and easily to those who they see themselves as *related to* and extend it to those they do not yet know, other than that *they are*. They are called to create the categories for communication in order to commune, in order to rise to the call of responsibility, in order to meet the call of the non-human face. *They can't be, and yet they are. They're us, and yet they're Other.*

The transpersonal level adds layers of nuance and meaning that reframe standard notions of self, agency, and Other. While it does not *replace* or *override* the concerns of the embodied Earthly plane or liminal interspecies register, it co-exists alongside them, rooting material concern for social and moral issues firmly in a robust multidimensional understanding of who we ultimately are. Being called into a relational participatory field, the experiencers do not simply *believe* in consciousness persisting beyond the body or an innate interconnectedness but directly live and experience them.

Conclusion: Ethics Beyond Spiritual and Moral Bypassing

Having heard the call of contact experiences, experiencers emerge with a new attitude towards being, an expanded framing of reality anchored in participatory multidimensionality. I argue that a complete framework for moral decision-making emerges from the experiencer ethic — one that unfolds across distinct but interrelated layers. At its core is the moral agent as a multidimensional being, whose concept of self extends into non-physical realms, the past, the future, and parallel realities. Moral actions are likewise multidimensional, with effects that transcend the limits of physical reality and linear time. Similar to ethics rooted in the coordination epistemologies of Indigenous American peoples, the ethic reflects reciprocal relations that must be cultivated throughout space, time, and planes of reality.

At the level of embodied, earthly relations, experiencers open to a widened moral community, recognizing their relationship to human and non-human beings whose self-determination must be respected. They articulate an expanded sense of autonomy grounded in obligation to the whole, adopt utilitarian thinking oriented toward the evolutionary growth of the species, and shift toward a “We” -centric ethic in which collective and self-interest are inseparable. At the liminal, interspecies level, experiencers shift positionality, no longer seeing humanity as the dominant species. Encountering the liminal Other calls them to respond in ways that dislodge the assumptions of our sphere of ownness and the demands they make regarding how an Other can or should appear. They recognize that human needs and morals emerge from embodiment and may not align with those of the non-human intelligences. At the transpersonal level, these experiences are understood to

contribute to “soul growth.” Conceiving of themselves as eternal beings, experiencers retain a sense of cosmic agency in whatever happens to them. Non-duality emerges as a core moral orientation, allowing them to hold conflicting truths: experiences may be simultaneously violating and necessary, traumatic and transformative. Ultimately, they express that alterity and Otherness dissolves at the deepest level, and that these radically other intelligences share the same ultimate source as we do.

This multidimensional ethic avoids both moral and spiritual bypassing by integrating the demands of the embodied, spatiotemporal world with an openness to multidimensional realities. It does not sidestep the hard work of addressing systemic injustice in the here and now: if anything, these injustices become *even more important* with their new understandings of self and world. Matthew Roberts comments on how his discovery of his own immortality through his contact experiences engendered a renewed emphasis on the value and importance of respecting human life. “In realizing my own immortality and knowing there is no such thing as death, life suddenly isn’t so cheap anymore.”²⁷⁵ The urgent, pressing moral concerns of our time—anti-Black racism, oppression and abuse of transgender people, ongoing exploitation and displacement of Indigenous peoples, genocide, war and violence—are wrong not only because they fail to promote human welfare or cannot be universalized by the rational liberal subject. They are understood to be deeply and wholly wrong because they *violate the true nature of the universe*, they distort the immediate phenomenological givenness of unconditional love and interconnection that experiencers consider a core characteristic of the monistic source of all that is. Truly confronting and potentially solving these moral crises, then, requires adjustments in behavior *rooted* in new ontological and metaphysical understandings. The moral is not reduced to the material but is understood to reflect a deeper truth of interconnected kinship.

Reflecting Kripal’s challenge for us to take a stand with respect to the real, the multidimensional ethic is ultimately rooted in ontological and metaphysical claims. First, that a human being is far more than a body, and far more than the rational, constrained decision-maker presupposed by the liberal conception of personhood. Second, the universe is far more than the physical spatiotemporal plane of consensus reality, and we can directly experience it through participation. I do not claim to know whether the ontological and metaphysical positions articulated by contact experiencers are correct or not. I do think they provide a useful foundation for a holistic attitude towards being that avoids both spiritual and moral bypassing. I also think this lived experience should be taken seriously when formulating

²⁷⁵ Roberts, *Initiated*, 391.

explanatory hypotheses that make claims regarding what is real.

In the next chapter, I explore how we can actually apply the experienter insights to our understanding of UAP, using the framework to ethically reflect on the behavior of the alleged entities in the encounters. Ultimately, I argue a multidimensional ethic serves as a more nuanced, post-anthropocentric approach to unpacking the ethical dimensions and questions embedded in the complex, ontologically shocking experience of contact.

Chapter Seven: Ethics at the Threshold: Transgression, Tricksters and Transformation

“Could it be that their power is more limited than their actions seem to imply? Could it be that someone, or something is playing a fantastic trick on us?”—Jacques Vallée

“Tricksters are boundary crossers; they destabilize structures; they govern transitions. They also embody paradox, contradiction, and ambiguity.”—George Hansen

“Tricksters are the translation of creation; the trickster creates the tribe in stories, and pronounces the moment of remembrance as the trace of liberation.”—Gerald Vizenor

We have explored the phenomenology of contact through descriptive, generative, and interpretative lenses. In the final two chapters, I take the exploration a step further. I ask, what would it look like to approach our exploration of UAP and contact events through the frameworks and insights introduced by experiencers? This turn is part of the pursuit of fuller witnessing. I do not assume that the insights offered by experiencers are true; rather, I ask what it would mean to treat them as possibly true and to engage them as a serious mode of philosophical analysis. I begin with an intentionally provocative case: the behavior of the alleged UAP entities themselves.

I have presented an overwhelmingly positive and transformative interpretation of contact events and close encounters, even while acknowledging the ontological shock and trauma. Some will argue that such an analysis fails to capture the entirety of the experience of contact, especially the deceptive or at times apparently malevolent behavior of the entities. Additionally, some encounters are shrouded in vagueness and ambiguity— or fear, violation, and terror, that does *not* always result in spiritual growth and evolution. In other words, it is not always clear that the harm some experience during encounters is offset by benefits in the individual’s self-transformation.

Amidst ongoing disclosure and the growing acceptance of the reality of UAP, there is corresponding increased interest in the *ethical* evaluation of the alleged UAP entities’ behavior: often framed in terms of threat, invasion, deception, and harms towards human health.²⁷⁶ The entities are described as violating human autonomy and personhood, operating in secrecy and without regard for human

²⁷⁶ For example, in *Imminent*, Luis Elizondo describes UAP craft as operating with essential impunity since at least World War II and emphasizes the non-human intelligence controlling these UAP have interfered with ongoing military and nuclear operations. Further he emphasizes the serious medical injuries sustained by U.S. service members and intelligence officers who have encountered UAP. See *Imminent: Inside the Pentagon’s Hunt for UFOs* (New York: William Morrow, 2024).

welfare. These charges come to their most extreme expression with respect to abduction accounts, which are seen as forms of kidnapping, torture, and non-consensual experimentation. While such framings are understandable within traditional moral theory and human ethical sensibilities, they may obscure the ontological complexity of what is unfolding. They presuppose a moral framework grounded in human-centered temporality and corporeality—precisely the categories that contact experiences destabilize. In this Chapter I would like to explore what it would look like to ethically evaluate the UAP entities’ behavior within a multidimensional moral realm: a moral field that includes beings, agencies, and causalities that operate across temporal and ontological registers not reducible to human frameworks of intention and accountability.

Key to this evaluation will be the conviction expressed consistently by experiencers that the entities appear to *know things we do not*—that they are positioned within time differently and understand the “big picture” from vantage points that we have very limited access to within human cognitive framings. We thus must be extremely cautious with respect to projecting simplistic human intentions and moral evaluations onto ostensibly non-human entities. As I have argued throughout this book, the experiences are *subversive* and *boundary-blurring*. Continuing to make use of hermeneutical resources offered by Indigenous American traditions, I will explore how drawing parallels with the trickster figure or archetype common in tribal narratives and cultures may help us consider the entities’ behavior in a more holistic, multidimensional way. In many Indigenous American traditions, the trickster employs deception and paradox not for malice but as a liberatory tool—to rupture complacent moral categories and invite a deeper spiritual awakening. Likewise, the secrecy, disorientation, and ambiguity of contact encounters may serve a liberatory or initiatory function, especially in shocking us into considering non-dual possibilities beyond our conventional moral framings. The full effects of what is happening may extend beyond our conventional spatiotemporal plane, ultimately dislodging the individual’s confidence in our current ways of relating and serving as a catalyst for ethical growth. Obtaining traditional consent for such a process may compromise the ultimate result, in which the ambiguity of what is occurring is crucial for destabilizing epistemic certainty and stimulating individual and collective transformation. Such an analysis reveals the alleged entities not as evil invaders nor as enlightened saviors, but as morally complex beings who, like humans, fall somewhere in between.

An Ethical Evaluation of the Non-Human Abductors

Contact inconveniently presents with a consistent phenomenological theme of *deception*. This comes not only in the secrecy, kidnapping, and lack of consent in

abduction events, but in more subtle forms of contact as well. 50 years before Bertrand Meheust published on UAP elusivity, Jacques Vallée emphasized the deceptive elements of UAP presentation as one of the main reasons UAP remain under our scientific radars. Not only are there strategies that discourage the reporting of UAP sightings and government convolution through the release of “official” reports that explain away the UAP events, *there are also built-in silencing mechanisms within the phenomenon itself*. As Vallée puts it, “the phenomenon negates itself,”²⁷⁷ meaning that UAP and the entities allegedly associated with them participate in obfuscation, tempting serious researchers to dismiss the phenomenon entirely.

It issues statements and demonstrates principles where some of the information conveyed is true and some is false. Determining which is the true half is left as an exercise to the investigator, but the logic is such that one is tempted to place it completely beyond the rational realm: a dangerous temptation!²⁷⁸

Vallée illustrates this dynamic through two emblematic cases: that of patrolman Herb Schirmer and of “Mrs. Keech.” Schirmer reported encountering a luminous craft while on duty, after which he experienced a headache, a buzzing sound, and a red welt below his ear. Twenty minutes of missing time followed, later explored under hypnosis. He recalled contact with the craft’s occupants, who offered elaborate but dubious explanations about their origins and technology, and warned him he would not “speak wisely” of the event. Vallée asks why such advanced beings, supposedly capable of controlling perception and memory, would allow hypnosis to uncover so much.

Have they not anticipated this method of disclosure? Or could it be that some parts of the human mind are inaccessible to them? Could it be that their power is more limited than their actions seem to imply? *Could it be that someone, or something is playing a fantastic trick on us?*²⁷⁹

A more provocative example is Mrs. Keech, a Midwestern woman who began producing automatic writings from alleged extraterrestrial “Guardians.” Their messages evolved into apocalyptic prophecies predicting disasters and salvation by the “Space Brothers.” When these prophecies failed, her followers’ faith only deepened, interpreting the non-event as proof of divine intervention. Vallée cautions against dismissing Mrs. Keech as delusional: she experienced genuine anomalous phenomena, including unexplainable visitations—including a duo in which one strange and silent individual was described as not being of this planet. Her community’s beliefs were sincere responses to those events. Victims of the third

²⁷⁷ Jacques Vallée, *UFOs: The Psychic Solution* (St Albans: Panther Books, 1977), 68.

²⁷⁸ Ibid.

²⁷⁹ Ibid., 66. My emphasis.

coverup, the anomalous happenings lead Mrs. Keech to look like the insincere one.²⁸⁰ Vallée argues we must look beyond a binary separation of the “real” from the “false,” and understand that deception, paradox, and absurdity are part of how the phenomenon manifests in human experience.

Perhaps nowhere are the deceptive elements of the UAP phenomenon more evident than in John Keel’s *The Mothman Prophecies*. The infamous “Mothman” sightings in Point Pleasant, West Virginia during the 1960s were accompanied by a range of paranormal events, including UAP and the unsettling appearance of “Men in Black.” These visitors seemed to mimic humans imperfectly—wearing ill-fitting clothes, driving outdated cars, and behaving in awkward, mechanical ways and warning witnesses to remain silent. Keel himself experienced intense interference during his investigation. His phone line was plagued by strange calls from alleged contactees and mysterious voices claiming to be non-human entities. Attempts to record the conversations always resulted in static, as if something were deliberately erasing the evidence. His phone was later discovered to be connected to two different numbers, one of which remained active even after his service was shut off. Someone—or something—was imitating his voice, contacting others about his research, and manipulating his communications.²⁸¹

The deception culminated in a chilling prediction. Keel and others were repeatedly warned of a massive power blackout set to occur on December 15, 1967. Instead, that very day, the Silver Bridge in Point Pleasant collapsed, killing dozens. “They knew this was going to happen...and when. And they gave me all that bilge about a power failure. They knew. They just didn’t want me to be able to warn anyone.”²⁸² Keel concludes that the entities had fed him false information to divert him from the truth. I admit that *The Mothman Prophecies* is one of the most perplexing and disturbing books I have ever read. It illustrates that deception *is* a part of how contact presents phenomenologically, and that we must take these aspects seriously, even as we surface the transformative elements of the phenomenon.

Then there are the complicated and puzzling abduction accounts. The beings allegedly intrude into bedrooms and cars without permission, paralyze abductees, “turn off” their family members while the abductions occur, perform non-consensual medical procedures, and ostensibly erase or alter the memories of the events such that the abductees are left with strange gaps of missing time or memories of talking owls, raccoons, or buffalo.

²⁸⁰ Ibid., 69-70.

²⁸¹ John Keel, *The Mothman Prophecies: A True Story* (New York: Tom Doherty Associates: 1975/1991), 263.

²⁸² Ibid., 285.

An evaluation of the beings' alleged behavior through the lens of traditional western ethics does not reflect well on the entities. From a Kantian perspective, we must only act in ways that are rationally universalizable and never treat anyone as a means only. Lying or deceiving is one of Kant's primary examples of behavior that cannot be universalized: if lying were a universal maxim of action, it would result in a logical contradiction: no one would ever believe anything anyone else says, and the very concepts of lying and truth-telling would break down.²⁸³ Further, abducting someone without their permission and performing non-consensual medical procedures is a classic example of treating someone as a means only, failing to respect their inherent dignity and choice-making. While more simplistic versions of utilitarian reasoning can support violating someone's consent for the greater good, most rule-based versions of utilitarianism argue that general rules in favor of honesty and bodily autonomy ultimately result in the best consequences for the greatest number of people. Additionally, it is unclear what the immediate benefits of these encounters are, in traditional human terms, that would justify the violations of consent in the name of maximizing overall welfare.

From the perspective of virtue theory, it's difficult to see the entities' behavior as anything other than vicious: their actions do not appear to reflect consistent traits of character like honesty, justice, or friendliness. Moreover, *phronesis* recognizes that truly virtuous action involves engaging others as rational equals, capable of their own good judgment, which is not reflected in deceptive or autonomy restricting acts. From a perspective of care ethics, it's unclear how the entities' behavior reflects caring relationships, sympathy, or the centering of vulnerability and need. Deception and disrespect of others' self-determination are not good foundations for caring, empathic relationships.

However, we must pause. Even within a traditional human ethical framework, the story may be more complex. We may be able to borrow a concept from medical ethics known as *paternalism* in which restrictions on someone's choices may be considered justified for their own well-being. For example, *soft paternalism* occurs in order to prevent *non-autonomous conduct*. In other words, when practitioners may feel that a patient's expressed wishes do not truly align with their autonomous choice (perhaps they are coerced by family members, impaired, or do not fully understand the implications of their choice), they may refuse an intervention. Additionally, *hard paternalistic* interventions occur in medical practice when an intervention is understood to be for the patient's own good and the patient is not considered capable of understanding the reasons *why* the intervention is for their

²⁸³ Immanuel Kant, *Grounding for the Metaphysics of Morals*, trans. James Ellington (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing, 1993), 14-15.

own good.²⁸⁴ This happens often in the case of small children, or when a family member makes decisions on an adult patient's behalf because the individual has been deemed incompetent to understand the risks and benefits of a particular decision. Additionally, in psychiatric care settings, patients frequently have non-consensual interventions that have been determined to ultimately be in their best interest.

As another illustrative example: consider the process of taking your cat to the vet. From the cat's perspective, they may be tricked or deceived into entering a cage or carrier (maybe with food or a treat!) or physically forced into one against their will. They are carried away to a strange environment, where they find themselves on a cold table, surrounded by strangers, who poke them and prod them for ends which they do not understand. They may attempt to react with physical defense, only to find they have been constrained or sedated. Eventually they return to their home environment, perplexed about what occurred. In this case, you justify treating your cat this way because *you know what is in the cat's highest good, and the cat isn't capable of understanding that the deception and violations of their will are ultimately for their own good*. This analogy is, of course, imperfect—humans are not house pets—but it illuminates the logic of benevolent deception when the epistemic gap between the caretaker and the cared-for is vast.

An immediate, understandable objection to this discussion may arise: the abductees and experiencers who are deceived, kidnapped or violated by the entities are *not* incapable of understanding. They are not small children, confused adults, psychiatric patients, or animals. They *can understand*, and the entities *can* communicate with experiencers honestly and get consent for all forms of interaction. This is a fair point, but once again we need to pause. There can be *other* reasons that deception or violations of autonomy may be justified in human interactions. The individual may be capable of understanding, but being upfront and getting full consent *would compromise the result*. This is seen most distinctly in drug trials that utilize placebos: individuals cannot be told outright that they are receiving a placebo. In order to measure whether the experimental drug is preferable to the placebo, it is crucial that the patients enrolled in the trial *believe* they may be receiving the actual drug. There are other examples where deception may be employed in order to help someone have a realization they otherwise may not have. Consider a mentor who hopes to instill humility in an overconfident student who prides himself on his intellect and frequently assumes his own arguments are superior. The mentor arranges for the student's essay, lightly reworded and anonymized, to be included in a set of papers submitted for peer critique. Confidently, the student critiques his own essay, pointing out what he perceives as fundamental errors, inconsistencies, and

²⁸⁴ Tom L. Beauchamp and James F. Childress, *The Principles of Biomedical Ethics*, 7th Edition (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 215-217.

weaknesses. Only afterward does the mentor reveal that the essay the student harshly criticized was his own. The temporary deception reveals a truth about his intellectual arrogance that no amount of straightforward reasoning could have achieved. Here, as in certain forms of therapy or moral education, the deception is not intended to undermine autonomy but instead to enhance it, to create conditions for genuine self-understanding. Being fully transparent from the outset would have made such insight impossible.

While these examples do not involve the same magnitude of capture, bodily violation, or trauma reported in abduction events, my point is that even within traditional western philosophical ethics, the use of deception and the suspension of consent are morally complicated. These complications deepen when there are substantial epistemic gaps between the parties involved—as in the case of taking a cat to the veterinarian. When those enacting the deception or overriding autonomy possess crucial knowledge about the event's purpose and outcomes that the deceived cannot access, the moral evaluation becomes less straightforward than it might otherwise be. In the case of the entities associated with UAP, I suggest that these epistemic gaps are likely immense. If the alleged beings are situated differently with respect to time, possess knowledge of dimensions or spectrums of reality inaccessible to us, or understand aspects of consciousness and human purpose that we do not, then their motivations and actions may not be as ethically clear-cut as they initially appear. These epistemic gaps may be so profound that making sense of their behavior requires a suspension of traditional binary thinking and the adoption of a more multidimensional ethical framework.

Multidimensional Knowing and Epistemic Gaps

A multidimensional moral evaluation asks a wider set of questions. It first looks at the full scope of the potential benefits of contact in terms of the multidimensional subject, not just the effects on the traditional liberal subject in physical reality. Additionally, we must consider the epistemic gaps between us and the entities and the possibility that they *know substantial things we do not* in terms of the best interest of individuals and the species as whole.

In suggesting that we consider the possibility that the entities possess epistemic access we do not, I am in effect arguing that we consider them epistemic authorities—an idea that may cause understandable resistance. Why, one may ask, should an autonomous, rational subject defer to the epistemic authority of mysterious, deceptive, and apparently non-human beings? Especially as authorities on human welfare? Yet as Linda Zagzebski argues, deference to epistemic authority

need not compromise one's own epistemic autonomy or status as a knower.²⁸⁵ Recognizing the limits of our own perspective—both as individuals and as a species—can itself be understood as an intellectual virtue, a form of epistemic humility. Our grasp of what is real, even within the human domain, is always partial, situated, and dependent upon others. Epistemic humility does not demand uncritical acceptance of any authority, but rather a disciplined openness to truths that may exceed our vantage point, reflective processes, or even our categories of reason. Epistemic humility requires we reign in moral impulses to judge the entities' methods solely through human norms of transparency and consent.

Zagzebski argues that we consider others epistemic authorities when they give us reasons that pre-empt our own reasons to believe something is true. In other words, the authority's reasons *replace* my own reasons, rather than simply adding to them. This is because in certain cases, "I have reasons for thinking that the authority is more trustworthy than myself in some range of beliefs" such that we are willing to let the authority's determination replace our own within that specific range.²⁸⁶ A simple example is the trust I put in my dermatologist to know, better than I, whether a particular mole is worrisome or not. In these cases, I let the dermatologist's judgments *replace or pre-empt* my own. It is not easy to articulate exactly what conditions would justify accepting someone as an epistemic authority on a particular range of beliefs. However, in many situations, Zagzebski argues, we identify people who not only have more access to or better grasp of the evidence but may also have deeper understanding or special insights that we trust that we would not come to on our own if we formed the beliefs independently. In other words, we make the conscientious judgment that we are more likely to form true beliefs and avoid false ones if we accept what the authority believes on a certain topic or area of knowledge.²⁸⁷

One could argue it is not immediately obvious that the entities have established themselves as epistemic authorities, especially with respect to what is in the best interest of human beings. As it is extremely difficult to understand their motives, intentions and behavior, or even how their rational and cognitive capacities operate, we are left in the dark regarding their epistemic processes and how they are reaching insight into human welfare. I submit there are reasons, however, to at least consider their epistemic position as distinctively privileged. First, their apparent relation to time seems non-linear, suggesting access to temporal knowledge unavailable to us. Second, they demonstrate intimate familiarity with consciousness itself—communicating non-locally, manipulating awareness, and eliciting

²⁸⁵ Linda Zagzebski, "A Defense of Epistemic Authority," *Res Philosophica* 90.2 (2013): 293-306.

²⁸⁶ *Ibid.*, 298.

²⁸⁷ *Ibid.*, 299.

experiences of separation from the body. Third, many experiencers report that the beings possess detailed personal knowledge of their lives, often accompanied by a powerful sense of recognition, as if these relationships pre-existed physical incarnation. Taken together, these claims suggest good reason to accept that epistemic humility appropriate to acknowledging the limits of a finite human standpoint requires acknowledging that the entities may have wider access to the truth. Such access may result in unique insight regarding human welfare and what is truly for the benefit of individuals and the species that we cannot see from our vantage point and would be unable to reach on our own.

Multidimensional Benefits

My goal is to take the insights and participatory frameworks experiencers derive from contact and use them to illuminate how we may come to different conclusions regarding the beings' behavior. In other words, how does thinking about ethics multidimensionally illuminate the potential motives and actions of the beings in a different light? I begin by outlining possibilities for the potential benefits of contact through a multidimensional lens, in which the full effects of what are happening may extend beyond spatiotemporal physical embodiment. I identify four potential multidimensional benefits that the entities would have deeper knowledge of from their epistemic standpoint: a) ontological expansion and the experience of oneself as more than just a body, b) the conscious evolution of the human species, c) a reflecting back to us of our moral shortcomings in order to facilitate (a) and (b) and d) the experience of non-duality. I then question if the entities being open about their aims in a traditional consensual sense may *compromise the intended results*. Given our limited epistemic standpoint, it may not be possible to make a definitive determination.

To begin, with a multidimensional understanding of subjectivity and self, the potential effects of contact reverberate through more than the individual's corporeal Earthly life. Emerging from contact with an expanded understanding of the universe and of the moral realm, the pedagogical results of contact are felt by experiencers to extend into other versions of themselves, and to open up a more highly evolved form of conscious interaction. Even if one does not literally accept experiencers' convictions regarding soul growth and other possible incarnations, their experiences of themselves in a wider conscious and atemporal field may be of direct benefit in a way that is difficult to traditionally measure. The experiences of consciousness not being limited to the body, and the increase in their own conviction that consciousness survives death are outcomes of contact that must inform our ethical evaluation. In the Reddit Experiencer forum, a user who goes by the name of MantisAwakening made a post titled "The 'all NHI are evil' narrative is a harmful

and counterproductive oversimplification.” In this post, MantisAwakening suggests that the non-human intelligences “are operating with a bigger picture” and know that consciousness exceeds human embodiment. “Experiencer stories often make it sound like many NHI lack empathy. That’s certainly possible, but another explanation is that they have the perspective of beings who have awareness of spirit.”²⁸⁸ In other words, the sometimes apparent indifference shown by the entities towards human suffering may be reflective of the fact that they know there are benefits to what is happening that go beyond corporeal human experience.

Additionally, a key part of the embodied Earthly layer of the multidimensional ethic involves a utilitarian reasoning towards the overall evolution of the species over time, not only to higher states of biological evolution but higher *conscious evolution*. That experiencers emerge from these experiences with a transformed ethical orientation potentially points to long-term benefits in conscious growth and relationality that are subtly affecting our collective attitude towards being. If the UAP entities experience time differently than we do and have access to knowledge about the long-term effects of contact on our species, it may be that the methods they employ are designed to stimulate subtle transformations in the individual and eventually the species.

For example, a key aspect of these transformations appears to be instigated in the individual feeling isolated from mainstream institutions and societal norms. To truly understand the shortcomings of our current attitudes and ways of being, those shortcomings must be reflected back in experience. Perhaps truly terrifying and reality-bending experience is necessary for the individual to become acutely aware of the exploitative nature of many existing systems. Matthew Roberts, who reports multiple extremely traumatic encounters, describes this as a pedagogical tool to reflect the weaknesses of humans’ current ways of relating back to us.

We project our badness. We assume that they would behave towards us as we do towards them. If you’re looking for bad aliens, we are it. Their mission here is to get us to realize this. They are in touch with consciousness and therefore could not be considered evil. The ability to communicate through consciousness would preclude you from being harmful. People insist on this evil alien theory because of the bad experiences. You have to understand that in doing things you would consider evil, they are pointing out *your* flaws.²⁸⁹

²⁸⁸ Reddit user MantisAwakening, “The ‘All NHI Are Evil’ Narrative Is a Harmful and Counterproductive Oversimplification,” post in r/Experiencers, https://www.reddit.com/r/Experiencers/comments/1dfueqm/the_all_nhi_are_evil_narrative_is_a_harmful_and/, accessed October 27, 2025.

²⁸⁹ Matthew Roberts, *Initiated: UAP, Dreams, Depression, Delusions, Shadow People, Psychosis, Sleep Paralysis and Pandemics* (Self-published, 2020), 255.

Roberts submits that the behavior is part of a strategy of holding up a mirror—reflecting back to us many of the exploitative and harmful things we do to each other and to non-human forms of life. While some may be sufficiently convinced of such shortcomings through being told or shown information, such as through the powerful visual imagery, others may not fully come to terms with the harmfulness of our current systems without being directly exposed through non-consensual experience. In the same Reddit post by MantisAwakening the user suggests, “None of the above is stating that some NHI aren’t operating with negative intentions, but due to the incredibly complex and unknown nature of these interactions it’s very difficult to know what is really happening and why... [The NHI] may even be consciously playing the role of the ‘evil aliens’ to encourage personal growth or some other response in the experiencer.”²⁹⁰ When placed into a larger framework that extends beyond the limits of current corporeal embodiment, the complexities of what is occurring may not be straightforward. The deeper meaning of negative experiences may come in their pedagogical effects, in their ability to reflect back inadequacies in one’s current ways of operating and direct the individual towards areas of growth and improvement.

Additionally, a crucial aspect of the transpersonal level of reasoning is an acceptance of non-duality: a breaking down of binaries and an ability to hold conflicting truths at once. This includes an acceptance of all experiences, even those we would traditionally classify as “negative” as a spectrum of human experiences that complement each other and are equally important parts of conscious life. This does not dampen the importance of the pursuit of justice and ending exploitation but includes an ability to simultaneously hold that even as we pursue this task, suffering and negative experiences are one half of the spectrum of experience. It is possible that such a realization could not come without an encounter that simultaneously devastates and transforms: that is both terrifying and non-consensual but also leads to empowerment and deeper understanding.

The full comprehension of the scope of multidimensional subjectivity seems to be gained only through participation—it cannot be communicated through words or through instilling of beliefs but must be directly experienced by the individual. This includes the breaking down of the subject/object binary, and the dissolution of the ego that comes through giving up control and dissolving the boundaries of what was previously understood to be the self. These transformations are not self-generated and cannot be initiated by the individual themselves. They appear rather through the encounter with radical Otherness. We return to the space of Kristeva’s abjection, in which the normal boundaries of the body and selfhood

²⁹⁰ Reddit user MantisAwakening, “The ‘all NHI are evil’ narrative”

are forcibly placed in question, resulting in a visceral recoil from what cannot be categorized or assimilated. Experiencers often begin here: with terror, disgust, paralysis, and a sense of contamination or ontological violation. This is ultimately a phenomenology of collapse: the ego experiences its limits through exposure to something radically alien; it is touched by something from beyond the sphere of the own. Abjection thus marks the initial rupture of intentionality, the moment in which the subject's conception of “me” is forcibly dislodged. In phenomenological terms, this is the moment when the “I” ceases to be the contained, autonomous subject and becomes rather a site of affective exposure. No longer the source of experience, the “I” is the place where experience happens: it feels, suffers, receives, and is transformed by what comes from beyond itself.

While abjection tears open the egoic boundary, a surrendering to receptivity can reconstitute the self, although it will be changed. Marion also posits the subject as a receiver rather than a constitutor, but this is understood to be generative. For example, in *The Erotic Phenomenon* he explores how the encounter with a beloved Other results in a givenness that radically dissolves the ego and transforms the subject. Marion describes the collapse of the boundaries of the self through *love* rather than horror or disgust. In Marion's terms, a lover must advance without assurance of an outcome, without guarantee that they will be loved in return, ultimately responding to a call that resists full comprehension or certainty of a result. The subject becomes a self not through their ability to think or doubt (as Descartes asserted) but through their ability to love and be loved—by experiencing the pure givenness of the Other and allowing it to overwhelm the rigidity of the self-Other boundary.²⁹¹ In the encounter with the Beloved, the Other's saturation of my comprehension and borders does not provoke dread but devotion. A key component of the phenomenological structure, however, remains the same: in both abjection and *eros*, the subject is decentered and autonomy is suspended. What changes is the *valence* of that decentering—in the loving encounter there is receptivity and surrender rather than resistance and defense.

We can formulate a “contact-sense” of erotic reduction, in which the encounter is not with a human beloved but with a mysterious ostensibly non-human intelligence. However the transformation still occurs by surrendering to the givenness of the Other and allowing the borders of the self to dissolve in the Other's presence. The experience is *saturated* and beyond conceptual mastery; it cannot be known through language or concepts but through direct participatory knowing. In the contact event, as in *eros*, one often experiences being *seen from within* or *known entirely*, often quite literally as the entities perform mindscans or demonstrate intimate

²⁹¹ Jean-Luc Marion, *The Erotic Phenomenon* trans. Stephen E. Lewis (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2007), 23-25.

knowledge of experiencers' inner lives and future experiences. This reversal of intentionality reveals the self as recipient rather than initiator of experience. In all varieties of encounters, the body or flesh becomes the threshold where alterity inscribes itself, as even more consciousness-centered encounters refer back to the corporeal and reconfigure the subject's understanding of the boundaries and capacities of the body. The dissolution of subject-object polarity becomes the condition for this revelation, but it occurs only in surrendering to the givenness of the unknown Other; in allowing saturation and ambiguity to overwhelm our desire to control the terms of the encounter.

The erotic relation opens toward what Marion calls the "Third Party," where the connection is witnessed or refers to a transcendence that exceeds both the lover and the beloved.²⁹² Marion uses "the child" that is born of a loving relationship as a phenomenological symbol of love not being contained only to the pair— an "unpredictable arrival" that they cannot completely control, which exceeds both of them.²⁹³ The relation projects towards that which is not yet— the child in this sense symbolizes the future. Love also becomes responsible before others, to those outside the dyad. The Third thus reorders time and relationality, introducing an unassimilable horizon of givenness. In contact, the irruption of the Third is the shattering of anthropocentric reciprocity and exposure of the subject to a new dimension of meaning beyond contractual relations— a widened moral circle, a breaking down of subject and object, a deep sense of interconnectedness with all that is. Far from signifying the loss of self, this exposure reveals a deeper ipseity— but one that emerges from allowing oneself to be constituted as the accumulation of the gifts. The *erotic reduction*, thus construed, offers a phenomenological grammar for contact as an event in which the self is unmade and remade through encounter with an excessive, transfiguring Other.

Seen together, abjection and erotic reduction illustrate the phenomenology of contact as a movement of unmaking. The abject encounter tears the fabric of the ego, while *eros* reweaves it within a larger field of givenness. Both dissolve the polarity of subject and object: abjection by exposing the instability of the self's borders, and eros by revealing selfhood as constituted through relation and exposure to the givenness of that which must exceed us and disrupt our habitual attitudes towards being. Contact may begin in the terror of exposure, but culminates in the affirmation of interpenetration— a porous self that experiences itself as the product of the gift of saturated experience, rather than the originator of identity. Presenting as embodied, liminal, or non-corporeal beings that challenge all our assumed parameters of how the Other *ought to appear*, the entities, even in disruption and deception, provide a

²⁹² Marion, *The Erotic Phenomenon*, 208.

²⁹³ *Ibid.*, 199.

unique field of experience for reconfiguring existing boundaries of self, other, and world.

The Necessity of Contact

The above mapping helps us explore the question of whether the benefits of contact could be achieved equally well through means *other than contact*. Given that near death experiences, psychedelic experiences, etc., can also be profoundly transformative in similar ways, might these lessons be learned in ways that don't require the secrecy, dishonesty, and violation of human will? And, if the entities are truly here to help, could they not simply be honest and transparent about their aims?

The transformative potential of the phenomenological structure of contact (in parallel with abjection and erotic reduction) comes precisely from an encounter with the saturated givenness of an unknown Other, the encountering of a conscious presence that exceeds and shatters all our understandings of how an Other *ought to appear*. Individuals are also highly variable, and if we grant that the entities possess knowledge we do not, or trust experiencers' convictions that the beings know them in highly personal ways, then they may know key things about each individual's transformative process. Matthew Roberts, for example, states that he never would have undergone the changes in his sense of self and ethics that he did without his contact encounter:

I was surprised [reading the Reddit Experiencer forum] that so few actually saw beings as I did, but I chalk this up to the fact that this is what I needed. I never would have looked at any of this stuff had it not smacked me in the face as it did; nor would I have believed anyone who was telling me these things.²⁹⁴

It is possible that the rigidity of certain individuals' belief systems require contact being the catalyst or mechanism for transformation that would otherwise not have been possible and would not occur in the same way if the entities were explicit about the process. Marion argues that the presence of the Other in erotic love leads to an opening of the boundaries of ego that would not have otherwise occurred. But perhaps in modern life something much more disruptive is required to shock us and loosen the grasp of anthropocentrism and our technological ways of being. For some, profound transformation may require the destabilizing realization that the world is not what one thought it was, and that one is not who one believed oneself to be—an insight precipitated through direct physical encounters with corporeal entities that violate the individual's sense of agency.

²⁹⁴ Matthew Roberts, *Initiated*, 319.

If this is the case, then the entities informing experiencers of what they are doing and getting consent would *indeed compromise the result*. It is *precisely because* they lack full epistemic access to the identity of the beings and aims of the encounter that the individual is prompted to go on an individual journey of exploration that often reconfigures their metaphysics, ethics, and expands their moral circle and ontological borders.

Last, we must consider some experiencers' convictions that they agreed, on some level, to have these experiences. Experiencers have different ways of expressing this, some articulating it in the language of past lives, or a current transcendent or "higher" version of themselves that is agreeing for these things to happen as a part of their individual "soul growth." Just as we may grant that the beings are epistemically privileged in relation to us, I am willing to grant that experiencers, through their direct experiential knowledge, are epistemically privileged in relation to non-experiencers in terms of understanding the purpose and motives of these encounters. While their convictions that they agreed to participate are not verifiable in traditional human or academic terms, they should give us pause to consider that the straightforward interpretation of the entities as performing these actions against the human will is overly simplistic. If an individual subject's "will" is actually much larger and more inclusive than the rational desires of their human mind in three-dimensional reality, what is occurring may actually be in line with their will within an expanded field of selfhood. A genuinely multidimensional evaluation, then, must remain open to the possibility that what appears coercive from within the bounded human frame may, from a cosmic vantage, participate in a wider liberation of consciousness. This framing does not diminish our own ethical responsibility to minimize suffering and respect autonomy—the ethical parameters of the Earthly, corporeal plane exist simultaneously, even if paradoxically.

The Hermeneutics of the Trickster

Across cultures, the trickster archetype mediates between worlds, exposing the limitations of fixed categories and forcing new modes of understanding through paradox and disruption. This figure may help us understand an inherent limitation to the parameters through which I have framed this ethical evaluation. It seems that much of what appears at the multidimensional level is *saturated*—it overwhelms human rationality and may be better understood through the language of paradox, symbolism or profound truth. This is not to suggest at all that the experiences are not *real*, but rather that the deeper purposes behind them may exceed traditional ethical analysis or comprehension. Indeed, even framing these experiences as about "learning" or the entities employing deception as a pedagogical device may be approaching the situation with too much metaphysical certainty. It is possible the

deeper aims and purposes of these encounters cannot become fully coherent within traditional moral philosophy or human understanding. Trying to make rational sense of every aspect of entity behavior may be leaving too little unknown, may be attempting to force something that exceeds human cognitive framings into contained categories we can understand.

Contact experiences sit in a gray area, a liminal in-between, in the ambiguous. Contact is simultaneously deceptive, terrifying, enlightening, and transformative—all while ostensibly exposing experiencers to an important understanding of self and world. Such characteristics move us away from the language of moral philosophy and put us in natural proximity with the language of the trickster archetype. The trickster uses paradox and deceit as liberatory tools, which engender moral insight in the deceived. If contact experiences unsettle our ontological assumptions and moral certainties, they do so in ways that often mirror the trickster's pedagogical mischief: consider Keel and his plethora of absurd phone calls, in addition to the entities who consistently misled him about the large power blackout to ultimately, he believes, distract him from the impending bridge disaster. Or, consider Rachel, who, during an abduction experience at 9 years old, encountered a tall gray who left her with the following puzzling exchange:

The next thing he said to me is something that I'll never forget. And that was, "the cure for cancer is something that we use every day"...I thought to him, quizzically, "you mean like toothpaste?" Because I am trying to think of something that we would use every day. And he chuckled back to me, in my head, "yeah, yeah like that."

If the entities truly knew the cure for cancer, why would they give this information to a young girl instead of the world's medical researchers? Second, why would they introduce the idea at all, only to leave the young girl in bewilderment, wondering if toothpaste holds the cure for humanity's most deadly disease? Nothing about the exchange makes logical human sense.

This ostensibly prankster or almost trolling behavior may be interwoven with a liberatory, pedagogical goal— but one that is also not fully comprehensible within the parameters of western rationality. Turning once more to hermeneutical resources of Indigenous American groups, the archetype of the trickster is not simply a straightforward deceiver but a form of *transmotion*—a living process of transformation that resists epistemic closure or certainty, mockingly liberating humans from the confines of rigid, dogmatic belief. Viewed through this lens, the contact phenomenon may enact a trickster function on both the individual and collective level, destabilizing entrenched epistemologies and illuminating new possibilities for being and becoming human.

The Trickster and Deceit as a Liberatory Tool

The trickster may be considered an epistemic authority, but not in the traditional sense. Trickster figures are often marginal and disruptive; they are not immediately *perceived by others* as ones who have special insight into a particular truth. But trickster figures often know something those who are subject to their tricks do not— even if they are not acknowledged or immediately recognized as epistemic authorities. There are gems of wisdom underlying their antics, deeper truths towards which their behavior is ultimately aimed.

Even though the trickster is often associated with Indigenous American worldviews, essentially all ancient cultures have trickster figures. Indigenous Americans have the coyote, among others, the Greeks have Hermes, and the Norse have Loke, etc.²⁹⁵ Folklorist Barbara Babcock-Abrahams succinctly identifies some of the key characteristics of trickster figures. Tricksters exhibit independence and ignore spatial and temporal boundaries— they often operate at night and defy circles of life and death. They tend to be located near crossroads, doorways or thresholds— usually halfway between the material realm and the world behind the veil. Tricksters typically have some kind of mental or physical abnormality, often taking the form of exaggerated sexual characteristics and enormous libido absent the ability to reproduce. Simultaneously, they have an uncertain or ambiguous sexual status. Tricksters have the ability to disguise themselves and are often shapeshifters, indeterminate in physical stature. They may be simultaneously young and old, perpetually young, or perpetually aged. They often exhibit a human/animal dualism and present with both human and animal characteristics at once. Tricksters are generally amoral and asocial, rebels against authority, and crossers of social norms. They are often situated liminally between life and death, good and evil, the human and the divine. Last, in all of their antics, there is a breakdown between the real and the unreal, between what is a genuine occurrence in external reality, and what is a reflection of one's own inner mind or self.²⁹⁶

Importantly, the trickster is ultimately a beneficent figure, but one whose beneficence is expressed through trickery, deceit, and the crossing of boundaries and violation of taboos. He consequently “must remain marginal and peripheral, forever betwixt and between. As a ‘criminal’ culture-hero, he embodies possibilities--the most positive and the most negative-- and is paradox personified.”²⁹⁷ By presenting on the margins of order and normality, the trickster opens up the space where logic and binaries break down. He paradoxically teaches and assists through deception

²⁹⁵ George Hansen, *The Trickster and the Paranormal* (Self-published, 2001), 35.

²⁹⁶ Barbara Babcock-Abrahams, “‘A Tolerated Margin of Mess’: The Trickster and His Tales Reconsidered,” *Journal of the Folklore Institute* 11.3 (1975): 159-160.

²⁹⁷ *Ibid.*, 148.

and disorder, allowing for the emergence of profound and primal truth. The trickster sits halfway in between the embodied material realm and the divine; the sacred and the secular are often represented in a singular figure. “Tricksters are boundary crossers; they destabilize structures; they govern transitions. They also embody paradox, contradiction, and ambiguity.”²⁹⁸

It is through crossing boundaries, destabilization, and transition that the trickster serves a liberatory role. As they are in-between, they are connected both with the infinite and with death and obliteration; tricksters bring the possibility of annihilation into a world of predictability and certainty. “Trickster’s connection with nothingness, with negativity, and often with the introduction of death into the world is a threat both to reality and to our ways of seeing it complexly. But this relationship may also transform if not ‘reality’, then our modes of perceiving it.”²⁹⁹ The trickster’s antics are not for naught; they open up perspectives from which we otherwise remain closed off. It is through subverting order, crossing boundaries, and disregarding moral norms that the subject is forced into a perspective that reflects critically on all of them.

George Hansen articulates the connections between the paranormal and the trickster archetype, showing that most “paranormal” entities, figures, or phenomena display similar liminal, deceptive, boundary-blurring characteristics. Liminality and anti-structure serve as disruptions to ordinary life. They are also the defining characteristics of the trickster, who upsets established methodologies and procedures, and refuses to play by the rules— including, Hansen argues, the rules of western logic. Western logic is crucially built on the law of non-contradiction, in other words, something is either A or -A. Additionally, the law of the excluded middle allows nothing in between. Subject/object, mind/matter, death/life are assumed to be binaries with no liminal space between them. “This kind of logic is thus particularly hostile to blurring of distinctions, but tricksters do just that. They are subversive to Western rationality.”³⁰⁰

Presenting consistently in the excluded middle are paranormal and anomalous phenomena. It is in the areas in between these binary oppositions, Hansen argues, such as Heaven and Earth, life and death, God and human, human and beast, that the paranormal and supernatural manifest. “Angels and UFOs traverse the realm between the heavens and the earth. Spirits, near death experiences, reincarnation, and ghosts call into question the boundary between life and death.”³⁰¹ The paranormal and anomalous in general sit in the space of the in-between; refusing

²⁹⁸ Hansen, *The Trickster*, 46.

²⁹⁹ Babcock-Abrahams, “‘A Tolerated Margin,’” 185.

³⁰⁰ Hansen, *The Trickster*, 62.

³⁰¹ Ibid. 64.

neat categorization or to play by the rules of binary logic. Those who are confronted by such phenomena are jolted out of rigid dualities, or mechanical, cause and effect thinking.

British physicist F. David Peat spent time living among the Blackfoot Indigenous American tribe and describes the clown or trickster figure in Indigenous American cultures. Clowns were known for disrupting sacred ceremonies and making a mockery of them. Sometimes they had exaggerated sexual characteristics and displayed inappropriate sexual gestures. “Indigenous clowns are disturbing in the way that they assault, frighten, even beat people.”³⁰² The clown’s intentional transgressing of boundaries served a specific purpose: to remind those present of the reasons for the boundaries themselves. “The clown makes boundaries explicit by crossing them; demonstrates the meaning of order through disorder. Most important of all, the clown reminds us that in the flux of the world nothing is certain.”³⁰³ The clown’s absurdity and disturbance prompts the audience to reflect on existing social structures and boundaries. In serving this end, the presence of the clown could be disruptive, frightening or traumatic.

But through the disturbance emerges a noble result: Hansen and Babcock-Abraham argue the lessons of the trickster lead to what Victor Turner called *communitas*—a feeling of fellowship that occurs when there is social leveling and subversion of hierarchies.³⁰⁴ The dominant and dominated are disrupted and transcended; those on the margins are brought into equal moral standing and consideration as those who have previously been centered or dominant. The trickster is thus a figure of empowerment, not victimry, and the violating behavior and taboo crossing has an ultimately beneficent purpose: “In contrast to the scapegoat or tragic victim, trickster belongs to the comic modality or marginality where violation is generally the precondition for laughter and *communitas*, and there tends to be an incorporation of the outsider, a levelling of hierarchy, a reversal of statuses.”³⁰⁵

The parallels between the entities encountered in contact and the trickster archetype should immediately stand out to the readers. Like the trickster, the entities employ deception and are not straightforward about their aims. They violate norms of spatiality and temporality, seeming to be situated on the edges of both. They appear halfway between embodied, biological beings and between immortal entities, manifesting distinct characteristics of embodiment and incorporeality. They take on

³⁰² F David Peat, *Blackfoot Physics: A Journey into the Native American Universe* (Boston: Weiser Books, 2005), 83.

³⁰³ Ibid.

³⁰⁴ Victor Turner, *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing Company, 1969), 128; Hansen, *The Trickster*, 57-58.

³⁰⁵ Babcock-Abrahams, “A Tolerated Margin,” 153.

animal characteristics, appearing as owls, raccoons, or deer. They present in sexual ways and sexual encounters are core components of contact and abduction events. Often androgynous, gender is identified by feeling or intuition, not overtly gendered characteristics. They occupy thresholds and liminal spaces, and blur the boundaries between mind and matter, subject and object. Further the ethical orientation that emerges from these experiences reflects *communitas*, a social leveling and centering of persons and experiences from the margins and restoration of non-human life to full consideration in our circle of moral considerability.

My point is not that the entities necessarily literally “are” the trickster, but that the trickster hermeneutic and archetype can help us consider their behavior in a more nuanced and multidimensional way. The language of multidimensionality, especially the transpersonal level, is not the moral language of Kantianism or western ethical philosophy. At this level paradox, non-duality, and symbolism emerge as core communicative tools. Thus, we must draw on hermeneutical resources that have spoken this language for centuries. Through this lens, the deceptive and ostensibly violating characteristics of contact events are not interpreted as straightforward signs of malevolence or ill-intent, but rather reflective of an ancient liberatory archetype. Of equal importance, a core message of the trickster elements of contact events may be prompting us to transcend the binaries that dominate modern representations of reality and knowledge.

In leaving space for ambiguity and disrupting fixed binaries like good and evil, truth and falsehood, or self and Other, the trickster’s antics adumbrate coherence only within a larger relational and interconnected web. Consciousness is thus opened to realities beyond what is considered rational, logical, or traditionally moral. In the deception is the unveiling, a peeling back of layers of hardened thought that have conditioned the filters of possibility through which humans interact with the world. In this lens, the trickster’s absurd or disorienting behavior should not be considered morally violating, but as engendering survival and renewal. This same dynamic lies at the heart of what Anishinaabe (White Earth Nation) scholar Gerald Vizenor calls *survivance*: a practice of narrative resilience and active presence that resists victimry and transforms trauma, irony, and trickery into creative ways for living authentically and meaningfully in the present.

Experiencer Narratives and Indigenous American Survivance

For Indigenous American peoples, European colonialism and genocide led to the suppression of authentic expressions of Indigenous cultures in their aftermath. Gerald Vizenor introduces the concept of *manifest manners*, or the colonial narratives and behaviors that sustain stereotypes of Indigenous Americans and uphold settler dominance. Colonial power masks itself through manifest manners— Indigenous

peoples are represented by the non-Indigenous in museums, movies, or institutions in stereotypical and inauthentic ways. Manifest manners present Indigenous people as passive victims who have been dominated and defeated by the more powerful Europeans, relegated to historical artifacts. “Manifest manners are the course of dominance, the racist notions and misnomers sustained in archives and lexicon as ‘authentic’ representations of *indian* cultures.”³⁰⁶

Vizenor introduces *survance* as the counterforce to manifest manners: a living narrative presence that resists reduction and erasure. A combination of survival and resistance, the term also goes beyond both: it refers to a refusal to disappear, an *active presence* and *ongoing vitality* of Indigenous identities, stories, and worldviews. Refusing to accept the role of victim forced upon them by the colonizing power, *survance* subverts the oppressor/oppressed binary and commits to telling and re-telling stories that generate life rather than memorialize loss. “Survance is an active sense of presence, the continuance of native stories, not a mere ration, or a survivable name. Native *survance* stories are renunciations of dominance, tragedy, and victimry.”³⁰⁷

Trickster hermeneutics play a pivotal role in *survance* narratives, especially as catalysts for subversion, transformation, and liberation; a direct countermeasure to the logic of manifest manners. “Trickster hermeneutics is the interpretation of simulations in the literature of *survance*, the ironies of descent and racialism, transmutation, third gender, and themes of transformation in oral tribal stories and written narratives.”³⁰⁸ Operating through logics that resist colonial dominance, trickster hermeneutics help resist the established hierarchies that have become so deeply ingrained that they appear inevitable. The trickster uses humor, trickery, and deceit to teach an important lesson: the world as we’ve constructed it is not inevitable, and that reality is not what it seems on the surface. The trickster also serves as an important reminder that this knowledge is contained within each of us; and that the subversion in the trickster journey is to transform each individual as much as it is to transform our broken ways of being. Trickster stories thus restore imagination and creativity and blur the boundaries of “reality” as it has been constructed within the parameters of manifest manners. “Tricksters are the translation of creation; the trickster creates the tribe in stories, and pronounces the moment of remembrance as the trace of liberation.”³⁰⁹

³⁰⁶ Gerald Vizenor, *Manifest Manners: Narratives on Post-Indian Survance* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1994), vii.

³⁰⁷ Gerald Vizenor, *Manifest Manners*, vii.

³⁰⁸ *Ibid.*, 15.

³⁰⁹ *Ibid.*

The language of survivance is not the language of western logic, but the language of shadow and symbol. “Shadow words are hermeneutics of survivance.”³¹⁰ “Shadow words” name the indirect, trickster-like language through which Indigenous people interpret and sustain their continued lived presence. The *postindian* embodies this ironic awareness, continually questioning the colonial “names, manners, and stories” that once defined Native identity. In turn, the shadows, reversals, and contradictions within trickster stories have the power to overturn the rigid and moralizing language of colonial authority, the “terminal vernacular of manifest manners.”³¹¹ These shadows represent a dynamic use of language that resists domination, undermines settled truths, and keeps spaces of meaning and identity in negotiation.

Indigenous survivance practices stand as powerful strategies of resistance to colonial power and the status quo. It is a refusal from Indigenous American peoples to disappear or to accept stereotypical colonial narratives about their identities. Further survivance contains a refusal to let naturalism and scientism be the final authorities of truth and meaning or be declared the ultimate arbiters of the real. It is a reclaiming of self-determination and sovereignty in the face of devastation and oppression. It also illustrates the power of narrative, storytelling, and cognitive reframing in shaping how one lives and makes meaning of the most traumatic and challenging of experiences.

The empowered language that experiencers employ in their own reconceptualization of their encounters in their aftermath also illustrates a refusal to surrender to victimry or dominant narratives about UAP threat. Illustrating their own forms of creative meaning-making and transformation, experiencer narratives can be understood as refusing erasure and transforming disorientation into creativity and living presence. They recover and rebuild a sense of agency or autonomy, feeling empowered by the ways the encounter has changed them, and reclaiming an element of choice in what occurred. With a transformed sense of corporeality, consciousness, and ethics, they transmute that which was disruptive or traumatic into a deep and meaningful presence. Their narratives and sense-making emerge within systems that seek to define, contain, or dismiss them: scientific naturalism, psychological reductionism, and our own “manifest manners” of modern epistemic authority. Yet experiencers persist in telling stories that resist those frameworks, recasting their understanding of their encounters in language that challenges our understandings of agency, choice, and selfhood. Their testimony is not only about survival after ontological rupture but about the assertion of presence—a reclaiming of meaning that refuses to be reduced to the role of passive victim in their encounters, even if

³¹⁰ Ibid., 68.

³¹¹ Ibid.

the sense of agency and choice they recover does not resonate with the modern liberal understanding of what a human being is.

Experiencer accounts thus can be considered analogous to survivance: they keep open various possibilities for interpretation, and resist the closure of official discourse that would seek to reduce their experience to straightforward kidnapping and violation (or dismissed as psychosis and confusion). They keep mystery, possibility, and creativity alive and use it to reassert a creative form of subjectivity, a renewed presence.

But this begs the question, in this framing, are the UAP entities the invasive colonizing power, or the trickster who liberates?

In true trickster fashion, the entities in contact events appear to play a dual role, at times taking on the appearance of an invading or oppressive force but simultaneously playing the role of the trickster who violates and disrupts in order to lead the individual on a journey to a deeper and more important truth. Experiencers ultimately emerge empowered, not defeated; transmuted, not reduced. Read through the framing of Matthew Roberts' assertion that "we project our badness" or that the entities reflect the shortcomings of our own ways of behaving back to us, the oppressive, invading characteristics become part of the trickster's message: our current attitudes towards being and ways of relating with human and non-human life are insufficient. In line with this interpretation, experiencers emerge seeking forms of relationality rooted in *communitas*, interconnectedness, and a rejection of exploitative systems and anthropocentric norms.

Conclusion: Breaking Down Binaries

The entities encountered in contact events appear to employ tactics common of trickster figures, leading the experiencer on a subversive and transformative journey into recovering and exploring their multidimensional selves. Perhaps possessing knowledge we do not through their unique situatedness in time and consciousness, their methods may not be easily evaluated through human ethical concepts. It is possible that the only way for some individuals to be open to such a journey is through the secretive and at times deceptive tactics employed by the alleged entities. It is also possible that direct communication about their aims and what they are trying to show us would not have the same results as shocking the individual into a journey that reconfigures everything they thought they knew about themselves and the world. Additionally, they may not be able to communicate the full scope of the purpose of contact in human language or do so without compromising the result. Furthermore, contact engenders abjection and the dissolving of the ego in the presence of the Other, which enables the breaking down of subject and object. From this angle, the ethical worth of the beings' actions are nuanced and morally complex.

Truly grokking the full extent of what contact experiences have to offer, and why contact unfolds the way it does, may require an ethical evaluation that makes room for flux, uncertainty, and moral ambiguity— a moral language that speaks to multiple registers of reality and truth.

It is from this space of the liminal, the in-between, and that which is resistant to binary logical framing that we make room for trickster hermeneutics; for transmotion and liberation, residing somewhere in the abjected, excluded middle. One of those excluded middles is the space in-between the “evil invader” and “benevolent helper” dichotomous framing of the entities. The nuances and complexities of contact cannot be reduced to an oppressive colonizing power nor to enlightened Space Brothers here to save us. The truth as described by experiencers slowly reveals itself as something more complex and powerful: the potential for new ways of conceptualizing ourselves and each other to emerge from ontological spaces from which we have too long collectively closed ourselves off.

One potential reason for this may stem from our avoidance of another excluded middle: the crossroads of science and religion. Within modern western democracies, science and religion are understood to be polar opposites; two fundamentally different ways of knowing and interacting with the world. In the language of Heidegger and Madden, they represent binary attitudes towards being, entirely different cognitive framings that lead to different considerably divergent filters of possibility. Within the academy, science is understood to be a genuine epistemic authority, religion is often dismissed as an imposter or distorter. Even the ancient divergence between *mythos* and *logos* made distinctions between profound and literal truth.

Though I am a phenomenologist, I originally set off to explore the contact phenomenon in purely secular ways. The filters of possibility I initially brought to the table did not allow for any other kind of analysis. In my unpacking of experiencer narratives, however, I consistently saw the lines between the secular and the sacred forcibly blurred. Full witnessing, I am convinced, does not require relegating UAP and contact experiences into the realm of “religious belief” or to dismiss them as “mythic” only, but rather calls us to dissolve the binary opposition between science and the spiritual that so heavily saturates modern ways of knowing, being, and doing. Perhaps multidimensional subjectivity and multidimensional knowing require a way of coming to know and interacting with the world that accepts that to know reality is to know it in ways that transcend the scientific/spiritual divide. To conclude this exploration, in the final chapter I will explore what it might look like to come to know the phenomenon in ways that break down the binary opposition between science and spirituality: to respond to the trickster’s call and cultivate ourselves as multidimensional knowers in a multidimensional lifeworld.

Chapter Eight: Multidimensional Knowing: Intersubjectivity and Epistemologies of Liminality

"I have been searching for answers for almost 30 years now and I have come to believe that the 'scientific' approach does not apply when studying and researching UFOs and related phenomena. We are dealing here with something more profound, something that will change the world." -John E. Mack Collection, Rice University, Anonymous PEER intake form.

"UFOs, in rendering both science and religion uncanny, render our secularity uncanny too." – Hussein Ali-Agrama

"Impossible thinking is not thinking in only three dimensions. That is entirely possible. It is imagining in four, or five, or more." – Jeffrey J. Kripal

Introduction

Through examining the lived experience of contact, I have attempted to bring experiences that are radically Other and rarely taken seriously into focus. However, bringing aspects of the experience into clarity inevitably leads to the blurring of other portions. In 1994, John E. Mack stated that the alien abduction phenomenon requires an entirely new paradigm for understanding reality. To create such a paradigm, we may need to cultivate different epistemic virtues, new ideals for what it means to be a knower and how to relate to the known. Continuing to build on the *implications of applying experienter insights*, I close this exploration with a discussion of how we could cultivate ourselves as multidimensional knowers in relation to a multidimensional world– the type of epistemology that contact and its trickster characteristics demands.

To begin, I argue that multidimensional knowing requires moving beyond the science versus religion binary and cultivating epistemologies that blend the secular with the spiritual, that are comfortable sitting in the excluded middle. By exploring the ways that UAP and contact experiences repeatedly blur the distinctions we try to draw between religion and science, I show that any attempt to know them as purely scientific or purely religious phenomena excludes too much from the table. Being comfortable with the space in between brings us in natural proximity with Indigenous American epistemologies, which have long held that to know the world is to know it in inherently spiritual ways. Drawing on the work of Muscogee (Creek) Nation scholar Daniel Wildcat, I show how dissolving the fact versus value binary allows a form of knowing from a liminal space, and more holistically engages the physical, psychical, spiritual and moral dimensions of contact at once.

In order to cultivate such epistemologies, we must understand how our conception of what it means to know something is interwoven with our

understanding of what it means to be a subject or self. Lorraine Daston and Peter Galison explore the concept of “objectivity” in the history of science, illustrating that this concept is historically situated and emerged alongside an ethical mandate to cultivate a particular type of self: a scientific self who removed any traces of their subjectivity from the knowing experience.³¹² Objectivity as an epistemic ideal cannot be divorced from the type of self that is required to produce it. But perhaps knowing contact experiences, or, rather, opening oneself up to contact as a source of knowledge, requires a different type of self—as our exploration suggests, a multidimensional one.

Ultimately, I argue that the contact phenomenon prompts us to reflect on our methods of knowing and invites us to broaden our scope of inquiry, focusing on unpacking the realm of the intersubjective—in all its variations—rather than the objective. But even our understanding of the intersubjective must evolve from its origins in phenomenology, for many aspects of contact events are experienced differently by different witnesses. Intersubjectivity becomes forms of shared experiencing, validation, and creation of meaning: co-creating and interpreting contact events together even when they do not completely cohere or correspond in how they are initially lived and witnessed. Building on the work of John E. Mack and Jeffrey J. Kripal, I propose a form of multidimensional, intersubjective knowing that enables exploration of liminal spaces.

I take the argument one step further: perhaps engaging the contact phenomenon itself may open possibilities for new forms of knowledge, though doing so would require an expansion of our epistemological methods. Such engagement entails a willingness to suspend prior assumptions, to inhabit the interpretive frameworks through which the phenomenon presents itself, and to participate rather than merely observe. This requires willingness to speak its language, to play the game, to follow its rules. This marks a shift from belief to participation, from the detached scientific self to what I have described as the multidimensional self. If this shift is possible, the contact experience may disclose us not as passive receivers of information but as participants in the co-creation of knowledge—physical, mental, spiritual, and moral—capable of fundamentally reshaping our ways of being human.

A Scientific or Religious Phenomenon?

As we have seen in our phenomenological exploration, contact experiences often contain spiritual or religious valence. The question of whether the UFO/UAP phenomenon should be considered a scientific matter or a religious one has haunted

³¹² Lorraine Daston and Peter Galison, *Objectivity* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2007).

UFO discourse since the western origins of ufology and the “Space Brothers” of the 1950s. I will argue that the answer lies somewhere in between. One of the most thorough and academically rigorous analyses of this conflict within the ufology community is explored by Brenda Denzler in her 2001 book *The Lure of the Edge*. The religious or spiritual valence of many experiences could not be denied, but came into conflict with desires to study the phenomenon more objectively or scientifically. During the 1990s, the height of abduction and “high strangeness” cases, a division emerged not only between ufologists who took abduction testimony seriously versus those that did not, but also a division within those who thought abduction testimony was genuine but were critical of how it was being approached. Some advocated for renewed commitment to scientific rigor within the study of UFOs/UAP and a rejection of religious, esoteric, or ostensibly “New Age” elements. But such a call did not emerge without various forms of pushback.

The difficulty of the search for an appropriate scientific methodology was compounded by the postmodern spirit of the late twentieth century, which questioned all knowledge claims, including those made by science. Even the notion of rationality itself—that cornerstone of scientific thinking—came under critical scrutiny.³¹³

In addition to the pushback against modern forms of knowledge production in general, Denzler identifies a more glaring problem: “ufology appeared to have entered into a ‘post-secular’ stage.”³¹⁴ The very nature of contact experiences, which contain alleged communication with non-human intelligences of higher evolutionary status and put experiencers in touch with their multidimensionality was a “natural magnet for ‘god-talk.’”³¹⁵ This so-called “god talk” came from experiencers of various religious backgrounds— or no background.

Of particular relevance, Denzler details the “Star Knowledge” conference of 1996 in Yankton South Dakota, in which Indigenous American groups, including most prominently Standing Elk, a Lakota Sioux elder, conveyed their traditional knowledge of the “Star People.” Standing Elk explained that knowledge of the existence of the Star People and their way of life was meant to reflect back to humanity possibilities for how our own lives and interactions could be different.³¹⁶ Very interestingly, featured speakers at the conference also included non-natives such as John Mack, Whitley Strieber, Steven Greer, and Richard Boylan.

³¹³ Brenda Denzler, *The Lure of the Edge: Scientific Passions, Religious Beliefs, and the Pursuit of UFOs* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2001), 142.

³¹⁴ Ibid.

³¹⁵ Ibid.

³¹⁶ Ibid., 145.

With the blending of abduction-inspired god-talk and Amerindian religious traditions, the alien abduction movement brought ufology to its closest encounter yet with religion. But the nature of that religion was highly eclectic, idiosyncratic, and still generally amorphous.³¹⁷

Denzler concludes her book by suggesting there are many ways that ufology *cannot* be considered a traditional religious movement—it does not coalesce around select charismatic figures nor stem from religious authority or scripture. Nor does it map neatly onto any traditional theological framework, even when considering abductees who have transferred Christian themes into a modern technological context. At the same time, Denzler emphasizes that many close encounters have a “religious valence” to them, even when not expressed in overtly religious terms. All the while, classical ufology remained rooted in scientific concepts and methods.³¹⁸

The religious undertones, and sometimes more explicit overtones, of contact encounters are discussed more recently in the work of religion scholar Diana Walsh Pasulka. In *American Cosmic*, Pasulka argues that “belief in extraterrestrials and UFOs constitutes a new form of religion.”³¹⁹ A distinct UFO *mythos*, or mythical understanding of reality has been delivered to mass audiences through popular culture and various forms of media. While some have formed new religious beliefs distinctly around close encounters and contact events, others, she argues, reinterpret their own religious hermeneutics to accommodate the idea of UAP and extraterrestrials.³²⁰ Mysterious luminous objects within religious imagery are interpreted as UFOs/UAP, and Biblical stories such as Ezekiel’s chariot in the sky are conceived as connected to the modern UFO and their non-human occupants. Pasulka’s ethnographic approach involves personally getting to know several scientists and researchers who were profoundly influenced by their own close encounter experiences, as well as trips to purported UAP crash sites and the Vatican.

Phenomenologically, Pasulka suspends judgment on the physical reality of the UAP occupants but argues that “perceived contact has very real effects with powerful social implications.”³²¹ Additionally the recovery of artifacts of unknown origin, that were scientifically determined not to have been constructed within the known universe, take on an element of sacredness. This again puts UAP in proximity with religions, Pasulka explains, as they contain a sacred element that is not easily defined nor studied empirically. The rationally minded scientists she accompanies themselves see something profoundly sacred about UAP, pointing them towards

³¹⁷ Ibid., 147

³¹⁸ Ibid., 157.

³¹⁹ Diana Walsh Pasulka, *American Cosmic: UFOs, Religion, Technology* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2019), 216.

³²⁰ Ibid.

³²¹ Ibid.

that which transcends the parameters of the physical world.³²² UAP and contact experiences continue to straddle the excluded middle.

However, the growing acceptance of UAP and their alleged occupants remains in part rooted in empirical, scientific evidence. Thus, anthropologist Hussein Ali Agrama argues modern ufology should not be considered a set of religious *beliefs*, but rather, a *new paradigm of religiosity*.³²³ Agrama emphasizes the historical contingency of western scientific rationalism and its strict separation of knowledge and value. The age of secularism reduced the religious to the realm of the unknowable and the mysterious “making it largely irrelevant to the truths of science and our growing technology.”³²⁴ However Agrama simultaneously rejects presentism, acknowledging that the strict separation of religion from knowledge does not represent the final say any more than the forms of rationality that pervaded other historical epochs. “[W]e currently live in a secular age, and just like ages past, it too will pass away, and be replaced by another.”³²⁵ That which surpasses the secular age will appear, from the perspective of our current ways of thinking, *uncanny* or extremely strange and unfamiliar. The UAP in particular:

[C]hallenges our secularity, rendering it uncanny through a profound transformation of our knowledge-making practices—not just in our objects of knowledge and the connections between them, but also in the ways that knowledge itself is produced and acquired. In other words, UFOs, in rendering both science and religion uncanny, render our secularity uncanny too.³²⁶

The study of UAP repeatedly intersects with other anomalous and “impossible” phenomena, showing “affinities and unexpected resonances with past knowledges once dismissed or forgotten”³²⁷ which Agrama refers to as “uncanny science.” Our technological attitude towards being has grounded us firmly in a secular sense of truth rooted in the sciences, and has also, Agrama argues, delineated the domains for the expression of human choice and agency. For this reason, the technological aspect of UAP poses a particular challenge to our age of secularity. Technology is supposed to be a realm where human beings still have a special place, so the possibility that non-human beings have their own technologies that transcend ours challenges anthropocentric humanism and the rooting of all “truth” in the affairs of

³²²Ibid., 242.

³²³ Hussein Ali Agrama, “Secularity, Synchronicity, and Uncanny Science: Considerations and Challenges,” *Zygon* 56.2 (2020): 398.

³²⁴ Ibid., 398.

³²⁵ Ibid., 399.

³²⁶ Ibid., 400.

³²⁷ Ibid., 401.

humans.³²⁸ Further, the technological characteristics of UAP make it impossible to fit them neatly in either a “scientific” or “religious” box. Despite the religious and spiritual valence of many contact experiences, the scientific verification of the physical objects prevents them from being relegated to the realm of “belief.”

An example of this tension is illustrated in *American Cosmic*, with Pasulka’s interaction with Tyler, a NASA engineer. Pasulka accompanies him to the Vatican to study the private archives on levitating and bilocating saints. The idea behind the visit was that the same powers that seemed to operate in the non-ordinary experiences of these holy figures were also at work in what Tyler had observed in his study of UAP.

What do saints and psychics have to do with aerospace engines? The strain in imagining how these might mesh is yet another indication of how we still live in a secular age. But it also shows how the UFO phenomenon seems to dislocate and even undo the differences between scientific and religious knowledges so crucial to our secular understandings.³²⁹

Agrama suggests that taking UFOs/UAP seriously requires an entirely new discursive practice, one that challenges not only what kind of objects we study, but also expands our modes of inquiry to potentially include “bodily practices that open up unexplored spaces of perception and enable a distinctly different orientation to knowing the world.”³³⁰ Such a shift requires exiting the positionality of *believer* and entering the positionality of *participant*. The scientists in Pasulka’s work do not just accept or reject propositions about contact, but have developed bodily techniques and protocols they believe allow them to perceive and connect with the UAP entities, often appearing through meaningful synchronicities that help advance their technological knowledge. Agrama states that such synchronicities shift the participants into “new ways of thinking, seeing, and living.”³³¹ If it seems too implausible to us that these scientists are actually communicating with a non-human Other, he writes, then these experiences highlight the anthropocentrism inherent in our conceptions of the plausible and implausible: “But what sort of world might disclose itself to us if these limits—perhaps suddenly—fell away?”³³²

As we saw in Chapters Two through Four, contact experiences often are accompanied by some kind of religious valence or spiritual component.

³²⁸ Michael E. Zimmerman describes the threat to anthropocentric humanism as one of the main reasons that discussion of contact events, especially abduction encounters, remains academically forbidden. See “The ‘Alien Abduction’ Phenomenon: Forbidden Knowledge of Hidden Events.” *Philosophy Today* 41.2 (1997): 235-254.

³²⁹ Agrama, “Secularity,” 408.

³³⁰ *Ibid.*, 410

³³¹ *Ibid.*, 411.

³³² *Ibid.*

Consciousness separates from the body, experiencers feel profound interconnection with all that is, and the non-human entities are sometimes interpreted as mediators between the corporeal human and the divine ultimate source. Similarly, the multidimensional ethic I presented in Chapters Five and Six straddles the boundary of religious and secular ethics. On the secular side, it is rooted in a conception of the human that has experiential grounding in the lived experience of contact. It is rooted in rational principles that reflect the type of self that contact unearths: a self that is simultaneously corporeal and capable of experiences beyond the body. It does not flow from religious scripture, religious authority, or any particular faith tradition; nor can it be reduced to a set of rules grounded in religious belief. However, on the religious side, it incorporates a sense of an eternal “higher” self that stretches into dimensions beyond the physical and cannot be scientifically measured or proven; as well as a conviction that consciousness survives death and is not reducible to a body. Simultaneously that conviction is inspired by direct experience and participation, not belief in religious tenets. It is a liminal ethic, born of the space in-between.

The solution to the problem of whether UAP are a religious or scientific phenomenon is not to relegate UAP and contact events into the realm of “belief” that so often accompanies the dichotomous, binary understandings of reality that dominate our modern technological attitudes towards being. Nor is the answer to focus on the scientific elements alone, reducing UAP and contact to the study of physical, technological craft. The trickster elements of contact experiences are pointing us beyond binary thinking: most prominently beyond the binary of the scientific and the religious—transcending, in Agrama’s language, our age of secularity.

Epistemologies of Liminality: Daniel Wildcat

The trickster reminds us to explore places in-between: spaces of flux, change, and uncertainty. Binary epistemologies that strictly separate the religious from the scientific may be insufficient not only for studying contact experiences and UAP but also for knowing the world in general. Perhaps what is needed are ways of knowing that are distinctly *liminal*: knowledge that arises through thresholds, transitions, and states that are not definitely one thing or another, but somewhere in-between. Liminal knowing would be relational and processual rather than static, always in flux and becoming. It would demand not belief in the existence of UAP or non-human entities, but participation in a multidimensional post-anthropocentric field. In epistemologies of liminality, the knower would be transformed through the very act of knowing — knowledge becomes not merely a passive receipt of information, but ontologically participatory. We see modalities of liminal knowing reflected in Indigenous American epistemologies of coordination, in which the world is known

through connections and kinship relationships that are always in flux. Simultaneously they are both natural and spiritual, sitting comfortably in an in-between space.

In “The Schizophrenic Nature of Western Metaphysics,”³³³ Haskell Indian Nations University professor and member of the Muscogee (Creek) Nation Daniel Wildcat argues that the fundamental difference between metaphysics as it is understood in western societies versus Indigenous American ones is that Indigenous Americans do not posit a duality between facts and values. The indigenous people of North America consequently do not see themselves as having a “religion,” because their spirituality is infused in their entire understanding of what reality is and how they relate to their tribal land. To know things is to know them in inherently spiritual ways. Thus, all knowledge is spiritual or religious knowledge; there is no division between the secular and the sacred to be overcome.³³⁴

Emphasized by Wildcat and his co-author Vine Deloria, Jr. (Standing Rock Sioux) is that Indigenous American knowledges focus on the particular rather than the universal and are always embedded in a physical context in connection with tribal land. To know something is to become experientially familiar with it; to understand its personality and spirit, and to understand how it relates to and connects with other beings. Religious experiences do not happen in a “transcendent elsewhere,” but occur within the natural world of lived experience.

The distinction between an indigenous metaphysics of human beings in the world versus a Western metaphysics of the world is crucial. The latter requires a level of abstraction beyond human experience, while the former requires abstract concept formation in the service of experience.³³⁵

Wildcat argues that Indigenous metaphysics does not seek an abstract understanding of “reality” that is removed from human experience, rather it seeks to formulate concepts that will help explain and connect more deeply to that which appears in experience. Thus, in Indigenous American communities, there is no dichotomy posited between facts and beliefs. Beliefs are most fundamentally about what is known and understood—derived from participatory lived experience in a particular place.

³³³ Wildcat’s use of “schizophrenic” follows a longstanding philosophical metaphor for structural contradiction. Given the history of using stigmatizing psychiatric language in academic discourse, I avoid such terminology elsewhere in this book when referring to conceptual fragmentation or contradiction.

³³⁴ Daniel Wildcat, “The Schizophrenic Nature of Western Metaphysics,” in Daniel Wildcat and Vine Deloria, *Power and Place Equals Personality: Indian Education in America* (Golden, CO: Fulcrum Books, 2001).

³³⁵ *Ibid.*, 47-48.

This intimate interaction with tribal land does not reveal a mechanical, cause and effect universe, nor a natural world that operates like a logical machine. Rather, nature is filled with animate connections and relationships, which respond and relate to each other in personal, meaning-filled ways.

An American Indian metaphysics has the advantage of designating science and religion not as mutually exclusive realms of experience or areas of human interest, but as fundamental questions of knowledge and understanding found on a “continuum of experience.”³³⁶

Understanding their connections with the natural world, including spiritual and moral connections, was a fundamental component of gaining knowledge. Deloria comments that for Indigenous Americans, all relationships have moral content, including our relationship to grass, water, trees, and mountains. To know something naturally entails understanding your obligations and responsibilities to a being.³³⁷ Thus there is no way for an individual knower not to be transformed through the process of gaining knowledge: to encounter the truth is to participate in it, to reconfigure your relationships and ways of being. When lived experience reveals a world that is dynamic, interconnected, and conscious, this experience has an effect on one’s behavior and relationships. Metaphysics, then, is not an abstract logical exercise about substance and its attributes that leads to the acceptance or rejection of propositions, but a holistic understanding that serves as a foundation for participating in a lifeworld.³³⁸

Wildcat shows that in Indigenous American communities, to truly know reality is to know it in all its manifestations. Such manifestations do not split nature from spirit, are in flux rather than static, and result in transformation of the relationality of the knower. They are epistemologies of liminality. In such a framework, we are not forced to decide whether UAP and contact experiences are *either* a scientific *or* a spiritual phenomenon: they are both at once and that poses no inherent conflict.

To understand how Indigenous American epistemologies of liminality may be able to inform our study of UAP and contact experiences, we must first ask what kind of self we must create to move beyond our current dominant knowledge practices. How do our current ways of knowing require the creation of a particular type of self? And in turn, what type of self would epistemologies of liminality require?

³³⁶ Ibid., 49.

³³⁷ Vine Deloria, “Power and Place Equals Personality,” in Daniel Wildcat and Vine Deloria, *Power and Place Equals Personality: Indian Education in America* (Golden, CO: Fulcrum Books, 2001), 21-28.

³³⁸ Wildcat, “Schizophrenic,” 49.

What Does it Mean to Be a Knower?

Michel Foucault and Practices of the Self

When we ask the question of what it means to gain knowledge through contact, we must interrogate our conceptions of knowledge and what it means to know something. The philosopher Michel Foucault famously studied the historical production of human knowledge and how our evolving conceptions of knowledge create possibilities for being a certain kind of self. What we consider knowledge to be, and our practices for acquiring it, are always intricately interwoven with what it means to be a subject or self. To be a self is to be a knower, and to implicate ourselves in methods for the production and acquisition of knowledge.

In his lecture series *The Hermeneutics of the Subject*,³³⁹ Foucault examines the philosophical attitude of “care of self” and its various expressions in Hellenistic, Greek, and early Christian cultures. Foucault refers to this philosophical attitude not only as an intellectual enterprise but as a set of *practices*. Care of self was a guiding principle that served as a rationale for a range of tests, meditative practices, and *actions* through which one could attain knowledge of self and world. Foucault posits that the ancient Greek proposition to “know thyself” (*gnōthi seauton*) was only possible in conjunction with “care of self” (*epimeleia heauton*). The Greek mandate to care for oneself played an equally important role in how the Greeks understood the path to truth, as caring for oneself was the “justificatory framework, ground, and foundation for the imperative ‘know yourself.’”³⁴⁰ The era guided by the principle of “care of self” included a sense of spirituality that we have lost today in our era of secularity and the perceived separation of knowledge from the spiritual. Spirituality, Foucault says, referred to the:

[S]earch, practice, and experience through which the subject carries out the necessary transformations on himself in order to access the truth...[Spirituality] postulates that the truth is not given to the subject by a simple act of knowledge (*connaissance*)...It postulates that for the subject to have right of access to the truth he must be changed, transformed, shifted, and become, to some extent and up to a certain point, other than himself.³⁴¹

The acquisition of knowledge was an active process; the individual must transform and become different in order to be capable of receiving the truth. For example, the Epicureans prepared for life’s possible events by knowing the principles that govern the world, the nature of the gods, the laws of nature, and the causes of life and death. These beliefs were accompanied by discourses about humans’ place in the natural

³³⁹ Michel Foucault, *The Hermeneutics of the Subject: Lectures at the Collège de France 1981-1982*, translated by Graham Burchell (New York: Picador, 2005).

³⁴⁰ Foucault, *Hermeneutics*, 8.

³⁴¹ *Ibid.*, 15.

order of the world. These discourses were meant to be available to subjects when they needed them and were appropriated through various methods: memory, listening, reading, writing, and mental retention exercises.³⁴² These discourses were not passively received; it was understood one must actively participate in their co-creation. Knowledge could not be passed from one individual to another like an item; to know was to transcend the boundaries of self, to become “other”, to expand the boundaries of the “me.” These were epistemologies of liminality, resulting in transformations of the knower.

After Descartes separated the mind from body and the knower from the known, access to the truth became possible through the autonomous development of knowledge as *connaissance*, and no longer required preparing or transforming oneself in order to receive the truth.³⁴³ Thus, while Foucault expresses admiration for care of self and the role it played in ancient forms of subjectivity, the requirement to change oneself in order to be capable of knowing is not a part of our modern attitudes towards being. Neither Foucault, nor I, believe that we can or should attempt to completely return to the practices of the Greeks – we cannot recover a lost historical epoch to meet our present moment. What I wish to emphasize is that modern knowledge practices have become linked to a very different kind of self, one that attempts to separate the knower from the known and demands the creation of a “scientific self.” After the Cartesian split, the epistemic ideal of objectivity that emerged in the 19th century brought with it a set of practices of the self far removed from the ancient philosophical way of life and the corresponding self it cultivated. Gone were the liminal, transformational dimensions of knowledge, replaced with a demand for the suppression of subjectivity.

Objectivity and the Scientific Self

In *Objectivity*, Lorraine Daston and Peter Galison explain the historical emergence of the epistemic ideal of objectivity, tracing the dominance of the concept through images in scientific atlases. While the term “objectivity” went through its own metamorphosis, it was always paired and understood as the opposite of subjectivity. In 19th century philosophical and scientific discourse, objectivity came to be understood as the countering of the subjective; that which was untainted by the judgments and expressions of the self. “[O]bjectivity is the suppression of some aspect of the self, the countering of subjectivity.”³⁴⁴ The subject’s will came to be understood as a danger to the production of knowledge, something that must be

³⁴² Ibid., 500.

³⁴³ Ibid., 24.

³⁴⁴ Daston and Galison, *Objectivity*, 36.

stifled and eliminated so the “objective” truth could emerge— a truth free from the contamination of the subject.³⁴⁵

Objectivity has not always been the reigning standard: Daston and Galison argue that objectivity emerged as an epistemic ideal in between the historical ideals of truth to nature, which preceded it, and trained judgment, which followed it. In the epoch of truth to nature, the images in scientific atlases were meant to represent perfected images of those observed in nature, to bring out the essence of the natural object. In this epoch, the scientist’s altering of the images was seen as their professional duty; to see the truth beyond any one individual instantiation of the natural being. This means that the corresponding scientific self was one who was active; they engaged in “observing and interpreting nature, monitoring and correcting the artist.”³⁴⁶ The scientist’s expertise and judgment was understood as necessary to see the essential truth of the object behind its individual appearances.

Mechanical objectivity emerged in the 19th century as the guiding ideal for scientific representation of nature, alongside the emergence of photographs and machination. Unlike truth to nature, mechanical objectivity aimed to remove any interference from the investigator, and present natural objects *exactly* as they appeared in all their imperfections. The will and reason of the researcher emerged as a threat to the truth rather than an aid in determining it. “Instead of freedom of will, machines offered freedom from will—from the willful interventions that had come to be seen as the most dangerous aspects of subjectivity.”³⁴⁷ The goal became to remove individual judgment from the equation entirely, even if that meant the images were less accurate—a murky photograph was still viewed as superior to a more detailed drawing because it preserved the image without any human intervention.³⁴⁸

The scientific self that objectivity demanded was also built through a set of practices or techniques of the self, but very different from those Foucault identifies as operating in ancient Greece:

[The scientific self] was realized and reinforced by specialized techniques of the self: the keeping of a lab notebook with real time entries, the discipline of grid-guided drawing, the artificial division of the self into active experimenter and passive observer, the introspective sorting of one’s own sensations into objective and subjective by sensory physiologists, the training of voluntary attention.³⁴⁹

³⁴⁵ Ibid., 37.

³⁴⁶ Ibid., 95.

³⁴⁷ Ibid. 123.

³⁴⁸ Ibid., 172.

³⁴⁹ Ibid., 38

The intention of these practices was to minimize the impact of the scientist's will on the data and representation of the world. The goal was to *remove the self* from the knowledge process rather than to know them both at once. "Epistemic virtues in science are preached and practiced in order to know the world, not the self."³⁵⁰

Daston and Galison argue that every epistemology so far is interwoven with an *ethos* that governs the connection between the knower and the known. The ideal of objectivity was connected to an ethical mandate to be a certain kind of self, a certain kind of scientist. Through the ethically mandated practices of the scientific self, objectivity emerged as a distinct *practice* inseparable from the production of truth. "It is by performing certain actions over and over again—not only bodily manipulations but also spiritual exercises—that objectivity comes into being."³⁵¹ The idea that objectivity is somehow removed from human will and values overlooks the fact that objectivity itself *is a set of values*, linked to an ideal of what it means to be a knower and relate to the known. As a set of values, it is up to us to see how useful and beneficial it actually is, and whether or not it produces the type of knowledge and type of selves that we want to be.³⁵²

Eventually, Daston and Galison illustrate that objectivity was put into competition with the epistemic ideal of trained judgment. Trained judgment introduced the need for a reader or interpreter of images, which was different from the reasoned or perfected image of the days of truth to nature. Rather than embellishing or exaggerating certain features to emphasize what the scientist saw as essential to the natural object, trained judgment relies on human judgment to interpret the photograph or mechanically produced image, rather than letting it stand entirely on its own.

Scientists, whether they were analyzing stellar spectra, x-rayed skulls, or cloud chamber images had no faith that pictures could be sorted automatically: the edict of mechanical objectivity to abstain from all interpretation turned out to be sterile.³⁵³

While the ideal of mechanical objectivity ultimately proved impossible and not entirely useful, the *residue* of objectivity lives on. The idea that the knower should, to the extent possible, remove themselves from the equation in the knowledge process is a part of modern scientific epistemology. This is, in part, what drives the removal or dismissal of eyewitness testimony from the formal study of UAP—the witness is often seen as a threat to the knowledge process and an unreliable imposition on the truth, which is better revealed through mechanical instruments.

³⁵⁰ Ibid., 39.

³⁵¹ Ibid., 52.

³⁵² Ibid., 53.

³⁵³ Ibid. 344.

What would an epistemic ideal look like that is capable of holistically examining the full scope of the lived experience of contact? Without appropriating Indigenous knowledges or attempting to resurrect the Greek past, how might we cultivate a liminal, transformative epistemology—one rooted in participation, attuned to thresholds, responsive to flux, and aware that the act of knowing changes the knower irreversibly? To seek understanding of contact experiences and UAP is to step into a process of transformation, for both those who have the experience and those who seek to understand such experiences. I suggest that such an epistemology be grounded in a renewed conception of inherently participatory *intersubjectivity*—however one that is attuned to the liminal, paradoxical, and disruptive nature of contact.

John E. Mack's 1997-1999 Multi-Witness Study

The importance of the intersubjective, and the transformations this concept must undergo, are illustrated in a multi-witness project initiated by Mack in 1997. Importantly, this study revealed that contact is often not experienced as a stable or consistent phenomenon, even from witnesses of the same event. Alongside the Program for Extraordinary Experience Research (PEER), Mack submitted a bold proposal to the National Institute for Discovery Science (NIDS). In their “Multiple Witness Pilot Project” Mack and co-investigator Roberta Colasanti sought to ground the alien abduction phenomenon firmly in consensus reality through an investigation of “perceptions which are shared and which are independently verifiable by different members of a community.”³⁵⁴ Our society, they argue, has traditionally looked to these kinds of observations to provide us with “a kind of objective truth.”³⁵⁵ By using the PEER network to identify abduction cases with more than one witness, and through interviewing different kinds of witnesses, such as secondary witnesses, tertiary witnesses, character witnesses, and effects witnesses, the proposal aimed to “establish the consistency and the validity of these extraordinary alien experiences.”³⁵⁶ In their summary, they authoritatively state their primary aim: “*we expect to provide evidence for the objective reality of the alien abduction phenomenon.*”³⁵⁷

Almost 30 years later, it is evident the study did not succeed in this intended aim, as the objective reality of the abduction phenomenon remains an open question. Of even more notable interest, the final project summary submitted to NIDS two years later openly acknowledges that their findings failed to produce the type of

³⁵⁴ John E. Mack and Roberta Colasanti, “Multiple Witness Pilot Project,” 1, *The John E. Mack Collection*, Woodson Research Center, Rice University, accessed August 1–9, 2025, with permission from the donor.

³⁵⁵ Ibid.

³⁵⁶ Ibid., 2.

³⁵⁷ Ibid., 8.

objective verification for which they had originally aimed.³⁵⁸ From hundreds of cases through four phases of research, they narrowed down to focus on the five strongest cases. Among these five, only *one* produced a result in which the primary and secondary witnesses both gave similar accounts that aligned pre-regression and during a regressive hypnotic session.

One might conclude, simplistically, that the project failed and that the abduction phenomenon has no objective reality. Yet such a conclusion misses the deeper insight revealed by the study: the limits of the epistemological ideals around which it was structured. The research succeeded in a different register. Across all five cases, witnesses reported experiences anchored in some shared perceptions—an *intersubjective*, rather than purely subjective, field of experience. This suggests the phenomenon is not reducible to hallucination nor individual pathology. At the same time, these experiences did not cross the threshold into full objectivity, into the domain of stable, replicable, and publicly verifiable events. The encounters remain suspended in a liminal zone—shared and interpersonal, yet indeterminate.

Husserl argued that the world discloses itself through the perspectives of others. My friend across the room perceives what I cannot; together our perceptions form a more complete sense of the world we inhabit. In encountering the Other, we recognize both the relativity and the partiality of our own vision. Intersubjectivity thus grounds the very possibility of a shared world: a field of overlapping intentions, where multiple consciousnesses verify and complete one another's experience.³⁵⁹ Crucially, it is through *shared observations*, or complementary, corroborative accounts of the same phenomena that we come to some understanding of a shared world; a world that transcends our own experience of it and it is rooted in the experiences of others.

Yet contact experiences inevitably strain these parameters. They occupy a space where perception is shared but never fully aligns—where multiple witnesses may encounter the same event but report fundamentally different phenomenological content. For example, in the Multi-Witness study Case 6, both the primary and secondary witness remembered extremely similar accounts prior to hypnotic regression, with two young women reporting the same experience of waking up

³⁵⁸ John E. Mack and Roberta Colasanti, "Comparative Narrative Reports of Multiply Witnessed Anomalous Experiences, Commonly Called 'Alien Abduction': A Pilot Study, Phase IV: Comparative Analysis and Review," 62–63, *The John E. Mack Collection*, Woodson Research Center, Rice University, accessed August 1–9, 2025, with permission from the donor.

³⁵⁹ See Edmund Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations: An Introduction to Phenomenology*, trans. Dorian Cairns (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff Publishers, 1982). For example, Husserl says, "If, with my understanding of someone else, I penetrate more deeply into him, into his horizon of ownness, I shall soon run into the fact that, just as his animate bodily organism lies in my field of perception, so my animate organism lies in his field of perception and that, in general, he experiences me forthwith as an Other for him, just as I experience him as my Other," (129–130).

thinking it was Saturday and attempting to go shopping in town, only to find all the stores closed because it was actually Sunday. Somehow they had both lost an *entire day* of time. On Friday night when they were falling asleep, the primary witness remembered seeing a figure at the end of her bed, while the secondary witness remembered seeing “a whisper of white” coming down as she fell asleep. Strikingly, when both witnesses were regressed by Mack to attempt to remember what happened during the missing day, the primary witness recalled a full abduction account involving entities and hybrid children. The secondary witness, however, who underwent regression, recovered *no additional information* from her hypnotic regression and could only remember having a gap of missing time between falling asleep on Friday night and realizing it was Sunday afternoon.³⁶⁰

The strongest case that Mack could find involved a male and female couple who both witnessed a strange, egg-shaped light hovering over the lake outside their cabin for over five minutes while vacationing in Maine. Both had a delayed recall of the light, with a gap of time in the morning in which neither recalled what they had seen, then both spontaneously remembered the sighting later the next day. Under regression, there were several points of corroboration in their regressed accounts, although also several points of significant divergence. For example, both described finding themselves in a tunnel made of light or energy and encountering entities within it, and both describe memories of medical procedures, including reproductive procedures that seemed to involve removal of ova or semen. However, the male, primary witness remembered seeing human-like figures, and the feeling of being on a ship, while the secondary witness reported no human-like figures, only “light beings” and “apparitions.” Additionally, in terms of their waking-state, prior to regression recall, the primary witness remembered black helicopters flying over the lake after the light departed, while the secondary witness did not.³⁶¹ This is a case with remarkable points of corroboration throughout, but even this *very strongest case* in Mack’s hundreds of files has significant points of divergence between the witness observations. There are distinct moments of *intersubjective verification* that bring the experience out of the realm of the purely subjective and into the realm of the *shared*, but simultaneous moments of *disjunctive intersubjectivity* in which the witness accounts do not align. The account does not reach the level in which the events that occurred can somehow be lifted or separated from the conscious experience of individuals who report them. While there are always discrepancies in eyewitness testimony, such divergences appear to be magnified in contact events.

³⁶⁰John Mack and Roberta Colasanti, “Phase III: Review of Selected Five Cases,” pp. 45-50. *John E. Mack Collection Multi-Witness Study*, Rice University Woodson Archive, accessed with permission from the donor August 1-9, 2025.

³⁶¹ Mack and Colasanti, “Phase III: Review of Selected Five Cases,” pp. 59-72.

These disparate experiences of the same event require a reconfigured sense of intersubjectivity that goes beyond the parameters originally introduced by Husserl and recognizes that UAP and contact experiences are *often not experienced as one stable or consistent thing*. This does not mean that there are not points of corroboration or sightings/experiences witnessed by multiple people; there often are. However, eyewitness accounts often have significant points of *divergence*, where the experience no longer aligns, even when *both witnesses report something anomalous*. I myself have experienced multiple instances of disjunctive intersubjectivity. In the most poignant episode, my close friend (who is a bit of a UAP skeptic) and I decided to try a human initiated contact meditation, putting out a conscious intention that we would like to be in contact with any advanced non-human intelligences in the area. A white orb of light appeared above us, which I was able to see and film on my phone camera. However, my skeptical friend not only witnessed the orb, but observed it performing feats and behaviors that I could not see. He seemed mesmerized as he described it “lighting up the whole sky,” “breaking into two” and “shooting down beams.” I did not witness it doing any of those things, although it clearly was differentiated from the other objects in the night sky.

What do we do, then, with a phenomenon that challenges the parameters of intersubjectivity as phenomenologists originally conceived of them? And challenges the parameters of shared human experience of the universe? What is needed is a reconfigured intersubjectivity—one capable of accommodating liminality itself. Such an intersubjectivity would not demand perfect congruence of perception but would allow knowledge to emerge from the thresholds and transformative spaces where realities touch without fully aligning. Contact invites precisely this reconfiguration: an epistemology rooted not in fixed objectivity, but in the mutable and intersubjective crossings through which the world—and the self—are continually remade.

Multidimensional Intersubjectivity

By multidimensional intersubjectivity, I mean an epistemic orientation towards knowledge production that arises not from detached observation or suppression of subjectivity, but from participatory, collaborative, cross-modal processes of witnessing, empathy, and shared meaning-making that operate across multiple registers of reality. Such an orientation produces knowledge that sits in between the liminal space of what we now refer to as scientific and religious knowledge. Multidimensional intersubjectivity is not rooted in complementary perception that provides different perspectives or angles of essentially an identically observed event. Instead, it emerges from partially aligned perceptions across multiple experiential dimensions of reality and modalities of consciousness, as well as shared processes of

validation and meaning-making. Unlike objectivity, the goal is not to remove the will or judgment of the individual or prevent a view from “nowhere”— but to produce a communal and collaborative interpretation of the meaning and nature of contact events, in which the knower is understood as a participant in the creation of the known. Multidimensional intersubjectivity thus requires a different set of practices of the self, ones that maintain the connection between the knowledge gained and the knower of the experience. At the same time, experience must transcend only the individual’s viewpoint, and be brought into the purview of other witnesses, who help co-create meaning, interpretation, and truth.

One of those practices of the self is the use of altered states of consciousness alongside more traditional forms of observation. In the final chapter of *Abduction*, Mack explains that his work with abductees led him to believe a paradigm shift in our ways of knowing is necessary, including a need for methods that reembrace neglected aspects of ourselves. Human consciousness itself, he argued, had tremendous epistemic potential, especially through the use of “non-ordinary” states of consciousness that take us as far from objectivity as we can possibly get. Inherently participatory, non-ordinary states of consciousness are arrived at only by inducing an *intentional distortion* in the normal faculties of the knower. And yet, cultures around the world for centuries have argued that such distortions pave the way for access to a deeper truth, one that is not conditioned by our need to check logical or scientific boxes. Mack saw hypnosis, shamanic journeys, meditation, Grof breathwork, vision quests, etc. not as distortive but as investigative allies. He argues that the use of such methods is a distinctly *intersubjective* process. “Alternative therapies and investigations of human consciousness appear to share an expanded use of the psyche as part of the exploratory process...This expanded use of the self relies on empathy and is, in essence, intersubjective.”³⁶²

Much of the experience and knowledge gained in contact events involves realms beyond the boundaries of physical reality as we currently understand it. The consciousness required for such an endeavor, Mack found, was co-creative and intersubjective, a process that he helped facilitate in his therapeutic work with abductees.

In order to learn about the worlds “beyond the veil,” as abductees put it, we may need a different kind of consciousness. This means that the process of gaining information about abductions is, to a large degree, “co-creative” —understanding comes to those who will accept it, and what I help bring forth from experiencers is something I am helping them to discover within themselves.³⁶³

³⁶² John E. Mack, *Abduction: Human Encounters with Aliens* (New York: Scribner and Sons, 1994), 390.

³⁶³ *Ibid.*, 391.

In the co-creative process, Mack helped abductees surface meanings, interpretations, and layers of their experience that they may not have reached on their own. Such a process is anathema when situated within methods oriented around the ideal of objectivity, a violation of the ethical practices of the scientific self. Mack acknowledges as much himself, but also sees what is happening as contributing to an evolution of our understanding of what it means to know. “From a Western perspective this might be called ‘distortion’; from a transpersonal point of view the experiencer and I may be participating in an evolution of consciousness.”³⁶⁴ In such an evolution of consciousness, there is an acknowledgement that the knower and the known are intertwined and co-constituted. Rather than ask whether a particular method for attempting to know contact experiences produces “objective truth,” he suggests that a more modest epistemic question be posed: “A more useful question would be whether the investigative method can yield information that is *consistent* among experiencers, carries emotional *conviction*, and appears to *enlarge* our knowledge of phenomena that are significant for the lives of experiencers and the larger culture.”³⁶⁵

The multidimensional intersubjectivity I suggest, then, would not see altered states of consciousness as distortive if such methods lead to insights about the phenomenon or wider reality in ways that demonstrate consistency and usefulness. Often contact experiences involuntarily induce some kind of altered state of consciousness in the knower: elements are experienced as dream-like or feel like they are occurring outside the boundaries of time and space. Memories of events are often distorted and partial and may only be recovered and interpreted through hypnosis, relaxation, breathwork, or deep meditation. States of awareness beyond everyday waking consciousness, then, become integral to both the experiences themselves and to the integration and interpretation of contact events. This positions the knower as a participant in the knowledge process, not one who verifies the truth value of propositions, but who becomes different through the act of knowing itself—one who asks not just “is this true?” but also “What does this demand of me?”

Complementary physical observations or perspectives within traditional physical reality play a role in intersubjective verification but contact events cannot be known through such perceptions alone. While *aspects* may be verifiable in such a way, for example in the Ariel School encounter where a coherent account of the landing can be pieced together from the various perspectives of the school children, often moments of significant divergence emerge when trying to piece together multi-witnessed encounters. For example, in Case 5 of the Multi-witness Study, prior to regression, a man and his wife both recalled seeing a strange light on the beach, that

³⁶⁴ Ibid., 391.

³⁶⁵ Ibid., 391-392.

they compared to a firefly the size of a ping pong ball and was behaving strangely. The man felt an extreme intrigue and fascination from the light, while his wife recalls seeing it and finding it strange but not being nearly as moved or intrigued. Under regression, the man recalled a full abduction event while his wife remembered the event identically to her waking state recall.³⁶⁶ The wife serves as a partial witness to what occurred—grounding *aspects* of the event in shared reality; she affirms seeing an odd light. However, the man's profound emotional fascination with the light and abduction experience are not part of her perception; they emerge and are processed through his interaction with Mack. Perceptions are partially aligned and help reconstruct an interpretation of what occurred. If successful, this interpretation could help both the individual and all involved or potentially learn from the event to have a deeper, more robust understanding of what occurred. Such an interpretation would *not* require declaration that the man's abduction experience occurred in his subjective mind alone. It *would* require acknowledgment that in whatever plane of reality it potentially occurred, the experience was not directly accessible to others located in the same physical environment.

Additionally, multidimensional intersubjectivity often begins in the subjective but with a more expanded, intuitive orientation towards reality. Individuals begin noticing meaningful synchronicities, having powerful intuitions, downloads or psychic experiences, or receiving information or messages in dreams. However, what begins at the subjective level often bursts into the intersubjective: the individual they communicate with telepathically, have a shared dream experience with, or who is involved in the synchronistic events. I myself remember being left speechless when I had my first dream of a classic flying saucer, then received an email from a student in one of my public seminars the next morning that she had received a strange intuitive message the night before that I would have a dream about a UFO that very night. Dreams are often assumed to be a private, local experience of the individual, however what I had conventionally assumed was a subjective event privy only to me uncannily surged into the realm of the intersubjectively shared.

While the methods and modalities of consciousness involved are multidimensional, so are the phenomenological field and potential participants. Perceptions, sensations and experiences that may be perceived as existing outside of time, or to be from future or past, or parallel timelines are brought into awareness and discussion. In addition to the human witnesses, participants may include the alleged non-human intelligences, who contribute to the intersubjective process in

³⁶⁶ John E Mack and Roberta Colasanti, "Phase III: Review of Selected Five Cases," 98-104. *John E. Mack Collection*, Woodson Research Center, Rice University, accessed August 1-9, 2025 with permission from the donor.

their varying degrees of corporeality. It may also include conscious interactions or communications with non-human animals, plants, or Earth. A transpersonal field of communication becomes part of the intersubjective plane, and dialogues or experiences with what one interprets to be one's higher, past, future, or parallel self contribute to the knowledge generation process. Through the incorporation of synchronicity, participants may also feel the universe or physical reality itself becomes a participant in the conversation.

An orientation of multidimensional intersubjectivity produces a different set of outcomes than knowledge processes rooted in objectivity. It does not produce "facts" nor "values" but something in-between: lived experience that reflects something meaningful about the relationships and connections embedded in the universe in which we live. The transformations in ethical orientation that emerge as the result of contact experiences reveal how the universe and our moral responsibilities are revealed together. The lived experience of ontological oneness and of the world as an interconnected flux engender new models for relationality. The meanings that emerge from contact, following Mack's criteria, are stronger when they are emotionally convincing, show some consistency across accounts, transformative, and ultimately enlarge our collective understanding of contact. Like Wildcat's characterization of Indigenous metaphysics, multidimensional intersubjectivity recognizes a world in flux, not a mechanical, cause and effect realm that can be known as a logical machine. From the thresholds in between physical and mental, subject and object, self and other, a coherent, though fluctuating, picture emerges.

Importantly, multidimensional knowing must accommodate the elusive, saturated, and trickster qualities that consistently disrupt attempts to categorize and classify UAP and contact phenomena. When the phenomenon is *elusive*, it resists capture; it withdraws even as it appears. Full comprehension remains out of reach, and any knowledge we gain is necessarily partial—an encounter with its edges rather than its essence. When it is *saturated*, the phenomenon overwhelms the ordinary capacities of human cognition. It exceeds our traditional categories, demanding that we perceive and interpret without the security of established rubrics of rationality or objectivity. And when it manifests in its *trickster* dimension, it introduces elements that are deceptive, absurd, paradoxical, or destabilizing. These moments are not mere noise; they function as provocations, forcing the knower to interrogate the certainty of their frameworks, the rigidity of their binary distinctions, and the stability of the very structures through which they attempt to make sense of reality. This combination of elusiveness, saturation, and trickster disruption means that multidimensional knowing must be flexible, self-reflective, and capable of holding tensions without prematurely attempting to resolve them and willing to work with

paradox and symbol. Only then can it remain responsive to a phenomenon that continually exceeds, evades, and transforms the act of knowing itself.

Multidimensional Knowers: Whitley Strieber and Matthew Roberts

Two experiencers who have bravely gone public with their stories, and who illustrate, in my view, the multidimensional and intersubjective practices of gaining knowledge through contact are found in the examples of Matthew Roberts and Whitley Strieber. Exemplary illustrations of *participants* in contact, I engage their stories briefly now to illustrate how the intersubjective process may unfold.

After returning from deployment—and following a near-death experience—Matthew Roberts began to have what he describes as “follow-on” experiences with the phenomenon, including direct encounters with entities in his room, as described in Chapter One. He titled his book *Initiated* because he came to understand these experiences as an initiatory process that opened him to a new sense of his psyche, his own multidimensional nature, and ultimately a new way of being human. His transformation unfolded through a continual dialogue with authors such as Carl Jung, Robert Moore, Mabel Collins, as well as *The Kybalion*, guided by a chain of synchronicities and anomalous experiences that seemed to direct him toward these texts—and toward a new ethical orientation.

I will leave it to the reader to follow Matthew’s journey in his own words. My aim here is not to retell his story but to illuminate the epistemological process he enacted—one that demonstrates how the phenomenon becomes a source of knowledge when a person loosens the constraints of the scientific self and the contemporary residue of objectivity. The phenomenon does not simply “present” information; it requires participation and practices of the self, particular ways of positioning oneself as a knower in relation to one’s own experience. Roberts embraced himself as “the gifted,” as someone who receives all of what appears. This receptive posture—this willingness to let meaning arrive through multiple channels—enabled him to connect dots he otherwise would not. Roberts sees this as a process open to all of us, should we choose to take it up.

A crucial turning point in Roberts’ transformation occurred at the level of human relationality—a moment of intersubjectivity that catalyzed a shift in his understanding. When the follow-on experiences began, including the sexual encounter with a blue non-human entity, Matthew felt terrified, depressed, and increasingly despaired. Like many experiencers, he feared the events might recur without warning and struggled to interpret them. It was only when he shared these events with his brother—bringing them out of the solitude of his own mind—that something opened. Matthew recounts:

I was terrified and told him that I was afraid for my life. I told him that I thought they might kill me and I felt something bad was coming for me...He stopped me and said, 'There's got to be something you're missing. Something you're misinterpreting. These beings don't have these crafts just so they could come here and terrorize you,' he said...After I got off the phone with him, I decided to go back through *The Kybalion*. Maybe there was something I was missing. It was worth another look.³⁶⁷

This was an essential intersubjective turning point. His brother did not have his own anomalous experiences, but he believed Matthew, validated him, and—most importantly—offered an interpretive frame that Matthew could not access alone in the grip of fear. This human-to-human intersubjectivity became the first layer of multidimensional intersubjectivity, giving Matthew permission to reconsider the meaning of what was occurring.

With this shift, Matthew opened himself to alternative knowledge practices. He began experimenting with non-ordinary states of consciousness and forms of non-local receptivity. He writes of his method: "I quiet my mind, listen to nothing and everything, think of nothing and yet be aware of everything; and some name will come to me, or some concept to look into."³⁶⁸ These practices generated what he experienced as meaningful correspondences between his inner mental states and external events. Synchronicity became another intersubjective channel—an exchange not with a human other but with a responsive world. He experienced these teachings as coming from beyond himself, as revelatory:

I feel I always pretty much understood that I didn't control this process in myself. I knew I was being shown what I needed to see. I instead continue to work on concentration, attention, mindfulness, and meditation. I'll let consciousness show me what it will; and I will do what I can with that; without forcing anything; and without selfish intent.³⁶⁹

These synchronicities formed the second dimension of intersubjectivity—a dialogue between his consciousness and the structures of the world around him.

The third dimension is the most striking: the intersubjective communication with apparent non-human intelligence. Throughout his journey, Matthew experienced the beings as intimately acquainted with his mind, often responding to decisions or emotions he had never verbalized. After a particularly difficult period,

³⁶⁷ Matthew Roberts, *Initiated: UAP, Dreams, Depression, Delusions, Shadow People, Psychosis, Sleep Paralysis and Pandemics* (Self-published, 2020), 100.

³⁶⁸ *Ibid.*, 382.

³⁶⁹ *Ibid.*

he decided—privately and without telling anyone—to give up: to put away the books and shut out the phenomenon. That very night, he was visited by a small humanoid figure:

“Don’t give up, keep going,” he said, as he began to induce me back to sleep. “Go fuck yourself” I thought quickly before my eyes shut. I woke up the next morning and looked at the books on my shelf. He’s right, I thought...*Maybe he knows something I don’t know*...All of this was clearly much bigger than me.³⁷⁰

The entity knew his decision despite him never saying it aloud. This is intersubjectivity in its expanded, multidimensional form: relationality that includes, but is not limited to, human others—and that crosses the boundaries of what we traditionally interpret to be the self. The entity knows to appear, apparently having access to Matthew’s inner mental states—communicating through synchronicity and presence. Matthew began to see himself as participating in something “bigger,” learning to understand the invasive nature of the contact episodes not as violations but as stemming from vast epistemic asymmetries between himself and the UAP intelligence.

By the end of his journey, Matthew encourages readers to recognize the phenomenon as a profound source of knowledge, but one that is ultimately helping you unlock knowledge from within yourself: “You don’t need to explore the farthest reaches of space to find answers to anything; all of the answers are right here; inside us...In the end, you discover that the universe is not what you hoped it would be because it is so much more than you could have ever imagined.”³⁷¹ Matthew’s ultimate message: to know the contact experience: look inward, not upward. Knowledge of the universe presents as inseparable from knowledge of the self. This knowledge does not arrive through a summons to believe, but through an invitation to participate.

Whitley Strieber has shared his experiences publicly since the 1989 publication of *Communion*, a firsthand account of his abduction experience that catalyzed an unprecedented intersubjective archive: thousands of letters from experiencers around the world. The very act of telling his story opened an intersubjective space for identifying patterns, coherences, and shared meanings across otherwise singular lives—an early form of the multidimensional intersubjectivity I am describing, and one that continues through the Rice University *Center for the Impossible* studies and archives. Like Roberts, Strieber developed his own unique *participatory epistemic practices* designed to encounter and collaborate with the phenomenon across multiple registers of reality.

³⁷⁰ Ibid. 122-123, my emphasis.

³⁷¹ Ibid., 401.

One of the earliest—and most decisive—multidimensional intersections emerged not from Whitley’s solitary reflections but from the shared interpretive space he and his late wife Ann created. Whitley’s 1983 encounter included seeing an old college acquaintance who, as he later learned, had died months earlier, a detail he omitted from *Communion*. It was Ann who first grasped the deeper pattern surfacing across reports.

Sometime in the early nineties, she said what I believe to be the single most important thing about the experience that has ever been said... “I think this has something to do with what we call death.”...On the occasions at our cabin when the visitors came, the human dead were generally also with them.³⁷²

Ann’s recognition was not merely an interpretive suggestion; it reoriented the entire horizon of the phenomenon by introducing a relational insight that Whitley alone had not articulated. Her acknowledgment of the link between the visitors and the human dead opened a shared, intersubjective frame in which the experience became intelligible. This intersubjective discovery suggests that the phenomenon is not confined to corporeal encounters with biological beings, but unfolds in a multidimensional field where human consciousness, the dead, and the unknown visitors converge. Ann’s recognition thus marks an early moment in which the phenomenon’s potential meaning could only emerge through a relational, co-constituted act of understanding.

Strieber has long argued that the UAP visitors are more complex than space aliens and raise fundamental questions about human subjectivity. *Communion* opens with the enigmatic line, “The human mind winks back from the dark,”³⁷³ later clarified in *The Super Natural*: “I don’t mean that it’s entirely in the mind, but that the mind might not be entirely in us.”³⁷⁴ With this idea, “mind” becomes something much bigger than individual consciousness, and intersubjectivity consequently expands beyond shared physical perceptions into a multidimensional field of expressions of consciousness and human experience.

This expansion is clearest in Strieber’s long-term practice of a “sensing meditation,” which he considers central to his ongoing communication with the visitors. He describes the practice: “[O]ne sits and places the attention on physical sensation...being attentive to first one foot, then the lower leg...opening my attention to the sensation of each part of my body...over the whole body.”³⁷⁵ The

³⁷² Whitley Strieber, *A New World* (Portland, OR: Beyond Worlds Publishing, 2020), 18.

³⁷³ Whitley Strieber, *Communion: A True Story* (San Antonio, TX: Walker and Collier 1987/2022).

³⁷⁴ Whitley Strieber, “Into the Woods,” in Whitley Strieber and Jeffrey J. Kripal, *The Super Natural: Why the Unexplained is Real* (New York: Penguin Randomhouse, 2017), 34.

³⁷⁵ Strieber, *A New World*, 34.

sensing exercise is not only an introspective exercise, but opens an intersubjective plane in which he experiences the visitors as entering his field of awareness, crossing the boundaries of what is usually understood to be the self. “Doing the sensing exercise enables the sharing of self. While you are doing it, they can enter the silence of your mind and join you in your life experience.”³⁷⁶ Intersubjectivity thus becomes multidimensional: a union of embodied sensation, non-local consciousness, and non-human presence.

During his daily “three o’clock meditation,” Strieber actively engages this shared space: “I open myself to the visitors and in return receive knowledge and am exposed to their teaching...If I wish to understand something, I enter into the sensing meditation, let my mind be still, and ask directly for knowledge.”³⁷⁷ Responses always follow, although they may be asymmetrical—through physical touches (“pinching”), lucid visions, symbolic dreams, apparitional beings, or sudden downloads of information. These modes together form a layered epistemic system that neither science nor religion alone can capture. Strieber recognizes that such experiences invite dismissal from skeptics who will accuse him of hallucinating, yet he insists that the visitors represent a genuine unknown Otherness. Simultaneously, he also sees them as connected to a deeper understanding of ourselves. “We are not just having a close encounter with what appear to be nonhuman beings but also with ourselves.”³⁷⁸ In this intentionally cultivated intersubjective field, boundaries between self and Other begin to blur and break down.

Both Roberts and Strieber describe a spectrum of encounters—physical events, subtle or energetic perceptions, and experiences that unfold entirely within a mental space. Their learning processes with the phenomenon emerged only after initial periods of fear, confusion, and trauma, including moments of significant bodily violation. Over time, however, each entered a trajectory of intersubjective knowledge production that involved not only the entities themselves but also the humans closest to them (Matthew’s brother, Whitley’s wife Ann) and eventually the wider public through their shared stories. For both, synchronicity becomes a key mode of communication, linking inner states with external events, and non-ordinary states of consciousness—especially meditative or relaxed conscious states—serve as crucial channels for receiving information. They approach their experiences with discernment, recognizing that the phenomenon often communicates symbolically rather than literally. As a result, both cultivate ways of knowing grounded in a participatory, multidimensional intersubjectivity rather than an “objective” stance that suppresses the will of the knower. In developing these practices of perception

³⁷⁶ Ibid., 35.

³⁷⁷ Ibid., 40.

³⁷⁸ Ibid., 80.

and interpretation, they cultivate their own practices of the self: a multidimensional subjectivity that can tolerate ambiguity, enter altered states, read meaning rather than chance or coincidence, and sustain engagement with the radically alien Other.

Intersubjectivity and *Thinking Impossibly*: Learning from the Experiences of Others

Roberts and Strieber present exemplary models of multidimensional knowing of one's own experience. What about the one who seeks to understand the experiences of others, such as the researcher? First, it is possible that any binary we attempt to draw between "researcher" and "experiencer" cannot fully hold. As many who have begun studying UAP can attest, when you take an interest in the phenomenon, *it takes an interest in you*. In other words, as researchers progress in their exploration of UAP and contact experiences, they often find themselves having their own experiences, surfacing their own memories, and immersed in their own ontologically shocking process of participatory sense-making. As I have hinted at several times, somewhere along my research journey, through the months of books, interviews, transcripts, letters, documentaries, and podcasts, I realized that I was more than a passive observer. The contact phenomenon was speaking to me in its own language: intense dreams, strange altered states, non-local receipt of information, and profound and meaningful synchronicities—often involving others in my life—that I had no traditional explanation for. Thus, even one who positions themselves in the role of "researcher" may soon learn that the phenomenon demands their own participation. Pasulka's work specifically shows how some scientists interested in the phenomenon eventually develop their own alternative knowledge processes for communicating with what they perceive to be non-human intelligences. Thus, we should not assume that there is a neat divide between "researcher" and "experiencer." Contact resists all binaries, including this one.

However, it is also true that some people have these experiences and others do not, or have different types of experiences, and that some may, even as they may or may not experience their own forms of interaction, wish to learn from the experiences of others. In the humanities, perhaps no one has done more work towards legitimizing and recognizing extraordinary experiences than historian of religions Jeffrey J. Kripal. In his latest book, *How to Think Impossibly*, Kripal devotes the conclusion to a guide for thinking impossibly, ultimately practices for scholars or researchers to "think-with" experiencers. The suggestions and method that he introduces signal towards an epistemology rooted in phenomenology and an orientation towards intersubjectivity. The steps he outlines are modern *practices of the self*, blueprints for creating ourselves as multidimensional subjects that can recover a renewed philosophical way of life that transforms the one who knows.

Thinking impossibly, Kripal argues, begins with the acknowledgement that every historical knowledge system has drawn boundaries around possible and impossible and what would or would not be left of the table. To counter this, we must simply leave everything on the table, no matter how weird or far it is from our cultural understandings of what is true.³⁷⁹ This is, of course, the starting point of the descriptive phenomenology that informs our explorations of experiences in this book. Second, Kripal encourages the researcher to be willing to “think out” of such extraordinary experiences; seeing them not as isolated anomalies but as the foundations for a new critical theory about reality. Simultaneously, we must remain aware that these experiences often speak through paradox, symbolism, and deception—we must be open to the possibility of being wrong about any experience and remain vigilant regarding accepting what appears at face value.³⁸⁰

Kripal stresses the importance of allowing the transcendent aspects of these experiences to stand, not to attempt to force them into a reductive or materialistic understanding of reality. There are times that the human imagination, he argues, takes on a life of its own, and offers a window into a deeper reality; one that is even more true or more real than our everyday experiences in the practical, natural attitude. This experience will not be intersubjective in the traditional sense of shared perception, but rather will participate in the wider epistemic field of multidimensional intersubjectivity. This deeper reality extends beyond corporeality, crossing multiple spatial and temporal planes of existence. “Impossible thinking is not thinking in only three dimensions. That is entirely possible. It is imagining in four, or five, or more.”³⁸¹ This requires a shift to temporal thinking rather than spatial thinking—so much about these encounters that doesn’t make sense when we conceive of the entities coming from a different place does indeed make sense when we consider them coming from another place in time.³⁸² Multidimensional thinking requires intertemporal thinking—conceiving of our conscious experience as intersecting with an expanded understanding of time, capable of communication with future selves and future beings—an expanded intersubjective plane.

Kripal concludes the book with a thought experiment that he introduces as the “three bars” of impossible thinking. Kripal’s first bar begins with a simple phenomenological commitment: people believe “impossible” things because impossible things happen, and our task is to consider the experience itself as real, although not necessarily captured by cultural representations. The second bar asks

³⁷⁹ Jeffrey Kripal, *How to Think Impossibly: About Souls, UFOs, Time, Belief, and Everything Else* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2024), 227.

³⁸⁰ *Ibid.*, 228.

³⁸¹ *Ibid.*, 232.

³⁸² *Ibid.*, 235

what these experiences imply about consciousness and human subjectivity—whether they reveal emerging dimensions of mind or new capacities of experience. The third bar extends this inquiry outward, asking what such experiences suggest about the structure of the physical universe and its relationship to consciousness.³⁸³ Kripal's methodology is groundbreaking in a cultural epoch that is committed to objectivity and the separation of the knower from the known. Sitting firmly in the excluded middle between science and religion, the method seeks to ask how these experiences can aid in our understanding of the physical universe, while simultaneously allowing the transcendent dimensions of the experiences to remain.

I additionally suggest that a “fourth bar” be added to Kripal's method (although it could also liminally fit between the second and third bars). We must also be willing to ask what these experiences suggest about *relationality and ethics*: how we ought to behave in light of the model of reality suggested. What do these experiences suggest about relationships of kinship, care, and connection? How must we reconfigure our relation to Otherness, in its human and non-human forms? What does it mean to welcome these experiences in a way that allows otherness to stand, that moves towards the ideal of unconditional hospitality, one that enables transformation of the self by letting the other appear on their own terms, without conditions? Such questions are of equal, if not greater importance, as we navigate an epistemological realm that is up to the task of attempting to know the complexities of contact. Reflecting Wildcat's assertions that there are no firm separations of facts and values, we must remember that knowledge about *who we are* and *how the universe is* always implicates us in ethical and moral considerations—to know the world is to know it in inherently ethical ways. A multidimensional model of human subjectivity—corporeal yet more than physical, extended across time and dimension, intertwined with other consciousnesses, and open to liminality—demands a corresponding multidimensional ethic. Such an orientation challenges our fractured systems of relation and calls us toward holistic attention to one another, to non-human life, and to the Earth itself. This is the potential of the call of contact and multidimensional knowing. Perhaps the most important remaining question is whether we will answer it.

Conclusion

A scientific or a religious phenomenon? The trickster reminds us the answer lies somewhere in between. These encounters demand a multidimensional epistemology: one that embraces ambiguity, and paradox; that moves beyond mere physical observation into subtle, relational, and symbolic realms; and that cultivates a knower

³⁸³ Ibid., 243.

capable of co-creating understanding with other human and non-human minds. It invites us out of a position of belief and into a position of participation—moving beyond the question of whether we should accept or reject experiencer claims, instead asking us to participate in a co-creative process that transforms us as knowers.

Multidimensional intersubjectivity shows us that knowing is never purely individual, nor reducible to measurable facts. Knowledge emerges through corroborative witnessing, shared processing, and interpretative meaning-making—through dialogue with others, engagement with one’s own consciousness, and openness to phenomena that may be “trickster-like” or otherwise subversive. In embracing this approach, we move from a culture of detached observers to one of participatory knowers, capable of navigating a universe that is multi-layered, interdependent, and suffused with meaning. As the examples in this chapter demonstrate, the pursuit of knowledge is inseparable from the cultivation of the self. To begin to know contact experiences requires a multidimensional, intersubjective, ethically attuned self that can meet the unknown on its terms, speak its language, and translate its insights into a deeper understanding of ourselves, each other, and the broader universe.

The book closes, then, in a similar place to where it began: with a call to take experiencer testimony seriously. Stepping into fuller witnessing requires challenging our assumptions, bearing witness to extraordinary testimony, participating in a co-creative process of shared meaning-making that may challenge all existing parameters of who we think we are and what we think the world is. Doing so reveals UAP and contact experiences as fundamentally participatory and transformative: not just of the individual who experiences the original contact event, but of the one who seeks to learn from such experiences. To become capable of receiving the gift of contact, we make ourselves different in the process, are open to what appears and allow it to stand without reduction into comfortable or convenient categories. We may find that a new sense of self emerges as an accumulation of the gifts, a product of our willingness to confront saturated phenomena and step into our own individual experiences of multidimensional subjectivity.

Conclusion: Living in the Age of Disclosure

The UAP conversation is rapidly changing and evolving, and it is possible by the time these words reach print, there will have been new revelations within the formal “disclosure” process. The groundbreaking documentary at the time of this writing, “The Age of Disclosure” frames UAP as primarily about the government hiding evidence of extraterrestrial life, which is potentially a threat to humanity because our technologies and destructive capacities have outpaced our moral development.³⁸⁴ Thus, there is an urgent need to “disclose” the existence of extraterrestrial life and technology so humanity can be prepared for the potential threat that the intelligence behind UAP pose. However, a full centering and witnessing of testimony of the contact experience, carefully examining not only the reported experiences but also the processed transformations that emerge from them, suggests that disclosure is not the revelation of an alien invasion, but a new understanding of reality and the human place in it. The shift ahead may not be so much extraterrestrial as it is phenomenological.

What if the “Age of Disclosure” is not about the revealing of extraterrestrial technological threats, but the destabilization of the very structures that this surface form of “disclosure” is aiming to protect? What if disclosure is not the unveiling of a secret alien presence, but a shift to understanding reality in ways that fundamentally rethink what it means to be human, to witness and relate to that which is Other? Can governments truly “disclose” something that challenges the very structures that they rely on? The disruption of the atomistic, liberal conception of personhood and boundaries of the self, as well the very possibility of non-human forms of life expressing nuanced forms of agency and choice-making, fundamentally questions the very concepts that undergird the modern nation-state. In this light, the most consequential disclosure will never come from congressional hearings or government announcements about alien technology. It will emerge from the voices of those who have confronted the experience and from the transformative ways they reorient themselves within reality.

Disclosure starts now—alongside any revelations that may or not emerge from an authority—in the process of truly witnessing and listening to the voices of those who have already met the phenomenon face to face. Treating experiencers as reliable knowers, stepping into *full witnessing rather than treating them as interesting data points*, reveals contact as a catalyst for engaging with our subjectivity and intersubjectivity in new and creative ways. Contact does not ask anyone to *believe*; it presents rather, as an opportunity to participate in a much wider multidimensional

³⁸⁴ Dan Farah, *The Age of Disclosure*, documentary film, directed by Dan Farah (Farah Films, 2025), narrated by Luis Elizondo, premiered March 9, 2025 at the South by Southwest Film Festival (SXSW), released November 21, 2025, on Amazon Prime Video.

reality. The deeper disclosure may be more human than alien, intricately interwoven with rethinking fundamental conceptions of consciousness, relationality, and ethics. Contact invites us, collectively, to show up differently— to proceed without full assurance or certainty into the unknown. It calls us to enter the world of the experiencer, to examine ourselves and our relationality. It ultimately demands relationships of kinship and care with Earth, human, and non-human life. It does not ask for assent or agreement, – rather, it presents as an *invitation* to participate in the world differently.

If all “disclosure” amounts to is the revealing of non-human technology, and the possibility of us all having polite dinner time conversation about UAP without being pathologized or mocked, yet changes nothing else about our forms of relating, our world, or our society, I personally would see that as a profound failure. What is being disclosed already, subtly and through lived experience, is an invitation to new forms of being, experiencing, relating, and showing up in our daily lived encounter. In this work, I have aimed to step into full witnessing of experiencers—not only the events they describe but the deeper meanings they convey, the transformations they undergo, and the possibilities they disclose for humanity. In shifting our subjective positioning from one of belief to one of participant, a new phenomenological structure is disclosed: one in which we are not asked to adjudicate the correspondence of every detail of contact narratives, but to explore how they present a framework for entering a participatory, relational field. What, then, has already been disclosed?

Exploring abduction events as a form of lived experience, we saw that contact involves human corporeal embodiment but also challenges its parameters. By offering new intercorporeal experiences with unknown embodied Others, some non-consensual and some not, it shifts the way experiencers relate to their own bodies. By problematizing the traditional boundaries of corporeality, the body not only dys-appears in forms of dysfunction but engenders conscious experiences beyond the traditional boundaries of the bodily. Abduction dislodges a fundamental structure of the self; in encounters with the abject, the normal subject/object distinction breaks down. The body itself is disassembled and reconceived. At the same time it engenders experiences beyond the bodily, contact anchors the experiencer more firmly in their bodies as the primary vehicle of their current experience. That which is disclosed is a multidimensional sense of corporeality– a body that is the primary locus of human conscious experience, but not the sole one.

Next, we explored how contact presents as a form of encounter with a liminal Other, one who straddles the boundaries between physical reality and the subtle or psychical realms. Appearing within waking reality as well as dreams, altered states, and meditative experiences, these Others unsettle the assumed parameters of

intersubjectivity and intercorporeality. Their arrival surges into awareness as *allopáthos*—a disruptive event that interrupts everyday oneness and renders a return to pre-contact life impossible. It engenders new pathways of response in which one is inevitably different, lives within thresholds, and is opened to spaces of invention and creativity. Confronted with the face of the liminal Other, experiencers feel a distinctly ethical call, one that need not provoke fear but a desire to communicate on the terms of the Other, to let the Other appear in their radical alterity. Moving as closely as possible to the ideal of unconditional hospitality, the self is interrupted, the conditions imposed on Otherness must dissolve without doing violence to the self, but rather, enhance it. That which is disclosed is the current limits and contradictions within our ways of relating: that to truly welcome this Other, we must give up our demands for certainty regarding who they are or why they're here; we must stop trying to force them to conform to human expectations.

Exploring contact as *saturated*, we acknowledge that it will not fit neatly into our human categories of rationality that govern traditional spatiotemporal experience; that any contact encounter will contain an excess that we cannot reduce to familiar understandings. When we consider contact something that is received rather than constituted, the sense of I becomes not the rational atomistic self who chooses and determines a world, but one who themselves is constituted by what appears. Undergoing noetic, fleshly, and extratemporal experiences, the experiencers receive contact on its terms and simultaneously confront new capacities and boundaries of consciousness that extend across an expanded sense of temporality. Contact serves as a vehicle for experiencers to encounter the transcendent aspects of themselves, leading to an expansion of their conscious capacities and their relationship to time. A multidimensional subjectivity (straddling the physical and subtle or psychical; past, present, future and atemporal) is disclosed as the accumulation of the gifts.

Exploring experiencer sense-making in the aftermath of the experience, and putting their insights and experiences in conversation with Indigenous American thought furthers the phenomenological disclosure. Through a close analysis of the effects of contact on experiencers' ethical orientation and commitments, a lifeworld is disclosed that is navigated and interpreted through relationships of interconnectedness and kinship with human and non-human life. The subject-object distinction is again blurred and problematized, and new attitudes towards being emerge that originate in a call from beyond the human Umwelt and modern technological framings. Earth, non-human terrestrial life, and the biosphere are disclosed not as resources for us to control and extract from, but fellow subjects in an interconnected field of becoming. Cracks in presentist thinking are revealed, and UAP are disclosed not as a novel crisis to be feared, but as catalysts for attuning

human consciousness to relationships of coordination and care within an expanded circle of moral considerability.

Experiencer insights on ethics are then cautiously reconstructed into a model of ethical reasoning that can be put into conversation with other ethical models. A multidimensional framework of moral reasoning is introduced, one that operates on planes of embodied corporeality, interspecies liminality, and transpersonal consciousness simultaneously. Events, actions, and choices are evaluated not based only on their effects within traditional spatiotemporal reality, but as reverberating across lifetimes and corporeal embodiments within a multidimensional plane dislodged from linear time. A multidimensional moral agent is disclosed, one who understands the moral realm as incorporating and transcending the corporeal, as situated in relation to liminal Otherness, and not confined by the boundaries of linear time. Ethics is disclosed as engaging both the corporeal and the transcendent together; moral bypassing is disclosed as equally insufficient to spiritual bypassing. The pressing moral concerns humanity faces are disclosed as wrong because they distort a relational whole and the immediate phenomenological givenness of unconditional love that characterizes the experience of a monistic source.

We then ask what it would look like to approach the world through the reasoning framework born from contact. The case test is evaluating the behavior of the entities themselves; how experiencers as ones who have directly lived the encounter make sense of and evaluate the elusive, deceptive, mysterious behavior of the entities. The epistemic gaps between the apparent entities and humans are confronted; as well as considering what is occurring as unfolding in a larger, extratemporally expanded multidimensional field that has effects that extend beyond the experiencers' immediate corporeal lives. The mysterious, at times apparently deceptive or malevolent behavior of the entities is examined through a post-anthropocentric and multidimensional lens; the role of the deception may be to awaken the one who is contacted to a deeper, liberatory truth that has meaning beyond its immediate physical effects. The trickster archetype, especially as it appears in Indigenous American traditions, discloses the possibility of sitting with paradox and deception as facilitators of insight, as tools for exposing the shortcomings of our modern colonialist models of relating.

Finally, contact is explored as itself a modality of knowing, not just of inner knowledge of self, but capable of producing insights about the nature of consciousness and reality itself. The self revealed through contact is not the detached scientific observer but the multidimensional participant in a malleable intersubjective field. To know the world as revealed through contact is to dislodge our assumptions about shared perception, and to enter into a communal process of sense-making in

which the reality and meaning of contact is processed from different vantage points, divergent experiences of the same event, and shared inquiry into the type of world it engenders. Alternate states of consciousness, synchronicity, and intuitive, non-local receipt of information disclose a way of knowing that emerges from in between the religious versus scientific split and attempts to know anomalous phenomena that present both as material technological craft and profoundly spiritual experiences that redefine what it means to live a human life.

The experiencers who accept the invitation of contact thus emerge with complex and nuanced understandings of corporeality, liminality, and consciousness. They show an expanded, post-anthropocentric ethical orientation as well as a complex moral reasoning process that considers not only what happens to them but how they proceed in the aftermath in an expanded, multidimensional relational field. This is incorporated not just into a form of “concepts” or understandings, but embodied in participation—a new form of relating—positioning themselves in reality differently; expanded in their capacity to confront, witness, and be transformed by Otherness. Disclosure is not the unveiling of alien bodies and craft (although it is possible they indeed exist and will someday be made publicly known) but the revealing of the multidimensional nature of human experience.

Implications and Future Directions

This book has centered experiencer testimony to explore the manifolds of how UAP and contact give themselves in the lifeworld. What other lines of inquiry and research are opened by examining contact?

As we’ve seen, contact presents in altered states, nonlinear temporality, dream-like sequences, missing time, and fragmented memory. Such presentation raises challenges for phenomenology, which was originally formulated to study the essence of experiences that arise within ordinary modes of consciousness. If the phenomenon restructures subjectivity itself—altering perception, agency, embodiment, and the core of our conceptions of selfhood—then our methodological tools must be able to witness and name those transformations. There is also the question of ontological multiplicity. The contact phenomenon appears as polysemous: experienced as technological, corporeal, liminal, psychical, spiritual, symbolic, relational, or initiatory—and sometimes all at once. What kind of method can let such multiplicity stand without forcing collapse or premature unification? How do we phenomenologically name and analyze events that appear in multiple ontological registers simultaneously? Contact as a saturated phenomenon overwhelms our intentional horizons, resists objectification, and discloses more than our categories can contain. The task becomes not merely to describe or explain the phenomenon but to develop new modes of receptivity—new

ways of witnessing—that can hold its excess. While I have foreshadowed possibilities for this throughout the book, it is far from a settled or completed matter.

Importantly, methodological strategies must be paired with an understanding of the fragmented memory and disjointed consciousness that often accompanies contact events, and so discrepancies or difficulty piecing together a fully coherent narrative should not be used as reasons to dismiss or ignore accounts. Even more vitally, the disjunctive intersubjective moments must be allowed to stand without reduction; researchers must be willing to sit with the ambiguity that the experience may have unfolded differently for different participants, and those divergent perceptions may only partially cohere with observations in physical reality. Close analysis of disjunctive moments, including which aspects of which accounts more closely align with what is observed in the physical environment, could shed light on how the physical and mental/psychical aspects of experience unfold with or without regularity. The idea would not be to identify which witnesses' recall is "more true" but to understand how these experiences unfold multidimensionally, how what occurs in physical reality is accompanied by perceptions and intersubjective witnessing that follow different rules and may take place in misunderstood realms.

And even after we unpack how the phenomenon behaves, how it restructures subjectivity and intersubjectivity, how it engenders new meaning-making processes and value transformations, we still must sit with the mystery and ambiguity of an ever-pressing question: *What is it* that is contacting us—and what does its arrival demand of our methods, our epistemologies, and our understanding of the human itself? Framed phenomenologically, this question does not require immediate resolution in terms of identified extraterrestrials or alien technology. It does, however, prompt a point of no return in terms of humans understanding ourselves not as masters of the known universe, but one advanced intelligence among others. Disclosure implicates *us* as human subjects, disrupting anthropocentric assumptions about consciousness, agency, and reality.

What we have also seen is that the contact phenomenon, in dislodging and challenging anthropocentric assumptions about intelligence, agency, and consciousness, discloses something prior to—and potentially more consequential than—any confirmation of extraterrestrial origin. Contact engenders a fundamentally *new attitude toward being*, a way of showing up and positioning oneself in relation to the Other and to the world that does see other humans or nature through the lens of technological extraction. Thus, UAP and contact studies cannot be separated from broader anti-colonial projects such as disability justice, Indigenous and First Nations sovereignty, the Black freedom struggle, deep ecology, eco-feminism, or animal liberation. These movements, like the profundity of contact,

challenge many of our prevailing social norms and structures and invite new forms of human and non-human relating.

Disability studies, for example, offers a particularly illuminating parallel to phenomenological disclosure. Centering the experiences of non-normative bodies and minds, reveals how alternative ways of knowing and being emerge from the experience of a disabled body or neurodivergent mind. Because disabled individuals deviate from what is centered and established as “normal” their needs are not centered in societal arrangements. Disability studies reminds us that many of the experiences that have been labeled deficient or “pathological” in modern culture are better understood as unique and alternative ways of relating to and interpreting reality.³⁸⁵ Additionally, operating without certain sensory abilities often leads to the heightening of other abilities that allows a uniquely tailored sensory understanding very different than an able-bodied person would have. Experiences of synesthesia, the ability to move easier into non-ordinary states, and even evidence that suggests non-speaking autistic people may possess telepathic abilities highlights how bodies and minds relegated to the margins of “normality” may have unique insights that can inform our interpretations of contact and the exploration of different ways of being and acknowledging the human.³⁸⁶

Additionally, while I have engaged with Indigenous American voices throughout this book, I have not directly examined contact encounters as they are lived and interpreted within specific Indigenous communities. Ardy Sixkiller Clarke has created a magnificent repository of contact experiences of Indigenous American people in her works *Encounters with Star People: Untold Stories of American Indians*, *More Encounters with Star People: Urban American Indians Tell Their Stories*, among others.³⁸⁷ These accounts warrant phenomenological examination in their own right, attentive to the particular patterns of meaning-making and the cosmologies that inform them. Such work would not subsume Indigenous narratives into a universal model of contact but would recognize the distinct epistemologies and relational orientations through which these encounters are understood. Engaging these testimonies on their own terms may reveal dimensions of the contact experience that remain inaccessible within western European epistemological and ontological assumptions, while honoring the sovereignty and specificity of the traditions from which they emerge.

Additionally, future research should examine how contact is experienced, narrated, and rendered meaningful within other communities that have historically

³⁸⁵ See for example, Rosemarie Garland-Thomson, “The Case for Conserving Disability,” *Bioethical Inquiry* 9 (2012): 339-355.

³⁸⁶ Ky Dickens, *The Telepathy Tapes*, podcast series, 2024–, <https://thetelepathytapes.com/>.

³⁸⁷ Ardy Sixkiller Clarke, *Encounters with Star People: Untold Stories of American Indians* (San Antonio, TX: Anomalist Books, 2012) and *More Encounters with Star People: Urban American Indians Tell Their Stories* (San Antonio, TX: Anomalist Books, 2016).

faced structural and epistemic injustice—those whose voices, interpretations, and lived realities are routinely dismissed or rendered unintelligible within dominant cultural frameworks. This includes, but is not limited to, Black and African American communities, Latina/o/x and Chicana/o/x communities, Asian American and Pacific Islander communities, immigrants and diasporic communities, transgender and LGBTQ+ persons, those labeled as mentally ill, and others whose social positions expose them to forms of testimonial silencing or other credibility deficits. Exploring these perspectives is not a matter of checking a diversity box, but of recognizing that structures of racism, coloniality, heteronormativity, and ableism shape how experiences are expressed, heard, and granted legitimacy. Resisting partial witnessing means acknowledging marginalized experiencers as credible knowers and reliable narrators of their own encounters. By situating their testimonies within broader dynamics of structural oppression and marginalization, researchers may illuminate dimensions of the phenomenon that remain inaccessible to inquiry structured by dominant cultural and academic norms. Such initiatives could expand not only who is heard, but what can be known, revealing how disclosure unfolds differently across lifeworlds marked by vulnerability but also profoundly unique insight.

Seen in this light, the key question embedded within a phenomenological disclosure is no longer whether we should *believe* experiencer testimony, but whether we are willing to *participate* in the forms of inquiry, responsibility, and transformation that such testimony demands.

Putting it all Together: The Age of Disclosure

The Age of Disclosure and the study of UAP is not merely a “hot topic” nor an “emerging discipline” nor any other simplistic add-on to our current ways of relating and being human. It emerges, rather, as part of a broader, collective and disruptive movement for human and non-human liberation. When we shift from belief to participation, when we *fully witness* the contact experience, we step out of our own filters of possibility, our own comfort zones, our own restrictions that we have put on the possible and the impossible. Being open to the possibilities of contact reveals the UFO/UAP as a portal to breaking down our habitual ways of relating to Otherness— and calling into question the marked states of “self” and “other” we use to organize experience at all.

Fully *seeing experiencers*— engaging their memories, sense-making, and transformative orientations is the most fruitful form of disclosure. That which is disclosed destabilizes the notions of anthropocentric sovereignty, liberal atomistic personhood, and a materialistic universe that are not ultimately serving the ends of human and non-human well-being. What emerges in its place is a multidimensional

field of thinking, being, acting, and knowing that enables new existential, ethical, and epistemic possibilities. These are open to all who are willing to cultivate a different type of self, who will confront and welcome the unknown Other in a way that cracks open the rigid boundaries of oneness, who will receive the gift of contact and the possibilities for subjectivity and intersubjectivity it engenders.

True disclosure may thus be a disclosure of *ourselves* as much as it is a revealing of a non-human presence. The human is disclosed alongside the non-human, in its relation to Otherness and how we allow ourselves to be transformed by the possibility of encounter. When confronted with the question of “Who are you?” we simultaneously must ask, “and who am I?” The UFO/UAP and contact surges into human awareness as both disruption and as a choice: will we continue with ontological closure, exploitative systems, and fear of that which we perceive as alien? Or will we allow the disruption to spark a tolerance towards ambiguity, a responsivity that allows Otherness to appear without condition, a willingness to be transformed in order to become capable of getting closer to the truth? Are we willing to step into the complexity and messiness of full witnessing, a difficult but worthwhile process of participatory shared inquiry and co-creation of meaning?

Perhaps the truth is not “out there” but within us. This does not mean that UAP and the contact phenomenon do not bring us into proximity with a genuine Other. It means the ultimate truth yet to be decided is how we are willing to meet the Other that appears.

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